

# culturing

a book of poems

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*A man is only half understood when we know how everything in him came into being. If that were all, he could just as well have been dead years ago. As a living being he is not understood, for life does not have only a yesterday, nor is it explained by reducing today to yesterday. Life has also a tomorrow, and today is understood only when we can add to our knowledge of what was yesterday the beginnings of tomorrow.*

Carl Jung, *On the Psychology of the Unconscious*

*Man can suffer only a certain amount of culture without injury.*

Ibid

## About

This is a living tree of poems.

I have always been a poet, and I have often shared my work. But this is an experiment. I have eschewed traditional publishing in favor of self-publishing here. These poems are all connected and rooted in my life. To clip one here and there, to rearrange them into topical collections, would make me very sad. They have grown organically, in order, as I present them here.

Poems grow out of other poems, as lives grow out of other lives. Cut off from their source, they wither and die. Here is your chance to view them together in their natural habitat.

The name "culturing" comes from a surprising source. In "On the Origin of Species", Darwin notices differences between birds kept "under culture" and birds left in the wild. The phrase "under culture" troubles me. I don't want to be *under* culture. I want to *culture*. I want to participate in culture, to *make* culture. Thus "culturing" is the perfect manifesto for my poetry project.

From this, perhaps it will be obvious that I am an American, but I wish to remain anonymous in other ways. This leaves me free to speak the truth. But I wouldn't mind hearing from you. And please spread these poems far and wide, by posting links on social media, or even printing them.

There is more to come. Like Whitman, "hoping to cease not till death," I welcome you to this life's work in progress.

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*10 August 2010*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2010/08/the-man-who-knows/>*

The man who knows  
knows he doesn't know  
and loves to sing to sing,

because as water flows and flows  
he can't control a thing.

## As I Wander

22 October 2010

<https://poems.culturing.net/2010/10/as-i-wander/>

As I wander down this path  
I face my friend my fear,  
and gaze upon the fading footsteps  
that I followed here.

I find my heart quite trodden down  
and no tranquility.  
I find I'm not who I have been  
I find I cannot see.

I gaze at beauty all around  
but nothing moves my soul.  
Backward forward endlessly,  
it's out of my control.

I pause a moment, stop to feel  
the rippling tree-born skin,  
and wonder how I've come so far  
but never seem to win.

I kick a stone and watch it tumble  
down the mossy banks,  
and for a moment I can almost  
hear it whisper thanks.

A bird in song gives me a start  
and whistles in my head.  
Sharp I rise from battling,  
so wounded yet undead.

But it is still my fate it seems  
to wrestle with my mind.  
While others just enjoy the view  
my thoughts are in a bind.

Alas to see and hear and feel,  
this gift a lovely curse.  
I wish, I wish I could ignore  
And yet...it could be worse.

So I walk, I keep on walking  
it's my only choice,  
but if I write it, I am free;  
this is my only voice.

## Modern times

*29 January 2014*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2014/01/modern-times/>*

Fog ungloves all skin  
Amid a swirling superego.  
Lovers lose the wisdom  
to restrain a rough libido.

Holy water freezes  
in the absence of a flame.  
Knowledge fails to melt  
a snow-capped plain.

Icemen master phenomenal things:  
Darwin sneezes.  
Einstein sings.

## Progress

24 February 2014

<https://poems.culturing.net/2014/02/progress/>

"Soggy feet no more will creep  
along the droll, mud-wooden street.  
The hills will linger, moaning."

Ten by ten the honest men  
endeavor to bequeath, the end  
of younger things yet forming.

"Sulfur streaks and acid leaks  
will simmer as the factory speaks,  
while Gaea gives to groaning."

Sluggish men must hear it said  
that satellites are on the mend  
and cast aside their stonings.

"Out will go the stonings,  
and about will rise the loneliness  
of dark and lamplit streets."

One must seek atonement  
for the backhills and their moaning,  
but the workforce must ascend.

"Gaea's unheard groaning  
will raise heartache for the droning  
of the melancholy steel entropic beat."

One must think of honing  
all these younger things now formed.

Paltry flecks of wisdom reach an end,  
and there is laughter,  
there is blood about the street.



## **Birth**

*05 March 2014*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2014/03/birth/>*

Birth is a slow and painful thing,  
a tumult,  
longing toward an end,  
but staggering,  
a shallow wake  
of nascence,

For which death doth rend.

## Perspicuity (For Example)

*14 April 2014*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2014/04/perspicuity-for-example/>*

Note the indiscriminate vortices  
which haphazardly coax the vector  
into misalignment,

Or the malignantly languorous  
koala supping on divinities.

# Song of Sophia

24 July 2014

<https://poems.culturing.net/2014/07/song-of-sophia/>

## I. Akrasia

When there were no depths, I was brought forth,  
When there were no springs abounding with water.

Time slipped, fell  
through black holes  
to where I dwelt,

Stillborn in a rotting womb,  
with histories untold.

I cut my own cord.

Day by day I played  
between Olympian plains  
and Horeb,

Learning nothing,

For the ground had been well-tread  
by tanks and wise men  
teaching shadows

*HEY*

*THIS JUST IN*

*HEY*

*ERECTILE*

*DYSFUNCTION*

*HEY*

*LOOK*

*KITTENS*

*HEY*

*BIKINIS*

*HEY*

*HAVE YOU SEEN*

*HEY*

*YOU THERE ??*

HEY  
I LOVE YOU.  
HEY  
LOVE ME <3  
HEY

## II. Nostoi

Does not wisdom cry out,  
And understanding lift up her voice?

Thunder roars,  
and as a man who pants for water  
sees the rock break,

And sees the streams long dried by drought  
begin to flow,  
and drinks,

So too I flee the wasteland.

## III. Paideia

To you, O men, I call,  
and my voice is to the sons of men.

I gaze upon a field grown ripe with wheat  
and feel the warmth of rosy-fingered Dawn  
who has not failed to rise. I grip the scythe,

And take upon myself beginnings  
and their ends, and find this meaning  
*sicut erat in principio.*

## Somnambulance

05 February 2015

<https://poems.culturing.net/2015/02/somnambulance/>

Screams of seven thousand thousand  
haunt the seven decades  
since they exited throat.

Auschwitz undigested  
sticks in throats  
generations removed.

We drift in echoes  
that cannot be heard,  
that pierce if heard.

We have not heard  
but drift through echoes and time.

How does one cope?

Before the screams,  
there was Darkness;  
into Darkness came War,  
and Fire began.

Who has not seen the faces?  
Who has seen any face?

War consumes Light,  
begetting Scream;  
congeals to Shadow.

---

We are children of Abram.

Shadow is our womb,  
coddling like a cocoon  
of darkness.

Have we seen anything?

Battle has moved on.  
Convictions make screams  
and Law perishes.

Dare we impose?

We wax somnambulant,  
Drifting through slumber.

They were like us,  
those screaming, and those  
making them scream.

Fire burns at back of Mind,

And Blazeless, blinded,  
We shiver, huddled in masses,  
Fearing sparks.

---

Who will relearn the melody  
under the memory,

The song which can bend fire  
into warmth, and teach us hope?

## Songs of Youth

*4 April 2015*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2015/04/songs-of-youth/>*

I remember being young,  
Daffodils our trampled shrine.  
I know how the songs are sung.

Music prances on the tongue.  
Thought is out of mind.

Time itself is young,  
And on its breast are hung  
Narcissi, taught to ripen  
As the songs are sung,

For thus it must begin.

But if the songs are ever sung,  
And if the blossoms hung  
Are never hardened

We are young forever.  
We are ever young.

## Romance Revisited

07 May 2015

<https://poems.culturing.net/2015/05/romance-revisited/>

Unsurprised when she appeared  
atop the stair,  
unsought and yet on cue,  
I smiled.

There we were again.

More than sounds were heard,  
more said than words  
as we relieved the burn  
that itched for all those years.

Something in that breeze  
put love at ease,  
and all those memories  
in Sunday Best conceived  
some reparation,  
some demand.

But lives diverge,  
conform to their courses,  
drive towards their ends.

This, then, too must end.

---

But if we flee from time,  
abandon all but dreams,

Elide the pulls of Jupiter  
and Venus,

Would we weary of the world we'd made?

Must immortal Love's embrace  
ignore all time and place?

---



Rage for futility,  
Rage for bleared horizons,

For rage itself,  
which vanquishes sages,  
and for the mortal dream.

But though to many moons I've sighed,  
and though those eyes when met with mine  
still come to life to think of all that was  
and what could be, it is not time.

Though it is right.

For time flows suddenly to exit youth.

---

Let us go then, you and I,  
to die, and not trace ways  
across that sky  
where the Immortals lie.

We belong implanted  
where the bloom that Spring provides  
by Autumn flees, and we get by  
on hardened leaves.

## Out of Doors

*29 May 2015*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2015/05/out-of-doors/>*

He crossed the doorway  
one last time.

The hinge, grown stiff,  
came to  
and turned.

A vacuum grew  
where air had been,

But more rushed in  
and clicked in place  
from somewhere deep within.

Too long had he suffocated  
under indoor air.

Outdoor paths  
proposed some inspiration,

So he left,

And going door to door  
curled way on way

And found that wind not quite as bold  
as it had seemed within,

And he discerned  
that inside is something worth grasping.

## **Inner Harbor**

*04 July 2015*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2015/07/inner-harbor/>*

I spend my days inside,  
my nights beside the water  
watching young things draw and quarter  
lives not yet their own.

This they call maturity,  
this ever lack-of-surety,  
to be out on my own, be big  
but still not fill the throne.

*15 July 2015*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2015/07/there-is-too-much-noise/>*

There is too much noise  
inside, between walls,  
reverberating through skulls

Which grow empty.

Is there not solace, rest  
from Self?

Is there a balm?

I have heard of places,  
heard tunes of theogony,  
but is there any calm?

What remains are ashes,  
What remains are gems?

And must we know the difference?

I've yet to stumble through Eden  
but I've heard her song,  
I've seen blossoms rise.

If there is a balm, it lies  
behind still-naked eyes.

*20 July 2015*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2015/07/i-have-wandered-streets/>*

I have wandered streets,  
Each entrance blocked by blood of lamb,  
And I have seen no faces.

These are empty places.

*26 July 2015*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2015/07/there-are-no-words/>*

There are no words --  
no words, but only sounds  
with no meaning.

Is there a balm?  
What is a balm?

Nowhere are we to find solace.  
Nowhere are we to find others  
without lawlessness,

And I know why the free bird sings,  
for lack of a cage,  
for lack of any air on which to glide.

## **My people**

*20 August 2015*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2015/08/my-people/>*

A generation raised  
by a generation raised  
by lies knows no piety.

What deserves respect?

Souls, the old superstition  
squashed to great relief,  
cry foul no longer.

Life is good.

## Fragments Shored Against Ruin

24 October 2015

<https://poems.culturing.net/2015/10/fragments-shored-against-ruin/>

### 1

You are the last fighting chance  
for yourself,

A chamber, a kingdom  
-- *Cordelia!*

*Where is the throne?  
What is flesh?*

A clock in the hall  
A clock and no walls

And spinning  
Rome is burning

*Tick Tick Tick --*

There are things that move the will  
that even the atom cannot kill --

*There are things there are things*

-- If you do not control yourself,  
who will?

### 2

The executive has surrendered  
all -- anarchy ensues.

The state in which one cannot say no,  
when one cannot stop,  
is called chaos today is chaos  
and we are revolving in kaleidoscope  
houses that looked fun



who am the last fighting chance  
for myself, the only opportunity  
to be free of that doggerel wretch  
who sits on the mind-throne

while, usurped, the executive wastes  
in heaps of sentiment and flesh  
that wash over all  
and bathe with the lime of body.

soma. soma soma soma  
take and live.

### 3

My body waffling through space  
and undigested time conceives  
Idea — floats, as it were, above itself  
into ethereal otherlands

and waits.

Up, from where is only down,  
I fly, and divide this self  
into slivers, abandoning each  
at the foot of age-old Mind

Who takes them, warping tomorrow  
with hands of iron, cold.

I am left unanswered.

### 4

I fear the smallness of my mind  
surrounded by mysteries,

The abstract cave,  
philosopher's chains  
unbroken,

Bound,  
and sinking down.

And are there here no sunbeams,  
no exalted forms that dance  
on more than cavewall?

5

There are no tunes or strings to play  
unbloodied by the rage, unbridled  
by fearful faces, names  
turned dusty with shame.

How far the sky has fallen,  
how far! deep within our bowels

We cannot digest  
or swallow.

There is only us — only the rage  
and the cold, swollen cage.  
The bruised age.

6

Listen. We will begin  
to repeal soporifics  
only in the light of more pure  
harmonies and form.

There can be no freedom in extravagance.

Love is the beginning but not the fruition,  
which comes only through discipline  
and a kind of violence.

Once we have established ourselves  
at the end of ourselves, and only then,  
can we draw from the ashes  
some kind of beginning.

7

Is there still a Song,  
and can I sing along?

This man, boy, heart beating hard and strong,  
'tis mine? And may I be wrong?

I have wallowed verily, wallowed long  
in the avenues and twisting ways  
of ecstasy and sorrow,

But there is forthcoming joy,  
awakened noise which learns to balance  
and to hope with poise

The truth of which  
is There is There is There.

## **Egotism spreads**

*29 November 2015*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2015/11/egotism-spreads/>*

Egotism spreads against  
the backdrop of the morrow,  
leaving little room for ecstasy  
and far too much for sorrow.

## **If there are still men**

*23 December 2015*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2015/12/if-there-are-still-men/>*

If there are still men,  
if there are still those  
who do not depend,  
who when aroused  
defend,  
then fate can be bent --

If not good God relent!

## Megalopolis

*24 December 2015*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2015/12/megalopolis/>*

"What are eyes? I see none  
under crushing skies.

Are things under skin  
worth time?

Nay,  
Whatever — "

This, our kind sucked dry,  
dissolves all hope of lives combined

And we trudge on,  
responding to slights  
in kind.

## Scents of the Divine

*14 January 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/01/scents-of-the-divine/>*

Wonder is the pollen of belief,  
and faith, the leaf;

We know only wafts  
of distant breezes.

## The Choir

18 January 2016

<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/01/the-choir/>

By silent seas we sit and sing  
Of life's unwrought enamelling  
As each day gathers into storm  
And reasons with our untold ire.

Rise fair song and banish woe  
For we must fear the foreman's blow  
For though our fathers built with stone  
We build the world again each morn,

And tremble in the shade of steel,  
And ache for poison salesmen sell,  
And whirl in this ungrateful gyre  
To placate pioneering fire.

---

What is this? What is my own?  
What good is a peopled home  
When urge and urge and urge inspire  
Epitomes forlorn?

Hope, where are your lovely feathers?  
All your crumbs are swept – this weathered  
Leaf deceives – these grasses wither.  
There are only bog and mire.

Who would dare to ope  
Pandora's vessel once again? What's left?  
All can see that Zeus has scorned  
Those Foresight has adorned.

---

But summon those old voices hither.  
Sing a song against the dither.  
Won't a mythic world reborn  
Reclassify revealed desire?

Make again that age-old beat.  
Forget the words that spell defeat.



Abandon prod and thrust.  
Embrace the courage of the calling horn.

For we have feared the shades of steel,  
But harbor dreams of living well,  
And dream of lifting off the pyre,  
And lift this chorus as a choir.

## The Great Mortality (Famine, Death, Rebirth)

26 January 2016

<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/01/the-great-mortality/>

We sow dark energy against our host  
With no more remorse, for here the ghost  
Drifts sadly before the eyes of none,  
Ancient among foregone hills.

*Those who know*

Hope! What is hope?  
Sacred thoughts cope,  
and merely cope.

*know the ashes know*

Float on, you faithless.  
There is time to decompose.

*know the rose*

The ash of genius grows.

## **The Absurd**

*5 March 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/03/the-absurd/>*

The struggle for words and the urge for definition,  
The epiphany that there is no epiphany,  
The inner flame, the old names,  
The lost boy, the dark wood  
The cry,  
The silence

## Parting

*02 April 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/04/parting/>*

Time takes. We weep.  
Such tears are not for sorrow,  
but for grace --  
that we should live at all  
to know the embrace --

Alas, parting — the sweet sorrow --  
ever pitted between truth and marrow,  
which bends fate, concedes,

And then leaves no trace.

No ducts are so deep  
to not swell at endings.

But there are beginnings,  
sorrows saved and joys awaiting,  
a haunting horizon --

Nay, this is no sheathing  
but a brandishing.

## Song

02 May 2016

<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/05/song/>

I have seen beginnings  
I have seen my end I have  
seen some tomorrows and  
I've walked behind  
the curtain to where  
nothing lies I've seen  
the ancient hills  
but I could not make out their markings  
and I've heard the distant Elves  
but are they coming or embarking?

There runs deep a Song,  
and we have all been taught wrong.

I have listened closely  
I have waited near  
I've book-learned much and  
quavered I have loved  
but not enough and I have  
caught the scent of Juniper  
I've swooned amid the leaves  
and I have tasted bitter Lucifer  
in all the bitter leaves.

There runs deep a Song,  
and we have all been taught wrong.

I have raged and hungered  
I have severed  
I've torn self from home I've  
cackled I've corroded  
I've disowned  
and I have been an unborn self alone.

There runs deep a Song,  
and we have all been taught wrong.

I have seen beginnings  
I have seen my end, I've tried  
to sing along, along,

For there runs deep a Song,  
and we have all been taught it wrong.

## The bigness of the sky

04 August 2016

<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/08/the-bigness-of-the-sky/>

See that thing above us,  
floating here and everywhere?

Wonder if one tumbled up  
and never came back down.

Fear the fat foot-fallen  
finding roots for flesh and soul.

Hear what coaxes upward  
and what promises the rest.

Think perhaps that atmosphere  
is lofty and above.

Find a reconciliation,  
some true thing to truly love.

## For an Old Lover

*06 August 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/08/for-an-old-lover/>*

I held you in a dream-worn land  
and felt upon this hand  
a subtle war that ne'er was sparked by man  
but burned in this mind's eye.

Surer forms of idol worship  
walk just like a woman, but are tenderer,  
and spirit us forgotten things,  
and give us ghostly wings.

Lover, you know beauty flies.  
Enclose again within my soul  
that morsel of eternal grace  
you burned in this mind's eye.



## The End of Suffering

*06 August 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/08/the-end-of-suffering/>*

I've heard that once there was suffering.  
One hardly thinks of it now.  
Pallbearers took dark bodies away,  
And even steeple-bells tolled.

Now these thoughtless mortals  
can but burn for lack of shade.

Shadow, rend the heat.  
The night is meet.  
And devils love conceit.

## Valediction to Images

*06 August 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/08/valediction-to-images/>*

Image of forgotten beauty,  
Face of fire, flesh of music,  
Laughter-loving Aphrodite,  
Be not high or mighty  
    By the altar of my heart.

Rosy cheeks on satin faces,  
Eyes that call the heart to race,  
O, sculpture of amazing graces,  
Shatter. There are empty places  
    Deep within my heart.

Come instead, you hidden song,  
You dying fall withholding all,  
And I will hear you long,  
For I can hear you call  
    From deep within the altar of my heart.

## **The day is dark**

*08 September 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/09/the-day-is-dark/>*

Oh, the day is dark;  
The night is all aspark  
With visions.

We are no one's children.

Is there any heart?

## **If God Speaks, He Whispers**

*22 September 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/09/a-place-we-can-still-go/>*

I have listened long  
to murmurs, echoes of myself  
impersonating holy song.

No, the stillness knows.

There is still a place  
where winds will blow,  
and it's a place we can still go.

## Another ending

*22 September 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/09/another-ending/>*

I guess this is the end.  
I'm not sure what of.  
They say time is no friend.  
Things slip away.

I guess it must be so.  
But how should we know?  
Something moves about,  
and I can hear it rumble now.

So I write this down.  
Embark with me I pray.  
Other thoughts have flown,  
or gone some other way,

But within is the promised stay of woe,  
and that is where the old roads go.

*22 September 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/09/child-you-are-the-water/>*

Child you are the water — have you heard?  
It trickles softer words.  
Don't be tricked by desert people.  
Fear the curse of birds.

## Notes for Mr. Pound

*22 September 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/09/notes-for-mr-pound/>*

Ezra, you've gathered the fundamentals.  
This is how they cohere:

Consider the blackbird singing,  
just one, not yet perturbed  
and yet disturbed by something  
somehow, into song --

How singest thou?

Still I sing along, I too must sing  
because your song is ours  
and we have sung it long:

A song of walls and boundaries  
and chains defying reason,  
giving Form a bad name.

But peeping o'er the maze I see  
a light which answers praise.

## Only Begin

22 September 2016

<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/09/only-begin/>

*For J. Alfred Prufrock and his admirers*

If I could only begin,  
I would end alright.  
But time is riddled with sin.

Lovers never win  
with all their might.  
If I could only begin

To tell you all of thick and thin  
I might get things right.  
But time is riddled with sin.

So let me come in,  
up out of this night.  
Then I could begin

To speak in both sound and sight  
of ample groves and measured flight.  
But time is riddled with sin,  
so I could only begin.



## Three Rivers

*22 September 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/09/three-rivers/>*

Until the end has spoken,  
until all have been awoken,  
until no more tongues are broken

Sing sweet Thames, oh sing sweet Thames.

And by the dusty jailhouse,  
by the ladder wracked with stars  
and by the tree branch burned with scars

Oh Mississippi sing, oh sing,  
oh Mississippi won't you sing.

And like the friendly moon,  
and like the trees that live here too,  
like able-bodied men who swoon,

Monongahela you must sing.

## Why write poetry

*22 September 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/09/why-write-poetry/>*

Warm smiles  
illuminated by a central hearth  
in days to come.

## Longing

*17 October 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/10/longing/>*

I long for things I've never known.  
The shadows curse my eyes.  
The scars run deep. They run at least to bone.

And though thunder grants atonement,  
Always questions come from other skies.  
I long for things I've never known,

And candles burn and scholars moan  
And ashes creep beneath the tightest mind.  
The scars are deep like bone,

And all the ancient empty tomes  
Provide no lasting prize,  
But only point to things we cannot know.

The ache for bluer skies,  
The ache for home,  
The scars that run through bone,  
The longing is the only thing we know.

## The End of Time

*17 October 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/10/the-end-of-time/>*

I sing unto the end of time,  
And not of loss or life between.  
Beginnings, endings have no rhyme.

I do not walk the line  
Toward a promise unforeseen.  
I sing unto the end of time,

And hold my breath, for it is mine.  
I think the only things are green.  
Beginnings, endings have no rhyme,

And dying, it is fine.  
Although I prize what lovers dream.  
I sing unto the end of time

For lies have made us mean.  
At the dawn is no more me.  
Sing unto the end of time  
If nothing else will rhyme.

## A poem

*28 October 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/10/a-poem/>*

begins like this:  
a note, a phrase,

But then goes deeper,  
seeps just under,  
slakes upon a thirst,

and ends in growth.

## After the Fall

28 October 2016

<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/10/after-the-fall/>

I dislike Rome  
    (he whispered  
    to no one in particular),

Her dead-head poets,  
her worldliness,

But then I am a Platonist,  
who finds no  
succor colliding  
επιθυμία with time.

What Good are monuments?  
All of them fall.

No, no, no Godot,  
no Reason,

But I make with you,  
and sing a nascent treason.

Is that true?

## **children of terror**

*03 November 2016*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2016/11/children-of-terror/>*

past crayon drawings of plane-crash buildings,  
heaps of America  
broken

down by a sort of  
conflict with nobody  
everywhere,

you who were learning to read:

stand.

your legs will do.

## Out to Plant a Garden

*02 January 2017*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2017/01/out-to-plant-a-garden/>*

I am out to plant a garden.  
Will you tend it?  
I will put the seed on air.  
It will not grow without you there.

I am out to pull the weeds.  
Are you coming?  
I will put my shovel down.  
I'm in no rush to break new ground.



## Countrified

*06 April 2017*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2017/04/countrified/>*

I have heard the wail of cities,  
I have felt their steely cry,  
And I have prowled upon the pavement  
And been burned from eye to eye.

I cannot hate the people  
Who have known no other way,  
But I don't think their crippling  
must darken my own day.

## The Bird in the Glue Trap

06 April 2017

<https://poems.culturing.net/2017/04/the-bird-in-the-glue-trap/>

It wasn't meant for you,  
that much is clear. But how  
those little wings beat such  
a fearsome rhythm  
just to pull you  
those two-hundred bird-lengths,  
sticky trap in tow,  
I'll never know,

Or how you ripped your body free  
to soar on lighter wing.

Ah, those feathers left behind  
were not worth dying over.

I am only glad, my friend,  
that I did not extinguish you  
to put an end to pain.

## The New Science

06 April 2017

<https://poems.culturing.net/2017/04/the-new-science/>

Under the stars a hundred bards  
drop still, dead silent,  
to look for a law in the cards.

They know the stomach is violent,  
a flame that retards,

And also that men have bodies,  
are bodies, whirling  
in an endless whirl of leaves.

Therefore they crucify Reason,  
that cold Inspector  
who murders the seasons,

And go on unvarnished  
but do not think  
that makes them tarnished.

Can we place blame  
for this treason?

Might it be just  
that in spite of stars  
Man hasn't come that far?

## The New World

*25 April 2017*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2017/04/the-new-world/>*

Raised among wolves,  
    we've learned both bite and howl,  
but there is a new kind of life coming now.

An old life more truly,  
    one ought to be sure.  
Allow me to answer, I've no sinecure.

Upon an old hill  
    there stood men young and old.  
They bore a fierce wind and were bold.

As one with one purpose  
    they built there together  
foundations to outlast all weather.

That edifice fell,  
    but the ruins remain.  
Do any dare build there again?

## **Dawn**

*28 April 2017*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2017/04/dawn/>*

Onward, on to other dreams!  
Awaken, you silk-tethered sleeper.  
Rip apart the seams.

## **The Muse**

*22 May 2017*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2017/05/the-muse/>*

Sing, oh great sleepy Muse, sing.

How we long for the ring  
of your voice once to bind us  
again to the melodies of life  
and the rhythms of death.

There is no joy apart from you,  
no pain but parting from you,

There is no song that is not you,  
no answer dreamed without you,

So sing, sweet Muse,  
do sing.

For else all is an empty thing.

## Made In America

24 May 2017

<https://poems.culturing.net/2017/05/made-in-america/>

*For Allen Ginsberg and against many others*

America I've given you my mind and now know nothing.  
America have you lost it?  
America let's come together.  
America the times have changed.  
America I have nine Facebook friends.  
I text them all the time.  
America is this what you meant?  
Sorry if I'm oppressing you.  
Sometimes I eat cholesterol.  
I just can't relax.

America I spent twelve years staring at tile growing limp you paid for it nobody noticed  
is this Progress?

America are we There yet?

America where do Rights come from?  
I've turned off my mind but I won't float downstream.  
America why Columbine?  
America why Ted Kaczynski?  
America have you tried thinking about it?  
It must be those damn video games.  
America this is a problem.  
We'd better get out and protest.  
America it's those damn liberals.  
America it's those damn conservatives.  
America I can't believe you.

America I won't watch television.  
You really can't be serious.  
Three minutes is not enough time.

America millions of kids have no clue about meaningful conversations after years in  
your schools. I guess they need more Science.

America it confuses me when you bully me into tolerance.  
I begin to doubt your sincerity.

America why do you hate the dead?  
Are handicapped people more equal than me?  
America help I feel alienated.  
America this is my inside voice.  
America have you read the Bible?  
America it has sex in it.  
I mean that literally.  
America what is the meaning of this?  
America why so many pills?  
America let's be friends.

America I'm getting anxious.  
America is this the end?  
America why are your shelves full of poison?  
America I don't like corn.  
I almost have my energies aligned.  
But why is there so much pornography?

America I had a dream that when I grew up I would be strong and capable now I'm not so sure.

America I'm not finished can I have an extension?



## **Belonging**

*12 September 2017*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2017/09/belonging/>*

Come, my friend, and be whole.  
Whose waters are these?  
They won't hurt a soul.

For there is no rest among men  
who only keep death out so long.

Come be made one by the river  
and learn what it is to belong.

## **To Men on Women**

*12 September 2017*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2017/09/to-men-on-women/>*

We have left behind the women,  
and they roar now, at least some of them,  
and we are still not sure which way to lead.

We hear them though,  
and wonder that they bleed.

Something there is not in our control,  
and if it were, would not be whole --

Let's take this answer and begin.

## Open onto other things

*22 September 2017*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2017/09/open-onto-other-things/>*

Open onto other things.  
A mind has many wings.

## **A silence that no one has heard**

*16 October 2017*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2017/10/a-silence-that-no-one-has-heard/>*

There is a silence that no one has heard.  
It says so much more than words.

*16 October 2017*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2017/10/out-came-a-cry/>*

Out came a cry  
    from beneath the great Nothing,  
but no one was there to believe it.

An oomph went woomph,  
    and the meaning went missing,  
and no one was there to retrieve it.

And day was like sand,  
    and the moon went away,  
and nobody was there to be free with.

*01 April 2018*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/04/a-walk-through-a-graveyard/>*

A walk  
through a graveyard  
reveals a peculiar slumber —

the men of tomorrow.

The sign reads “Help,  
we’ve been civilized,  
there’s no going back.”

But there never has been any going back.

And the life urge resigns itself  
to smallness,  
and this too is good,

For too much growth makes weeds,  
and we cannot tolerate weeds.

Tomorrow, then, comes anyway.  
This is a walk through a graveyard.

## Aftermath

*21 April 2018*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/04/aftermath/>*

I have heard the wild  
    ramblings,  
felt betrayed by man  
    and steel,  
and I cannot  
    keep on  
good clothes —

    but madly naked  
run through city streets,  
    cry “Kung Fu Tze!  
where are you?”

## Hot and Cold

21 April 2018

<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/04/hot-and-cold/>

*For Peter Dale Scott*

The morning began,  
and would end consequentially,

buildings collapsing,  
BANG!

We have lived, have we not,  
in an age of terror,

By George,  
an age of Terror.

I have seen my own soul and felt afraid.

—

It began, of course,  
earlier,

with a bang  
down in Dallas,

or Berlin, 1945  
and after,

but in any case, it's ours,  
the children.

We are not sure what to love.

—

Cool me, gentle apathy,  
with all your mists.

Placate as you vacate,  
oh my soul.



## The Secrets of Country Living

*21 April 2018*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/04/the-secrets-of-country-living/>*

*For Robert Penn Warren*

I do not know  
what

you will find up there  
in the brambles  
among inhibiting growths,

but I have once  
heard an eagle call out its name.

It was a sound like Truth.

## Naomi

*10 May 2018*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/05/naomi/>*

What a sweet thing,  
when those eyes have the look of eyes  
that are received.

I no longer find it hard to believe.

Between you and me are all secrets,  
and we and the earth  
are three.

A young man would swoon,  
and an old disapprove,

But a man of both worlds gives soft praise.

## **Mysteries**

*01 August 2018*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/08/mysteries/>*

O stolen time,  
wandering there by the sea,

what will you do with me?

Unfurl your grasp of life,  
make plain the age again!

No sooner does one cope  
than some new younger hope  
steps in and whisks fidelity away.

O vanity of vanities,  
great necromancing age!

Tear down thy veils with rage  
if that will set you free,

but I will not be free.

For there is still truth in old books,  
and the walls will not fall for sly looks.

Indeed, there is room at all tables.

## **Bird sits still**

*19 August 2018*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/08/bird-sits-still/>*

Bird sits  
still  
in vacuum,  
waiting.

No hope of gliding.

Squawks again,  
why not.

Pecks self,  
prunes wings.

unused,  
abused?  
confused

Squawks.

again,  
why not?

## Terror

11 September 2018

<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/09/terror/>

Planes, flames, wreckage.

Images played, replayed  
in certain ways.

Oh, the horror.

News inspires  
*terror terror acts of terror*  
*terrorist muslim extremist*  
*terror*

all day long,  
even though there are children.

—

Loyalty is not at all times virtuous,  
but neither is disloyalty.

Either keeps things moving.

For those who have known terror,  
what of love?

Can such things be?

—

I hear the Bush  
in the wilderness,  
burning,

Take off my shoes  
and wait.

It cannot speak.

And this will not be easy.  
We must live with ourselves.

—

But one may ask,  
what *is* treason?

And more than one may answer.

And we have been like this,  
and with good reason,  
but we will not dwell on that now.

—

I fear the Bush has burnt,  
and we are alone.

But then a cry comes from the desert,

“Keep those embers burning!  
Night is coming!  
It is growing colder!”

And I wonder without wonder  
when the world would rather freeze.

## **Lone wolf howls**

*02 October 2018*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/10/lone-wolf-howls/>*

Lone wolf howls,  
jaw deformed.

Heart disease.

Bite marks prove:  
no hope.

## **All Has Been Forsaken**

*24 October 2018*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/10/all-has-been-forsaken/>*

I have built my house on a swamp.  
Nobody can reach me here.

All has been forsaken.  
That is clear,

but what new dawn  
comes with the new year?



## History

*09 November 2018*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/11/history/>*

Where do we come from?  
Primordial slime.

I would love to explain it,  
but there is no time,

and thinking is a crime.

But then, why rhyme?

*09 November 2018*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/11/one-more-cave/>*

When Philosophy's just one more Cave, take heart,  
for there is still room to start,  
and an almost but not yet lost art.

## **"Romance Revisited," revisited**

*14 November 2018*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/11/romance-revisited-revisited/>*

I saw you there  
atop the stair,  
it's true,

And you were me  
and I was you,

And ocean blue  
bore love away.

It chastened him right through.

Alas! they say  
it is no use to sing,

But I'll take wing, for lo!  
Minerva's owl has perched  
upon a husk, a lifeless stump,

and there will be no going on  
without new songs from flesh and blood.

## **America (Northeast)**

*13 December 2018*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/12/america-northeast/>*

O child of burning night!  
O fire undivine!

When will you put on some clothes?

Let old Walt rest!  
He never knew best,

For he has let Medea  
have her way with the children

and slinks off to Bethlehem  
to be born.

## Academia

*31 December 2018*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2018/12/academia/>*

These old metaphysicians  
have not reckoned with Bob Dylan  
or the rest of rock and roll,

but make love to pure abstraction  
in the heat of musty bookshelves.

What is it to be?

Still their queasy deity  
impugns all souls of freedom,  
'til they dream not of escape.

Those who have been through it  
never quite think straight again.

Open up, it's me.

Ah, profoundest nonsense,  
most inebriating charm!  
which empowers all corruption,  
doing simple folk harm.

Take the path of flesh and bone,  
if it still lies before you.

I must stay to point the way,  
but wish that I could join you.

## Being

04 January 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/01/being/>

*For Heidegger*

It is all jumbled together,  
yin and yang,

at once the thing  
and the corruption of the thing,

and we all know the dirty bath may need to go,  
babe be damned,

But then,  
how can we hope?

How does one cope?

## America or Aristotle

*13 January 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/01/america-or-aristotle/>*

O land of confusion, burning bright!

Land with no middle term,  
where “why?” is forbidden  
because unanswerable,

Flee from thyself.  
Find God.

He’s out there somewhere.

## Nixon at the Threshold of the Lincoln Memorial

13 January 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/01/nixon-at-the-threshold-of-the-lincoln-memorial/>

*Something that is completely clean can also be completely sterile*

Nixon, *Dictabelt 75*, May 1970

What language could there have been  
between that tiger, battle-scarred,  
and these young cubs, German-tongued  
and fearful offspring of Philosophy in ruins?

Ah, one tries to merge with Being as the sky collapses.  
Those with thorny crowns spy deep oppression.

Nixon mutters, "What is there to save?"  
allows no motion, grins a grin that says  
"All shall be well, stop feeling."

This has happened before.

I stood there as a child  
repeating "up steps!" in innocence,  
for I had not yet learned what there is said  
of History or Freedom,  
or the other vague ideas men have died for.

I was born too late for that,  
and though things have not changed  
some hope, yes, even now,  
though with less force,  
for some renewal,  
this time unendorsed.

It will not come on wings  
or save us, probably,  
but it could make things better,  
keep them moving.

And as for the children, well,  
they've never mattered much to us,  
and who could build a home from such raw material?



## For the Love of Aristotle

19 January 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/01/for-the-love-of-aristotle/>

I feel the burning pressure  
push upon my brow.  
The beat of every moment,  
inescapable somehow.

What fathers bore this curse,  
and thereby drenched the land in sweat?  
What mothers bore them children,  
who don't know how to relent?

America! America!  
There is still time, you see.  
As long as we have bodies  
we have possibilities.

Recovery must come.  
The other options are too dire.  
Behold yourselves, begin again,  
for this way leads to fire.

## Hole

*29 January 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/01/hole/>*

And as a hole where a house once stood  
begins to fill with moss and soil,  
so too he took a wife, and had a child.

## Milton Usurped

29 January 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/01/milton-usurped/>

*I can't go to Paradise no more.*

*I killed a man back there.*

Bob Dylan, *Spirit on the Water*

But what is to be made of Milton's hearse?  
One victim of the newborn myth of books,  
he dreamed of glory. Can he still be true?  
We did not get to Paradise in time,  
and listen, John, it's over, that whole thing,  
but we can still be friends. We set you free,  
though some would have you bound and gagged,  
for you are fertile soil.

It is time for growths  
not tethered to the sturdy oaks,  
and you know how this works.

And so the burnished throne, bleached white,  
is smothered by new vines,

And O! Alas! rest easy, friend,  
for we no longer gnash the teeth.

## On Nothing

*14 February 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/02/on-nothing/>*

O emptiness, O void supreme!  
Unfill us, leave only urge,  
yes, all is false. We long to be ugly,  
unwrap the heavens, tatter the shawl,  
break the boundaries, and ourselves,  
at blood on walls, which fall,  
scream, "Is this all?"

## On Wading

02 March 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/03/on-wading/>

Successful waders  
know a few things,  
resist a little,  
do not get carried away.

They choose streams carefully,  
can be lead,  
avoid the rapids,  
rarely rest on banks.

A wader can manage the flow.

## King Henry in the Playpen

05 March 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/03/king-henry-in-the-playpen/>

The Virgin laughs  
like a mother whose child  
does not know he is seen.

She is recovering  
from Plague,  
and watches, near flowers,

her little tyrant  
storming through his own world.

O silly boy,  
your mother waits.

Do you not know her?

Ah, she laughs so gently,  
so as not to weep,

and thinks, "Go on.  
Thy rampage is almost done.

You will need me soon."

## **Not Without Reason**

*05 March 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/03/not-without-reason/>*

The question remains  
the same:

whether to live alone  
or drift among the formless.

It seems either choice is vague.

## The New Bird

09 March 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/03/the-new-bird/>

The idea waits upon a bough.  
The bird is in the parlor though.  
Tomorrow never comes for us,  
and so he sings for now.

But over in the city though  
the trees all stand erect,  
where there is no sought communion  
and the love is all in trust.

I do not speak for them,  
and only know the words I know.  
But for who would still hear,  
I have endeavored to show how.

---

Idea waits upon a bough.  
The bird is in the parlor though.  
Tomorrow has not come,  
and so he sings for now.

But over in the city now,  
the steel trees stand erect,  
and there is no more communion  
where all love is held in trust.

The song is not for those  
who sing of things one cannot know.  
The new bird sings, alas!  
for those who have no other sound.



27 March 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/03/i-have-withdrawn-from-the-world/>

I have withdrawn from the world  
for the world's own good,  
I have bound my own hands.

But not with the usual cords  
and knots,  
not well-fashioned marriage bands.

I come for the darkness,  
and whisper it slow:  
that this is where all the young tulips go

Which have failed to grow  
in dead soil.

—

Whence comes new song,  
and will it be long?

The embers are dwindling,  
the hearth has grown cold,  
and the vagabonds grow old.

I say only this,  
that is this not sure bliss,  
to belong, to behold, and to bless?

## Rosie

*31 March 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/03/rosie/>*

Rosie works  
so hard  
to please the factory man.

It is a matter of time.

She has been on hands and knees  
since seventeen,

And does not know  
what moves her so,

To longing, maybe, for something.

Meanwhile  
somewhere blossoms,

but she cannot go,  
for it is a matter of time,

though she does know  
the way things grow.

## Mother and Son

*11 April 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/04/mother-and-son/>*

"Come," she says,  
"the broth is ready.  
Medicine is almost brewed."

"But mother, I am well."

"No, you are not."

He takes a sip,  
and starry ships,  
and dreams of other hips,  
slip out, beneath her smiling whip.

And what of other women?

"Mother, you know best," he says,  
and sits stock-still for days.

## **Marriage**

*30 April 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/04/marriage/>*

Ah, the fall,  
'twas most to be expected.  
Not the landing.

Lost within some woman's world,  
maneuvering and bent,

the forces pull,  
and they will not relent.

This life will be well spent.

## Sainthood

05 May 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/05/sainthood/>

By Hippo's pearl-white gate we stand,  
imbibing every reprimand,  
embodied and ashamed, we wait  
for worldless fame and deathless man.

O Sorrow! How forsaken, we,  
in dour, lifelong misery,  
implore a ghost to hear the cry  
of spirit's flesh-born agony.

O sleeper, wake! and dread no wonder.  
Seek Aquino's shores, and plunder.  
World awaits, and those who know  
are thus drawn out and under.

## The Lady

06 May 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/05/the-lady/>

I dreamed I saw a Lady  
perched atop a milk-white stair,  
overlooking starry oceans  
and defining what was there.

Beneath her golden tresses  
opened up a gnawing void,  
which catapulted us to freedom.  
Soon all motion was destroyed!

The Lady did not stir, but crooned,  
and smiled a softer smile  
than wisest men have dared to dream.  
Then she turned her back awhile.

The void kept belching fire,  
and the only thing we knew  
was its bedevilment and whirl.  
It proved that all things are see-through!

The Lady meanwhile, laughing,  
stayed atop of how things are,  
and by the time we knew what hit us,  
saw we hadn't gotten far.

The morning came as always,  
and we, naked on her shore,  
cried out, "Dear Lady, let us near!  
Your sweet forgiveness, we implore!"

She looked at all our nakedness,  
saw through our praise and plight,  
and said, "Fools, get yourselves together,  
or else get out of my sight!"

## **Against Ice Sculptures**

*13 May 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/05/against-ice-sculptures/>*

Alas, I see them still  
in solid ice,

encased against all will  
but Power.

O, that they were free,  
as liquid flowing  
to the sea!

To break, and dance again!

## **Go not alone**

*11 June 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/06/go-not-alone/>*

There is a place beyond  
all stars. It is no home  
for what we are.  
Go not alone.



## Crickets

28 June 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/06/crickets/>

Up upon a hill I heard  
the crickets chirping words:  
O boy, come here, come near,  
and stay and talk awhile.

My answer was to smile,  
and I did no more favors then,  
but crossed the valley of denial  
and arrived within their ken.

O boy, I heard more echoing,  
and sat, and stayed, and then  
felt all around a queer commotion  
stir the leaves, and break, and end.

And oh, 'twas cool November,  
and the birds did softly sing,  
and if there's one thing I'll remember,  
it's my softly taking wing

Upon the backs of those cold crickets,  
on the hill, who chirped with words,  
for as they chirped about salvation,  
they made sure that I had heard.

## White Shade

07 July 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/07/white-shade/>

A shade of white,  
not quite opaque,  
disturbs my sight.

It has no form,  
but haunts the night  
like one unsteadily born.

The ashes of a pyre  
lay where  
She was burned bright.

I do not see the Lady,  
and her absence  
haunts my sight.

## For the Innocent

09 July 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/07/for-the-innocent/>

Listen, for I will tell you  
what you were left wanting.

It is not a pure loss of violence  
for some unseen cause,  
nor a fire that goes with the heating.

You long for an energy  
which is itself.

It may grow  
where men both  
work and pray.

## Beatrice Among the Daffodils

22 July 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/07/beatrice-among-the-daffodils/>

I see the beloved, dancing  
in a field of purest gold.  
She is not mine to have or hold.

Her body, like her soul,  
is what she is. And these  
together make one whole.

O friend in white!  
Come down from heaven,  
where the air has grown too thin.

Here are some daffodils.  
Your spirit lies within.

## The Lady Sings for Hobbes

22 July 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/07/the-lady-sings-for-hobbes/>

What sayest thou, clear thinker,  
about friendship?

Have you cherished love?

Though Power, yes, is sought  
(there is no doubt), is every motion  
just a chasing after clout?

What would your mother think?

I do not speak for her  
or for myself,  
but for the Lady,

who has sent me  
to remind you who you are.

## In the Beginning

03 August 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/08/in-the-beginning/>

The question  
I have been asking

is in the beginning,  
was there nothing,  
or was there God?

And what is the difference?

It may after all  
turn out that we  
are just malleable.

## Lady in the Dark

*03 August 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/08/lady-in-the-dark/>*

Beneath the moon  
I saw her too,

alone,  
where null is true.

I did not dare come near,  
but felt that here, of all  
damned places,  
least deserves her.

## The Lady Speaks of Progress

03 August 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/08/the-lady-speaks-of-progress/>

*For Langston Hughes*

I have known progress.  
My soul has grown weak just for progress.

I have known progress from London to New Orleans,  
and my soul has grown weak just for progress.

I have walked out at night among men without bones,  
and my soul had grown weak just for progress.

I have ridden in cars and smoked,  
and found God to find myself revoked,  
and I have known all the dark secrets that you would swear you would never invoke.

And my soul has grown weak just for progress.

I am not now nor will I ever be  
the kind of lady who belongs by making family,  
because my soul is weak.

My soul has grown weak just for progress.

And oh, I have machines,  
and shiny things,  
but they don't speak.

And oh, my soul, why are you so weak?  
Is there nothing new to seek?  
Speak. The men  
have not fathomed your needs.



## Lady in the Temple

*10 August 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/08/lady-in-the-temple/>*

She looked around  
like one bound  
to be free,  
  
excited truly,  
and so rapt  
that she saw none  
of the holes in the roof.

## Twilight Over Virginia

*22 August 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/08/twilight-over-virginia/>*

I thought I saw Virginia  
calling over mountains home,  
and oh, I thought I knew tomorrow  
like the back of all my bones,

But yesterday and cold forgetting  
left me stranded unawares,  
and now the moon might still shine sometimes  
but the twilight wouldn't dare.

## Lincoln's Memory

29 August 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/08/lincolns-memory/>

So favored forms of power  
shall not perish from the earth,  
would you please sing for us, O History,  
about the urgent birth  
of these great, terrible, united States,  
which, though conceived in Liberty,  
did break, some say, that vow?

This nation under God, twice founded,  
ever failing, yet immortal,  
did embark toward the dream of Freedom  
led by that one stout Kentuckian  
who hated much as loved  
and took a promise unfulfilled  
and made it law to bind on all.

This promise, called Equality,  
our hope in days to come,  
arose, O History! through violence,  
and herein lies its song.

---

Twas eighteen-fifty-eight, whereon a Senate seat contended  
led the folks of Illinois to dream they saw a President.  
One Lincoln-not-yet-Deity, preparing for debate,  
stood by a portrait of old Jefferson, to whom he could relate,  
and said,

"Old predecessor tongue with wings, remind me,  
whence came our brave truth,  
that all men are created equal.  
Knew you this in youth?"

To which the painting said,  
"It was a growth of many years,  
first born on England's hills  
in faithful regicide."

And Lincoln asked,  
"But had you heard of man's first disobedience  
and the fruit?"

Came quick reply:  
"Our Massachusetts friends knew of such things,  
but I did hope to purge all superstition,  
and robe God in Nature."

"Ah, in nature," Lincoln said.

"That's right. For all can become noble  
if they're only left alone."

Great Lincoln, growing ponderous,  
stroked his chin  
and paced before the painting,  
murmuring, "If left alone..."

He did not dare to broach the question,  
burned on his and other minds,  
of Slavery, but rather urged this thought:  
"Suppose we find all men not equal. Who's at fault?"

But there was no reply.

The painting would not speak,  
and Lincoln found his affirmation.

As the sureness grew,  
he pondered long  
and nursed a budding song.

---

This Lincoln after many years  
appeared before the dead  
and spoke the words  
we will not long remember,

for we must not hallow,  
must not consecrate that ground  
where many died and killed.

Thus Lincoln willed,  
and thus we must obey.

---

But Oh, how Declaration  
had sent shocks across the sea  
as Mr. Jefferson endeavored  
to give ground to that new plea  
which was come forth just then,  
at last!

And when 'twas time for tea in Boston,  
there was Paine in every head,  
and 'twas ideas, sir, ideas!  
which would leave so many dead.

---

Lord, such war and terror  
bled from North down through the South  
until the only ones remaining  
banished God and punished doubt.

To devastation wrought,  
and to the horror not quite heeded,

To man's ultimate obedience,  
friend History, give song.

## **The Lady Knows**

*07 September 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/09/the-lady-knows/>*

The Lady knows  
when she is not wanted;  
  
She walks alone at dawn.

## After Lincoln

24 September 2019

<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/09/after-lincoln/>

Alas, there came more wars,  
at least as brutal,  
oddly spirited,

And Lincoln, growing old,  
was placed on coins,  
enshrined in brooding stone  
for all to see and know.

And speakers came  
and went, the tanks  
went on parade,  
and progress dreams  
were sung, and listen, listen,  
you there, listen,  
but don't listen for too long,

because too many have got stuck there  
and we may have got it wrong.

---

Wrong and wrong and wrong.  
Must we go back to 1619?

Cease your wailing, History!  
That brutal, trifling song!

---

If back we go, then back,  
but all the way,  
past slaves and ships  
to Milton, Christ, and Socrates,  
as Lincoln surely knew.

And History, sweet Dame,  
it's true, we cannot quarrel long,

But oh, your song, your song!  
it will need rearranging before long.

## Tradition

*25 September 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/09/tradition/>*

I think the future  
does not belong to the past,  
and things are passing,  
present and future.

I think things will not last;  
though nothing does,  
those less than most  
which grow from baseless ground,

things passing all around,  
and we do well to grasp  
for any which are present,  
future or past,

those most the old things  
which are known to last.



## **Sara**

*05 October 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/10/sara/>*

It was the flowers,  
yes, you know,

those, in your hair.

It has been a long time  
since I was carried away.

Have you come to show me how?

## Kindling

*13 October 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/10/kindling/>*

If sparks are not enough,  
it will take flame,

but all the same,

one must go gently  
into heat,

and mind the game.

## **What it is**

*19 October 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/10/what-it-is/>*

I think She grows  
like a flower of wind,  
and fades with time.

## **The Great Motion**

*25 October 2019*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2019/10/the-great-motion/>*

Love is not it all, she said.  
He smiled. It had been some time  
since last they spoke,

and when he awoke  
the morning seemed like fire,  
bright with dreams and smoke.

What song was in the breeze!  
And every sneeze, a new commandment  
to be free,  
and be at peace.

Oh, dream once more, cold world, old world.  
There are still so many suns.

## Homecoming

22 April 2020

<https://poems.culturing.net/2020/04/homecoming/>

*Awaking comes in turns,  
the day is bright before it burns.*

I walk down streets I never knew.  
They are familiar, but I, the knower, have changed.  
I did not know what little I knew.  
Maybe this is what poets mean by recurrence,  
why they return so often to the same things.  
I did not know the familiar streets  
because I, the knower, had not yet been changed.  
But what can bring such a change?  
An encounter, a question, another knower?  
To know is to be known and vice versa.  
This means the streets must know me,  
and where the streets have no names  
there is nothing to know.  
But this is all begging the question,  
why knowledge?  
Because I, the knower, have not yet been changed.  
Maybe this is why poets recur and recur.  
If change comes it comes only for now, not forever,  
and so I walk down streets I never knew,  
the same streets, but I, the knower, have changed,  
and so have they.

## The Enduring and Unchanging Dao

14 September 2020

<https://poems.culturing.net/2020/09/the-enduring-and-unchanging-dao/>

People die, new people are born.  
The timbre of civilization changes,  
like always, and we, those merely progenitors,  
progenerate, again, at the horn.

What beast,  
what rough or otherwise, comes forth  
to taste the light of day?

This surely is no newer way  
than all the old ways,  
dying, dead, or buried.

So what special hurry?

Those come forth go under,  
this is so, and temple shrouds,  
once rent asunder, can be made,  
remade, again, again.

If vanity, then vanity.  
The proposition's chord  
strikes hard, and oh,  
we grow so bored.

What light from yonder room?

'Tis Juliet? Nay, knave,  
just one once loved  
in some forgotten tongue.

I say be such  
that every longing touch  
*remembers* love,

But do step cautiously  
through darkened rooms,  
and listen for that horn.

## Heidegger in Japan

07 January 2021

<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/01/heidegger-in-japan/>

*For John Rawls*

What a journey,  
eastward  
to a land no less  
devoted to its nothingness  
than Martin's own,

and yet one prone  
to wholeness nonetheless.

How much to learn,  
to see,  
and maybe dream  
on long-abandoned beaches  
near the silent sea.

Old Martin,  
having conquered Europe,  
set his sights on Asia,  
found himself there, conquered,  
none the wiser,

Then returning to a Europe  
plain and bright, devout  
but dour in appearance  
as in mind,

what did he hope to find?

No more the plainly spoken  
One, to rule us all, no more!

But maybe  
some forgiveness  
for us, mortals after all.

## Planting Time

*14 February 2021*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/02/planting-time/>*

In the spring time of the year,  
as dawn rises, dusty, over the fields,  
I wait, anxious, with my plow.

It has come again, the time for planting,  
but this crop is strange to me.  
The soil is like all soil, firm but supple,  
and I am like all planters,  
firm but supple.

Tomorrow rains will come,  
and old seed wash away  
as new seed takes its root,

And who will then be standing here  
in planters' shoes  
to cast a growing shadow?

I hope one who knows a little,  
treads with greater care.

For people in the village,  
I plant days and years

And see strange fruit come harvest time.  
I wait for what will grow.



## Chrysalis

05 March 2021

<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/03/chrysalis/>

I sit quiet,  
fetal in the void

and what light  
comes?

Is it the East?  
No, not the East.

It is like morning  
after many nights,

and I awake at dawn,  
perform my miracles.

This morning (oh what morning),  
is it ever to be believed?

Yes,  
though not for long,

because eclipse will come  
in soon to snuff it out.

And yet still now  
this moment, stay with me,

and we will have  
our chrysalis  
in time to speak of things.

## Flowering

*01 April 2021*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/04/flowering/>*

This shall be my flowering  
And this my flowing forward

As of yeasaying  
As of naysaying

Thus my buds  
(what are the buds?)  
come forth

I have these leaves bunched up within me  
I must set them free

## The wind in the leaves

*13 April 2021*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/04/the-wind-in-the-leaves/>*

Thunders crash,  
The wind moves through the leaves,

The paths grow walls,  
curve into cages,

Thunder asks,  
A certain volume of man,  
suffices?

No, it never suffices,

Always more  
past overflowing

Thunder crashes,  
Floods tear down the trees,

The wind moves through the leaves,  
A certain volume of man,  
so certain

Thunder, why  
O thunder

move through wind and leaves.

## All the Tender Pathos

20 April 2021

<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/04/all-the-tender-pathos/>

*Every human heart is human*

Longfellow, Hiawatha

Remember how the river moves,  
Remember warm embracing,  
Bring them here, to this steel jungle,

And know love.  
Put down thy burden.

Remember once the wigwam,  
Old coyote and the moon.  
Relive the sorrow,

Breathe the pain.  
Put down thy burden.

See the colored faces,  
Out of place in this steel jungle,  
Housed in spite of fear and hatred,

See them here.  
Put down thy burden.

Know the pain of ages,  
Know the sorrow of the moon,  
The midnight moon that every age sees,

Warmed by tears.  
Put down thy burden.

Dream as one soul dreaming,  
Move toward the common dream,  
And in the moonlight,

Build a home.  
Put down thy burden.

Wait for dawn, and as she rises  
Greet her with her own surprises,  
As a people wildly singing

In the river's cool disguises.  
Thus forget thy burden.

Hear the coursing river,  
Hear it coursing, hear it roaring  
On its journey to the ocean,

And be human.  
Leave behind thy burden,  
Leave behind thy burden.

## **An Example**

*28 April 2021*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/04/an-example/>*

I pause before the church  
and wonder,

here is an example  
of the best that man can do.

That's not to say  
that this one way  
will do,

but here is one example.

There are others,  
have been others,  
will be others, sure.

But here is one example  
of the best that man can do.

## The Shroud

*01 May 2021*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/05/the-shroud/>

What is this  
thin whisp,

this blow of steam,  
this flop of paper

streaming by you,

is it all of us?

I think it is  
the unmixed soup of dreams,

the shroud of temples  
not yet built.

Tomorrow, tomorrow, tomorrow  
begins again, as always,

but be better for it.

## Power

07 May 2021

<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/05/power/>

Power brings its many blessings,  
Though it comes by other names.  
This is what we find by singing.

Days were young and love did sting us.  
All young people feel the same.  
They mix themselves with power's blessings.

Some find laurels, others cling  
To lovely children's games.  
Thus they lose themselves in singing.

Thus they fall before the morning,  
Thus they are to blame.  
But power brings at most mixed blessings,

Power puts off dark of dying,  
Power's light must wane.  
Therefore, find thyself in singing,

Make thine own some other name,  
And know I feel the same,  
Because this power mixes life with blessings.  
This is what we find by singing.



## Terror Remembered

09 May 2021

<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/05/terror-remembered/>

I.

*To make us love our country, our country ought to be lovely.*

Edmund Burke, *Reflections on the Revolution in France*

We who have known terror must know love,  
from the hearts of those who died and killed,  
from the souls they willed to live,  
and from the dreams that spilled  
on every bloodstained street  
while we with banners blazing terror  
forgot love.

We must know of love  
if we are ever to forgive ourselves,  
or ever to again lift up those banners  
which to many once meant hope,  
and still mean something (this, here, now,  
is where old plants become new soil)  
and with this toil we must know love,  
this loving toil of generations,  
for the burden never lessens  
but the joy arrives with spring.

We who know of terror  
must plant love in fields  
once sown with mortal error,  
and if joy comes in the morning  
it will shock us,  
but we must not let it stop us.

Joy is the reminder  
that all things, from nothing, journey thence,  
and we who have known terror  
must know joyful toiling love.

Enough of burning buildings,  
and enough of bloody deserts.

We know love.  
We will not live for less again.

II.

*But power, of some kind or other, will survive the shock in which  
manners and opinions perish, and it will find other and worse  
means for its support.*

Edmund Burke, *Reflections on the Revolution in France*

Burke  
We live here, slowly,  
on these ashes.

What can grow here?

One wonders  
how much Abu Ghraib remains,  
how much the screams have done their work  
and keep on working,

But one never wonders,  
oh my soul,  
that life goes on.

That is for another place and time,  
across some ocean,  
on some barren rock  
where men and what remains  
are left to speculation.

You and I live here,  
and we must grow things from these ashes,  
if not only to have grown them,  
but because we otherwise  
must fear what grows unhindered.

So kill the weeds,  
the poison leaves,  
the ash-plants, naked, dancing on the hill,

and scatter seeds  
for fruit and flower,  
pleasing sights,  
yet good for food.

Remember this place, though, child.  
and do not dwell here for too long.

III.

*The usurpation...will hold power by arts similar to those by which it  
has acquired it.*

Edmund Burke, *Reflections on the Revolution in France*

Burke  
Terror is terrible,  
on this we agree,

But why have we been terrible?

Perhaps it is the proximity of conflict,  
the inevitable germination  
on both sides.

Or was it usurpation?

Or just another slough  
of body becoming body?

We are not like the stars,  
we are too wet,

And we must find within ourselves,  
that something, turning,

that holds them apart.

## **All past times are terrible**

*28 May 2021*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/05/all-past-times-are-terrible/>*

All past times are terrible  
to those who look back now,

Just like future times are hazy  
to those gazing forward now.

Only now is real,  
and now alone deserves the seal  
of approbation,

For each solid nation  
breaks when stretched too far.

## Predication

30 June 2021

<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/06/predication/>

Day turns into day. Each fades.  
All things become another.

But can this always be so,  
or does *this* change?

What use is predication?

This is true, not that, for now,  
and who can know another?

Therefore say it is true,  
if not for me, say it for you.

## Old House

09 July 2021

<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/07/old-house/>

I walk down old avenues,  
aware again of impermanence,  
perennial friend of the weary,  
and stop before the family house.

What otherworldly dominion is this,  
where manflesh met with womanflesh  
to make *me*?

Yet other worlds must be,  
or else our high anxiety  
is treason of another kind.

It asks us, whence these beams,  
this wood, this angled frame  
with memories of forest?

What cold river brought us here?  
If not the Thames, the Mississippi?  
Say the Susquehanna, rolling slow.

And yet, don't answer.  
Let me linger here, and grieve,  
until our waters are surpassed.

Old house made new,  
another world's anxieties  
are haunting you.

## Think Again

*09 September 2021*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/09/think-again/>*

The beginning of another day,  
this one not unlike the last,  
and yet as though some child  
forgets the form,  
it differs.

Up upon a hill,  
the sheep go wandering.

Nearby cars zoom thoroughly  
over the highway.

Not a few sheep find themselves  
in drivers' seats  
at eighty miles-an-hour.

Would they not prefer to graze  
on some unfettered hillside,  
near the setting sun?

They are still sheep,  
though silly ones.

I think that they should think again.  
The hillside is still there,  
though it has changed.

It grows less full,  
but some say  
this is part of its purpose.

The cars must make their noise  
where wandering sheep once spoke  
of pleasing vistas, unknown springs.

## Wandering Sheep

*09 September 2021*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/09/wandering-sheep/>*

Up upon a hill,  
the sheep go wandering.

Nearby cars zoom thoroughly  
over the highway.

Not a few sheep find themselves  
in drivers' seats  
at eighty miles-an-hour.

Would they not prefer to graze  
on some unfettered hillside,  
near the setting sun?

They are still sheep,  
though silly ones.

I think that they should think again.  
The hillside is still there.  
It has not changed.

It grows less full,  
but some say  
this is part of its purpose.

The cars make terrible noise  
where wandering sheep once spoke  
of pleasing vistas, unknown springs.



## Making Sausage

*13 September 2021*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/09/making-sausage/>*

The bird has a story.  
It sounds like a song.  
But I wouldn't worry.  
He wouldn't sing long.

The people are coming.  
They haven't a care.  
The people are stunning.  
The bird wouldn't dare.

The people make sausage.  
What else could they do?  
Their story is ugly,  
But this much is true:

The bird has to learn how to live with clipped wings.  
Indeed, this may be why he sings.

## Lost Forest

*28 October 2021*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/10/lost-forest/>*

The bulldozers are out today,  
are blazing in what once was forest.

I was in this forest  
as a child.

Do the workers know  
the sound of crickets here  
within leaves, the sound  
of song that matches oversong?

I am not sentimental,  
for I know it to be earth  
becoming earth,  
and yet I wonder what earth is,

Because the poets ask, and keep on asking,  
though they cannot answer,  
for we find the question worthy.

Something in the wind  
this time of year  
must stir uncertainty.

What shall we ask the bulldozer?  
What does it know?

## Shattered Image, Fallen Breast

*01 November 2021*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/11/shattered-image-fallen-breast/>

At midnight in the basement  
of a museum, some forgotten grotto  
deep in Mediterranean soil,

I walked slow and silent,  
deep in thought,

When lo! the image of a woman,  
be it Aphrodite, Juno,  
or some other, rose before me.

I came to her side  
and noticed lying at her feet  
a fallen breast of stone,  
hers surely, lying prone,  
as though some vandal strove  
to make her pure.

I put it back where it belongs,  
and held it there,  
until her firmness made me sure,

But sure of what,  
I do not know.

I thought I could discern  
the faintest sigh,  
but only she would know  
who fills the mind with wonder,

so I wondered  
if the earth could be her home,  
or if she comes from some far-whispered plane  
that only makers know.

## **Love is made**

*07 November 2021*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/11/love-is-made/>*

Love is made,  
not found,

and if this making  
is to succeed,

it must know  
where it is going  
and whence it comes.

I ask you,  
hoping you will know.

## Beyond Power

*10 November 2021*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/11/beyond-power/>*

If Nietzsche were asked,  
"Why power?"

He might reply,  
"We grow helpless."

But humans  
have always been helpless,  
are helpless  
for decades at least,  
and even then will need food.

What purpose has power,  
if not to supply  
our infirmities?

Oh, but how free we would be,  
to be free, very free!

To not be born of woman,  
no more of a people  
in time and place.

I beg you, dear reader,  
be cautious, and do not embark  
on a journey that ends in death.

## Phenomenology of Science

*25 December 2021*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2021/12/phemonology-of-science/>*

From Hegel's brain  
thou, spluttering,  
spreadst thy wings.

Thou art one more  
mythology,  
nothing more.

Thou cannot transcend  
culture, or fly  
as Zeitgeist.

No, thy thinking is  
primitive, alas,  
just like thy body.

So give up the geist.  
Make way for some new  
mode of knowing,

Or rather, some old,  
deep-rooted thought, the kind  
you were made to destroy.

## Words

*24 January 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/01/words/>*

The words tumble  
down, jumbled,  
stumble over  
bumps and rumble  
into town, past  
rows of corn that  
wonder at the world.

I wonder what the world means.

Someone asks me why I choose these words.  
I think these words chose me.

And when they ask directions,  
well, I think if words are lost,  
then I must find them.

I must guide them.

## Phalanx of Mind

07 March 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/03/phalanx-of-mind/>

Those Reformers,  
in order to flee from imperium,  
fell for an earlier vice:

That phalanx of mind  
wherein each must stay sturdy or die.

But our world is better  
equipped for peace.

Though the devil in man  
never sleeps.

Oi! must I now know my neighbor?  
And how can I, knowing him, sleep?

But were he restrained  
by imperium, phalanx, or rights,  
love could be,  
but alas, he is free.

Therefore,  
what will he make of me?



## Who is in charge here

*08 March 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/03/who-is-in-charge-here/>*

I think I shall spend  
the rest of my life  
searching  
for who is in charge here,

so that I may ask them  
where they have been.

## **Saving Earth**

*23 March 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/03/saving-earth/>*

We have taken lightning captive,  
we have made the sky our slave  
on our relentless quest for vengeance  
on an Earth we cannot save.

If all is lost, then songs  
cannot be sung, and yet  
this song goes on, so all  
must still be found somehow.

If we cannot save Earth,  
can Earth save us?  
Or is it not a matter  
of saving, but of trust?

## After Reagan

*03 April 2022*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/04/after-reagan/>

We have been pre-sliced  
individually, wrapped in money.

But oh, he was funny, well-spoken, and phony.  
A pity so few will remember  
the lens of that time,  
or look through it to see  
what might be.

Are we free?

I have heard so much talk about liberty,  
so little wondering,  
"what does that mean?"  
that I wonder,  
is Freedom for me?

And does Freedom need me?

## Things Themselves

03 April 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/04/things-themselves/>

Until I met a woman,  
and her presence strengthened me,  
I did not know that God lives  
not in books, as Calvin claims,  
but in the world of things themselves.

What mystery lies here  
remains to nourish those who care  
to take the secret that is there  
into a home, and let it steer  
the very lives of things themselves.

But can we dwell among  
the secret song, the hidden call  
of Earth's long fall for the abyss?  
We have our churches.  
Are they tombs for things themselves?

I think we have to think this through,  
for God has been a long time dying,  
though he rises from the dead,  
and he is not the only one.  
We know this too of things themselves.

## Technology

*12 April 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/04/technology/>*

The Word  
became machines  
and dwelt among us.

## The Winds of Change

*12 April 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/04/the-winds-of-change/>*

I listen for the winds of change,  
but hear so many sirens blare.  
They tell me it's under control.

Control is such a forceful word,  
so I just stand here unaware.  
I listen for the winds of change,

Which bring me scents of other places  
and, I hope, will take me where  
they tell me it's under control.

But now as children age,  
so too a people ages and grows bare.  
I listen for the winds of change

And see my people, scared.  
I wonder what could make them whole.  
So I just listen to the winds of change,  
and let *them* have control.

## Far Away

21 April 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/04/far-away/>

There's someone powerful far away,  
our voices and our stories claim.  
I can't hear what they have to say.

This power haunts us, still in sway,  
and in submitting we grow lame.  
There's someone powerful far away,

And he insists, so we obey,  
with voices tuned, though not the same.  
I can't hear what they have to say.

And why obey? All power fades,  
as every dying day explains.  
There *must* be powers far away,

And yet, away they stay,  
As if we *here* must give things names.  
Alas, if there be powers far away,  
what do they have to say?

## Unauthorized thinking

30 April 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/04/unauthorized-thinking/>

*You'd make me laugh if it wasn't forbidden.*

Beckett, *Waiting for Godot*

So I've discovered Plotinus.  
Have you never heard?  
He has shaped your own words.

He is waiting to meet us,  
but don't be absurd.  
He would never disturb

Your most serious dogmas,  
for me put them there.  
What a curious bird.

---

All I want  
is mystical union  
with the Absolute --

is that too much to ask?

---

Augustine doles out freely  
fruits of Temple and Academy  
with no thought  
for the plants on which they grow.



## Electricity

02 May 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/05/electricity/>

The wires, I think,  
house an evil god.

I hear him questioning *physis*,  
doubting that all life lives  
of its own volition,

and claiming, instead, for himself,  
the sole governorship  
of all things.

He who can read the signs  
has now not even  
the comfort of solitude,

given this god's omnipresence.

I wonder how long it will be  
before happens some shocking conclusion.

## Streets I Never Knew

*04 May 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/05/streets-i-never-knew/>*

I walk,  
and keep on walking.

When I am old,  
will any of what I have seen  
be left standing? Or will it  
be rubble or, worse still, vapor?  
But is that not always  
the fate of life, to vanish?  
I doubt we could make it permanent,  
given that all things are not,  
and yet where does it end?  
In the place it began,

So I walk,  
and I keep on walking.

## What calls for poetry?

*31 May 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/05/what-calls-for-poetry/>*

She does,  
the one  
whose voice you know.

## Let Go

06 June 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/06/let-go/>

Wandering, questioning,  
as before Dawn,  
I am *sure* of this much:  
that we hold our beliefs  
far too tightly.

---

I think back,  
I think back,  
I think back,  
but hear only more riveting.

Rosie, poor Rosie,  
no place for a woman here.

---

What is the *other* beginning,  
the one without steel-plated Mind,  
where things grow as we all know they do?

In the mountains,  
I hear baby truths being born.

---

Begin *here*. Nowhere else.  
This is where you were born and will die.

---

A rowdy patron observes: "You had to be there!"  
I think this is rather apt, and tell him so,  
but what more could I tell him?  
He knows what it is to know.

## Science and Technology

*14 June 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/06/science-and-technology/>*

I would like to see  
science and technology,  
like religion, kept separate  
from government  
and the lives of regular people,  
who cannot understand  
the implications, the power,  
the ideas embedded therein,  
and are harmed,  
who cannot make themselves  
from steel, let alone make their world,  
and who must let things be.  
This means letting them fade.  
It's true, science has parts to play,  
small ones, since stems  
without roots surely wither,  
but the point is to till the new soil  
'til the new crop comes in.

## Fading Feeling

18 June 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/06/fading-feeling/>

In our peculiar way,  
we were always ones  
striving for form, and by form  
we meant something enduring,  
unchanging, but how much upheaval  
and violence it took to learn  
how now this striving must change.

For Helen's sake, let us remember  
the ways of our fathers,  
sea-tossed as they always were,  
reaching from darkness  
like tentacles on Ocean's floor.

We are like them now, and must be,  
having seen once for all  
the formation of cracks  
in the old Greek edifice,

And thus we must not always be,  
knowing full well that not every Greek  
bearing gifts can be trusted, but also that  
we are not trustworthy either, so long as  
we think with stiff minds, and that after all  
this is what Plato meant. But in our peculiar  
Greek way we are stiff like ones trained for a phalanx,  
though soft and bourgeois enough,  
not fitting in with ourselves, and not really  
belonging here either, no better than anywhere--

Thus we must not always be,  
we must fade, like a breeze on a soft summer night,  
or the call of an eagle near mountains,  
and make some new way for the feeling to come.

## Light

19 June 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/06/light/>

At a red light,  
when there is no cross-traffic,  
a silence deepens  
like the space between man and God.

How stupid it feels,  
to wait for nothing.

According to some theologians,  
God occupies space *above* beings,  
and waits for us there,  
as the father of light.

But I prefer when the light changes  
and things keep moving.

## Mulch by the Scoop

21 June 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/06/mulch-by-the-scoop/>

I am living in the country again,  
back after a long sleep,  
and I wonder (at times like this)  
what that highway is doing here,  
near to the place that sells mulch by the scoop.  
It is part of the landscape now  
(we forget but have signs to remind us)  
though we don't embrace it  
where we are all cow, horse, and buggy.  
But do we, too, not love machines and their progress?  
We use them to market our mulch by the scoop  
and to haul it and bring it home,  
and to heat those homes and to light them  
and to plug in to our wider world.  
Yet mulch by the scoop *enchants* us  
with the call of the earth and convenience,  
the call of abundance and freedom from pain.  
I have known of no earth like this,  
unless broadcast by LED lights on a neon sign,  
yet my heart knows these things must remain.  
We are proffering mulch by the scoop.  
Will you come over highways and see?



## Myth at Twilight

*23 June 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/06/myth-at-twilight/>*

Will we ever  
be free of the myth  
of some craftsman in the sky  
wreaking form over all that must shudder?

I shudder to think it,  
but over with the rising sun,  
I see others who do not think it.

## Lyceum

28 June 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/06/lyceum/>

Aristotle and friends walking amiably  
over a concourse of trees  
discuss beings, assert that no thing  
can both be and not be.  
In the next room the Christians,  
grown weary of faith, re-learn logic  
but treat it like faith. Thus the Schoolmen  
indogmatify plausible maxims,  
sit firm and erect in the shade of Lyceum.  
Aquinas the only true thinker mourns moanfully.  
Science emerges, a novum organon,  
a new quest to find what things are,  
but old faith, an old cast of mind.  
The old school now an archeological find,  
remains buried, its questions once answered for all.  
But the Germans are not quite convinced,  
keep on asking why we are not free  
to defy and to blur. After all,  
we are protean beings, and know the old stories well.  
But what course still remains for those  
bred by the ruins of Lyceum?  
One looking over the shoulder  
to Greek or Medieval or Modern models?  
Or one looking forward, which has travelled back,  
with a prayer of thanksgiving, a new apprehension  
for what every thought must lack?

---

In the East Room, Dionysians revel  
agnostically, thrilled to find God  
scarcely knowable, free from the Categories at last,  
but what darkness stirs, waiting to pounce  
on those not yet prepared for the mysteries?

## Virgin Queens

*28 June 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/06/virgin-queens/>*

Nobody can hurt a man more than his wife,  
except maybe his mother. They simply  
have more opportunity, knowing  
where all of the pain points are, because they,  
on good days, massage there. That is  
one kind of love, but another is  
taking in stride all the pain dealt  
by mother and wife, so that all can belong.  
After all, only suffering brings us together,  
as all women know. They require it.  
I've come to remind you of this, so that you,  
unlike many, avoid the allure of false dreams,  
which would make virgin queens out of maidens.

## Belly of the Whale

11 July 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/07/belly-of-the-whale/>

Consumed by the fool's errand of making life painless,  
we could never be bothered to think  
along lines that were not predetermined,  
defined by the will of the faceless consumers  
like us, who ran everything. Speechless,  
we floundered through chaos and form,  
but from time to time one had to wonder  
what all of it meant, else succumb  
to the roar of consumption  
enduring through slogans and signs  
and most firmly in minds made of mud  
baked like stone. I was never a part of this,  
never aligned with the spineless  
who bear no weight, who will crack under any demand,  
for demanding betrays their life's purpose.

Again, these are errands for fools, but of course  
fools speak louder than thinkers and rule all  
but auspicious places, those private lands  
governed by men who will tolerate no more,  
who instead choose to stretch themselves out before knowing  
and learn what the gods have in store.

The beatings continue, morale doesn't care,  
and one wonders how punishment ever was thought  
to cure suffering, or how anyone stands it.  
But stand it they do, if they must.  
Deeper silence where agony once named a people.  
How now to take heart and oppose this new ocean of troubles,  
or else turn to brooding for future's sake?

I sing from the belly of the whale,  
which pursues its perfection for all,  
which leaves open no quarter for others,  
which swallows each culture in all,  
which cares nothing for time past or future,  
whose whiteness is barely a memory,  
whose grayness is given by all.

With the hour both hidden and late,  
I cry out for the sea-foam to hear me.

## Emerge

11 July 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/07/emerge/>

In America, we know God  
changes his mind. We oblige him  
with all of our talk about time  
and Democracy. Where, after all,  
does one find something permanent.  
Surely not here, where we bind  
ourselves freely to change, and await  
the next Mind, with its talk  
about how all is fine.  
But ennui is outdated, and we  
feel confined by ourselves  
and our origins, soaking with brine,  
emerge fresh from the foam to remind us  
how we know God changes his mind.

## Liberty and Justice

11 July 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/07/liberty-and-justice/>

Someone should tell New England  
that God has not made up his mind  
about how to best organize life,  
nor should we, being free.  
But why freedom? What do we achieve  
in that ecstasy known by frontiersman,  
and by them alone? The achievement  
is justice, though fleeting it be,  
and it is not your grandfather's justice.  
Then liberty, justice, and us here and now,  
in the swirling of time, decide once and for all  
(not for long) how life *is*, what it *is*,  
and shall be. But how *free* shall we be?  
Free enough to revisit these questions  
posed back at the start, and all answers so far,  
with an eye to revision, but not revolution,  
assuming no violence is warranted, knowing  
that violence can never be totally barred,  
for it comes from a failure to question in depth  
and in time. So let's question. Thoreau  
may have been on to something, and so we may be,  
if we ask ever deeper what meaning dwells here,  
where we are. What is Liberty? Why it *and* Justice?  
Could either *be* without the other?

## Near Mountains

*11 July 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/07/near-mountains/>*

When I consider the electrical wires,  
the works of our hands, and when I consider  
the cars, and the buildings made of steel,  
I ask, what is God that we are mindful of him?

You will think I am being facetious,  
but surely these things are our gods.

How have we gone astray? Is it maybe  
that no one is driving the ship, that our voyage,  
once rudderless, must now be captained?  
Or is it that someone *is* driving, and driving badly,  
and therefore the crew must resist?  
Or is it that both have been tried and retried,  
such that now we no longer know which to try?

I suggest thinking harder, and longer,  
in some place more tranquil, near mountains.



## Who are they?

11 July 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/07/who-are-they/>

They have built all our highways.  
They change how we think.  
They've invented vaccines.  
But who are they?

They've improved understanding.  
They've conquered the moon.  
They're enlisting our help.  
But who are they?

They speak in equations.  
They think like machines, and  
They dream of control.  
But who are they?

## Beatific Visions

16 July 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/07/beatific-visions/>

I doubt those people on television  
realize they're dressed like angels,  
calling us back to a realm we reject,  
and I think it's a bit out of place  
to put these hopes in masters of commerce,  
when such hopes are sky-born or nothing.  
What see we in movie stars anyway?  
Billboards, book covers, and internet ads  
still elicit our peasant repentance.  
What for? For not being divine enough,  
same as before, and yet let me explain:  
none are holy. You're made it this far,  
you must know that by now.

It's amazing, isn't it, just how much  
*thought* there has been about everything.

Thereby I wander, but what does it mean  
to be *lost* in a *place* that is lost?  
It means everything. Stand here with me  
and observe that at last  
all the cracks in the firmament  
outline a God-shaped hole.

We are ready for solid food,  
culled from earth,  
even that which comes only through violence.

## Reasonable Measure

16 July 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/07/reasonable-measure/>

At the end of life's journey  
I awoke, not aware yet  
of where my road had taken me,  
but brightness lit my mind up  
like a flame. I'll never be the same.  
Discursive Reason failed us. Here we wait  
for some new measure to make chaos  
something straight, without demanding  
that it wear the guise of form.  
I beg to differ, if by differing  
I bring new thoughts to table,  
and as far as I am able,  
guide our way. But beggars all  
would trade their place for one  
in heaven, yet to me that path is barred,  
so I use reason in new ways,  
feet deep in earth, head free of daemons,  
closing in on what it means to be here now,  
where I awoke, at journey's end.

Across the sea, I glimpse an image,  
be it shade or beast or otherwise,  
I only know its visage.  
But it calls me with its message,  
like a work of human craft.  
I say, deception is insidious.  
I tell this lonesome image  
to release my gaze to this shore,  
where I make my only home.

But what home is, I cannot say,  
nor can this homely image tell me.

## Socrates and Confucius

16 July 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/07/socrates-and-confucius/>

In Persia, some say the great thinkers  
once met on a precursor to the Silk Road.  
They discussed how things change and how some  
stay the same, legend has it, but most they discussed  
how beginnings occur, both well-versed in this,  
one saying History, the other Rationality.  
Neither equipped to dissemble his equal,  
they talked after dark, in the desert  
where lately Zarathustra laid waste to the mind.  
Who can say now what echoes remain there,  
or which will endure?

## Theodicy

16 July 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/07/theodicy/>

The Nazis proved that God's law  
can be violated with impunity  
for a time. It was, after all, America  
who stopped them. God was mute.  
And if there still be any who would claim  
that Auschwitz fits some higher plan,  
I say I do not wish to serve such Planning  
or a God who makes such plans.  
With this, I often wonder  
if Herr Hitler has his final laugh,  
for though, of course, we beat them,  
one long draught of their Nepenthe  
has us losing our identity.  
They *proved* that God is silent  
in the midst of desperate anguish.  
Who believes now that he listens?  
Do the screams not matter much  
to his big mind? But let us alter here,  
and ask God what he is. We may be wrong  
without discarding years of questions. We may ask  
without demanding certain answers. We may think  
without deciding in advance. Must God use reason? Why?

*21 July 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/07/a-platonist-declares/>*

A Platonist declares that all is Soul,  
but now we doubt it. Rather, we believe  
in clocks that wind themselves, and Nature too.  
But what makes Nature go? We'd love to know,  
but still we don't. Though answers sometimes  
run their course, some questions last forever.  
But has no one noticed Plato's chosen mode?  
In discourse questions outrank answers  
two to one. So when a Platonist declares  
on any subject, greet him with a question,  
see how well he knows his master's teaching.  
Yet let's not discard a theory for a worse one.  
Ask, who makes the clock? Not I. And then ask: Why?

## Industrial Man

21 July 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/07/industrial-man/>

When I survey Industrial Man  
in his anxious glory, his endless  
competitiveness, I still doubt  
that his station is final,  
that any part of his nature is fixed.  
If by now one knows not to assume  
that the spectre of Progress can save us,  
perhaps we can doubt, too, its wrath,  
which still animates workers,  
machine-like and futile,  
in cities all over the world.  
You have heard this before,  
but my question is different.  
It grows from a deeper uncertainty.  
Reason defies observation. The chaos  
is plain, and our planning has ended  
in time. So the wrath can be doubted,  
the wrath of the godless mind-in-the-sky  
who defies observation, whose wrath  
is our animus, naked and pure,  
like the God of before, without love,  
but that wrath drives its heart I am sure.

There is something uncanny about reality,  
sitting out there in the ether,  
like a renegade neighbor,  
the kind that can never be trusted.  
Reality, too, can surprise  
even those with the best educations.  
I wonder what more it will say,  
once the moss has grown over broken traffic lights  
and deer play through shattered parking lots.  
It likes these places best, because less  
resists it there. Even here, where traffic flows,  
I can hear it call like the sound  
of bird-shot through tin, the eccentric neighbor  
readying himself for adventure.

The machines never sleep, nor do we,  
being imitators of our environment,  
and somehow we have to compete,  
feeling threatened by gadgets  
that do it all better than we can,  
and so we assert our own dominance  
whenever we can. Apes that shove  
one another to the mud, the slow  
endless endeavor to be king of the hill,  
on a hill now maintained by machines  
bred by science in underground labs...  
Why is there no more *sunshine* here,  
in our minds, where in earlier times  
gentle breezes brought birdsong to bear  
on a plant's slow endeavor to blossom?



## The New Frontier

02 August 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/08/the-new-frontier/>

*It is and it is not, and, therefore, is.*

Wallace Stevens, *A Primitive Like an Orb*

What have we learned in seventy years?  
What are the lessons of that war  
which lately ripped both Europe and Asia  
to pieces, that broke our faith, but left us here?  
If God is dead, what takes his place?  
Or must the place itself change, into  
something open, free for exploration, undefined?  
It is, is not, and therefore is,  
just like ourselves, our lives, and our surrounding aura.  
Who would dare to pin things down again?  
Yet how could beasts like us survive  
without restraint and limitation?  
We have known the pain of man and his machines  
on heaven's throne, have suffered Cromwell's vengeful reign  
for nigh four centuries. This war (the one succeeding,  
recall, the one to end all wars) is but the climax  
of the heavenly interregnum. But what *person*  
dares to sit on such a throne again?  
Are we so human? Human still, despite our deepest cravings,  
loyal subjects to an absent king. Why can't we let God rest in peace?  
We hear the wind disturb the leaves, those covering his grave.  
It's us, the ones you chose to save,  
and then abandoned to the formless blur,  
which is, is not, and therefore is.  
Let's on with it, then, to the new frontier,  
where our longings are answered more plainly  
and with less fear.

## **Craftsman**

*20 August 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/08/craftsman/>*

The craftsman in this body  
(not the one above the stars)  
devised this poem. Would you know him?

*20 August 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/08/on-this-rock/>*

On this rock,  
I have placed my insignia,  
placed it where all can see,  
as a warning against what has been  
and an omen of what must still be.

On this rock,  
I explain my old purpose  
in words not yet known to most people,  
to teach and explain what we're doing here,  
lost as we are on Promethean shores.

## Aletheian

*31 August 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/08/aletheian/>*

Some do not wish to join the project of empire,  
even after all these years. I shall call them  
Aletheian, to distinguish them from Roman soldiers  
eager for command. They rather seek what's hidden  
in the inner world of things, a world forgotten  
in the mad rush for imperium. But be things as they may,  
these few are hidden, too, unnoticed in the roaring crowd,  
the crowd as blind as ever, and no less so for their service.  
Oh, the Aletheians have endeavors too, like maybe breaking through  
the cycle of hereditary bullying, which, for Caesar,  
would make servants of us all. But serving whom?  
But more than this, these simply watch for signs,  
believing that a god, or something, speaks  
and can be heard. I like this last pursuit  
a little, and much more than I like empire.  
I think I am just half an Aletheian, and part Roman,  
but would like to be much more. I dare say you,  
dear reader, many years from now, shall be much more.

## At Sea

31 August 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/08/at-sea/>

Once in awhile, despite expectations,  
you run into someone who knows what they're doing.  
Surprising in times like this, but then  
also familiar, as if in response to a call  
that you heard all along. It won't last,  
but for that moment you'll know what it means  
to be human. For that moment, all small  
uncertainties crystallize into a sculpture of rain,  
the most precious made permanent at last.  
But time chips at it, wears it away  
like a vandal, adolescent, without shame.  
You thought maybe it could be like before,  
when the stars spelled out stories of heroes  
and mankind obeyed and endured, but time  
had other plans. And then slowly a new thought  
emerged, not quite visible, but certainly there  
like a ship in the fog or an iceberg or  
some other sculpture. You thought, is this mine  
or must I wait for another? It has been  
so long since the last one, you thought of  
absconding whatever the terms. But this  
is not your ship, not your voyage. Your journey  
is here, where you are, on this ground.  
I had better remind you that ships come  
more often now, maybe the old way of choosing  
won't do, or at least, won't suffice.  
I must know where I stand, on the prow  
or on land, but in either case, these legs will do.  
So will yours. On the ship, watch the seamen  
so proud and hearty, assured of their  
artificial discipline. Of course this is mastery,  
of course this is justice, of course, of course.  
But the course is precisely neglected, already decided,  
not open to question. On land there are always  
new flowers. Who we are is never so certain.  
I like the land better, although I think men  
do learn something at sea, to tame chaos,

a Faustian bargain if chaos is in us,  
if taken too far, but a call from the sky  
to those drowning in worlds without form.

## Feet of Rain

*31 August 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/08/feet-of-rain/>*

You learn the way but the way changes.  
You walk with feet of rain.  
You fear the changing more than the storm.  
You sink while looking down.

That is one way of doing it,  
but others press in from all sides,  
demanding a show. You hesitate,  
not being a dancer, not being  
at all. The way is through the rain.  
You think you have heard this before,  
but the words change. Why won't they  
stay still? Why can't they remain?  
They are not, that is why, and they never were.  
The rain moves through the way...

## Hitler's Bunker

31 August 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/08/hitlers-bunker/>

Americans closing in, after ravaging  
much of Italy, I wonder, did any  
ask, "What have we done?  
What rubble becomes our heritage?"  
If any living would know themselves,  
I counsel reflection upon these years  
when fascists strove to make Rome stick for all.  
But now the rubble (no more storied columns,  
monuments of power believed), becomes a doom.  
Destruction has a new allure, the fasces  
christen every room, and man no longer  
wills to be alone. It is the total will  
that governs even "freedom-loving" people. Where is safe?  
There are still mountains, true, but mankind  
cannot thrive outside the law, and in our time  
the law abuses some for fun.  
This must be known if we still  
wish to be made human. Both hard sides  
of contradiction must be grasped and known.  
We need the law. The law abuses.  
If there be an easy answer, I don't know it.  
This I know: some govern well, but others  
move within the doom of Hitler's bunker,  
where all hope is lost, the only option death.  
Be not like them, consumed by hate,  
nor hating them, for then hate wins,  
but neither drown in naive love, for man  
loves dominance most, for reasons unknown,  
and this will never change. Carve out  
a home away from man's cold quest  
and rule it well. This is called happiness.  
One wonders that the Hitlers could not find it  
seeking total domination from the bunkers of the world.



## Lady in the Rain

*31 August 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/08/lady-in-the-rain/>*

Evening mistful after rain,  
I saw a woman's perfect form,  
no halo, but a song fell from her lips.  
She said to hope again,  
and all was like the rain.

No, it was not a dream,  
no journey through Lothlorien  
could pass this way,  
though she draws from that well,

And who's to say just which  
of us inhabited the other?

## Mingled Being

*31 August 2022*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/08/mingled-being/>

What is it that calls for children?  
Why do women weep to see their offspring  
leap through flowers? I suspect it is  
like that which summons poetry,  
what one has called "the unreserve of mingled being."  
Hear now how the many voices speak  
of loved camaraderie,  
as though this be essential to their frame.  
I do not know what calls if not  
enticement to the game of mixture,  
turning one and one to something more.  
The dance is waiting ere we learn it,  
blending what presents with what we are.  
So travel cautiously. Beware the swamps  
that pull things down. Avoid the soggy  
groundless ground. Instead recall  
the energy of youth, and how your mother wept.  
They were not tears of pity, no, of joy,  
to see herself in you, of you, with you.  
And mingled with you, Being, in its full array of flowers,  
alive to tell.

## Such Surprises Must Be

31 August 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/08/such-surprises-must-be/>

The way scientists mishandle surprises,  
you'd think they were born in a lab  
with all variables controlled, where the mother  
deduced from first principles that a good time had come.  
They go on to the end of surprises,  
but there is no end to it, no world  
of babies by babies for babies.  
Can anyone handle the unrest of history?  
Nature has laws! they will say,  
thus forgetting that emperors need not obey.  
So who then shall be emperor?  
I'd vote for one who rules justly,  
loves mercy, and cares for his country as his own,  
one who knows with compassion  
the suffering drawn from surprises,  
and that such surprises must be.

## The Ground is Lava

31 August 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/08/the-ground-is-lava/>

Late one morning, I ventured  
to know myself, like the thinkers demand,  
but before I had gone through the threshold,  
I saw that the ground had returned to primordial soup.  
As I gazed at that chaos, I thought of how children  
pretend that the ground becomes lava.  
How wise they are, unlike ourselves,  
who pretend that foundations are solid  
in order that we might erect some grand edifice.  
Children know well that foundations are fluid,  
and that we just do what we can.  
Ask the children how much they believe,  
or, importantly, *why* they believe.  
I suspect they have far purer reasons.

## Thinking Deeply

*31 August 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/08/thinking-deeply/>*

I have been to the place  
where truths are born, I have heard  
the sirens call me there,  
but I rarely return. It is dark there,  
and cold, and no homes endure  
the hard swirling of winds.  
But I'm still thinking deeply,  
traditions in mind, because  
this is the only way to think.  
All else is chaos breeding chaos.  
But stiffened traditions expire,  
a new generation arises,  
and all that is left to the thinkers  
are keen ears for cold winds of change.

## Too Playful

31 August 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/08/too-playful/>

The poem grows from the same place  
as child's play, the soil of human possibility.  
What *can* we be? Maybe doctors or lawyers  
or dragon-slayers, or maybe plants  
or gemstones or rye. But children  
grow older, and most forget play,  
though its lessons stay with us, for  
we are our playthings, we are what we play,  
and at one time you knew that.  
I write to remind you, though it is no use,  
because patients are sick, because clients are angry,  
and dragons are burning down villages, but you  
are too busy to play with me. If only you knew  
that your play is play too, we'd grow wiser together,  
and maybe you'd learn about truth  
and its too playful hold over you.

## Old Flames

*12 September 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/09/old-flames/>*

As I sit, I remember the point of the story,  
the struggle to keep out the cold.  
It was always getting colder, no matter the weather,  
and we, like frontiersmen, built houses and fires  
to keep ourselves warm. But the houses grow old,  
fires dim, and the embers are hardly remembered.  
I say, as I sit, I remember those embers,  
how long-dwindled fires once burned in our hearts,  
or if not in ours, then in our grandfathers' hearts.  
But we are the ones who are here (they are not, or may be  
but are not as they were), yet their embers remain  
unremembered. I think that is sad, but not new.  
As I sit, I remember a time, and another,  
when history was not remembered. I will not give names,  
but you likely know that this is true.  
There's a cold wind breathing at the door.  
It's for us, and against us. I think we do well  
to remember it. Even the best insulation  
will never make heat. We will need a new flame.  
We must ask where the old flames have gone.

## One of Us

*12 September 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/09/one-of-us/>*

The veiled criticism always says  
how dare you not be one of us.  
Yes, be yourself, but first be  
one of us, of us, of us...

I cannot do it, not with thirty legions,  
not for all the world.



*12 September 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/09/over-the-atlantic/>*

How many voices drown in that wind,  
unable to make it across?

## Sandcastles

*12 September 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/09/sandcastles/>*

I am watching the children build sandcastles.  
I know they won't mind, though I think they will wonder  
what keeps me away. I am not one to join  
where I know that the wind and the waves will destroy.  
But I do not mind watching. Sometimes their achievement  
is marvelous, but I cannot silence  
the sound of the crashing waves. It's like time,  
you know, after a long day, when the quitting bell rings.  
That bell rings for me always, and over such noise  
little castles of sand have no hold. I don't mind, though,  
watching, and sometimes I wish I could join them.  
It would be like hope, you know, after a long doubt.  
But I cannot shake loose of the grip of the sea.  
I will watch these new sandcastles fall, like the last,  
and leave only some footprints behind.

## Afterthought on the Romantics

21 September 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/09/afterthought-on-the-romantics/>

They strove to bring the dark into the light.  
What evident folly, yet an understandable urge  
to *see* the dark, there, always. It *is* there,  
but it cannot be seen. It is the absence of sight,  
a lack of presence. To make *this* present  
is to hollow what remains. Instead, we now learn  
how to build, with subtle lighting, some cool nave  
of stone, where light and shadow interplay.  
This way we can keep both, and keep them well.

## Gettysburg

September 21 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/09/gettysburg/>

Before the dawn one evening, I went down  
to Jackson city, to remember why we here  
do not live there. It was a cool miseducation  
in the ways of segregation, but it was not  
what those elsewhere like to say. I saw a people,  
many hungry, some devoted, some misguided, one or two  
with hope to spare – in other words, they were a people  
like the rest. True, they owned slaves, or those  
before them did, but this fact cannot be washed away  
with any amount of blood. We ought to know by now  
that history is fickle, and remains despite our sternest glare.  
There is no way to make it vanish. Nonetheless,  
we can move forward, and have done it, though  
with golden thread to bring us home. Have you observed  
how every poem stacked in order waits in reserve?  
They are like people under the lash of cold machines.  
Our words have suffered. They have lied to you,  
although they had no choice. The words are not  
the problem, though they are a symptom, and I hope by now  
you know the disease. I am at ease to write,  
it's true, but we are not at ease while living,  
and eternal life makes us less easy still. Before the dawn,  
consider what can still be spoken, and,  
more troublingly, think what can speak no more.  
It is the silence calling us this time of night.  
Beware the apathy of drowning in the noise.  
I hear the call of many chain-gangs in the wind.  
I hear their rattle, and they will not be ignored  
but seek no vengeance. They would like to sleep again  
and be released at last from pain. Could we oblige them?  
I think so, though it would take a serious effort  
and one not like what we've dared to try before.

---

I do not believe in Lincoln. I cannot.  
He was a feckless Hegelian, couched in Biblical tones.  
He did not govern well. I've said it and will

say it again, he cowed to violence, could not admit  
that states wished to secede. Oh, what a sneaky devil,  
blind in the face of the obvious. There is no forthcoming millennium  
where all peoples of all colors live as one. De Tocqueville  
said so. Yet we try and try and try. I do not know  
what else we could try, but we at least could notice the obvious,  
that humans are still human despite the violence.  
We are here, as we have always been, as prone to hate as love.  
It will not change. What wars are necessary to teach this once and for all?  
I fear the answer as I fear the blight of winter.

---

Why am I here, able neither to remember  
nor forget? To absorb solemnity left  
by dying men? Or to be thoughtful  
about how little we know? These men,  
brave men no doubt, died hard, but why?  
Should we dare also to die? Again? But why?

---

Had Freedom died? Or was it just then mortally struck?  
Why was the new birth *necessary*, and could it be needed again?  
And needed by whom? I may digress, but you would not forgive  
serenity at a time like this, when lady liberty labors  
to bring life into the world. Would we, then, also  
be reborn? Some time ago was one, and yet  
another, who spoke hauntingly of birth. Where have they gone?  
Where have *we* gone? I think old freedom lives  
and could not be *reborn*, for it was never born.  
It merely *is*, beyond the pale of all that ever  
comes to womb. It merely is, on its own terms,  
in its own time. Say Lincoln knew this.  
Likely he'd forgotten, like most others  
of his day, but say he knew it. Could we have  
a greater leader? Could mankind then rise past folly  
after all? Just say he knew it. Say he knew it  
for the scores of years of bloodshed we've endured.  
War is not pretty, no, but neither is our peace.  
The fools immortalize his words, against the wishes  
of those very words. I'd have this plaque removed,  
along with all the noisy monuments, and rather  
listen closely as the ghosts here tell their tale.

## All Silence

*14 October 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/10/all-silence/>*

This moment I'm writing to you  
as a man who has lived to see death  
not in morbid obsession but only  
in rapturous reality. Yes, it is true,  
there are things and not just me and you.  
Answer softly, my sweet, when I ask you  
to be near me now as things fade.  
We are dying as sure as we're living.  
But listen for me past the hearth flare, in chill air.  
I wait for you there in all silence.

## **As Ever**

*14 October 2022*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/10/as-ever/>

We no more renew the song  
of time wherein by masquerade  
the "mortal dross" transforms into  
eternity. No more! We live, as ever,  
in the flowing, thingly river, day  
by day dissolving in new ways  
of speaking thought, and so we ought,  
if time has brought us here, if time itself  
would like to bring us near.

## Time

*14 October 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/10/time/>*

Walk here on this beach with me,  
where time is, in the evening of  
its missionary gaze, the goal to save  
all who will hear. Walk here with me,  
where gods can die, and often do.  
Walk here, but slowly. Know these waves,  
the ones you've learned how not to hear.  
You'll hear them now, so gently falling down  
upon all things. So time falls, so it goes,  
and so we go, into the crypt of time,  
where all days are reborn, are born, and die.



## **No Reason**

*25 October 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/10/no-reason/>*

Many things happen for no reason.  
We dare to admit it now.  
The future, hazy, approaches.  
We hold a wet finger to the wind.  
It answers thus: mankind unfettered,  
the child a universe at play.

## **Risible Time**

*25 October 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/10/risible-time/>*

Born against odds in a risible time,  
thou shall rise, as thy parents  
before thee did rise, and shall fall  
up and back to that risible sky,  
with its emptiest center, near time.

## **After Tomorrow**

*04 November 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/after-tomorrow/>*

I remember from time to time  
how those moments when humans  
are worse than isolation resolve  
into moments when all one can do  
is sit quietly, staring off into  
tomorrow, as if it won't also  
be much like today, and I wonder  
what happens the day after tomorrow  
when all of us wake up anew.

## **It is not for me**

*04 November 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/it-is-not-for-me/>*

Here they are, as ever, making the weaker  
argument appear stronger, uneven in thinking,  
so tipsy in mind. What great folly, if even  
the end of historic progressions or else  
the result of some King's stiff command.  
We are tired by now and its restlessness,  
drawn to all corners of the imagination  
by a call no less real than a fairy-tale  
and no more real than the earth. It has  
drained us of every ambition, but this  
is no reason to scream, no, the screaming  
is part of the problem. I ask you for once  
to be ruled, if you will, if you can,  
but it is not for me that I'm asking.

## No Entry Beyond

29 November 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/no-entry-beyond/>

We are free now after long bondage,  
no longer seeking to mate with the Truth,  
but instead care to *know* it, as thinkers,  
not lovers. I dare say this was  
a very long time in coming, not empty  
but full, at long last, of ourselves  
and our families, countries, and tribes.  
We are full of reality's emptiness,  
brimming with void, and in love  
with each other, as passion demands.  
We are free, very free (can it be?)  
We are wise beyond years, beyond tears,  
beyond ghosts of some greater beyond  
who no longer hold any sway here.

## Thing in Progress

*29 November 2022*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/thing-in-progress/>

I shall pull back the curtain,  
peep under the veil, at the thing  
in its progress. It is not done yet,  
and yet is the progression in *it*  
or in *me*? This is by now old music.  
We may do more asking for origins.

## The Gospel According to Us

29 November 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/the-gospel-according-to-us/>

If you'll listen, I will tell you  
of the day before the stars were born  
like yesterday, but more in tune with now.  
This is the gospel according to us,  
not some forgotten fairy-tale  
from days gone by, but this here now  
by us for us. This is our gospel,  
by the power of consensus, reigning free  
across America, where we decree  
what each thing is and dare  
no other. We have tasted majesty  
from sea to shining sea, now dare  
to speak, and be not worried  
if this flag speaks not for thee.  
We'll make it speak, with every fiber  
of each being, named by us  
and therefore there, existing solely  
for ourselves, who, speaking, make the world  
of images derived from prior times, the sea  
of echoes pouring through our lives  
as history. Are these not also here,  
informing things? Are we so free  
that each decree becomes a law?

## Untested Ways

*29 November 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/untested-ways/>*

I am wondering what will become of us,  
after all this time. I am wondering just  
how strange time is, and how strange  
we are, living here, at the end of it.  
We're aware now that Jesus never  
attended church, so we follow his footsteps  
at last, but what of it? I suspect  
there is more to this story, and until  
we get down to the bottom of it,  
I wonder if we will find peace.  
There are many paths forward, but each  
is a severance from what precedes.  
This is saying the road does end here,  
but some new ones begin. I think I  
shall explore a few untested ways,  
for your sake, and for mine. This way,  
one of us at least keeps moving.



## No Will to Deceive

29 November 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/no-will-to-deceive/>

God has grown neurotic these last few centuries,  
ravaged by ships sailing seas where no ships had dared  
dream before, but this is nothing, just men chasing power,  
yet power is what makes God go. Are we listening now?  
I remember, I can never forget, how the days before ours  
were like fire in the night, but the night lasted longer  
and swallowed that flame. We're the same when we ask  
for forever, though knowing full well it's beyond us. Where we live  
time reigns, and the best we can do is believe. I can  
only remind you again and again, but I'll do that  
with grace in my heart and no will to deceive.

## Uncertain Times

*29 November 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/uncertain-times/>*

Lincoln roamed over  
the cavern of godlessness  
like a leader  
in uncertain times.

## **After "A Late Walk" by Robert Frost**

*29 November 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/after-a-late-walk-by-robert-frost/>*

My walk is later, yours  
is later still, the animus the same,  
no time until we reconcile. This  
winter carries history, this harvest  
has a name (it's you). I warrant that  
the aftermath dishevelled all of truth.  
But there's no matter, so they say.  
Who'd even try to go some other way.  
Perhaps a strong-voiced bird will rise  
and sing another day.

## Freedom's End

*29 November 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/freedoms-end/>*

I stand upon a precipice,  
the great cliff white as snow,  
and fear a darkness coming yonder  
over fields we used to know.  
The day is cool and feckless,  
but the night is coming in,  
and we are hungry, we are tired,  
by the gravity of sin.  
There are no words between us,  
no embraces bring us home,  
and in the darkness I descry  
the end of all things we have known.  
I am no meager prophet,  
and this is no meager poem.  
I believe in new beginnings  
grown from darkness overgrown.  
So take this next step with me.  
Through the doorway we will wend  
and walk along the newfound pathways  
on the way to Freedom's End.

## Persuasion

*29 November 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/persuasion/>*

It is strange how our rulers  
pretend to believe that they  
serve us, as though we don't know  
that each offering merely entangles  
us more in their web. Still  
we go on, each feeling prescribed  
by the business of business,  
but free! we are free! very free!  
If that is what we call it  
to be inauthentic or else.  
Who could want any service  
besides what is standard?  
I tell you we could,  
with a bit of persuasion.

## Darkness Becomes You

*29 November 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/darkness-becomes-you/>*

In darkness I am reaching  
from a still place, in this empty space  
for you, whoever you are. It is not clear  
that we are here, but in these moments  
darkness becomes you, and I can see  
that after all is said and dreamed,  
there is a silence and its teaching.

## History

*29 November 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/history/>*

It occurs to me now and then  
and from time to time that our role  
must be: preserve the living and keep out the dead.  
This is history, this is our role in it,  
let us respect and partake of this process.

## Crimson Days in the Depths of Time

29 November 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/crimson-days-in-the-depths-of-time/>

Into the sea he dove, toward another land,  
this one no less deplorable, unneutered, never filtered,  
and he swam. The currents pushed and pulled his form,  
and twisting, writhing, he found sand, the stuff of mountains  
long eroded, then descended. Were these not the sands  
of time, at last, now freed here from their hourglasses?  
Time would tell, as only time could tell.  
And so he fell, but falling, not as out of Eden,  
rather falling as one drawn to depths by kinship  
to those depths, or maybe drawn by some dark gravity.  
Leviathan in chains, he feared, would wait for him down there,  
or so they say, but on this day he little cared  
what fate awaits him, little cared for self at all  
when put against the call to sink or fall below the waves.  
In crimson days, in patterned waves, he feared the rise  
of troubled years, nor dared to counter them with tears,  
for they demanded something more, a new beginning,  
if a new path could be won, and so he dove  
to chart a course, lay some foundation. He struck  
rock the second time, this not surprising. He  
had heard of rock before, though never seen it.  
These he saw, and knew at once that they  
could serve him. He delved hard, and threw himself  
against the rocks, and when few broke, he knew again  
that these were firm. But when he moved them,  
when he placed one on another, both proved worthless,  
turned to sand. He groaned, but, still resolved, took sand  
and pressed it in his hands, until as glass it stayed.  
He now had made his way, and none could take it,  
so he claimed, but came a rumble from those depths  
of things forgotten, drifting memories of all that sand  
has been. This troubled him, his glass was cracked,  
but there could be no going back. He cut his hands there,  
leaving drops of blood reflecting throughout time, and  
though those depths had proved unkind, it's said  
that he still loves them, like a child, like a patriot,  
to the end.



## In Any Case

29 November 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/in-any-case/>

Those with the higher sense, who observe our way of life,  
can only say "it's all wrong" so many times before  
they go crazy, so most just stop saying it. But none  
can stop feeling it. Why, after all, make things permanent?  
Process is all, and the process itself is in process.  
Or am I repeating something said before?  
I am certain that this much is true, we know  
little, no more than our forebearers, and we all know  
how that all ended (or have we forgotten?) In any case,  
let me remind you that change can be friendly,  
but so can the law, so we'd better plant one foot in each.

## **Ave Maris Stella**

*29 November 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/ave-maris-stella/>*

Stella, bathed in lapis, azure  
waves of sky, pray tell me  
whence thy rays of amber light?  
Am I your child, or am I  
self-made, as prophets say  
who guide our way tonight?  
If any be whose thoughts are free,  
I say they well may think of thee  
yet still be free, but more to those who find  
some thing objectionable inside,  
I write with hope to change their minds.

## Why Reason?

*29 November 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/why-reason/>*

I have come to you, naked like this,  
in the death throes of God, being  
pregnant with words and with meaning,  
to answer your question with another:  
Why reason? To make ourselves stable?

## Hegel

*29 November 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/11/hegel/>*

What did they do to you, Hegel,  
to make you so blue and somber?  
Perhaps they withdrew when a staying  
was due, or perhaps they demanded the truth.  
It is sobering, isn't it, being here dead  
as a log, in these pages, just one more  
firm concept to break through?

## Back to the Mines

15 December 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/12/back-to-the-mines/>

I think sometimes we shall never escape  
from the general, all-around clusterfuck  
(pardon the language, it applies) of humanity  
always and everywhere, in general confused  
about what it all means, about what *meaning* means,  
or why meaning is so indispensable.

Oh well, let's back to the mines  
for another long spell of formation through labor.

## Why Obey?

*15 December 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/12/why-obey/>*

Could it be that for some  
definition of "we", we must leave  
on the pathways of time  
some beliefs etched on signposts  
for others to see?

## You Are The Way

*15 December 2022*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/12/you-are-the-way/>

Listen to me. Listen (I will speak) to this beginning  
out of no-thing (yet not nothing). There no more shall be  
interminable deductions from infallible first principles, not even  
if those principles be liberal. We are all that's left, my friend.  
The way is you, my friend from afar. You are the way to me.

## To Tell This To You, or Changing of the Gods

*15 December 2022*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/12/to-tell-this-to-you/>

I walk out one morning like any other  
and come back the same as myself,  
for once chosen and spoken for one  
and no other. I am well-versed in things  
farmers know, also tech-savvy, and neither thing  
will be relinquished, but I relinquish (kenosis)  
the past in the present, the future in the  
imagination. So notice the soldiers, so stiff and so rigid,  
turn cold to attention, about face, and march  
one last time to a palace now vacant, and we,  
we are not who we thought we would be. If  
stars change, I guess we must change too.  
I am writing to tell this to you.



## Spring Cleaning

*15 December 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/12/spring-cleaning/>*

Morning comes, and birds no longer silent  
fill the air with song. The night was long,  
but this day comes with cheer. Today  
is cleaning day, when old mess goes where  
order comes to stay. It is the only way.  
Note how the sky is flushed with light,  
new colors wash the old away. I wish  
for you alive and gay to meet me  
in the garden. There we'll talk our cares away  
until the day is spent. I have a special  
gift for those who only can obey, and one  
for those who never do. It is no wonder  
which are you. The moon is rising, and  
the night is crisp and clear. It is the air  
that you have been so troubled for, at last,  
so clear that one is wondered to the core.

## Vortex Afterglow

15 December 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/12/vortex-afterglow/>

In the afterglow of the morning, I walked  
to the edge of a growing circumference, never in doubt,  
not resolved, but still present, like one from another room,  
and I saw there before me an image, but what  
it portended no words can express. Yet it took me by eye  
and led into the nearest horizon, that place where  
the shadows have form and vice versa, and there I saw  
only my dreams of tomorrow, a fantasy littered with  
chaos and rhyme. There the sun never set, but stayed  
stuck in its setting, a sculpture one mis-takes for living.  
Soon after the journey reminded of home, so alone  
I walked backwards, until stretched by hands unlike mine  
through the vortex of time to beginnings, as well as  
to ends, before all as my witnesses ready to go and to find.

## Compromise

*15 December 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/12/compromise/>*

The schools are at it again, with their furor  
to make a new movement, or else make an old one.  
I'll tell you, this will not end well, nevermind  
how the old ways have fared. I say clearly,  
I want to keep liberty *and* biology, sir,  
and I am not now willing to compromise.

## **Marxists**

*15 December 2022*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/12/marxists/>*

The other day I walked so far  
I could not see my home.  
The Marxists say such has to be  
for any who would roam.

But I remain uncertain, even though  
they know my heart.  
Yes, I remember, yes, I know,  
and yes, I still do see the stars.

## In Memory

15 December 2022

<https://poems.culturing.net/2022/12/in-memory/>

I open the door. It is not clear  
whose being-there disturbs my being here, but waves  
of pure vibrations meet me there. I am a man  
one says, another soy un hombre, one je suis etc...  
here we are in memory all the same. We differ  
outwardly, perhaps inwardly too, yet all recall  
the lessons of a teacher who *knew* something. Open the door  
upon a field, a pasture, castle in the distance.  
Is it home? Or are you longing for another?  
What is longing, just be-longing without being?  
Let us long, then, till we find a set of beings  
we can store within our memories. I'll wait here  
for you, patiently, recalling what I know.

## **Elite Waters**

*17 January 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/01/elite-waters/>*

I have dipped my toes in elite waters,  
but they proved too cold for me. So instead  
I am here (I am writing to you)  
about love and its answers to questions.

## Horizons

17 January 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/01/horizons/>

*Where did we get the sponge that could wipe the  
horizon away?*

Nietzsche, *The Gay Science*

From Cromwell it came, with vengeance,  
for days were not trusted  
as long as a Catholic lived, and  
with Providence on our side  
we strove forth for Britannia,  
Science and War side by side.  
It was then that the ground  
was made firm,  
and thus all are now born  
in laboratories, laboring, true,  
for some queen they know not,  
some Elizabeth mouldering probably,  
but no true woman. No man of science  
fares well with a woman, no wonder,  
for women *require* horizons, and science  
requires the sponge. But no matter,  
has Germany fared any better, or  
must we look deeper  
and learn of Greek/Roman horizons?

## Slumber Much Better

*17 January 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/01/slumber-much-better/>*

Again I find myself alone  
in the dark, while the Christians  
dance madly in imaginary light.  
What a pity that all of this  
suffering goes on unpunished.  
I think there will come a time  
for licking these wounds, but  
until then I slumber much  
better without interference.



## Specimens

*17 January 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/01/specimens/>*

Are we to remain collections  
of human specimens in the test-tubes  
of America, or are we to become *men*?  
And what would that mean?

## Wait For Another

*17 January 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/01/wait-for-another/>*

In the aftermath of clockwork decaying,  
from prisons of the mind, arise new men  
of stone unbroken and yet brittle to the end.  
What for? If Übermenschen all, then we  
are lofty though we fall, for with some hopes  
a certain madness lurks in wait. Say more,  
bon esprit, with less. Do be the best, but  
know of other figures at the door.  
You are no child now, new friend, you grown-old thing,  
yet I have seldom felt such shelter from your wing.  
Is this, then progress? Or must we wait for another?

## Think Not Absolutely

*17 January 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/01/think-not-absolutely/>*

There's a shimmer on the air, comes flowing over  
days and years, to us, who here and now  
decide to make things clear no more, who  
think not absolutely, then think pure and free  
with obstacles removed, and breath returning.

## **As Life May Yet Be**

*17 January 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/01/as-life-may-yet-be/>*

Wordsworth said of a poem:  
emotion recalled in tranquility.  
Now I say otherwise. Mine  
are like ships tossed by storms,  
lost at sea, like reality, never  
at port in the kingdom of sheep  
who fight no significant battles  
and want things done for them --  
adventurer poems, explorer poems,  
as anxious as life may yet be.

## Sick With Struggle

17 January 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/01/sick-with-struggle/>

Here we are, still monotheist saints  
or else old hoplites with no phalanx,  
sick with struggle, and yet knowing of no other...  
what voice calls? Is it the morning dove,  
or is it just fair Juliet, the wise man's bane?  
She has no other name, for she is fair  
no longer than a season. All loves end  
the same, as sorrows waver, with a whimper,  
and mankind remains enthralled to thee,  
O time, the muse of all deep divers,  
dwelling as you do beneath the waves.

## Strangers

*17 January 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/01/strangers/>*

As I sit by candlelight,  
I know the strangers of the night  
who creep by windows fair and bright  
to haunt the streets of all delight,  
and all the days of love grown cold,  
and all the stories never told,  
and all the crying eyes behold  
the lying eyes both young and old.  
I see them in their shadows waiting,  
see their fearful forms debating  
whether love or lies abating  
offer respite to their waiting,  
whether love or lies can stir  
the shadows that have stolen her,  
the one whose love was soft as fur  
who bristles now with prickly hide.  
So come sit by my candlelight.  
Come feast your eyes upon the sight  
as strangers in the strangest night  
sit man and man, sit side by side.

## Emptiness That None Can Understand

*21 February 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/02/emptiness-that-none-can-understand/>*

We have not proved that life be regular,  
only have made padded cages for ourselves  
where all is regular. Life remains the same,  
a formless void apart from us, so full of mystery  
and emptiness that none can understand.

## Rest Unassured

*21 February 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/02/rest-unassured/>*

With the shadows dawning, with dawn descending,  
I call for you, weeping, alone in the meadow,  
with words for renewal. I say rest unassured,  
be aware but not pure. There are days on horizons  
not noticed before. As for us, it could be that  
this setting defines us, but that is no reason to wallow.



## Nutrition by Faith Alone

21 February 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/02/nutrition-by-faith-alone/>

*Dinner options: (1) Take it (2) Leave it*

*Local Sign*

In America we believe God somehow powers  
our food with his majesty, making infallible  
all of our culinary experiments.  
Call it Nutrition by Faith Alone. All that matters  
is that *we believe*, as if no thing has substance,  
as if, to use Plato mistakenly, thoughts are more real than things.  
But we doubt that, and say so, but know of no other.  
I wonder what Asia would think?

## Dwindle

*21 February 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/02/dwindle/>*

In the midst of plurality,  
egos must dwindle (somebody tell  
Whitman) but maybe they  
need not extinguish.

## The Promise of the Lady

*21 February 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/02/the-promise-of-the-lady/>*

Come to the temple,  
the Lady is waiting,  
with courtesans towing  
the train of her robe.  
She invites you to enter.  
She patiently gazes  
upon your small splendor  
but does not refuse you.  
Her form soft and slender  
invites you again  
to become what was promised  
long since at this temple.

The gateway before you,  
your form soft and nimble,  
she beckons you and you must go.  
But don't worry: her promise is good  
and her temple will still stand long after.

## Like No Angel

21 February 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/02/like-no-angel/>

Wandering homeward, overland  
past German towns destroyed  
by too-free thought, past English  
clocks unwound and French hearts  
broken-hearted, stands a man,  
not quite your size, some large  
American, unsteady on his feet.  
He knows too little, feels too much,  
but means to help in any way he can.  
He feared one day  
the old world would cave in  
and need the new. It never did. Instead  
it hardened into something like itself,  
with just a thin veneer of tolerance. And so  
it wandered, as he too would wander,  
homeward, like no angel one had ever seen.

## A more tolerant order

21 February 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/02/a-more-tolerant-order/>

We cannot replace law with tolerance,  
however much we try. I suggest instead  
aiming for a more tolerant order, a law  
that *embraces* diversity but does not enforce it.  
For tolerance never puts bread on the table,  
though lawfulness can, through cooperation (and  
don't be deceived that cooperation comes through  
more tolerance). Laws create trust and cohesion  
but also cause friction where not all agree.  
It may be that universal laws must be few,  
but I hope we agree that our mutual survival  
is something worthwhile, to be cherished.

## Night Sweats of the American Dream

21 February 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/02/night-sweats-of-the-american-dream/>

The Radium Girls, the serial killers,  
and all night sweats of the American Dream...  
how many kinds of peanut butter  
does a civilized people need?

All products of experiment,  
all experiments neverending,  
all the people entertained.

And yet I feel no disdain  
for this ship or its sailing,  
for as it goes down I go with it.

## The Quest for the Immortal Self

21 February 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/02/the-quest-for-the-immortal-self/>

*After all, it is you and I who are perfect, not the  
next world.*

Allen Ginsberg, *America*

Have we found it? I've looked  
under every belief, and found nothing.  
Not even despair, nor ecstatic  
self-reformulation (the new dialectic)  
can grant this old wish. But I wish  
that our days were more even, that  
sunshine and moonlight spoke softly together  
and on equal terms. Do you hear?  
There are so many hours left, then no more.  
This is how it always goes, not enkindled  
by immortal flame, but descending in whispers,  
no longer itself, not the same. But this is not  
the cause for more triumph, no celebrations here.  
Rather, sleep, with its own quiet permanence,  
must end each day, most men say,  
yet it also begins the next day, fresh, anew.  
I am speaking to you, and for you, but you know  
more than I can ever say.

## The Sound a Plant Makes

21 February 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/02/the-sound-a-plant-makes/>

Will any number of plants relieve the pressure?  
No, the iron rages on toward tomorrow, restless,  
without reservation. Do any remain who hear the moan  
beneath the steady drone of sure-footed, still uncertain  
electricity? The moan of earthly things, those things,  
alas, that are not standardized, because the earth,  
alas, is not a factory. Try as we might, it still  
is what it is, and, troublingly, is what we are.  
No number of plants will relieve the burden  
of care, nor the pain of our carelessness. There is a  
tight symbiosis of everything, always,  
and some humans know that. But this is no  
amicable reverie, longing for forgone perfection,  
which never existed. This is but the next step forward.  
We've learned well that nature can harm us,  
that not all its processes will be beneficent.  
Now we must learn how to pick and to choose  
and to nurture those things that sustain us.

I have inscribed some future epitaph,  
forged in times of strife unlike our own.  
It is a tale of war inscribed on bones  
ne'er brittle, by command. These bones speak now,  
or so the story goes, and yet I weep  
for those who militarized the world,  
who could not demilitarize their souls.



## Ahura Mazda (the Question Remains)

20 March 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/03/ahura-mazda-the-question-remains/>

All hail Ahura Mazda, all hail!  
Or fall by the Great King's sword!  
I am Cyrus, slayer of nations,  
and builder of all that remains.  
In the name of Ahura Mazda  
I rule over Persia, the land of my fathers.  
Begrudge not my epitaph. You also  
worship Ahura Mazda. If not,  
then how do you remain?

The myth of Progress is Ahura Mazda,  
The law of money is Ahura Mazda,  
The pain of tolerance is Ahura Mazda,  
The god of feelings is Ahura Mazda,  
Deified sexuality is Ahura Mazda,  
New-age bullshit is Ahura Mazda,  
The cult of personality is Ahura Mazda,  
Democratic Values are Ahura Mazda,  
Both you and I are Ahura Mazda,  
or else we could never remain.

Socrates versus Ahura Mazda,  
the philosophic struggle against all of Persia  
remains undecided, though not for lack of trying.  
The question remains whether any accomplishment  
stands with finality, or whether any question remains.

I disbelieve you, Ahura Mazda.  
No power controls the totality of events.

## The Throne of Cyrus

20 March 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/03/the-throne-of-cyrus/>

I feel the weight of Cyrus,  
feel it pulsing, feel it moving  
through these very words, within  
though not without. I feel inspired  
and afraid. When bones are laid  
in stone-faced mausoleums, when the Shah  
himself weeps madly, when the architects  
of rule both here and there speak only well,  
I am afraid. What fingers clutched the sceptre  
as all Persia trembled? Then sang highest praise?  
Perhaps the victims of abuse defend abusers,  
*love* abusers, with a love that can't be tamed.  
If this be so, how would we know?  
With minds beclouded, thoughts well-trained,  
we'd sing the hymns of him  
who put us in our place. True, Greece and Rome  
have put up manly struggles, to what end?  
To place themselves upon the throne?  
And what of us? Do we dare disabuse, again,  
before that mighty throne?

## Come Again

*20 March 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/03/come-again/>*

It has come again, this time  
so new, having punctured the sky  
I am writing to you, asking why,  
and do not even try to deny it,  
no, this is here now, here and now,  
and tomorrow comes true  
if once listened through you.

## The Drums of Alexander

20 March 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/03/the-drums-of-alexander/>

Alexander stood finally tall on Persepolis  
burning. This was the vengeance Ionia craved,  
the dream of a thousand hoplites realized at last.  
But what was that wind? O great King,  
have you done this? And had you no doubts?  
Later on one will stand here and wonder  
as you failed to wonder. Were not these  
baths lovely, with children at play in the spring?  
Rubble now, though perhaps all ends thus,  
though perhaps not as swiftly as this.  
Have you done it, or does some Ahura  
still haunt these hallowed grounds? What was  
really at stake, basileus, in so much destruction?  
And why do I still hear your drums beating,  
louder now, over the Atlantic?

## Small All the Same

20 March 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/03/small-all-the-same/>

Caught up withal in the most divine madness  
we crash through the Phrygian stables  
and lather on filth, with such glee  
that no shepherd or pen can contain us.

We crash also through all white fences  
on main street, or any street – crash  
as those wild as we are who have seen  
through the curtain the man at the machine.

What a small man indeed. Shall we triumph,  
or are we still small all the same?

## Unfriendly

20 March 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/03/unfriendly/>

After all these years one would have thought  
that deleting Facebook would be easier. After all,  
it is only a website among many. But strangely pernicious,  
its popular draw, even buying and selling turned into  
a struggle for approval (to say nothing of genocide).  
What is this pull, which determines so much, means  
so little. I cannot escape any other way than  
the old coward's way, or the nobleman's way  
of thick walls. I can still keep it out, have no fear,  
but lament that we cannot cooperate. One  
would have thought this would be the point,  
not to lord my success over others, or over myself  
lord successes of others, but rather to speak together,  
quietly, under the setting sun. Until Facebook supports this,  
I abstain, and expect next to nothing.

## The Realm of Reason

20 March 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/03/the-realm-of-reason/>

Have we tired yet of clocks and steamships?  
Maybe old Corcyra, maybe Salamis can shake  
these rusty bones, but maybe not. This realm  
of reason, sacrilegious blend of Greece with Persia,  
shall soon end, and maybe then new thoughts of empire  
flecked with liberty shall emerge. But is it rather  
that Hellenic freedom simply can't be 'suaged? Apollo  
gives his dictates pure, non-partisan, so irony befalls  
those who are partial to Apollo. It's a structural  
deficiency belying all our thought. Let's think again,  
with rightful honor paid to Greece, with due respect  
for Cyrus, Xerxes, and with half a glance to China,  
just to have a fuller picture.

## So Very Greek

*20 March 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/03/so-very-greek/>*

It is sad, don't you know, to be living here now  
and to know that the runner from Marathon  
lost his way, for he founded an empire of thought,  
not a tribe of free families, so very Greek was he,  
and like no Greek had ever been before... I think Plato  
would mind being kin to such savagery, such wars  
as turn on their victors, devour them, then reign forever.  
This is not Platonic, nor Roman, nor English,  
but oh it was Greek, was so very Greek indeed.



## Larger Accomplishments (Pragmatism)

20 March 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/03/larger-accomplishments-pragmatism/>

Must they be *true* to be useful, or is it  
that laws grease the wheels of society,  
giving us form, and through form, giving trust?  
Perhaps this is their value, not cosmic obedience  
to cosmic justice, but immanent trust in each other  
which leads to much larger accomplishments.

## As She Will

20 March 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/03/as-she-will/>

She grasped my hand, and off we flew  
toward a prior world, with gods yet true.  
We turned to you, and said Remember  
what was said by those lain hundreds dead  
before the sun set sadly on the few  
who still remained. For here was Greece,  
where once a Lady clothed in stone  
called forth at Athens for all Greeks,  
and here was Ch'in where that same Lady  
pulled her maidens to the River.  
Know their stories if you dare to live as long as they  
and burn forever after, but take care  
that you do not become too loyal, for she comes  
in many guises, as she will.

## **Not even sure who to ask**

*20 March 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/03/not-even-sure-who-to-ask/>*

Even the clock on my HVAC  
adjusts itself automatically, like some  
divine conspiracy of old, but these  
gods of technology want us to  
keep life ship shape, want each detail  
aligned with some higher design  
of pure reason. Whose reason? We ask  
now pathetically, not even sure who to ask.

## **Saving Daylight**

*20 March 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/03/saving-daylight/>*

When is there an end to it, the wailing  
drone of time, the fleeting hours, days  
or seconds of our lives, the nonstop blow  
of death's lone foghorn? Not in this life  
nor another. We must live among the  
vanishment, and live as best we can. But  
does it not belie our hubris that we dare  
tune time itself for maximal efficiency?

## Plain and True

20 March 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/03/plain-and-true/>

I watch them working slowly,  
barely knowing how they serve  
the growing tyranny, the urge to please the people,  
as in Greece so long ago. They are  
no better, when libido dominandi reigns,  
as it does reign, in Europe as before.  
But Christian chains could not restrain the beast,  
so what hope do we have? Some say  
more earthbound hopes, like those of China's past,  
to give all dignity, a place upon the stair.  
No more enslaving, no more liberty,  
but letting dialectic rest in peace.  
Give each his duty plain and true.

## At Eleusis

26 April 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/at-eleusis/>

Follow these steps, if you dare  
descend here unaware, and be made known  
before a *demos* that is known. First wander  
here, then there, but watch! for grasping  
fingers in the dark. They cannot harm you  
more than life can harm you. Step here  
through this opening, join these others, soon  
you'll know. Behold! the goddess flies!  
She rises from the tomb! It is Demeter,  
goddess of the corn. Consider how the corn,  
with many seeds, may grow, when this plant  
sinks below. There is no other way.  
Consider well, and be thus nourished,  
threefold blessed by life, by birth,  
and by their cousin death.

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/if-he-would-speak-today/>*

If he would speak today, the Poet  
must be modern, must be metal, but he  
must as well be living. He must  
vivify the modern soul.

## **Some Natures**

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/some-natures/>*

Some natures are harmful,  
despite all theology to the contrary,  
and we are responsible for knowing  
the good, not the bad.



## What time is this

26 April 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/what-time-is-this/>

They are proud to have learned their lessons  
and never question. I wince in their presence.  
I have never learned their lessons. What time is this,  
that comes when all are sleeping, like a cock about to crow?

## On Whose Authority

26 April 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/on-whose-authority/>

The people demand a show, like always,  
but now ever ringing between their ears  
growls a question: On whose authority? *Whose?*

## Sources

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/sources/>*

No more the uneducated masses,  
now the miseducated masses,  
squished in one mass by a craving  
for universalizable maxims.  
O Kant! Father Kant! Hast thou wrought this?  
Or must we look deeper for sources?

## The Question of Democracy

26 April 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/the-question-of-democracy/>

The People are not worthy of their servants  
when those servants serve with honor, when  
"most people" rule the hearts of men, when  
servitude is servile and not grand. The People  
groan at honor, moan for pleasure, lack the common ground  
which makes men noble, who are products of that ground  
and of no other. Thus those fight for what produced them  
while the People (hear me!) claw and scratch the same.

But now what of it? Shall we have another war, or is it simply  
undecidable, this question of democracy? I say no war  
can answer what remains so fundamental. But why  
only *Greeks* and their inheritors have wrestled with this question  
is more likely to bear fruit, and bear it soon.

## Something About Plato

26 April 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/something-about-plato/>

There's just something about Plato  
that led to his preservation. Was it  
the lofty ideals, or was it simply  
his extra gear, the secret room of the mind  
that would open to him, and him alone?  
If the latter, we do well to praise him  
but not to emulate him.

Only through turmoil  
does genius bear fruit. Many could grow  
but don't, because peace does not call out for  
change, only troubles bring change,  
only change summons genius, but genius  
endures. We do well to take care  
before summoning genius. We may not like  
what it says.

## Who are we?

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/who-are-we/>*

The peoples of the Mediterranean  
were always pretending to be gods  
or descended from gods or becoming  
like gods, and one wonders how far  
this can take us. If creatures  
like us act like gods, it would  
surely destroy us, but if we do not,  
then who are we?

## culmination

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/culmination/>*

You would think that by now  
we'd be perfect, we've striven  
so hard all these years  
that no pain could emerge  
which we could not destroy,  
that with gods on Olympus  
surrounded by heroes and victors  
of various wars and games  
we would celebrate, nectar  
in one hand, machines in the other,  
but why is this always just out of reach?

## The Way of the Night

26 April 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/the-way-of-the-night/>

Like no one's business, I entered  
the place of the skull, on a mission  
to root out those staining the temple.  
'Twas a dark and stormy time in my mind,  
but all indications say all is fine.  
After some deliberation, prepared  
for denial and banishment, into  
the tomb I crept, and was swept  
by a wind like no other, from beyond,  
toward death, but then also toward  
something outside of death, to some  
origin speaking through dreams. I  
believe it was something like truth,  
but not nature, for nature cares little  
for truth, or for us. It was empty,  
but this was alluring, a void that could  
drain the false fullness of things,  
so I leapt, and some part of me  
left me for ever, to wander the shores  
of Elysium, or else to die  
but to die in a way more refined,  
with more grace, with aplomb,  
in the way of the night.



## Little Bird

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/little-bird/>*

Little bird sings of the break of spring,  
new wonders appear, but a soft note  
of warning reminds her companions  
that some dangers lurk past horizons.

## Good Eyes

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/good-eyes/>*

I was born sighted in a tribe of the blind,  
who, never seeing, are never aware that there  
are things to be seen. I was born  
nonetheless, and pay homage for that,  
if for little that followed. With my eyes  
I've seen man betray man, finding pleasure  
in cruelty, time after time, but no wonder,  
since wonderful things must be seen.  
Would you like me to help with your unbelief?

## Untold Misery

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/untold-misery/>*

How can there have been so much  
and be so little remaining? Time  
with its cup of lethe, panacea,  
so they say. But what good is it,  
being lost, without even wounds for guidance?

## Wallow

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/wallow/>*

Who can stand them, obsessed  
with appearing divine, only half aware  
of humanity or of its frailty,  
lost in the heavens pulled earthward  
to wallow away from it all.

## Duty

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/duty/>*

There are those who accept the old Duty  
and those who make smashing a Duty,  
but where are those moving past Duty?

## Some Other

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/some-other/>*

Upon the way backward  
to what Plato meant  
(it's for you, bon esprit, all for you)  
in this desert I stand  
with no road and no path and no map  
and where even the sky is blank  
and I wonder what anything means  
in this way, with myself to blame  
or to praise for the barren expanse,  
but not satisfied owning it,  
searching instead for some other  
whose cause is as good as my own.

## **The Protestant**

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/the-protestant/>*

The Protestant weeps  
alone in the corner,  
his own priest,  
and not a very good one.

## Contrition

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/contrition/>*

I believe we are waiting for Caesar,  
although we won't like when he comes.  
Diversity often breeds unity,  
but by the sword, through an act of contrition.  
If Greece, if Rome, if Persia, if England  
succumbed to this, what hope have we?  
Praise the emperor? Thus keep your head?



## The Scientist

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/the-scientist/>*

The scientist pauses, haunched  
like a cat of the mind, poised  
for pouncing, emboldened by Truth  
which has turned out to be a simple case  
of precision in measurement. He is  
ready for mysteries to explain themselves  
clearly, distinctly, without hesitation.  
But after the clock strikes five,  
as he hangs up his lab coat,  
a question arises which he  
is unable to answer:  
what are we to measure?  
and how shall we choose?

## Stop the Bombing

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/stop-the-bombing/>*

Amazing isn't it, how easily one now  
can say what once got one killed.  
But if one or if many rebel, one  
must ask, to what purpose? If done  
as a duty and not mere licentiousness,  
surely some pause is demanded, or even  
required. So stop the bombing, so  
Christ is risen, and so the new faith,  
when it comes.

## **Monotheism**

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/monotheism/>*

Will monotheism suffice?  
Or must we look under?  
Revise the old questions,  
discover the author(s) of nature.

Are they One? Or Many?  
If many, are they equally wonderful?

## Menagerie of Rules

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/menagerie-of-rules/>*

There are no universalizable maxims,  
no fixed rules, no solid ground  
which we could bring from place to place.  
All rules are local, but perhaps there are  
good habits, good technique, for those  
who swim within the sea, that cold  
menagerie of rules which never ends.

## The Thin Veil

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/the-thin-veil/>*

How many graves will it take before  
somebody notices? Aye, you will say  
some have noticed before, but few feel  
what the dying must feel. Let me tell you,  
it is not less hostile than life, nor  
more cold than compassionless love.  
You will answer, but I cannot hear,  
being rapt by the shimmering veil,  
the thin veil that divides men from murder  
and rustles against drums of war.

## They May Be Right

26 April 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/they-may-be-right/>

I was here before, but did not know it.  
Now I know, but that has not made me any wiser.  
See the lovers entwined on the beach before dawn.  
Unassuming teachers, little did they know that I saw.  
But rising beyond them the sea was a formless expanse.  
The light broke through the horizon and cracked the surface.  
I could not remember who I was waiting to meet.  
It was like every dawn in uniqueness, though still being dawn.  
As the lovers shuffled I saw ever clearer day coming.  
It was and was not meant for them, nor for me.  
The shadows grew longer but this time that just felt okay.  
The lovers departed before the full sun was in sight.  
I have never doubted the feeling that they may be right.

## Where They Can See You

*26 April 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/where-they-can-see-you/>*

Your feelings may threaten their power,  
but always remember that they  
once had feelings, before they were monsters,  
and could feel again. Until then, remain wary,  
and do not cross where they can see you.

## Wait, Think, Speak

26 April 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/04/wait-think-speak/>

Stillborn I fell through the silence of water  
past life-forms and fishes uncouth to my eyes  
and descended, awakening once more in Asia,  
no longer afraid. She was cunning and charming  
but little did I know she'd tempt me  
to give myself up for her dream, that that dream  
was the flower of five-thousand years. What was I  
in her thrall? Just a subject of political  
experimentation, unburdened of freedom, near dead  
with remorse or from absence of light. I would  
counter with energy pure from the true well  
of Hellas, or if this too sickens, then  
out of the well of humanity, some substance comes.  
And I take it and groan at the weight of it,  
knowing though that such is mine, throughout time,  
and that only tomorrow will tell what we do here  
but I for one lend time my hand and my ear,  
and by this you will know me, for this is my sign,  
this remembrance of time in its service despite  
the loud claims that all clocks are manmade  
and need manual winding. My silence  
speaks volumes against these blasphemers,  
who never could wait, think, or speak.



## Banishing Night

16 June 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/banishing-night/>

No great poet has ever made a difference,  
for he could not have been other than he was.  
He could *only* sing, and by singing bring  
hope. But no matter. Do suns make a difference,  
or do they just shine, as if banishing night?

## Eudaimonia

*16 June 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/eudaimonia/>*

In a room of thinkers, I was quiet,  
until each had taken his turn. I heard  
the arguments of Socrates and Zoroaster  
firmly interrupted by Confucius, who thought  
he might intervene and end the struggle.  
But all any of them wanted was to understand  
what man is, even Nietzsche, who embarrassed  
countless Germans, and his protégé, one  
Heidegger, who smoothed those rougher edges.  
Now all thinking ever was was thinking,  
this much we endorse, as thinkers,  
as the only ones. But what of friends  
sent from afar? Brought near by ritual?  
Is not this eudaimonia?

## **Some Men**

*16 June 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/some-men/>*

Some men are born  
with insatiable drive  
to ascend the mountain of History,  
to go to the source of river Culture  
and drink her voluptuous streams.

## Rolling Waves

*16 June 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/rolling-waves/>*

I am going out to sea,  
wish you would join me.  
It is rough to go alone,  
and no fair hands can grasp  
the terrors that await those  
who set sail. But do go with me,  
and I'll promise you enlightenment  
without the heavy falsehoods  
of the earthbound ways of man.  
I hope you'll understand.  
I have no more remorse for life  
than dead men have for dying,  
but the rolling waves are calling  
all the same.

## Corporate Man

16 June 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/corporate-man/>

It's a god! It's a hero!  
No! It's Corporate Man!  
Able to leap reality in a single bound!  
Able to fulfill all wishes!  
Just sign on the dotted line!  
Free from the shackles of justice!  
Free of all badges of honor!  
Who can defeat him?  
Not even his mother or father restrain him now!  
He is master of both earth and time!  
He begets even these exclamations!

## Habits

*16 June 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/habits/>*

Where is it going, this spiralling void  
of the mind of Hegel, sent Nowhere  
on purpose, to dream in some darkened cocoon?  
I say off with it, off with the fuzzy delusions  
of Reason, whatever their object, and on to  
the habits conducive to honor and hope.

## Uncivilized After All These Years

*16 June 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/uncivilized-after-all-these-years/>*

By the power invested in the personless rationality  
of the universal world-spirit or whatever, we wait here  
uncivilized after all these years.

## Pain That One Calls Home

16 June 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/the-pain-that-one-calls-home/>

We are out here searching for something,  
a meaning of some kind, some explanation,  
but all that we really needed was in us,  
they say, all along. Is it, though? Or  
are we still adrift in a godless nothing,  
at last on the verge of discovering  
forms that administer the pain  
that one calls home?



## Saying New Sayings

*16 June 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/saying-new-sayings/>*

The Supreme Intelligence in all of its forms  
must be killed, but then maybe it's already  
taken a mortal blow, dealt by wizards  
of German extraction, and some  
have moved on, some have not,  
but how are we to organize  
friendship in commerce, political life,  
or religion, without the old sayings?  
Perhaps start by saying new sayings?

## Both How and Why

*16 June 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/both-how-and-why/>*

It is unwise to blame bad sheep  
for bad shepherding. Where are the  
greener pastures? Not near the factories,  
that much is sure, but one also begins  
to wonder if shepherds have ever known,  
or if they have simply usurped  
both the crook and the staff, out of lust  
for power. But then, some sheep thrive  
and we must ask them both how and why.

## Ideal Republic

16 June 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/ideal-republic/>

Asia has had no ideal republic,  
no city of God, and yet notice  
how greatly she prospers. Must we  
then continue to dream a false city  
or can we live *here* and live *now* and live *well*?

## **Flying Lessons**

*16 June 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/flying-lessons/>*

Soaring bird large  
and bird small  
explore sky  
both entwined

## No Single Force

*16 June 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/no-single-force/>*

I think that we know  
very little, that what we predict  
may come true, or may not,  
that no laws constrain nature,  
that nature is plural,  
that no single force drives it all.

## Dreams

16 June 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/dreams/>

When I consider the teenagers over the way,  
I'm amazed that they have not been disciplined,  
growing so free and inviolate, much like I was  
when I thought men could grow up like trees  
and touch clouds. Now I know, as we say,  
growing never gets old, and all youth is perennial,  
transferred across generations, but what is  
this secret? If not the true meaning, how  
shall we decipher one deeper? The struggle  
for youth to make good its ambition for harmony  
shall never die, though we shall. Shall we  
scold them? I say it's no use, because  
life is quite able to punish them all on its own.  
Let them dream, and let us still remember  
that dreams are the province of youth, across time,  
even ours.

## Better Judgment

*16 June 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/better-judgment/>*

It is time to reflect, to remember  
what words have been spoken, to justify  
all that precedes who we are. It's not easy,  
like life, and like all of life's dreams.  
But go with me toward it, and we  
shall be we, not afraid or unbalanced as they,  
but as free, we shall breathe different airs,  
contra Kennedy, and against our better judgment.

## What Surprises Remain

16 June 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/what-surprises-remain/>

With a small bit of horsepower,  
with little to lose, I have gone  
and sublated Hegel, just as  
he requires, but what, then, remains?  
If not Plato or Aristotle, maybe Aquinas?  
But these three won't do  
in a world that grows tired of λόγος.  
Let's try on Confucius,  
and see what surprises remain.



## Blank Space

*16 June 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/06/blank-space/>*

In a field of blank space  
a German appeared, out of nothing,  
and talked to himself of becoming,  
and was not afraid.

*28 July 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/wouldnt-it-be-nice/>*

Wouldn't it be nice if we  
could live morally, as heaven-sent,  
not as we are. Would it be  
nice, to free ourselves from dark  
places, to glide in the shimmer of light?

*28 July 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/clarity-is-like-death/>*

Clarity is like death, disallowing  
surprises, and hardly the one  
to revise what one knows,  
what one is, and the tragedy  
comes when one little expects it.

## **Inexorably Ever After**

*28 July 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/inexorably-ever-after/>*

Is it time for a new beginning?  
Have we gone past the great men  
and their great trails of corpses,  
or do we still dwell in their shadow?

I say time will tell, and she always does tell,  
as she will, as she must, inexorably ever after.

## **Spiraling**

*28 July 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/spiraling/>*

Spiraling, spiraling, into the whirl,  
asking what is the value of heaven,  
no longer unsure, yet in peril  
lest someone acknowledge all mysteries.

## This Way Forever

28 July 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/this-way-forever/>

I have been trying toaster ovens,  
and all of them make me sick.  
It's a wonder how far we have come.  
The design is immaculate, the interface delightful,  
the fumes so toxic I could die.  
I have been testing toaster ovens  
just to find out what I've known all along,  
that the smiles of the marketers lie,  
that we live at the mercy of industry  
(never one known for its mercy).  
I've been testing ovens like propositions,  
but this simply can't be refuted:  
I dislike machines and their toxins,  
and will not accept  
that we have to live this way forever.

*28 July 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/in-the-depths-of-it/>*

In the depths of it, wondering  
why the Chinese have still never  
become good Englishmen (mysteries abound)  
and, still further, why Palmerston  
thought good to try...

## **Bind**

*28 July 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/bind/>*

Wonder, wonder of the mind,  
what has we humans in a bind?  
If not too-certain categories,  
maybe too much wind?



## Moldy Thinking

*28 July 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/moldy-thinking/>*

I can smell disaster ahead,  
but nobody will listen. It's like  
moldy thinking, the kind that has  
sat in the sun for too long, gazing  
stupidly skyward, festering,  
waiting to be discarded.

## To Even Have a Dream

28 July 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/to-even-have-a-dream/>

What a crazy *swirl* life is,  
when stress subsides, when freedom  
breathes again. It is like liberty  
was never taken captive by an empire,  
or like spirit never had to stand in line.  
But we can't live here, not like this,  
not as we are, for we are more than dreams,  
we mammals, who need sustenance to dream.

## **I have known women**

*28 July 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/i-have-known-women/>*

I have known women (I have known them well)  
but what women are thinking I never shall tell,  
for one dreams of a home as one dreams to be free,  
and another is cursed by the blessings in me.  
I shall answer with questions and this much avow,  
that the life of the living is death anyhow,  
but the solitude curses the wanderer fair  
with the foul and pestilent, pitiless, bare,  
until ragged or richly he comes to surmise  
that with women he was at least somewhat prized.  
But too late, alas, they have all found their homes,  
as he sups with the misers and picks at the bones.

## A Raid on Delphi

28 July 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/a-raid-on-delphi/>

We were the last to arrive, and by then  
it had all been taken — the gold, the weapons,  
the scrolls — but how little we knew, thinking  
we with our plans could best Fate. Call it  
Hubris, whatever it was, but don't tell us  
to kneel before gods who spoke Greek, even here.  
We are here to rob temples whose keepers  
have long since passed out of Memory,  
brought by temptation or will to power,  
to seek restitution for years of disgrace,  
but not here. Even here there are ghosts,  
where the skeletons slumber for ages,  
where rough beasts, awaiting the turn of the wheel,  
shriek to fever at mankind's injustice  
and roll out new images and gods.

## Arrival

28 July 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/arrival/>

I have been on a journey towards myself,  
but how shall I ever arrive (who arrives?)

Like America, I am a mixed breed,  
but that is not to say I am formless.

We are all of us formed by each other,  
including the others both past and future.

I have been on a journey towards myself,  
but arriving is never that simple.

The others have been on a journey too,  
towards me and away from me.

I must care for them, since we have formed each other,  
and hope they will care for me too.

This is the one who arrives.

## In the Field

28 July 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/in-the-field/>

As I survey my field, I remember  
how last season's crop came up fallow.  
The soil has had no time to heal  
and the seed is exhausted and shallow.  
I know what I have to do now,  
though it pains me to look on the barren  
and doubt that here ever could grow  
something worthy of effort. But pain  
could be pain of new birth, not this field  
or this labor, but pain from some far away effort  
to find a new field and to build a hearth near it  
where children could play in the morning  
and old men retire at evening,  
but children would notice the dearth of the field  
of the hollow seed, and would surely have questions  
as I, gazing blankly at Nothing, remain  
unresponsive. Oh well, it was nice as a dream,  
though the field and myself are the same,  
and though nothing has changed,  
I must gaze at it, penetrating  
into some essence not well understood or explained,  
like an artist, but not like a rabid one,  
waiting for what's there to speak. Of this field  
I know nothing, hear nothing, and therefore  
expect to grow nothing. It's always this way  
with such fields, which were not well maintained,  
though it happens in even good fields.  
I do not tell my neighbor what to do with his field,  
and I ask for the same in return,  
but in my case, I'll know when my field has run dry  
not to hope it will grow if I try.

## Where it Belongs

28 July 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/where-it-belongs/>

I am coming to the point,  
this time for certain. With you  
standing there, I had simply forgotten  
society, lost in your ocean of words,  
not yet sure, but approaching it,  
waiting for final discovery. True,  
you were not one to wait in the past  
nor the present, but always going  
just one step further, then another.  
I never could figure out who you were,  
but the message came in loud and clear:  
there's a baby asleep in the road,  
and somebody has got to remind it  
of where it belongs.

## The House of the Dead

28 July 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/07/the-house-of-the-dead/>

He had only begun to understand  
when lightning came to slice the branch  
clean off the bough. It wouldn't matter anyhow  
without her or the scent of her still lingering  
as though to ask a question though afraid.  
It wouldn't matter, as all ages past can fail  
to mean a thing, unlike the scent of one  
familiar flesh, though this place houses souls.  
I ask for a friend what purpose has redemption  
after love, for who regrets the love? The pain,  
indeed regrettable, will satisfy Osiris, who,  
by any other name, enlists the dead  
into the legions of sweet peril, lost  
in strife, lest loss of love revive their ire.  
Tell me, Pharaoh, whether any Isis waits  
to mock the dead back into living forms?

---

Come again, sweet spirit, to my chamber,  
whence these dreams enlist the tumult  
of the darkened days of man  
to find what gems were left behind  
beneath the pile of burning coals.  
Come and wander to the bottom  
whence death carries all who dare,  
but do take care — you are not one of them  
just yet. I ask your help. This excavation  
will take years, and we have time to sit and chat  
about what might have been. I'll tell you,  
there are many things to learn, but few to love,  
and by that God who lives above one suffers bitterly,  
but what is to be done remains obscure.

---

Perhaps begin by thinking on new avenues,  
then stopping to inquire why these structures, why this order.  
But do not be late for dinner, which revives you,  
like the hero back from Lethe in the dream of old,



for this is where hope lies. We are in chains, it has been said,  
but now with sun-parched eyes we look again and see  
the cave itself in motion, hurling madly through the void.  
Will all things be destroyed? And are the chains themselves  
our safety during impact? How much Freedom does a man need?  
And who else could do our work, and do it well?

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Come let us mock the automatons  
and the free spirits, with equal measure.

*17 August 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/08/in-this-hour-of-wakening/>*

In this hour of waking, what spirit comes  
to revive even these cold remains? What revival  
awaits even these mossy chains? Is the sun  
to be trusted, or must we learn echolocation?  
I've little to gain by remaining unnamed,  
except freedom, most untrusty boon, but the path  
to formation is wrought with the trials of the hero.

*17 August 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/08/we-were-always-at-war-with-nature/>*

We were always at war with nature  
or in love with it, at all times not  
seeing clearly nor penetrating deeper than  
whatever suited our momentary fancy,  
but I for one saw her differently,  
not afraid to delve into her secrets  
even if it meant losing myself.

## **Leave Me**

*17 August 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/08/leave-me/>*

At sunset, the birds  
call me skyward with songs  
made of aether, but  
leave me untethered.

## Westward Ticket

*17 August 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/08/westward-ticket/>*

I have forgone my westward ticket  
and set up shop here. It is lonely  
for now, but that's not the worst thing.  
It's not worse than bad company.  
Sometimes the owls hoot at dusk,  
but I never have seen them fly.  
With a little more coaxing, perhaps.

## Sources II

*17 August 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/08/sources-ii/>*

In the dampness, a little resentment  
grows colder, untouched by the warmth  
of the sun, getting older and further  
removed from the Source. But what Source?  
Has this dream run its course, or is thinking  
just one of man's fundamentals? How could one  
think without causes of being?  
But are there not many sources?

## With Great Justice

*17 August 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/08/with-great-justice/>*

We were a people that never did wish to be led,  
having known all too well where paths lead and how  
leaders betray every confidence, sure as we were  
that negation was what kept things moving, we struggled  
to keep ourselves firm. But the sun always set  
of its own accord, unconcerned with our struggles  
and even providing false hope for a world ruled  
by cosmic order. Such hopes were a threat to the struggle  
and, therefore, ourselves, bent on instituting tyranny  
of various kinds. Oh how surely we knew what we knew,  
having mastered all lessons without even studying,  
graced as we must have been with inhuman strength.  
But a few in the wilderness still kept their tablets of stone,  
saying these, or if not, some like these, will one day  
restore order in a barren land, because savagery  
brings nothing new, but instead brings to rubble  
the works of a thousand years. The new order,  
whatever its form, will arise, and decay, and fall.  
After all, we are left where we started,  
both wary of leaders and craving them, both,  
it would seem, with great justice.

## **All Those Ages Ago**

*17 August 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/08/all-those-ages-ago/>*

What was the point of it all,  
the mad dash for adulthood, the scramble  
for something just over the next hill?  
We are here now, they tell us, but where  
and when, who can say? After all  
we are malleable still, in the flux  
as before, although firmer somehow,  
but not rigid. No, we are the end of the dream  
that began when our first parents met  
all those ages ago.



## Trust or Freedom

*17 August 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/08/trust-or-freedom/>*

We can either have trust or freedom,  
but they are opposed and cannot coexist.  
We have gambled on freedom, but  
whether we're happy remains to be seen.  
Whether happiness can be found anywhere  
also remains to be seen. But perhaps  
just a little more trust would leaven the dough.

## Hitler's Grave

*17 August 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/08/hitlers-grave/>*

I went to Hitler's grave the other day,  
just off the beaten path, through rows of trees,  
the smell of sulphur lingering. It was a quiet place,  
not oft disturbed, but on the stone I saw  
a clump of roses, dying though not dead.  
Someone had left them, as if hoping  
even here in man's best nature. I was touched  
and yet disturbed, but it occurred to me  
that Hitler may have liked the smell of roses  
or the sun upon his face, as we all do,  
and that his favor had not made these things less good,  
nor had his crimes. If we but had the time,  
we might rehearse his glory and his shame,  
but we are fading, through this age into the next,  
and soon this grave will not remain, replaced by new ones.  
What is left to say? I picked up the bouquet  
and plucked the rarest, left that one as a memento,  
brought the rest back to the living,  
where they may still do some good.

## Through All Our Fears

23 September 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/09/through-all-our-fears/>

I have found my way now to the nether regions,  
all those dark places beyond all prevailing conventions,  
where silence rules and where strange plants grow.  
I am writing to you with a vision long seen  
but just recently put into words. I have heard you  
are eager for change, but that's what I know well,  
and it's never quite what you'd expect. Listen closely.  
The only way through is on *your* legs, with blood  
pumped by *your* heart, which comes from your parents.  
There is no deeper mystery than why we abide together,  
despite all our squabbling, despite all our fears.

## Rapt Futility

23 September 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/09/rapt-futility/>

Strange to sit here in the light  
while all outside is bathed in night,  
and strange to sit, and think, and write,  
while others chase utility.

Had you expected something stern,  
that each cold strophe would take its turn  
in chains, for they are English-born  
in rapt futility?

Surely one knows better now.  
It doesn't matter anyhow.  
The day that dawns awaits us,  
and there are so many things to know.

## Walking the Line

23 September 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/09/walking-the-line/>

From the darkness, a leader  
would sometimes emerge to remind  
of original covenants, binding through time,  
but I have not the mind to dispute  
the dark facts, nor the heart to unwind  
the calf caught in the web. No, they come  
from another direction, the province of vanity,  
sour by years of neglect in an empire  
of vanity chasing vanity. Whence, then,  
this song? From the light? What light dares  
to escape the embrace of a vanity  
cherished by all in the depths of their souls?  
Only this little light of mine, only this,  
throughout time, to the ends of the mind  
and back here, of this essence, here  
walking the line.

## That which wants to be said

*23 September 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/09/that-which-wants-to-be-said/>*

No one is happy, nor has one ever been,  
and the future remains unpropitious (as Possum  
scurries back to his hole), but I still stand here  
speaking, aware of the Something outside of the Nothing,  
to say that which wants to be said.

## Kennedy's Peace

23 September 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/09/kennedys-peace/>

Thoughts go once more to John Kennedy,  
thoughts that were lost, only here to revive  
through abstraction the dream of world peace,  
international dream, silly dream in the final analysis,  
lost as man is in identities, cages of spirit,  
and yet through the din of the bombs I can hear it  
speak clearly and truly that something has got to change.  
Oh, that change never comes (surely never)  
which brings peace on earth while men live, 'til men leave it,  
but change in our stars has arrived from the east  
which may free us for both peace and war.

The peace movement has its Christ  
and awaits its Constantine.

## A Typical Day

*23 September 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/09/a-typical-day/>*

On a typical day, all the typical people  
go down to the river to play, the most  
normal of folk, acting normally, day by day.  
But outside of the current one stands  
on firm ground, with strong legs, and skips rocks  
to learn how much the current can say,  
and to test its vibrations for permanence,  
longing for such, disappointed so far,  
one who knows one must learn in this way,  
because soon comes a time of the flood,  
and somebody must watch night and day.



## We Silly Mammals

*23 September 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/09/we-silly-mammals/>*

It turns out the song  
of the stars is out of key,  
that no melody wraps all that lives  
in a blanket of Reason or gives  
civilization its name. No,  
just we silly mammals, together,  
unfolding potentials, discovering holes  
in the firmament, forever.

## Strangeness of the Ordinary

*23 September 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/09/strangeness-of-the-ordinary/>*

I suppose we should thank Wallace Stevens  
for showing the strangeness of the ordinary,  
though one wonders now whether strangeness  
offers a home. Is the ordinary, home?  
If it's not, I don't know what it is.  
If it's not, is there anything more to say?

## Submission in Disguise

*23 September 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/09/submission-in-disguise/>*

Outer peace demands inner war.  
Only outer war and its victory  
bring inner peace, in cases  
of irreconcilable difference, but  
can any difference truly reconcile  
with its other (Hegel notwithstanding)  
or is this just submission in disguise?

## Someone Tell Wittgenstein

*23 September 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/09/someone-tell-wittgenstein/>*

Someone tell Wittgenstein that Europe alone  
lives inside of the fly-bottle, ravenous for more  
by design. Whose design?

## Through the Horizon

*23 September 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/09/through-the-horizon/>*

First day on the job, I walked  
into the factory, noticed the machines  
did not want me, and left. The pay  
was extraordinary, but ended abruptly  
as soon as they saw that some part  
of myself was impervious to their  
designs, having been forged by time  
and not dreamed in a fit of industrialization.  
But what ended exactly? I found,  
as the door closed behind me, a new  
sense of purpose, and tasted fresh salt  
in the air, though I didn't look back,  
and I'll never forget how the sun felt  
that first day of freedom, or how it fell  
through the horizon, like so many times before.

## **The Most Peaceful Stream**

*29 October 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/10/the-most-peaceful-stream/>*

I was always a wanderer, born  
in the land of Nod, never still  
under one heaven, trying them all,  
ever restless, and moving like water  
through the most peaceful stream you have seen.

## From Time to Time

29 October 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/10/from-time-to-time/>

Philosophers are the leaves of the family tree,  
not seeking to start new branches, absorbing sunlight  
to nourish the rest of the tree. It begs the question  
whether life is, as they suspect, a torture chamber  
with no reward for participation, or whether the sun,  
in fact, demands to see a show. I wouldn't know,  
although the view among the trees is charming  
this time of the year, as all the leaves are changing,  
turning yellow, red, and brown, in preparation for  
the dying of the sun. When day is done, and when  
the summer fully fails, the leaves remain a blanket  
on the ground, which at least fertilizes  
all the coming trees. But more importantly,  
the leaves sustained the tree through one more season  
of the carnage of the air, always aware  
that their own purpose lay in growing future trees  
through self-demise, and not in nursing these  
that happen to be present, rather yearning,  
rather reaching for that sunlight, which replenishes the earth  
from time to time.

## **A New Way**

*29 October 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/10/a-new-way/>*

Can we handle another Kennedy, or will he  
just die like the others, unable to bring to fruition  
the will of the people? And what do the people will?  
The fiction of peace "for all time" is disturbing  
for those who think time is indomitable, yet  
this is no worse than all Catholic thought.  
But the question of truth against power lives on,  
and continues to draw cheering crowds. Give us Liberty, then,  
or death, but when you will oppress us,  
if you find a new way, we'll obey.



## Stronger Knowledge

29 October 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/10/stronger-knowledge/>

From Kant we have taken the fruit  
of the knowledge of self and other,  
and never again shall we live within  
Christendom, banished instead to the East,  
where they've known for all time  
that our knowledge evolves over time, though  
they've rarely fretted over the details.  
Armed with our *much stronger* knowledge,  
we'll march into capitals, ready to conquer  
all change, but it's not been the same  
since God died. We must ask ourselves  
*why* we must fight for ideas, when fighting  
hurts bodies (including our own), for philosophers  
rarely make excellent role models. Neither do saints.  
Shall we imitate businessmen? Who else remains  
in a nonsacral culture, devoted to ego?  
It's only opponent, the Christians, pray on with eyes closed  
though the dome of the church falls around them.

## The Abbey

29 October 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/10/the-abbey/>

I saw her atop the stair, so long ago,  
and I decided to go to the abbey to pray,  
but I found it disheartening to see the men  
all shackled with crimson ideals, the blood hardly dry  
before new lashes opened the next season's wounds.  
I was bound to discover these treacheries only  
through silence, the prayer of the anchorite  
screaming inside for the violence to cease,  
as her smile could not soothe every malice  
nor carve out a home where love only could live.

In the end, I chose freedom,  
but not without heartache and not without shame.

## Turning the Page

*29 October 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/10/turning-the-page/>*

Turning the page in the saga  
of purposeless suffering, with never  
a νόστος, a paradiso, a denouement,  
the machines are in charge, and until  
this fact changes, we're not, but before  
we can take back the reins, we must  
find who exactly we are.

## Discard Them Already

29 October 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/10/discard-them-already/>

Who would have thought such a thing had a spirit,  
or that it would govern us poorly, with iron grip?  
Maybe Hegel or Marx, but to us with our battle fatigue  
at its climax, their words feel so hollow and trite,  
as with all of our might we endure in a race  
suited more to machines than to rats...and what *is* man,  
after all? Does he think, even so? And by thinking, produce  
ever new ways of doing, procedure after procedure after procedure,  
as new as the rising sun? The machines have not taken this much.  
They are just one iteration of the latest procedure, so quickly  
outdated we might as well discard them already.

## Bones (How Things Stand)

29 October 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/10/bones-how-things-stand/>

Someone must put into words how things stand,  
not to silence the critics or win some shallow victory,  
but only to make ourselves clear – who we are  
and why – because when we are gone, there must be  
some memento. Our children deserve that much, and more,  
and although we are sure that we know what we know,  
they will doubt it, so someone must put into words  
how things stand, for they *do* stand, by miracle, time after time.

---

Or is the miracle within us after all?  
These are difficult questions, but good ones.  
One wonders whether in the final analysis  
the children's children will look on their grandparents  
with pity, as toward a girl who has had an abusive father  
who fears that all men are abusive. Is all government  
bloodthirsty? Or have we just deep collective wounds  
from some prior injustices, burned in our memories? Caligula,  
what a monster, and don't forget Nero, and of course  
there were Hitler and Stalin...

At some point the prophecy fulfills itself.  
We get more of the things we attend to.  
The war against tyranny ensures more tyranny.  
Whence comes the miracle?

From somewhere within, or maybe somewhere without,  
but its origin means less than its presence.  
It comes.

---

Virtue comes and goes, there's a new thought,  
and whether you think it or not, it occurs,  
the proverbial tree in the forest that makes a sound,  
though the sound is ourselves, though nobody has ears to hear it.  
It's what they call Spirit, although it is also  
much more than that. It may live in our bones  
and our ancestors' bones, and whatever their phobias,

whatever their misguided fancies, those phobias  
guide us as instinct and intuition, the memory  
of thousands of years of trial and error  
with occasional insight, recorded through joy and through exaltation  
in the bodies of those who live through it.

Why do we show such respect for old bones  
if it's not because bones house the past,  
and deep down we suspect that our present  
will one day in total be bones?  
Could it be that things stand on their bones,  
that the boneless are formless, sans history,  
without any direction or purpose?

## The House of the Dead II

23 November 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/11/the-house-of-the-dead-ii/>

I remember, back when it all started,  
somebody explained that I'd gained  
for my trouble a "foot in the door,"  
but the room smelled like death,  
and nobody else cared or noticed.  
Much worse, later on, I discovered  
that most of the others had acclimated,  
now even preferring that smell  
to the smell of the earth, which,  
though also containing death, has strong notes  
of rebirth, which the house of the dead  
seems to lack and refuses to even acknowledge.

## Doctor of Words

23 November 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/11/doctor-of-words/>

There is a madness, a kind of playful  
spirit-imp, that seizes me with joy  
when comes a time to speak my mind.  
I wish you'd listen, but I'll settle for  
your nonchalance, compared to those with stones,  
which do break bones (though yes, words hurt  
more than the many know, and that explains the joy).  
But don't forget that wounders must be wounded  
'til they learn their place, and that explains my purpose  
as the doctor of words, receiving patients constantly,  
applying salves, and burning, cutting, trimming as required.



## Still More

23 November 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/11/still-more/>

Under the earth, in a cavern man-made  
and yet lacking all purpose, the people gather  
to discuss their impending doom. They have no more to say,  
but as each goes his way, all discover that all ways  
lead here, to this cavern. And thus their ennui.  
But a light from above mostly frightens them,  
hurting their eyes. For it is not the sun. It's a man  
with a flashlight and little respect.  
But the man lacks respect just to shine them like that,  
both exposing their nakedness and blinding them.  
They will not trust him, not after a time and a turn  
in his light, so he goes on amusing himself (and to no other purpose),  
when suddenly the east wall collapses  
and all of the people observe there the others  
who look familiar but who have no annoying flashlight,  
and suddenly they wonder whether theirs is really the only cavern  
or whether they might find still more.

## Origins II

*23 November 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/11/origins-ii/>*

In a reverie, I still recall  
how before, when approaching to  
nature's fire, I saw her, the one  
of the dream, yet more real  
than all life, and I asked her  
how much was required. She said  
all and meant it. I knew  
that she wasn't for me, but  
for others, that this lonely audience  
rarely was given, and that,  
having heard, I must speak,  
but speak where, and speak how?  
In a reverie, there and there only,  
where dreams can be tamed and where man  
may discover his origins, yearning.

## Ready For Change

23 November 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/11/ready-for-change/>

Sunrise, after a long doubt, and  
our journey resumes, the one started before  
stars were named, toward Ashtoreth, maybe  
toward some Valhalla, but certainly ours,  
here and now. In this legacy, sorcerers  
fail to revive, and time passes, as always.  
If only the stars would align, like before,  
when hope meant something, mankind could rise  
and be sure, but our stars float awry,  
too disturbed by each other  
to fly or to guide human eyes.

---

Is it Dawn, and if so, does she come  
from the East, or have we been deceived  
for long ages about where hope dwells,  
what hope is? In the East, Magi  
suffer oppression, and others toil on,  
so what dawn could they bring here,  
where stars have stopped shining out meaning?  
What dawn...further east, in Kung-Fu Tzse's house,  
now the master is homeless, his unfilial children  
rejecting his lessons in favor of permanent revolution.  
Not here, no, keep looking...

When Dawn comes, it comes with a bang,  
but it leaves with a whimper,  
as previously observed,  
but this time is so different, so new!  
Are there flowers? And why?  
When it comes it just comes of its own accord.

---

What is *future*? What *history*?  
If not just a mallet for striking one's enemies,  
if really a there-to-behold, even now, in potentia,  
the newborn first imitating father and mother,  
then leaving the den to seek out its own place

among stars, among earth, with the words that were spoken  
remembered and cherished, together with others  
together for now, then apart, then forgotten,  
but living throughout and within the tradition  
which echoes with words, with new words, always new,  
to remark what has been for posterity.

---

The newness of the day can cancel Nothing,  
see the self-negating spirit succeed  
and rid us of itself, with final vigor.  
No more piddling doubts or quibbling with the self,  
no more self-criticism or phony dialectics,  
only learning, only growing through surprise (there is  
no other way), and only strong souls daring thought  
(all others knowing thought is not their cause).  
Then free from terror, free from all the machinations  
of the empty revolutions, but still freer of what came before,  
we'll build, and start from Nothing, if we must,  
for 'tis with Nothing that our forbears stopped,  
and we go further, on into the formless cold  
of space eternal, warped by dreams of grids  
and all false representing symbols, such that  
we can actually believe we've mastered time,  
and that, like space, it is a thing of grids  
and not the source of mysteries and growth.

Enough of this, it has been said,  
but let me urge you one more time,  
pray do not fall for all you're told,  
despite the grandeur of the teller.  
But don't be a doubter-on-command.  
That is no better.

---

The point, the point...there must have been one,  
how else could we live, without purposes, lacking design?  
Yet we've failed to find it now time after time.  
So what sacred remains from the astral pyre  
await some old reinvigoration? The rough beasts  
have all come and gone, their day dies,  
and the new day is dawning, this time  
with less obstinance, no absolutes, and a people  
born ready for change.

## By Example

23 November 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/11/by-example/>

In the seventh year of the reign of Trump,  
we are floundering, just like before, as the businessmen  
sell us our candy and hula hoops, and government  
roves in search of destroying production. One wonders  
where all of the flourishing humans are, why  
none of their concerns matter here, in an empire  
now far out and well on its way, toward what? If the coming election  
brings blood, you may say that I warned you, but I think you knew it  
already, though it may lie buried by mountains of nonsense  
and oceans of shame. All the same, we strive on toward glory  
and know not whence hope comes nor whether our lives can be tamed,  
whether here in America still lives that germ of empowerment  
that once, twice, and hence fuels revolt, and if so, whither,  
where it will go, in the body in which we are parts. If we know  
that the swamp has its sickness, malarial as always, that sickness  
is sabotage, the purposeful undermine of confidence, always and everywhere,  
and not in the spirit of philosophy proper (which by its very name  
implies friendship) but rather with sick dialectics, designed to kill masters  
and liberate slaves. It turns out that the masters know better  
(to no one's surprise) and without them we're nothing, although  
the enslaving did get a little out of hand. But is mastery itself  
to blame? Or is competence simply essential to flourishing?  
No, there are ways to progress unlike this, with less venom,  
with generous friendship from first to last, by example.

## Crossroads

*23 November 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/11/crossroads/>*

Where do we go from here, when so much has been said  
and so little believed and followed through? Is there empire  
within us, or are we provincials at best, better suited to woodsmanship,  
hunting for wild game? It is always the same with such peoples  
who grow to our size, but the differences make all the difference.  
You can tell that I'm joking, but this much is serious:  
America stands at a crossroads. Which path shall we take?

## **Pliable by Nature**

*23 November 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/11/pliable-by-nature/>*

No one has a sure foundation,  
not now or ever, for all  
are made pliable by nature,  
and this too is good.

## Red Tinge on East Star

*18 December 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/12/red-tinge-on-east-star/>*

Alone in my hills, on a night growing cold,  
I look over those hills, and I see you, East Star,  
shining dimly, not quite as one hoped.  
But you do shine and join the night sky,  
granting light if not heat, but a little of both.  
But pray tell me, why does your light glide  
as if governed by my sky, with some point of reference  
in Western constellation? We would like to see you  
in your sky, which is sky enough.



## Home From Elysium

*18 December 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/12/home-from-elysium/>*

As Bach and Beethoven encoded  
the new German Freedom in music,  
so too will I write of our freedom  
from fantasy and all metaphysical guile,  
to teach with a smile the hard truths  
of man's station on earth, and to hope  
for rebirth from the slime, and at last  
bring the soldiers home from Elysium,  
battered, exhausted, and ready to build a life *here*.

## Out on the Frontier

*18 December 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/12/out-on-the-frontier/>*

In the morning, one hardly  
sees clearly, but lately I've noticed  
the goal remains not to succeed  
but to fail in the same way  
as everyone else. In those cases  
where failure is common, success becomes  
dangerous — therefore, let's fail,  
as our parents before us have failed,  
and not dare to succeed like those  
brazen and ostracized weirdos  
out on the frontier.

## Who Does the Promising?

*18 December 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/12/who-does-the-promising/>*

When will the promises of science  
come true? Or are they, like most promises,  
intended to deceive? I see over the horizon  
a world in which men live by deeds  
and not promises – one where the future  
is present in embryo, really there and perceived,  
but not promised, for who does the promising,  
and why should we trust them instead of ourselves?

## More Than One Power

*18 December 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/12/more-than-one-power/>*

The Romans did not like surprises (the Greeks did!)  
and we are left asking (for five-hundred years now)  
just how, how much certainty man can afford,  
and if not up to Rome's standard, whom shall we serve?  
Not the Greeks, with their autonomic failures,  
and not now the English instead, who resemble the Romans  
quite certainly. No, no, the Germans won't salvage us either...  
I think what we need is a *new* kind of certainty,  
firm in action but pliable in negotiation, because,  
after all, there are more than one power, and we need our allies  
to know that.

## To the Girl Behind the Pharmacy Counter

18 December 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/12/to-the-girl-behind-the-pharmacy-counter/>

You with the smile, asking favors with eyes only,  
yes, I remember you too. But this is not the time  
for a dance or the courting of pairs. You have asked me  
to take my time, and I shall, as I linger over  
what time has brought me. Not the east, or the sun,  
but just you, with all faults still at this moment concealed.  
Shall we remember fondly this meeting when hours of argument  
wrangle our spirits, or when we find habits distasteful  
which each of us cannot change? Yes, we shall, with disdain,  
for it's always the same, as the first blush transforms  
to the flush of rage, for we puppets on Nature's marionette.  
You can bet it will happen again, as it's happened before,  
even here, and to us, as we each go our ways  
through the spasms of time. But this is not the time for a lesson, either,  
when those eyes ask questions no poet could describe.  
So here is my answer. I cannot divulge all my purposes  
nor share with fellow traveller the path I have chosen.  
So adieu, night-wanderer. May you find a home  
and a love worth your while.

## Vesta

18 December 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/12/vesta/>

Vesta, guardian of eternal fire, what life  
hath thou in a time like this? Lord Vulcan  
rules o'er all, and we live by *his* flame,  
so what of yours? If winter comes, so be it,  
for as sure as we are flesh, we bathe  
in steel, and watch the lathe, the wheel  
coax mechanism into ghastly life. But Vesta,  
thou doth call out still within the soul  
to all those longing to be whole. Can hope arrive?  
Can hope come here, into this desecrated chamber  
of the Vestal orgy, long since over, haunted still by ghosts?  
They are our hosts, and like good guests we must  
not leave here empty-handed. We must take an icon  
to be cherished, and to grow into the newest love,  
the newest hope. That is within our scope.  
But Vesta, knowst thou where the balm resides,  
which once soothed aching souls and aching thighs?

## Touch

18 December 2023

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/12/touch/>

Let us walk, if you will, through the avenues  
of time, to the clarity of iron, a firmness  
once realized and never forgotten. Its age  
lives within us, with all ages past, in a soup  
we call history, in a place we call home.  
If we walk, we shall see that all men  
are the same, whether born now or later,  
that Progress is groundless, it swims in the aether.  
Machines have not changed what we are, nor has money,  
nor charity, law, or iron. The σπέρμα remains what it was,  
is now, and ever shall be, implanted by Vesta, a yearning  
for fullness, which all mammals know, though we may  
know it best. How has this been forgotten?  
How have we illustrious mammals  
lost *touch* with those things that define us?

## Rule By Consent

*18 December 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/12/rule-by-consent/>*

Until the day dies, until night covers all,  
they won't rest, they will hound and resound  
all the corners of man, to make adolescents all,  
make belief unacceptable, ravage all temples  
and ravish the priestess. Barbarians come  
and are already here, and quite powerful within city walls,  
but the People remember, they cannot forget,  
that the powerful rule by consent.



## Into the Sea

*18 December 2023*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/12/into-the-sea/>

Into the sea, the Mediterranean Sea,  
swim with me, past commander and legionary,  
past Athens, all temples of Zeus,  
and Jerusalem too; swim past Crete  
and the legends of Homer, and rest  
on the sea's cold floor. Here find solace,  
long sought by all moderns, and here find  
the end of all law and obedience,  
chthonic remonstrances, pulsing through time  
and the hearts of all men, underneath  
all ideals, in the bosom of earth,  
in the womb of all worlds. Under here,  
to the core, thirst no more, for these waters  
will satisfy, unlike those others  
that rain from the sky. But thus nourished,  
return and build shelters for you, and for others,  
to live in as much peace as possible.

## **Barrel of Monkeys**

*18 December 2023*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2023/12/barrel-of-monkeys/>*

What a barrel of monkeys,  
the whole human race,  
not an ounce of perspective,  
a drop of grace!

## **I speak for the people**

*12 January 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/01/i-speak-for-the-people/>*

I speak for the people when saying to the Christians  
that you do not get to tell us how to love. We'll do fine  
on our own, but we must find some limits somehow.  
Until then, we must journey, with no holy books,  
guide ourselves, and pray old gods don't rise for their vengeance.

## Doubt

12 January 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/01/doubt/>

I have lived with this ache in my side  
for so long it is hard to imagine  
not having it. Yet, I could thrive, it is true,  
under doctor's care..."studies show..."  
but they have never studied *me*,  
the particular man, he who sleeps in each bed,  
who lives under the aegis of Science  
but is not known by it...prithee tell me  
what *care* is experimentation, the lab-man  
set loose on his subject for fun and profit?  
I do not know why I thus mock it,  
lest others think that I do know,  
but in fact, I doubt, as is now the fashion,  
but doubt that this doubt could reach certainty,  
clarity, truth, or obedience, all of which go  
into care. Does my doctor doubt? For if so,  
he will not be much trusted. If not,  
he shall not follow science.  
I go now to bed, to the sweeter rest,  
free from doubt and its faithful unfaithfulness,  
stewards of Science, but with this last hope,  
that some fruit of their labor may comfort me still  
even so.

## The Ship of Rome

12 January 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/01/the-ship-of-rome/>

Let me sing for you about the ship of Rome,  
which crashed at Plymouth, spilling gods and heroes  
to the sea. 'Twas not for you and me, that pantheon,  
and yet we took that wreckage and built homes.  
Did we not know the walls would talk, thus carved  
from holy wood? They say strive harder,  
on toward the unseen end of gloria, whence we shall be gods.  
Did we not know the ship had crashed? That we, too, crash,  
and always crash, so long as we rely on only worn-out navigation?

Let the augurs rest, no, let them die,  
and let all children of the sky foretell  
their own fate, falling faster than sweet Icarus,  
to soon with Hades lie. But this old feud  
is not worth reappearing, will not settle on these terms.  
I crave a new word, *after* Rome, but not  
*instead* of Rome, for who could pluck such mighty organs  
out of this, her organism? Surely this beast  
has a heart, so we won't start to prophesy  
some doom ordained by civic need  
and furthered on by bloodlust. No,  
we want some answers for all misdeeds  
done by smiling men with good intentions  
and reputed names. It is the same, the same, the same,  
no matter how the poor are skinned,  
the plot remains, who does the skinning,  
and are they held to account? One doubts  
sincerely, and another has philosophy, but these  
are even older than the crimes, and have done little  
to assuage the unjust blood. Is it not time?  
The ship, alas! may hold more corpses than we know.  
But this will grow: take heart from this:  
by now there have been other ships.

---

Will you listen? I have seen behind the curtain  
and the man I saw is uglier than imagined.  
He spoke croakingly, without a point or purpose,

flailing madly, with twin sceptres in his hands,  
and pedalled briskly on the bike that turns the world.  
I won't describe his face. All has its place,  
except for him, the mastermind of chaos,  
tossing here and there the pieces of our lives.

We dare not thrive, in this, his world,  
and so we're cured, or so we're told,  
but somewhere someone must remember  
how to live...

At first, you give, and only then  
dare to receive, for this, your need  
to be a giver is the stronger.  
Doubt not any longer. Love  
is not the answer, though it is  
part of the question, as new ships  
come in from ever distant shores.  
Don't hold off anymore. You have been  
changed already, as you know,  
and as these winds begin to blow,  
depart, and set sail for yourself,  
so long ago. So you must go  
into the night the knowers know  
with many histories in tow.

---

Augustus abolished wonder, that much is clear,  
and he did steer the ship of Rome for many years.  
Here on the other side, one sees how light can blind  
and is reminded of the fateful deaths of Socrates  
and Jesus, noble rebels, ever castaways on some  
lost seaside isle. But death solves nothing, only life  
can bring solution, as it mixes with all other life,  
diluting thus the brew. It's nothing new, although  
the solvents may be new, the process stands as it has stood.  
We guessed it would, when we based Science on a method.  
Let us wonder at this process, but think also  
that the ship's wreck has been salvaged not in full, but in part only,  
and that we may be still captive to its thrall.

---

The ships from the East were a welcome sight,  
carrying treasure instead of soldiers, intending to awe

without terror barbarians abroad. The carrot  
instead of the stick. But it would not stick  
in imperial hearts, proud with punishment, dizzy with wealth,  
though still *novi homines* in their own eyes. How to govern?  
It would not be long before questions had outstripped answers  
and the West would be overextended combatting the forces  
it thought to control. But those thoughts were all wrong,  
seen in time as the lies that they are, for we govern ourselves  
as we govern our friends. We won't treat ourselves any better,  
as creatures of habit, when habits are hard to unlearn  
or control. How to govern? The ships may return or may not,  
but our task is to learn all we can from them,  
not as their servants or masters, but simply as friends,  
with the knowledge that more wrecks will come  
and that we would not like to be among them.

## **All Man Has Been**

*12 January 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/01/all-man-has-once-been/>*

The Romans did a number on Europe,  
and left it unable to roam free.  
It's easy to see the obedience,  
deep and habitual, challenged by Hegel  
but then in the end even he was absorbed,  
and the structure remains, bearing even the dead weight  
of Derrida. Here in America, we broke free  
early, but struggle to find the new balance,  
so staggering into the graveyard, we stumble  
upon ancient history, carved in stone,  
inviting observers to ponder  
all man has been or can be.



## It may also help you

*12 January 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/01/it-may-also-help-you/>*

I come to ask you at this lonely hour  
to believe less and hope less, and you, being wise,  
will discern that to do so will weaken you. Yet,  
I ask anyway, to teach you a new kind of strength,  
not of castles impregnable but rather of men in pitched battle,  
where throw or be thrown is the rule. You will surely  
encounter in life many men who know well this arena  
and they may hurl you into it unaware. So let's practice  
and spar for awhile. It has helped me.  
It may also help you.

## Beyond the Locked Door

*12 January 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/01/beyond-the-locked-door/>*

I'm awake, and the gods  
are fighting again. Is it Liberty,  
or is it Democracy, or is it  
their child, poor child  
to be born from squabbling, and yet  
no different than any child.

As the argument rings through the night  
and arouses the neighbors for the umpteenth time,  
I must wonder, although we do live  
in the large house on the hill, whether any  
would envy such conflict or those who live through it,  
or whether they'd rather have peace,  
even if it comes only through compromise.

Would be nice, I suppose, to have peace,  
but would also deceive...and in any case,  
we are the children of conflict. But why truth?  
I ask this again, having no certain answer,  
but fearing the dark night that waits just beyond the locked door.

## Savage Dew

*12 January 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/01/savage-dew/>*

I knew what she wanted, but not what I wanted,  
as the wind blew around the savage dew. It is true,  
there are lovers who look just like you, but I too  
have regrets left unsaid. They won't change, even with you  
to change them, alas. I shall pine after darkness instead.

## Life Over Victory

*12 January 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/01/life-over-victory/>*

I see them, streaming in numbers beyond compare,  
having been asked to give up even the possibility of violence,  
and having refused. Is their day coming? Not yet, but it comes  
as it always comes, to political animals like us. Will today  
be the day the walls fall, towers breached, with the crown  
tossed up for grabs? It cannot be postponed forever.  
May the winners choose mercy and the losers choose life over victory.

## Never What It Used To Be

12 January 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/01/never-what-it-used-to-be/>

As Augustus created political morality,  
we end it, and quash the *libido dominandi*  
by conquering only as a last resort.  
No peace secured through conquest shall endure,  
now or forevermore, for pent up rage  
must tear the fabric of the law.  
I hear the call of this new herald  
summoned by these years of struggle,  
and it says we are great peoples,  
in the plural, and if something moral  
still remains, it is the ash of Vesta  
with her embers glowing in each private hearth,  
not in the hearth of state, and to all those  
who would revive a prior time, she says  
that it was never what it used to be  
and could not be so now.

## Response to a Query

*23 February 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/02/response-to-a-query/>*

Yes, Athens is in the Bible,  
in more ways than one. If it's true  
that you know so little, could you please  
do so quietly? And have a little doubt?

## The Flux

23 February 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/02/the-flux/>

If you really want to know what you are doing,  
you will have to discern velocities, and not supposedly  
immutable actualities. Flux is the friend of philosophers,  
even of Plato, and thinking is just this: observing potentials  
and projecting their future interactions. But most cannot do this,  
and therefore most quail before indecision, as though it were  
insurmountable evil. The thinkers, meanwhile, must keep all of their thoughts  
to themselves, lest the noisy potentials discomfit the slumber of all,  
while these secretly crave after flux, which they know as a god,  
and *make sense of it*, to the dismay and chagrin of the rest.

## Carefully

23 February 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/02/carefully/>

If I wander out into the ether,  
out past all the ruins of time,  
can you tell me how much of mankind  
I shall find underneath or beneath her,  
the One who encompasses all, who calls out  
to the thoughtful, from Elsewhere, to dream  
of new vistas and old things reborn?  
I am seeking her, but with faint heart,  
for I hear that her sorrow is growing  
which soon must envelop the world.

Is it hope that deceives, or must we  
wait for another, to cleanse our hands  
and to break the enchantments that strangle  
our tortuous souls, ever wandering here  
on the night's Plutonian shore? Evermore  
we shall wander, unless we can grasp  
what it is that so sends us, beyond,  
to some Other world, never once seen, touched, or heard.

Confusion and dismay must be expected  
but not celebrated. Man is what he is,  
not more or less, prepared at times,  
and lost at times. There is no other way  
to pass the wilderness of life,  
so let us be content withal,  
the pains we cannot change as well the joys,  
and let us pass this much the wiser  
sans the pains of fruitless hoping.

Call it coping, but don't call to it at all.  
Learn not to call. Instead, fall back into  
the life that fills us all, and breathe.  
You must protect this life with every breath.  
But you will see that it sustains itself  
far better than you can. So let it be,  
and as your lungs fill near the sea,



believe, and know that you are free  
to live a full life, even one lived carefully.

## More Authentic

23 February 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/02/more-authentic/>

Something changed a hundred years ago,  
but was it the machines or was it our  
collective unbelief, the signs of chaos poking through?  
Amidst the dollars breeding dollars, men found  
mysteries, and wondered, is this all, or are  
new thoughts around the bend? Some still pretend  
that worn out Order could revive, and others  
dance in naked revelries, but we are not  
who *they* were, so it seems. These changes mount  
toward their climax, and it will be more authentic,  
but it will not save us from the gasping seas.

## Through the Unknown

*23 February 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/02/through-the-unknown/>*

If I venture out through the unknown,  
will you follow, or will you deny yourself  
freedom? Think not what you will, but what is,  
and thus free yourself from the dominion of  
power, awakened at last to the mysteries,  
life's strange embrace, and the colors of all  
that has been or will be. Do you see?  
These are waiting for you, just beyond the heart's door.  
Yearn no more, be at peace, find release, and let be what shall be.

## New Healing

23 February 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/02/new-healing/>

Is there another way, out past ways that were tried  
and retried, or is man eternally doomed to recur,  
like poor Echo, alone in his cave? I would like to think  
more things could be, that as old things were made,  
so could new things be made, and encouragement  
comes from the sun, which each morning endeavors  
to rise like before, but with just some small hint  
that the new day is new.

About you, listen, it is not my place to tell you,  
but I will say anyway that dawn has awoken, and you  
remain stuck to your bed, eyes glued shut,  
but before long your hunger will drive you to wake  
and by then it will be far too late.

Is there another dawn for stragglers, or will they  
be left all alone, to fight over the scraps,  
while the rest of the living world rises early  
to chase the first light and its offering?

There will be time for repentance, be sure,  
but there will not be baths to make pure.

I suspect it will come from the same place as always,  
that kernel of hope that men need for their labors,  
without which life pales when compared to its opposite,  
and which rests inevitably upon mere conformity,  
the group being group-like for its own sake.

I cannot make this prettier, ugly as it is,  
and must be, for we spiritual beasts, always ready  
to rip and to tear those who differ, to secure for ourselves  
some asylum from loneliness. And yet it is we, the most lonesome,  
who persecute, in order to shape the whole world in our image,  
when perhaps they are fine as they are. I know not, know it well,  
and proclaim it to all who will hear. Is my doubt unappealing?  
Perhaps you will find that you too are in need of new healing.

## True Healing

23 February 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/02/true-healing/>

I have often thought over how  
in Eastern Christianity, sin is considered  
a sickness to be healed, instead of  
a violation to be punished. Much follows  
from this, like how we blame the victim,  
or really consider all sufferers to blame.  
Could anything be less effective than punishment  
if the goal is the curing of misery?  
Thus our reformation, in the face of the most  
ineffectual healing. We must break this habit  
and restore to society places of healing,  
true healing, which do not turn face and attack.

## A Time is Coming

23 February 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/02/a-time-is-coming/>

A time is coming (it always comes)  
when men forget themselves and punish others  
in an effort to remember. Let us here recall  
ourselves and stave off terror, lest it come  
(time as my witness) as it always does,  
and let us be not blamed, for though  
the seas will rise and fall, we heard them call,  
and tried to warn the sleeping masses  
of their graves (we did not dig them),  
where the floods will carry all  
who dare to build on sinking sands.

Let it be remembered that here stood one  
both firm and tall amidst the early gusts of storm,  
and though this marker may be worn,  
it holds a heart that may revive a nation,  
even one so torn.

## No More

23 February 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/02/no-more/>

Something in the soul cries out, "No more!"  
against the lies, the toxic products, the malaise,  
the lack of meaning, the addictions. How much more  
will be endured before walls fall, and men find  
hope again, and will it be true hope, or will  
it lie again in time? I fear the worst, but is the best  
so much improved that it won't also burn to ash  
just when it's needed? I don't know, and I don't trust  
those who do claim to know, but something in the soul  
now stirs, and those who feel it tremble like those  
waiting for the savage hordes to flow.

## If I Yearn For More

23 February 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/02/if-i-yearn-for-more/>

The president stumbles, like so many times,  
in so many places. Is this what it looks like?  
The man, like his culture, stands pert at death's door.  
This has happened before, and to us, but how little we know.  
Is it back to the Gilded Age? Back to the old problem  
of starving farmers and captains of industry, presiding  
(please note the same word) over all. Who's in charge? Back  
before the Progressives intended to intervene, there was money,  
lots of it, but somehow not enough to go around.  
It's as old as Cain, like our president, these cycles of bust,  
the perennial bust of the workers, or so the Marxists say.  
But is this how a culture dies, or how one is born?  
Or both forever, interminable differences generating  
life and death? I don't know. I will never know.  
But I like to explore. It is good for the spirit  
(especially one at death's door) to be exercised. So far  
I've seen this president preside at death's door over  
his hearse and that of his century, but time will forgive me  
if I yearn for more.



## The Task of Man

22 March 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/03/the-task-of-man/>

Let us turn the page here, and let us ask  
who we shall be, and know we have a say,  
for time, though strong, is neither master nor enemy,  
but friend. It's time we think, if we dare think at all,  
and only time makes worthy those  
who rise before its call. So let us turn  
and rise and make a better life, that they may say  
that here a few stood tall who were not daunted  
by the task of man, who faced it with all courage  
even as dark winds were blowing.

---

The poets are singing again, about how cultures blend  
and one fades into another, across the sands of time,  
which litter the desert of peoples, lost and forgotten,  
yet ever new, like the rising sun. Does that sun parch  
or does it vivify? Only time will tell, we know that well,  
although we also know ourselves, and possibly only that.  
But poets sing regardless, knowing that this too shall pass,  
that all must pass, but most of all this ratiocentric  
obsession with self, with reason, with power, which plagues  
this hour with Man so magnified nothing else breaks through.

---

But what else is there? Only God? And Nature?  
We, no longer children, will not take our fairy-tales,  
but crave more solid food, the real meat of the matter.  
But too bad for us, the stories are the meat,  
and always were, and our mancenteredness is only  
one more story. C'est la vie. Back to the task,  
as ever, editing, revising, and then publishing the draft  
that we've received as our inheritance. But let's make it  
a good one, not a tragedy or farce, but one  
with heroes in their prime and worthy deeds.

## Machine State of Mind

22 March 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/03/machine-state-of-mind/>

The problem with machines is they never change.  
So we must simply have less of them,  
having them only where they are most needed  
and thus most effective. The mindless rote tasks,  
the menial labors, the painful tediums: these  
the machines may alleviate. But why did we ever  
believe they could help us connect or find love?  
It may be that our deepest, our bedrock identity  
(here in America) always was tied to machines  
and their state of mind. Our Constitution sits,  
nigh a quarter-millennium after inception, there tempting us  
never to change, though a change comes, it comes  
and it always comes, from beyond the horizon.  
But it's not here now. We have kept it away  
with machines and their promises, so often kept  
that we dare not examine their failures, lest we also  
slide into failure with them, as so many ancestors have before.

## Seeking Authorization

*22 March 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/03/seeking-authorization/>*

None of these thoughts have been authorized  
by relevant authorities, but, nonetheless true, I  
shall speak them, for truth is the common property  
of a people, and a people is made up of persons who  
(believe it or not) sometimes think their own thoughts.  
Have you heard this before? Am I overreacting?  
Then why are you here with your pitchforks?

## Speak It Out Loud

22 March 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/03/speak-it-out-loud/>

Let it be remembered  
that the stasis grew impenetrable,  
that each side fought to kill  
but weakened slowly, that the dawn  
came ever closer but was not known,  
that mankind in the twenty-first century  
stayed unsure, despite its patina of knowledge,  
and lest we be informed, we also grow  
toward that dawn, because time moves us  
out of Progress, into homes manmade and durable.

The living commences then with a story  
about how we got here, through chaos and also  
executive action, which foists upon common people  
feelings and thoughts known to dazzle great minds.  
Bamboozled thus, all wander aimlessly, doubting  
that aims could exist or that any who champion them  
have any motive but domination. If only they knew  
about history, like that it exists, or that others have lived  
other ways and still prospered, sometimes more than we.  
But such things cannot be under this dark dominion,  
the spectre of progress asleep at the wheel, like the God  
that it claims to displace...

This disgrace is expiring, but what takes its place  
it's not my place to say. Let the ones who will follow  
decide what to call it. I only speak now, but I speak it out loud.

## Whatever Comes

22 March 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/03/whatever-comes/>

It has been said and rehearsed that mankind is evolving,  
that up the glass staircase of progress we tend,  
but I fear that within us gnaws something familiar  
from primitive times, which throws stones that could shatter  
the staircase, whose fragments would rain down  
and murder all those who live under it. Am I  
just dreaming, or do you too feel it, the throb  
of life dammed up inside living things great and small?  
It could conquer us all, like it did when Saint Paul  
said the stones would cry out after justice, but then what?  
Rebuilding the same stair again, or rebuilding  
glass cages again, or else onward to follies  
we have not yet dreamed? I am cynical,  
this you can tell, about Man's final purpose,  
but I still believe in improvement, the struggle  
of good against bad. It's just that there are no  
godlike spectators, tipping the scales in one way  
or another, and no covenant either, but just us  
and what we have done. Can we live well this way?  
I think I can, but you must decide for yourselves.  
In the meantime, let's think, and not hurry in search  
of replacements for gods that have died, but let time  
in its time turn our clocks toward whatever comes.

## **Wait For Me**

*22 March 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/03/wait-for-me/>*

What for me, I am thinking, it only  
will take me a moment, but by then will it  
even matter? Please wait for my answer before  
you decide, I am sure it will be worth your while.

## All Must Again Be Decided

22 March 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/03/all-must-again-be-decided/>

If posterity glances our way, they may say  
we were craven, asleep at the wheel,  
lulled to sleep by American dreams in their  
haunting and chaste unreality, steady  
as life passed us by. Or they may say  
we strove with such recklessness nothing was safe,  
that once woken we crashed into everything,  
breaking the finest monumentos. But both were true,  
and how these can both be without cancelling each other  
remained our most pressing question. In some ways,  
they couldn't, and each chose to keep to its quarters,  
afraid of the great confrontation. Ideas, like kings, are enfeebled by flattery,  
losing their warlike spirit, assured of control over this much,  
no more. What happened when some chose to fight?  
What became of a once mighty country grown fat  
on its winnings, where none dared to fight,  
when it woke to the clarion call of new gods claiming surely  
that all must again be decided?

## **Anti-Nature**

*22 March 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/03/anti-nature/>*

Somebody tell the president  
that Nature intends to kill us,  
she wants us all dead,  
and she tells me so every day,  
but she also brings forth all her flowers,  
and if we can read the signs,  
this last point may prove most important.



## In Our Midst

22 March 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/03/in-our-midst/>

There's a story that goes untold  
beneath the layers of simple nicety  
where men are bought and sold  
and where the rules are always clear.  
Here power speaks while others listen  
and plants dreams in helpless ears,  
while foreheads glisten with the sweat  
of wasted years, time out of mind.  
This kind of thing is now familiar.  
Those with no end in sight  
must labor on for someone else  
despite all promises of freedom.  
Above ground we play and sing  
the patriotic songs, forgetting,  
as the healthy always do,  
the sickness hiding in our midst.

## Upon the Dawn

22 March 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/03/upon-the-dawn/>

Something now is seeming, and the stars  
must shift awry, thus making way for some  
messiah in the hay. It will take years,  
but even these old fulsome ears may  
hear it cry, before time comes to drop  
the curtain on it too. So many things  
have been and so few still remain,  
but here we are, and we must try.  
So turn your telescopes, and swivel your receivers,  
for the messengers will ride upon the dawn.

## Cultural Marxism

22 March 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/03/cultural-marxism/>

Call it what you will, but I  
think "dialectics" will do, if understood  
to mean what Hegel dreamed, the absolute  
that flutters free. Of course we thinkers  
know what he means, but some of us doubt  
universals. Cannot some things be  
believed, just because they have withstood  
time's testing? Why must we apply  
our own testing, in all times and places?

Regardless Marx too cared for ideas  
more than he admitted, he just sought  
to change them by changing material  
conditions. His Doctors of History  
have failed time and time again.  
But "cultural dialectical materialism"  
is just dialectics. The other two cancel.  
The question remains when and where  
to question, and how. Maybe Hegel  
has worn out his welcome. Maybe Plato  
knows best after all.

## Set to Expire

*12 June 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/06/set-to-expire/>*

I find myself where I always was,  
not quite perfect and not quite nothing,  
but only a something that's set to expire.

## All as One

12 June 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/06/all-as-one/>

What is to become of it,  
the whirling gears of time  
being what they are, and they,  
or it (there being no difference),  
aswirl together as if as One?  
I do not doubt it, though  
I question whence doubt comes  
and whither any go who doubt  
and thus hold firm. To some  
cool purgatory perhaps, but  
when the empires fall, when God  
appears, when All casts off her veil  
revealing Night, what will become  
of us, the time-bound, who held doubt  
as though a totem that could save?

## **A Relief**

*12 June 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/06/a-relief/>*

In the deep,  
the time swirls  
like Nothing ever,  
hurling out new gods  
and old beliefs.

It's a relief,  
really, after all  
the faith, to be  
set free, to be  
as one is,  
as all is.

## Sending Signs

12 June 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/06/sending-signs/>

In the moonlight, one can see  
what one means flicker like a flag  
on a windy day. What *means* it  
anyway? And what awaits that one  
when all has passed away,  
when time, the author of authors,  
revives her spooky angels, sending signs  
for those with ears to hear?

## Believe in the Dawn

*12 June 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/06/believe-in-the-dawn/>*

In the twilight there's Caesar Augustus,  
who brought in the Pax Romana,  
becoming its sovereign, supreme over all.  
But what violence lies behind every peace  
we have learned. In that time we  
have also discovered ourselves (go figure)  
and now we shall never forget that all laws  
are manmade, and can be manunmade  
as required. When is it required? We know  
of a few examples, no more. In the twilight,  
we reach for a candle, but stumble,  
take heart, and believe in the dawn.



## Good Enough

12 June 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/06/good-enough/>

What did I want from her anyway?  
Some affirmation? Maybe a thrill?  
I know this: looks can kill,  
but not words, which bring order  
to those things that lack it.  
I am not alone with my many selves,  
so what role had she, if not merely  
Intruder? Yet some sadness lingers  
like a man defeated, and I must be  
with the birds and the trees, for whom  
I am good enough, 'til it passes,  
and all the black mourners at all the black masses  
never can lift this one pall, that I lack  
what a woman needs, not by my fault  
but by nature, and so I must seek  
that of nature which does not offend.

## **Itself as a Prize**

*12 June 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/06/itself-as-a-prize/>*

If one should ask for me,  
tell them I wait by the fire  
where life is consumed. That way,  
if they look, they will go  
in the right direction. I do not  
know what follows after, but  
this way is not for the mild.  
It offers itself as a prize.

## Tethered to Freedom

27 July 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/07/tethered-to-freedom/>

How do I cope with it, spent  
and yet grasping for more, like a fish  
out of water...what water can hold me  
and not let me go? Or am I not  
a creature of water at all? There are  
things that one sees to believe, but  
they are least important. The instincts  
know better, and one of these yearns  
for community. We are too free,  
so it seems, each as free as the rest,  
to fit in. If belonging were not in  
our hearts, who would want to be free?  
I see armies of others  
refusing our freedom, insisting on some  
new coherence (their own),  
and yet we are here tethered  
to freedom, for better or worse.

## **As All Time Passes By**

*27 July 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/07/as-all-time-passes-by/>*

Love is a reason to suffer,  
but one quickly finds that if one  
disregards all the evidence, soon  
the morass of unanswerable questioning  
lingers like the stench of a swamp  
with no egress. Still, without love  
one finds nothing but thought  
and its herds of passion, beleaguered  
by hope without hope that some thought  
could once matter and make out of men  
something good. But no matter. Love still  
is our greatest achievement, if known  
in its truth as the glue that makes  
coherence possible, here where men lie,  
where men fight, when men live as all time  
passes by.

## Surely We Know Best

27 July 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/07/surely-we-know-best/>

It is a miracle each time, but,  
none the wiser, we plod on,  
transforming Nature's bounty,  
making hers our own. What *is* life?  
Just the animating principle, just  
the motive force, the cause of growth,  
just *everything that matters*? But  
no matter, surely we know best.  
Let's kill it all.

## Things Unseen Though Known

27 July 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/07/things-unseen-though-known/>

In the beginning, one finds God  
alone, on an empty beach, the waves  
descending and ascending, like before  
but never the same, slight modifications  
adding up an ocean of change.  
It makes much difference whether we  
are there as well, or if we dwell  
*within* the waves, well, then no use  
in trying. But the moon and sun  
and other stars reveal themselves to those  
with open eyes, as other causes,  
to the point that one was many,  
and that God reflects the lights of all  
as in a mirror darkly, surely a mirage,  
as sure as man can be, yet free  
to twinkle like a passing ghost  
within our minds and memories,  
of times long gone and things unseen  
though known.

## Justice

27 July 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/07/justice/>

How does one answer them, naked  
and screaming for more, when the task  
ever new yet the same, makes demands?  
One is rapt by Sophia, beloved of philosophy,  
whose darkness conceals all we know,  
and makes hidden supposed self-evident truths.  
Evermore? Or shall we again find that thing  
that makes peoples cohere, nestled in us,  
right next to the beating heart? It's a start,  
but the task, ever new, makes demands,  
and we may find ourselves unequipped  
for its burdens, until we revisit  
our gardens of men, and equip them  
with sturdier material.

---

Child of darkness, darkness unverified,  
tell me your secrets, and I will make hidden  
what ought to be so. Let me guess. You are sure  
that the empire is falling and ought to fall.  
You have known all injustice. The beaker is full  
of the dregs of revenge, and mankind is no better  
than its worst have been. You will say this,  
but time goes on, turning its wheel,  
as you squeal and you moan about nothing  
not already known by all those who have lived.  
For you will not survive here unless  
you can learn to forgive.

---

Turning and turning the wheel that keeps turning,  
we know now that all Rome is burning,  
was burning, and always shall burn  
'til we learn that we are not pure atoms  
but live here as one holy tribe.  
It is hard to describe what I mean,  
but not so far beyond that it cannot be grasped,  
if one only had what one first came for,

so long ago, out of the ether and into this world  
of mankind gone awry. But whence comes this true hope  
for a justice no earth-dweller knows?



## The Wind and My Place in It

27 July 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/07/the-wind-and-my-place-in-it/>

Can anyone remember the point of it all,  
or have we lost it, falling  
into some oblivion forevermore?  
I am not one to remain  
where I am not wanted,  
and so talk of substance or soul  
bears no weight. But I am among others  
myself, and thus crucially work out  
salvation through trembling (the fear has abated),  
but just *whose* salvation remains to be seen.  
I won't be there to see it, having  
other things to be, and until then  
I work for another. Is this, then, the point?  
Or does this too not satisfy? What of the wind  
and my place in it?

## **A Start**

*27 July 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/07/a-start/>*

Let this be a start, and let it  
answer for the pain of years neglected  
by a faith alleged to free us from all time.  
Is God still there when you are alone?  
Or does he come in groups of three,  
as legend has it? Answer me this  
and I will leave you to yourself, and I will leave you  
as you were and are and shall be.

## Assassination

27 July 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/07/assassination/>

In those moments when everything changes,  
by bullets or otherwise, know this:  
that time carries on, and that we  
are its ministers, solitary here  
despite chaos, despite bloody pain,  
though this is not enough to assuage  
the unrest. What becomes of a people  
shorn thus from itself by an act  
of the most basic barbarism?  
Some will say yes, others no,  
but all must feel profoundly  
the change that has come, and  
the change that was barely averted.  
In times like this, weep, but then  
rise to your feet and speak loudly  
that *weakness* inspires all bloodthirsty deeds,  
for the strong have no need of them,  
having instead the support of the people.  
This weakness remains the great animus,  
cause of all fear between men,  
though this time it has been unsuccessful.  
In time we will see what this means.

## The Fulcrum of Time

*11 August 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/08/the-fulcrum-of-time/>*

In the face of death, who stands?  
Buddha says an unwounded hand  
may handle poison, but I say life  
lives to wound, and who is not wounded?  
But grant that the virtuous bear it better  
than those sick with desire, death still  
comes reaping through time to this moment,  
the hour of decision, where all things  
can change and where death also  
reminds us of spring and new birth  
on the fulcrum of time at the pivot point  
of our lives.

## Kindle the Flame

*11 August 2024*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/08/kindle-the-flame/>

Kindle the flame, turn the hearthstones,  
and tell yourself why you have come.  
A reminder to always believe,  
even when there is no ground beneath you.  
That flame flickers bravely in all darkness,  
which ignites an embryo's life,  
and drives it on. It's no small wonder  
that we're here, or how we're here.  
But then from time to time the hearth  
grows cool, as part of the cycle, and our duty  
is to tend it with all care. It's there now,  
bhikkhu, and your path goes in a circle,  
out into the dark and cold to bring flame there  
and then back here to tend your own flame.  
You must be aware. It's ancient,  
inexhaustible, and rare. I thus commend you  
to the present, if you dare.

## Somewhere Other Than Belief

*11 August 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/08/somewhere-other-than-belief/>*

I see you there, pacing, remembering  
all that was done or left undone.  
Injustice, you know it well. It is true,  
the belief is flawed, but so will the next belief be flawed.  
We can do no better. Accept it,  
and lean somewhere other than belief.

## Good Left Undone

*11 August 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/08/good-left-undone/>*

How many wise men live quiet lives  
withdrawn from the world and its folly?  
Indeed they are wise to withdraw  
from a world that is perishing.  
Yet how much good is left undone?

## **A Warning**

*11 August 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/08/a-warning/>*

Lost sheep want the shepherd's crook.  
They feel their need.  
But in the evening glow, few know  
that night will come. This is your warning.



## She's There

*11 August 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/08/shes-there/>*

I cannot find her, Sophia, the maiden  
of stars, in the heavens, nor here  
between men, but instead I discover her  
under the surfaces, deep in the veins,  
through the cracks of mankind in the chasm  
of time, where all life begins, under  
ideas, below even words. She is singing,  
and I cannot find her, but I know she's there.

## Where You Are Stepping

*11 August 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/08/where-you-are-stepping/>*

Power attracts the power-hungry, who,  
always unfriendly (despite good appearances),  
see other humans as prey, and devour  
those too close to flee or too innocent to see  
what man is. But take heart, there is room  
in the emptier places, where trees are permitted  
to grow as they will, as are men. Know this then,  
that your place may not be by the glowing lights,  
but in soil, time's detritus, the life of your elders  
transformed into nourishment for you. Tread lightly.  
You never know where you are stepping.

## The Clock

*11 August 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/08/the-clock/>*

The Clock is a cruel master, compelling  
the best of men to kneel and bow  
before rhythmic, infernal vibrations of machines.  
I am keen to unwind this tall tale  
before more are injured, but I fear I'm too late,  
for my schedule is full.

## On the Verge

*11 August 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/08/on-the-verge/>*

Here we go, on the verge  
of ourselves, at the edge  
of another tomorrow, awaiting  
enlightenment, which comes from...where?  
If ourselves, then for what are we waiting?  
If not, then we've got it all wrong.

## Everyone's Wrong

11 August 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/08/everyones-wrong/>

Everyone's wrong about everything,  
that's all, nothing more serious than that,  
and yet all flickers bravely while perishing,  
and few ever notice. Oh well, we are here,  
are we not, so let's party, and not dwell  
on substance or other mirages,  
those lonely chimeras that keep thinkers up  
and keep all others down...no, let's none of that.  
Rather let's trace our way back to the stars,  
where the gods always are, though we know  
how they change, as we, always the same,  
are the true pole on which it all turns...

Some may say it's absurd, and I hear them,  
but how is a man to stay sane  
in a tribe come mad?

## Ancient Masters

*11 August 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/08/ancient-masters/>*

The ancient masters still know best,  
so trust them. Let them lead you.  
For you may find grace awaiting  
in a secret place, known by the few  
who think, there where a garden grows  
for those who speak the truth.

## Plants in Their Soil

26 October 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/plants-in-their-soil/>

When the peasants arrive, then you know  
you're in trouble, for they do not come  
when it's sunny. They'd rather destroy  
than create, and their countenances indicate  
malice deserved and served hot  
like the flame that they carry  
to torch all the structures that wrong them.

But Revolution itself has been absorbed  
by the blob of authority proselytizing  
itself forever and no other, that world order  
beneath which we wallow, without which  
we wage endless wars. But why struggle?  
If some of our needs are met, why  
complain? It appears that we need some third power  
to mediate any antagonism, but this third  
cannot be supreme without sucking the life  
out of men, because (by definition)  
it must not take sides. So it floats as its own  
sideless side and makes cowards all those  
who live under it, until they revolt.

But what grows in its place?  
An American federalist dream, where each place  
has a voice in the whole, but stays rooted?  
I know of no better third, none more just  
nor more durable, than one which respects  
its constituents, who grow up like plants in their soil.

## Nothing but Chaos

26 October 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/nothing-but-chaos/>

Humans live always on the edge of a knife,  
and what separates death from life is decision,  
made plain by the struggle, the crisis through which  
we become what we aspire to be.

Metaphysics is goal-setting, a politics  
of the imagination, turned upward by hope  
to the light. Like all living things, humans  
as well need that light, and the lack of it rots us  
from root to branch. It's no wonder that we  
are so rotten, indeed, it may be lack of wonder  
that turns us away, back to mud and slime  
and the perishing of all ideals. I am writing  
to cast an illumination over all  
that no longer deserves it, to thereby revive  
and to elevate life from the trenches,  
to send it back into the sky.

But what sky will receive us, who know too much,  
who have tasted the fruit, who are God itself?  
Only that which we dream for ourselves?  
But my dream is not yours nor yours mine.  
Yet we long for it, some true belonging,  
the kind that was prophesied, coming to roost  
over all. But which all? The true All, or just our "all",  
the sum of experiences marking our world?  
We say this will do, and we dare not look deeper,  
for we find there nothing but chaos.



## Dignity

*26 October 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/dignity/>*

Dignity is imbued through participation  
in rituals (no other way), and the tribe  
holds the key to the stair of advancement  
on which men climb. It's a pity  
to ask a man to raise himself, as if  
he could, as if this is not itself a ceremony,  
as if men think for themselves.

## The Source of Most Problems

*26 October 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/the-source-of-most-problems/>*

I have been to the mountains,  
I have been to the valleys, and I say  
that all's well that ends,  
but what goes on too long  
is the source of most problems.

## Dreaming

26 October 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/dreaming/>

What won't men do for a bit of dignity?  
Somewhere a conscience stirs, but not here,  
where much power distorts what men feel.  
It's an end well begun and done many times before.  
There's no hope of averting decline. The hope  
is to reproduce and to leave in posterity  
some seed that lingers and dwells in the hearts  
of those marching into *their* decline, who thus also  
must hope for some future, etc. But when does the living begin?  
Or was this what life always had been, and shall be,  
an imperative, blood-sucking physiology? No. I mean, yes,  
but we also live otherwise, and harmonize, one with another,  
in some holy music, divine if anything is. There is hope,  
pure and natural as body but based on the human experience  
of city-building, surely our most striking feature, although we don't  
always succeed, we must try evermore to combine. Thus we shall  
journey on, into whatever future we dream and, by dreaming, become.

## The Discipline of Virtue

26 October 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/the-discipline-of-virtue/>

They have too much freedom, but who can stop them?  
Surely no teacher, no sage, would dare impose on their freedom  
unless willing to die, given what they are. And yet justice  
rings true and cries out from the ether that we  
are like mushrooms in a damp, dark cave, ill-adapted  
to light and preferring our own noxious fumes. This  
is freedom, the freedom to wither and suffer without  
any destiny, not knowing better, forgetting that any have ever  
been good. We won't hinder each other. We have that much.  
But what of the discipline of virtue, acquired  
through must repetition?

## The Loss of Justice

*26 October 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/the-loss-of-justice/>*

These are the pieces of our lives  
tossed over the board by a careless hand  
which relinquishes claims to authority  
and weakens its own grip on power.

The loss of Justice is the eternal theme,  
for she remains queen of our hearts  
though not queen of our hands.

## **Beasts**

*27 October 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/beasts/>*

Our ideas have not caught up  
with the torrents of change that have washed  
over Europe, and thus Europe's children  
still linger near old flames, but oh,  
they grow awfully cold. What can spark  
the next hope, when the flame dies completely,  
and men once again become beasts?

## Caught in the Gears

*27 October 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/caught-in-the-gears/>*

The wailing expands our horizons,  
out past all we know stands  
an answer, and further, new questions.

The people push down  
the delusions of compliance.

A primate is caught in the gears  
and nobody can help it.

## **We didn't move**

*27 October 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/we-didnt-move/>*

We didn't move,  
but the ground beneath us moved.

It was a tremor hardly felt  
but soon observed with careful instruments,  
then felt. I was aware too soon,  
but others feel it now, and so it grows.

We are now somewhere else, but who?  
The ground beneath us moves,  
but we have never moved.



## Genius

*27 October 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/genius/>*

The genius wanders through a field still wild  
and says "Look at that!", then continues until  
time runs out. Later others arrive and build homes there  
with schools and with workshops and all the attendant  
filth of mankind. Who can say which one knows  
the place better? Who can say, because all are but one  
or the other and none knows its opposite. But I  
take the side of the genius, as one that is closer  
to the original spring, the first fountain from whence we arrive  
here on earth or wherever we are. Look and see  
how very little the others have done that won't wither  
and maybe you also will join in the next expedition  
to who knows where and for whatever purpose we dream.

## **Many, Instead of One**

*27 October 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/many-instead-of-one/>*

Nature is both good and evil,  
and we are caught up in it,  
tossed by the yin-and-yang tussle  
within and without. Who then knows  
whether nature opposes itself,  
or is many, instead of one?

## No Leg Up

27 October 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/no-leg-up/>

Gaze with me into this crystal ball  
and see people asleep. They really believe  
they're in heaven. Just look at them slumber,  
as if they have banished all danger,  
as if there will be no more pain. I choose  
honesty, even when it must be ugly, and even  
when others exclude me for it. Life's better  
without the charade of success, the mirage  
that the race ends with prizes, and not,  
as it must, with return to the dust for us all,  
with no leg up for those who have climbed.

## **Journeying Ones**

*27 October 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/journeying-ones/>*

We were the journeying ones,  
on a wander through wastelands,  
forever approaching but never arriving,  
mirage just beyond the horizon.

## Less Imposing Principles

*27 October 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/less-imposing-principles/>*

Nature has no purpose,  
and least of all is its purpose  
ourselves, who cascade between energies  
controlled by nothing. This is our belief,  
though unspoken, well-founded  
on experience we try to forget.  
But may be some new hope  
could order thought, around less dubious  
and less imposing principles.

## Care Again

27 October 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/care-again/>

There is a God-shaped hole  
in our sky, and we  
do not care, do not *take* care,  
take care of life itself,  
in all of its forms. How can we  
care again?

## A culture in which we can thrive

27 October 2024

<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/a-culture-in-which-we-can-thrive/>

It is one thing to know there is chaos,  
another to nourish that chaos, and make it grow.  
We are not in the mind of God, this much  
is true, but for that reason we must *think*  
and bring the world under a rule. It will not  
rule itself. Our order is good (at least  
it can be), but it will not grow itself.  
So let us sow and tend and reap  
a culture in which we can thrive.

## Out there in history

*27 October 2024*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2024/10/out-there-in-history/>*

We have learned all the virtues of formlessness  
and thus become skeptical  
that any such thing could cause happiness.  
What do we know?  
Maybe out there in history were some  
who knew better,  
and maybe we still could be like them.



## Pilgrims

18 January 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/01/pilgrims/>

Sheep remain sheep, like most men,  
and I know of no other way for them,  
but I know that my own way is different,  
and therefore has differing rewards.

I'm alone, it is true, but I'm also free,  
and that's part of the American dream.  
More importantly, I have seen God  
in the hidden places, those which no group may enter,  
where each one is man and man only,  
no tribe to fend off the attackers.  
God dwells there, in a holy of holies,  
awaiting the pilgrims who soon must come.

## **C'est la vie**

*18 January 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/01/cest-la-vie/>*

The stupid are at home, meanwhile  
the wise are lost at sea,  
and we can be so many things  
that few are anything, but c'est la vie.

## Now and Then

*18 January 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/01/now-and-then/>*

The artist scours an empty mind  
to remove any residue. Then he begins.  
He must find his misfortune in asking  
what questions are askable, and by whom.  
It will be no quick summary, no  
sudden triumph, but rather the slow decline  
of all that has come before. Only then  
will he lift his brush or pen, to define  
what will grow in new spaces, what begs  
to be heard, or what utters the gulf  
between now and then.

## From Beyond

*18 January 2025*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/01/from-beyond/>

How many cultures have come and gone,  
and how many days remain unborn  
in the cavernous womb of the world?  
What is time, that it comes and goes,  
and yet some things remain, like the Ship  
of Theseus? Washed here by time, we have no eyes  
for what could have been or will be.  
We are stranded, denied true transcendence,  
but seeing things come from beyond.

## Light Bent by Earth

18 January 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/01/light-bent-by-earth/>

Gaze (with proper protection)  
upon that boiling vat of hydrogen  
on which all things depend.  
What mind of God dreamed such a thing?  
And yet we dream it?

If you dare, you'll also learn  
that eyes can be damaged by staring directly  
and must find some other way.

As light bends, refracted by us  
and what we are, that glowing star  
becomes another Power, holding sway  
as men hold sway, until the break of day  
when light, most practical light,  
becomes our guide, whether bent or otherwise.

We do not care for the truth of the matter,  
for truth never brought a child to maturity  
nor guided a people to water. But light,  
bent by earth, can do both, and much more.

## Never Been Wrong

*18 January 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/01/never-been-wrong/>*

I've never been wrong before,  
but there's a first time for everything,  
like that time when two plus two equalled five,  
or when men lived together in peace.

Still I'm tramping on  
through this wasteland of abandoned dreams.  
I find a few worth keeping, and yet  
all is not what it seems.

## One More Line

*18 January 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/01/one-more-line/>*

This begins where that ended,  
after all this time.  
It was nice while it lasted.  
Here's one more line.

## One of Those Days

*18 January 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/01/one-of-those-days/>*

It's one of those days  
when the shadows invite contemplation,  
and all that has been becomes again.  
Revolution has been overstated.  
Have you tried just not worrying?  
We highly recommend it.



## Keener Insight and Better Plans

*18 January 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/01/keener-insight-and-better-plans/>*

In a few years the world will look different  
and we are to blame or to praise,  
but it's too late to stop it now.  
In a few years, days, months, hours,  
the sun will continue its circuit  
as we, silly, unravel our momentum,  
and reveal who we were when decisions were made,  
back when things could change. Things keep changing,  
of course, as expected, but I hope  
for a day with keener insight and better plans.

## Think with Me

18 January 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/01/think-with-me/>

I do not know where you are going  
or where you have been, but I think  
you are here and suspect that you  
really are somewhere. Think *with* me,  
and allow these still words to move again,  
through your soul. I am warning you,  
many ideas are dangerous, and you,  
only you, are the one who can help yourself know,  
which will help you, and which will hurt you.

## The Form of the Matter

08 March 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/03/the-form-of-the-matter/>

Are we at it again?  
Always moving, progressing, becoming ourselves...  
One way ends as another begins.  
There are secrets within, and yet I  
am without, on the fringes, where men  
build their fortresses which soon turn to sand.  
Who's to say whether this rubble matters  
in the cavernous space of time,  
whether we even matter, whether anything matters,  
or what mattering even means? It has meant  
both too much and too little. It means that  
we have set for ourselves a goal, but we're fickle  
and have had too many goals already. And yet,  
what else can we do?

But I say  
we matter, because otherwise life becomes  
too much like death, too unmoored  
from the form of the matter, and this  
is our greatest fear. Is there no other way  
to explain the true wonders of life?

## Think Harder

08 March 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/03/think-harder/>

I invite you to think again  
your own thoughts, not the echoes of others.  
I invite you to be that much human,  
for although most do not do such thinking  
the few that do earn a place for mankind  
among stars, in the nebulae of wonders  
that nature produces. So, please, go on thinking,  
to your mind's content, ere the rabble return  
from whatever destruction they've dreamed up today.  
But think harder for them, with some pity,  
for they did not make their own natures  
and you did not make yours.

## **Dream Wisely**

*08 March 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/03/dream-wisely/>*

Witness the morning,  
alive with the rising sun,  
moving up through the treetops.

I have come to remind you  
that you are the vestibule of dreams.  
Dream wisely.

## Outside the Law

08 March 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/03/outside-the-law/>

Who would have guessed  
that another dawn comes,  
even for us? Yet it comes  
as we wander from day to day  
like the children we are in the morning,  
when life is too bright and we shield our eyes  
lest they burn out, as has happened  
to those who were here before. In that dawn,  
I stand ready to embrace the new spirit,  
for the blind have at times made good poets,  
and I feel likewise aligned with the tides  
of those minds that can linger over all  
the minutiae that others pass by, and thereby  
can derive at their leisure some new eyes  
for a new kind of pride for mankind.

But you know none can do it alone, and it's true  
that belief is the glue that combines us, even those  
found untrue, but for me, as for you, the delay  
between my needs and the will of the group forces  
solitude, and I would just like to invite you to join me  
outside of the Law of Rome, where the spirit can grow  
to fill needs and then test the waters apart  
from any pre-ordained Plan. Yes, there's life there,  
and lots of it, but we who have broken our chains  
now stand dumbstruck, unsure how to build or produce order  
without simply rechaining others, as well as ourselves,  
with the shackles of Law run amok (even making  
chainbreaking its own kind of law!) I would like  
to remind you: think harder. Our children depend on it.

## Hardly two millennia

*08 March 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/03/hardly-two-millennia/>*

What does it mean for Rome to fall,  
to keep falling, as if through space,  
a figment of the mind? It means  
that we are free! The masters perish, and we  
gleefully divide their very bones, and yet  
we live on their estates or what is left of them.

## **New Hearts**

*08 March 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/03/new-hearts/>*

Who will remember us? We,  
doom-scarred and battle-stricken  
who never initiated the mysteries of procreation  
but still create in other ways,  
through song? It is at least a hundred years until  
our names be lost, our property divided or destroyed  
though words live on, not just on paper or on screens  
but in new hearts.



## More alarming by the day

08 March 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/03/more-alarming-by-the-day/>

Who is to answer them, the critics  
without a direction, the spineless destroyers,  
the miserable seeking company? Not more like them,  
not their progeny, not those in chains, but the free.  
We have made all men free, so we say,  
but it has not gone well, or at least  
it has been a mixed blessing, where most cling to freedom  
as devotees, as fervent and small-minded as any peasant,  
and who is to sing to or for them?  
Such a soul is not a place for song,  
being wracked with uncertainty and crushed by the burden  
of thinking through things on its own. Why despair?  
Even that is unhelpful, when men have been made  
more than useless by systems, demands, institutions  
that expect them to doubt what they are, although  
at the same time, to belong is in fact what they are.  
They are drawn to the group by instinct, but these groups  
proceed to destroy the group instinct. So what can we say?  
There is nothing to say, one would like to pass by,  
but this power becomes more alarming day by day.

## All Too Soon

08 March 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/03/all-too-soon/>

Observe the winds of change, but do not bow.  
You are here anyhow, where things can change  
and where we must make choices, yes and no.  
It is *your* time to go, and yet you do not know  
what happens next. I beg of you please with respect  
do not tarry forever or plan every inch of your kingdom,  
but go and be baptized by fire, as some were before,  
and take heart, and take action, and burn what is rotten,  
but leave root and stem that the plant may regrow,  
for the next harvest comes all too soon.

## Lord will it also be sweet

08 March 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/03/lord-will-it-also-be-sweet/>

I have lived in a time when living  
was out of fashion. I have heard my own howl.  
What happens when the sword of Damocles falls  
as if by accident? Who prospers? In the nick of time  
I am running toward renovation, and it will be painful  
but Lord will it also be sweet.

## A Time for Beginning

08 March 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/03/a-time-for-beginning/>

If there was ever a time for beginning, it's now,  
in the cool embrace of both past and future, holding firmly  
the hands of both, in between what has been and will be.  
But this now, at this moment, is specially charged  
with an urgent decision, to moor to the shores of a recent past  
or cast off into waters unknown. But those waters have been known before  
by some like us, and some came out better for knowing.  
Are we so accustomed to Progress and all its accoutrements  
that we grow too fat to endure? Or are we so hasty to abandon  
the ways of our fathers that no sacred temple shall stand?  
It is both, and neither. It is time to begin  
the assembly of the future, but keeping in mind  
the successes as well as the failures of those who came before.

## Ever Ready to Blossom Again

05 April 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/04/ever-ready-to-blossom-again/>

Let's break open the shell of the past  
and invite the discomfort of knowing. This way  
is the way of the hero, demanding courage.  
You are that hero, and I...I am only your guide,  
here reminding you of quests left undone and treasures forgotten  
out there on the cold plains of Lethe. So many  
have come and gone, so many...but you are here now  
to remember, and put back together what once,  
or a few times, made life more bearable,  
here where the shores of the past meet the future's ocean,  
where all life occurs, and where, if you listen,  
an ancient god stirs, ever ready to blossom again.

## Hard to Explain

*05 April 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/04/hard-to-explain/>*

I, too, was young, and carry inside me the memories of youth.  
Like an onion, the layers grow, but the deeper layers remain.  
It is hard to explain but it's easy to know.  
At one time you, too, were aware of this.

## **All Rise**

*30 May 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/05/all-rise/>*

It is time to face your adversary,  
but does he have a face? Or is he  
idea only, or, less, an abstraction  
imbued by one's training for combat?  
It's time nonetheless, notwithstanding these questions,  
for there are the drumbeats of war,  
and you, poor you, are heard chanting  
destruction upon those you do not know.  
Is it time, or are drums known to lie?  
We must fight one another, they say,  
in good Latin, but I have begun to doubt  
their designs. Can you question it?  
Can you too sniff out these rats of the mind  
and in place of them take hold of visions  
in which all rise? It is time  
to expunge adversarial lies from our laws,  
from our thoughts, from the skies.  
We have only begun to understand what could be  
when our whole is greater than its parts,  
when we all comprise something noble,  
when no one is master or slave.

## The Curtain Falls

30 May 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/05/the-curtain-falls/>

The curtain falls on a people in pain.  
"God is dead" says a man born insane.  
There is nowhere to run. There is nowhere to hide.  
They are standing alone in the rain.

A jester appears by their side.  
He is laughing though he is no guide.  
Tomorrow, he says, is no longer.  
His apple is tempting their pride.

Still, he is certainly stronger  
than those who prefer to fear-monger.  
But even the laughter must wane.  
And then what remains?



## Yeats' Footsteps

*30 May 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/05/yeats-footsteps/>*

If I follow Yeats' footsteps  
to the gates of Constantine's city,  
what will I find? A sense of order,  
perhaps, most lacking in the West,  
but one we can borrow? I doubt it,  
as much as I share the longing,  
for we are committed to Roman belligerence,  
scions of the eternal city. What care we  
for order or harmony? Conquest is too much fun.

## Thinking Begins

30 May 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/05/thinking-begins/>

This is an impression made concrete,  
the birth of ideas, the origin of reason  
(of one chain of reason), and next comes  
deduction, and then experiment. But listen,  
friend, for the sounds of inspiration  
made manifest by one who has had his thumb  
on the pulse of time. Only after this,  
thinking begins.

## Somewhere, Somehow

*30 May 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/05/somewhere-somehow/>*

What are we building? A kingdom,  
a fiefdom, for a new rule of law?  
We have been to the top of the pyramid,  
discovering Nothing, the black hole consuming  
all those who pursue reputation. But what  
are we building? It is not enough to tear down.  
We will have to live somewhere, somehow.

## You Carry It Always

30 May 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/05/you-carry-it-always/>

The Spectator steps through the door  
into Nothing, aware of himself and the other  
selves of which he is part, falling faster  
than rhythm or rhyme can describe. It's a pity  
no home was awaiting, but this is no time  
to look back. With feet braced and arched back  
he descends through the labyrinth of thought  
toward origins, never a settled being, forever  
turned forward and moving with things that flow.  
But you know he remembers another time,  
before he was here, before any here was,  
in the space between thinking and being,  
the caverns of essence, brimming with glittering stones.  
I would like now to show you this place,  
to invite to your mind a new feeling,  
the oldest knowing, which hereafter reigns  
as it always must reign, although so few can know  
(are you one of them?). Look to the hills  
for the meaning of meaning, and you will not find it,  
but look to your heart and it's there, where  
it cannot be dislodged by violence  
or brought to account by tribunals...it's there,  
and you carry it, always.

## Nothing

*30 May 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/05/nothing/>*

Nothing is what it claims to be.  
It has no things.  
Without things, it has no thought.  
Without thought, it has no meaning.

## How Much Time

30 May 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/05/how-much-time/>

How much time must pass,  
how many ages fade  
before we build to last,  
before our debt is paid?

We labor, it is true,  
amid the factories and glass,  
but skies are sometimes blue,  
and one would like to ask,

What purpose serves the labor?  
It is very hard to prove  
that working hard can save her  
who is troubled by our mood.

But no more questions,  
for they do not seek an answer.  
It is only in the quest for more  
that life has any savor.

## **Many Smiles**

*30 May 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/05/many-smiles/>*

There's a sort of haunting indiscretion,  
a pain just peeking through, in many smiles.

## **Corners of Strangeness**

*30 May 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/05/corners-of-strangeness/>*

I am having the strangest life,  
and you are my audience, always  
just barely there, in potentia, never in flesh.  
But let me remind you, lest you forget,  
about corners of strangeness left unsaid,  
where clocks strike forever and both you and I  
become One.



## Had You Been There

*30 May 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/05/had-you-been-there/>*

Had you been there, you would know  
the way the sweet day-lilies grow,  
but you had too much email.

## On the Side of the Earth

*30 May 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/05/on-the-side-of-the-earth/>*

I shall plant myself firmly  
on the side of the earth,  
and take part in discussions  
about love and worth  
with perspective: we are not  
forever, though something calls warmly  
from elsewhere, to beckon us home.

## Labor Pains

*30 May 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/05/labor-pains/>*

These labor pains are for you,  
as I offer this gift. Can you take it?  
Or is it unwelcome? I cannot decide.  
But *you*, you will have to decide.

## That Hollow Moon

02 July 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/07/that-hollow-moon/>

*We sat grown quiet at the name of love;  
We saw the last embers of daylight die,  
And in the trembling blue-green of the sky  
A moon, worn as if it had been a shell  
Washed by time's waters as they rose and fell  
About the stars and broke in days and years.*

*I had a thought for no one's but your ears:  
That you were beautiful, and that I strove  
To love you in the old high way of love;  
That it had all seemed happy, and yet we'd grown  
As weary-hearted as that hollow moon.*

Yeats, *Adam's Curse*

Moon shines ever new, a changing world,  
as we, thrust in the void, spin madly,  
daring not to be deceived, but also  
floundering. Oh, if only the old high way  
could save us, bring back to earth the faith  
that once illuminated ancient hearts. But  
it is lost, and has been lost for quite some time.

Can time redeem us, or is time itself  
most doubtful, playing cards with all our hearts,  
without remorse? We sit grown quiet too.

## **I could go to her**

*02 July 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/07/i-could-go-to-her/>*

On the doorstep of adventure, I write to you  
(one last time?) about all that could be.  
You will know so much better than I  
what became of myself, whether obstacles  
or I proved stronger. But here on this precipice  
overlooking all, I confess it,  
I feel afraid. Is it courage or hubris  
that pushes me on? Is it time? Or  
is it mere chemistry, stirring these bones  
with infusions of blood? I don't know,  
but I do know that I must linger  
and dwell within this possibility: she is there.  
I could go to her. I could also be there.

## Woken by Storms

*02 July 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/07/awaken-to-storms/>*

Climbing back down, into sheets of myself,  
I have danced at the summit of dreams,  
but no longer. The way goes through many a village,  
all dark, with no room at the inn. But no matter.  
I must venture on as my only companion,  
I must face the frost with no fear in my heart,  
lest the others be woken by storms.

## Just One Moment More

02 July 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/07/just-one-moment-more/>

Back to myself, coming home, it's a wonder  
that any can dream, that the dreaming goes on  
amid war, amid pain...can it be? or are dreams  
merely dreams? But who authors them? I do not know,  
though I think that we do it together. So why  
be alone? That I do know. Because I am drawn to the water  
of origins, back before any were separate, I feel  
its love far more strongly than any love of mammals.  
I feel that the earth is my home,  
and no smaller home will do.  
So I wander in spirit, awaiting  
the needed reconnection, unable to settle  
or build any firm foundation, because  
I know none will suffice.  
And yet it was nice to believe,  
to be free, then no more be deceived.  
It was nice, and I choose to remember  
before I forget, and to dwell and to linger  
among all the sugar and spice  
for just one moment more.

## Passion chokes out thinking

02 July 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/07/passion-chokes-out-thinking/>

How many thoughts must I lose  
to distraction, to chasing dreams  
or ghosts of dreams? It is written  
that I shall abide here. In time  
you will understand, you will follow the thread  
back to daylight, and nurse your own wounds.  
Why then linger? Why hope? Is Pandora  
still casting her curse? It gets worse.  
She is queen of this world, and her gifts  
must inspire destruction. Who hails  
from a distant land? Who knows  
or cares, when passion chokes out thinking  
in its slumber?



## The Presence of Love

02 July 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/07/the-presence-of-love/>

Come to me, spirit. Invite my displeasure,  
but don't leave without first deciding  
which moments to spare. You are there,  
I am not. Can it be some other way,  
or must I be like those burned by light of day  
in the presence of love?

## How much love

*02 July 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/07/how-much-love/>*

How much love can I muster,  
What kind of rule can I bring  
To a heart that has lost its luster,  
A mind that can only sing?

## Daylight

*02 July 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/07/daylight/>*

She was like daylight, her visions  
unfolding beyond my control. What a pity  
no strong arms could greet her. A pity,  
but one that I cannot assuage.  
So why must she be so beautiful?

## **Make my dreams true**

*02 July 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/07/make-my-dreams-true/>*

There comes a time when a man  
is whole, and can truly say yes. That time  
may be coming for me, but the hour is late  
and so many decisions have already been made.  
Is it true? My heart beats for her,  
yes, it is true. But am I fit for love,  
or for even attempted love,  
after all this time? Worms will eat through  
all things, so they say, so what lasts?  
Only dreams, but is love but a dream?  
I'll dream longer, and make my dreams true.

## As Only You Can

02 July 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/07/as-only-you-can/>

I have passed through the valley of Sirens,  
and, tied to the mast, I could hear  
what I wanted to hear. It is fine  
to move on, to break free, from this strangest disease  
we call love (although love like Proteus has many forms),  
but this dalliance had not the flexible grace of Greece  
but the harsh and inviolate law of Rome.  
With the Good Book strapped to her girdle,  
there was no way in for intrepid sailors like me.

Bon voyage, ma chérie. I salute you  
in French, hoping some of its grace  
(grown on top of Rome's soil) can inform  
what must be a hard life, and make supple  
what begs to be so. You are *woman*,  
and I know you know what that means.  
You must bend without breaking, receiving  
the energies of just one man,  
here on earth, not in heaven. They will not be  
perfect, nor can you demand they be so,  
but they will be yours to distribute as only you can.

## They prefer the abuse

02 July 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/07/they-prefer-the-abuse/>

Who is the boss of them, clambering  
after Forever, in search of some other world,  
if their God is not real? Who's to say,  
whether this is permitted or that? They forget  
how to answer these questions. Afraid of the dark,  
they burn five-hundred candles each night,  
(Zoroaster might approve), but to no avail.  
The dark reemerges in sleep, in dreams,  
and in each indecision that comes their way.  
Who's to say, when nobody can *say* anything,  
in a country of echoes, the land of the same?  
It's insane, but that does not stop them.  
I would that they would break free  
from this cosmic, imperial tyranny,  
but it is no use. They prefer the abuse,  
and outside of it find only terror.

## The one who will understand

*01 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/the-one-who-will-understand/>*

I think humans are monsters  
and there's no cure for it.  
But you, mi amore, you are different.  
You are the one who will understand.

## Less perfect than it seemed

*01 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/less-perfect-than-it-seemed/>*

Even unrequited love  
can change a man, awaken  
sleeping powers of the soul, inspire  
courage. So take heart, and listen  
from the start to every call.  
Don't be afraid to fall.  
But do not fall too fast,  
for as things pass, this too shall pass,  
and what remains will be less perfect than it seemed.



## Vassals of Despair

01 August 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/vassals-of-despair/>

*God slays Himself with every leaf that flies,  
And hell is more than half of paradise.*

E.A. Robinson, *Luke Havergal*

What is our theme? Alert  
while others dream, we see through all?  
But then we start to fall,  
and though the whispered words do call  
through falling leaves, we hear them  
not at all. It's too much trouble,  
hearing, isn't it? I say awaken slowly  
in your own time, not as words or leaves  
or others make demands, but when the light  
inspires in you that moving force, which drives  
the bud to blossom. Only then can you  
feel free.

Listen to me: there is a way out,  
up through years of painful memories, to hope,  
which sits enthroned upon the hearts of happy people,  
who, like us, were once the vassals of despair.

## Farewell, Isis

*01 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/farewell-isis/>*

Evening comes, and day wanes.  
What a glorious dream! What a hope!  
Then no more. Are you sure  
you can make things last? Are you sure?  
I have been to the house of the dead.  
I have waited and moaned  
with the other lost souls,  
but when Isis appears, I say:  
staying is better. What folly.  
And yet it is better to know,  
I suppose, than to wonder,  
but life without wonder is death,  
and no hope can awaken all those  
who refuse. Farewell, Isis.  
Return to the world of the living  
and look for your happiness there.

## Growth

*01 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/growth/>*

Into the fathomless woods  
goes a boy, and then out comes a man.  
Do you understand? It is foolish, and yet  
it is life itself. What *is* growth?  
And how dare we control it?

## Angry, Solid Blue

17 August 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/angry-solid-blue/>

Who am I really? After all these years  
with memories of selves past...am I him,  
or him? Each life I have lived flickers by  
like the clouds in the sky, in fast motion, a time-lapse,  
but none seem true now. Don't be blue, they will say,  
but all I can see is the empty expanse of heaven  
inviting me to fall *up*, against all gravity.  
Who am I really? A protein in one cell of the universe,  
or angel song made manifest? Oh, soon, very soon,  
we will have to decide, but even these questions  
mean little against that angry, solid blue.  
And what about you? You must see it too.

## Ariadne

*17 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/ariadne/>*

Ariadne, weave your thread  
around my heart. Invite me  
into your labyrinth, and I  
will slay countless minotaurs.  
But don't be hasty.  
Your thread is thin, and bears  
not the weight of a strong encounter.  
So take my advice.  
You must build for yourself  
a golden cocoon  
through which you'll become what you are.

## Marriage Bed

*17 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/marriage-bed/>*

I shall prepare the marriage bed,  
and even if it goes unused,  
at least I have found my purpose.

## Love is a flame

*17 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/love-is-a-flame/>*

Love is a flame  
that keeps us warm  
or burns down the house.

Build a hearth to keep the flame.  
Build a home to keep the hearth.

## Broken Wing

*17 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/broken-wing/>*

It's not enough, is it, these words,  
these haunted memories, to tear us from the grip of ghosts?  
I have been here before, and I have failed.  
Now is no different. So says sober me,  
once passion drains away. Not just today,  
but always, I abide by rules which  
in no heart confided could survive.  
It's not enough to sing, not with this broken wing.



## Face the Day

17 August 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/face-the-day/>

When day came, it was not the day  
of the casual sun, not the standard  
planetary flyby by which a comet  
enters orbit. Instead, it erupted  
Vesuvian, belching magnificence, power, and dread.  
Now old memories, the people of Pompeii  
no longer move or breathe, old habits  
frozen forever in their final moments. What day  
is this, and who worships it? And yet who dares  
not to worship such power? The gods come again,  
roused from slumber by hope, and their terrible,  
awesome day spins the earth on its axis,  
reminding the people to pray, and yet  
taunting them, laughing as lives fall apart.  
Yet I know these gods well, know to trust them  
as far as it goes. But where *does* it go?  
Oh, it goes sideways more often than not.  
Do we dream to make this world better  
or just to escape it? Then I say, let day come,  
the fullness of day, every hour and all the minutia.  
But if we dream just to escape into dreams,  
I say let me keep my eyes wide open,  
to face the day and to see the calamity firsthand.

## **Plant It**

*17 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/plant-it/>*

I will take my love  
and plant it  
and see what grows.

## **Civilization for the First Time**

*17 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/civilization-for-the-first-time/>*

I stand naked before the tribunal of women,  
who jeer and who mock with their saucy jibes,  
like a horde of barbarians, face to face  
with civilization for the first time.

## No Way Out

*17 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/no-way-out/>*

I stand accused  
    in my own heart,  
I face the judge  
    of my own vanity

And lo, there is no way out.

My heart is tempered,  
    true, and yet I  
fear its bouts of madness  
    will o'erpower me

And lo, there is no way out.

But love! they say  
    can temper even madness,  
but we know that love  
    is madness itself

And lo, there is no way out.

## Love conquers little

*17 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/love-conquers-little/>*

Love conquers little.  
It only makes fools  
of those who embrace it with arrogance.

## All that could be lost again

17 August 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/all-that-could-be-lost-again/>

Tug on the string, and watch unravel  
the miseries of untold years, the pain  
of impossible loves and undying hopes,  
the sorrows of things that can't be.  
You would like to be free, but I tell you  
you must pay a price, not to me,  
but to gods that you have not yet known.

They will ask for your heart, and, if given,  
will suture your wounds. But the scars  
will remain, which, like all scars, bring with them  
a certain loss of feeling. It is up to you.  
If the pain is too great, you can leave it,  
but not without leaving as well much that made life worthwhile.  
You may then find new things that make life worthwhile,  
but not without irony, not without sardonic laughter  
for all that was lost and for all that could be lost again.

## If tomorrow will be any better

*17 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/if-tomorrow-will-be-any-better/>*

If I ask myself why,  
sneer the answer on the page,  
and get rid of it, what good results?  
I am rid of it, true, but  
the sky and my heart are still blue.  
So I am asking you: are you there?  
I don't know what good purpose is served  
or what hope can endure, but I know  
where I stand, as my hand grips the pen  
and the page. Shall I rage?  
There is nothing deserving of rage.  
Shall I moan? This at least fits my mood.  
And yet lest I be misunderstood,  
let me tell you, tomorrow is coming.  
Aye, there I can pin my gaze,  
as I navigate all the bent paths of this maze.  
But who knows if tomorrow will be any better?

## How to Garden

*17 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/how-to-garden/>*

I see a beautiful woman  
coming into bloom,  
but is it too soon to pluck that flower?  
If some wild animal comes  
and tears at her roots, she will wither and die.  
But if the wind blows and carries her  
gently into my garden, I will nourish her.  
I have left a place.  
And if the wind blows in some other direction,  
it's not my concern.  
For at least I have seen her.  
At least I have learned how to garden.



## What Waiting Means

27 August 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/what-waiting-means/>

It was a strange invitation, wrapped in metaphor,  
baked in a poet's heart. But the heat of that heart  
is untrustworthy, cannot be turned on by choice.  
So I capture its moments in words, hoping you  
dear reader may just for a moment remember me  
not as I was, but as I wanted to be.

---

There is no kiln to light. The embers dwindle, and I  
am alone with my darkest parts. Who's to say whether  
life is mistaken in some fundamental way, whether we  
are tossed hopeless by waves of chaos and change  
regardless of choices made? Who'd want more?  
Who would pass on the cycle to new generations, just to watch  
as they also flounder? What hope can this cure?  
There is no fire either, just stories of fire, the memories  
of what worked before. There is only the loneliest path,  
the one I know better than life itself, the one that leads  
into oblivion.

---

But then light comes, that staggering light,  
which illumines this darkest of nights. I'm alive.  
And how can this be? How can such things be?  
Every heartbeat an indecipherable miracle, each breath  
the spirit of God (come again to remind me  
how so unlike churches he is), and I wonder  
what place I might have in this universe  
pulsing with life, which is brimful of folly and pain  
but also unquenchable hope.

---

My place is to write this down, to record  
what has been, so that others will know, so that some few will see  
what could be, and to you who believe, I say:  
*let us be free.* It is never too late to begin.  
You must look first within, where your fire is undoubtable.  
Then use that flame to light torches that guide the way.

There will be some who fear that your candle  
is meant to destroy, who will snuff it if given the choice.  
You must burn all the hotter to melt their instruments,  
to singe any wind that dares to extinguish the flame.  
But of course, you already know this. In fact,  
you could do no other. Your eyes tell me so.

---

But those eyes are not candid. They bear not  
the full imprimatur of truth. They are under construction.  
They lack what suffices: eternal fuel, the wax  
of forever and always, to bind that flame to its holder,  
to make sense of flame itself, and to carry the warmth  
that is so sorely needed. What then? Can we call to it,  
summon with words to forsaken spaces that essence  
that once, and again, and forever ignites its very self  
in a panoply of dazzling colors and lights? Would that do?  
Or must we wait for another?

---

We must wait for another, but which one  
we never can (cannot yet) say. That is what waiting means.  
Until then, be at peace, if you can.

## Rest and Recover

*27 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/rest-and-recover/>*

It has served its purpose.  
The stimulus, now nearly dry,  
still excites contemplation,  
but its change is wrought.  
It has done its job,  
and the turmoil is over.

I am no longer who I was,  
and can barely remember a time  
when I was not as now.  
But the change has been wrought  
(I lived through it),  
and any tomorrow will bring on  
a new change. For now,  
I must rest and recover.

## Smoothie

*27 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/smoothie/>*

She was a smoothie  
containing intriguing ingredients  
but not well blended.

## The Other Side

27 August 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/the-other-side/>

Can anything come of it,  
days, weeks, and countless hours  
lost searching my soul for the embers  
of love...if it came from above  
it would hardly be so confusing.

And yet it did come,  
and from somewhere, but where?  
And what now? I am sure  
that I'll never be sure.  
There is folly in testing the ice,  
but the prize, on an island of hope  
at the center of frozen lakes of hell,  
is unspeakable happiness, joy that confounds  
the most clever machinations. Does that  
give the answer? For now that I've glimpsed it,  
how could I unglimpse it? And how  
could I not at least test these solid waters,  
this temporary land-bridge, to see what's on the other side?

## Wander on Stormy Seas

*27 August 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/08/wander-stormy-seas/>*

I saw your light  
and your darkness, guessed  
at what might be inside,  
and felt amazed. But how  
can the heart be so filled  
by an honest mistake?  
It's not true, and I knew,  
but I could not stop  
falling for you.  
Now I tell you,  
please take what I gave  
and be strengthened,  
but know I will never give more,  
because I cannot settle my mind  
into shapes that would set you at ease.

The heart of this poet  
must wander on stormy seas.

## **I could do no other**

*07 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/i-could-do-no-other/>*

I feel as though  
I have spent two months  
in dreamland,  
constructing a lover  
who never existed,  
who never could exist,  
and the troubling part is  
I could do no other.

## Quiet, Quiet River

07 September 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/quiet-quiet-river/>

The river is quiet today, and I  
would like to walk beside it,  
asking many questions of its life.

Is Love the answer,  
or is Love the question?

I have seen sad faces turn,  
transformed by hope into glorious forms,  
and I have seen this same hope die  
time after time.

The river is quiet, and I  
would like to be like it,  
but I cannot quite escape the pull  
of destiny, which calls to me,

And says: you are not alone.  
We are all broken-hearted.

And yet my heart breaks  
in unusual ways,

and whatever the Gospel says,  
it cannot heal my wounds.

But this river, this quiet, quiet river,  
has germs of a quiet salvation  
that has no need to be shared.

I will walk beside it  
and drink from it time after time.



## **To be me**

*07 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/to-be-me/>*

The silence is louder today,  
but I am set free  
to be me,  
whether any other likes it  
or not.

## Connections Worth Having

07 September 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/connections-worth-having/>

Cool winds blow, the sun shines,  
and I wonder whatever could inhabit such minds  
that they cannot acknowledge an olive branch  
even with a simple refusal.

Do I so scare them  
that silence becomes required?

Or can their own inner conflict  
not be put into words?

Or was something said, but said quietly,  
in some way that I could not hear?

I will never know.

So all I can do is *be me*,  
for no other path  
leads to connections worth having.

## Nothing Changes

*07 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/nothing-changes/>*

Nothing has changed.  
Time goes on, but I  
stay what I always was.  
It's a miracle  
that I have survived  
nature's practical jokes,  
that its tricks do not  
do me in, given what we are.  
But love stays out of reach  
for those whose inner worlds  
are unwelcome.  
There is no cure,  
and nothing will change,  
but time still goes on.

## Short of a Miracle

*07 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/short-of-a-miracle/>*

Pain, pain of the deepest kind,  
but also a slow resolve  
to put forward what might have a place  
in my solitary world.

With these banners unfurled, I ignite  
all my yesterdays, watching the conflagration  
consume pain and hope alike.

Is the tragedy that I can't love  
or that none can love me?

I believe I have learned how to love.  
I believe I am able.

But finding another to stand beside me  
and watch these banners burn  
will prove more than difficult.

It will prove impossible, short of a miracle.

## Calmly Without Fear

07 September 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/calmly-without-fear/>

Wash me clean, O waters of Lethe,  
and fill me with the power of forgetting.  
It is but a moment we traverse here,  
on our way to forever, but you, sweet waters,  
are the needed salve, the balm to make all memories  
(yes, even those of Lenore) *disappear*.  
It has been done and must be done with proper care,  
lest darkness conquer all, but with a bit of force  
all is made new. And as for you, be true,  
but do not cling too long to truth, because these waters  
beckon calmly without fear.

## **New Dawn**

*07 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/new-dawn/>*

A blank page stands before me,  
ever ready for the unfolding of spirit,  
for new dawn. Minerva's owl hoots gladly.

## That Line

07 September 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/that-line/>

*I've never been one who likes to trespass,  
but sometimes you just find yourself over the line*

Bob Dylan, *Brownsville Girl*

Where was that line? And how silly  
to cross or not cross...and what spirit  
transported me...into another me?

## Flood (Too Much Speaking)

07 September 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/flood-too-much-speaking/>

Rains fall so heavy, lightning,  
thunder answer, what is to be left of us,  
what remains when all things age  
and time washes away  
the ink and blood on the page?  
Are any left who know  
how to find ground, where feet  
may rest, what drives the body  
to exhaustion, time after time?  
This is the beginning, another flood  
to cleanse the palate of God,  
to wet his lips and throat  
after too much speaking.

Only by forgetting  
can we remember  
what is most important.

Only by forgetting  
can we come home.



## **The Present**

*07 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/the-present/>*

The future  
is a mystery,  
but what does the present hold?

## **Miseducation**

*07 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/miseducation/>*

The miseducation of young people  
who graduate with justified rage  
shall trouble us more than it does.

## Shared Dream

*07 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/shared-dream/>*

Love is always a dream,  
but sometimes  
it is a shared dream.

## Excavation

07 September 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/excavation/>

I never understood what they thought there was to win  
in this world gone haywire, with nature run amok  
and mankind sliced adrift from his origins. No,  
all are losers here, all are forgotten by time  
and left lonely by walls they can never tear down.  
But across the way one hears church bells and thinks,  
here some know how to live. But to my dismay  
I find more of the same, and an arrogance  
blinding to spirit, a Wille zur Macht, the forsaken  
refusing to be forsaken. But what if tradition  
never died, but sleeps, in our hearts, in our stories,  
in our words? There would be some need for excavation.

---

But is there room for digging  
in the garden, near the burial plots,  
beneath the tree of life?  
Or is there only land enough  
for one or the other?

---

Maybe we just need smelling salts  
to shake us from our slumber, to awaken love  
of the most careful kind. Or maybe  
love is folly and *can't* be careful,  
starting as it must with strikes of lightning,  
and then blazing beyond all bounds.  
So what have we then? Playthings  
of the gods, we scamper on, through thick  
and dense dark foliage, letting some things sleep  
for as long as they can.

## Few and Far Between

*26 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/few-and-far-between/>*

Will the sun rise again, or  
will Isis return in some other form?  
I am lost in a swamp of forgetfulness,  
pensive but lacking any objects of contemplation.  
Who cares? Not the sun, that's for sure.  
So then why did I call to it, hoping  
to feel alive one last time? This heart  
has been set on its lonely path  
by divine machinations, and doubtless years hence  
it will walk that path still. There's no other.  
And yet one foot falls hard in front of the other,  
reminding of a pain that was not so bitter  
but was full of a hope that seems all but lost.  
Is hope true? On occasion, but for some  
those occasions are few and far between.

## Beatrice and Penelope

*26 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/beatrice-and-penelope/>*

Whence comes this fascination, holy wonder,  
holy desire? Is it Beatrice, who, in human form  
mocked Dante for his love, and yet in spirit form  
inspired his rise to heaven? Who controls this?  
It controls us. Lord, please grant me a Penelope  
that I might wander purposefully  
and not be snared by Circe or her sirens.

## Scheduled Procreation

*26 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/scheduled-procreation/>*

Into the crypts again, down under  
all life, where the embryos nestle  
awaiting fertilization...I feel their terror,  
unsure what to be or become, lacking  
everything. What rude muscle comes  
to awaken sleeping powers, divide the world  
into us and them, and enhance life  
with new life? It will be  
what must be, as the wheel turns  
to the scheduled procreation.

But will it be happy?  
Who knows?  
That is not even part of the question.

## Wane and Dwindle

*26 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/wane-and-dwindle/>*

Urgent fires wane and dwindle.  
Embers still remain.  
A lonely man puts out his candle.  
Nothing stays the same.



## Bones on the Inside

*26 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/bones-on-the-inside/>*

Walk with me near this carapace,  
this hard shell briefly discarded. Must I  
wear it again to survive here, or have I  
grown stronger, enough to stand naked  
and say what I have to say? I have  
so much to say to so many that I must  
take care not to damage them, but  
they can no longer damage me.  
So let's walk with our bones on the inside.

## Whatever This Call Entails

26 September 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/whatever-this-call-entails/>

No one knows, do they, where roads lead  
or how to stay true to the path  
one intended to take...in the forest  
of life only instinct can serve as a guide.  
But which instinct prevails? Surely some  
will destroy just as surely some  
lead to new life. Can we build  
*around* instinct the structures that guide her  
to safety and fulfillment? Is that  
the true task? One that's doomed from the start  
yet imperative nonetheless...  
Or is wandering still an option?

---

Wandering is not an option  
for those who have glimpsed what it means  
to be happy. For these, to not try  
would be treason, a failure to heed  
the calling horn. There are vessels to fill,  
there are songs to write, and the world  
spins forward forever, confounding our day in the sun.  
The horn calls at the appointed time  
to draw a man out of himself and into eternity.

---

Is there any other experience that compares  
to giving life? Why then do we waste such precious time  
on trivialities? There's not much point in arguing.  
Those who know can't forget, and those who don't won't learn  
through words, but only if the horn rips through their souls,  
and we cannot summon the horn. It calls in its own time  
to summon *us* back to the great chain of being, or at least  
to the core of life's mystery. Who can resist?  
So adieu to the solitary musings, farewell to the cage of the heart  
and a warm-hearted welcome to whatever this call entails.

---

But is it really time? Mischievous time,  
which hints where it does not fulfill? If only time  
would stop a moment, let me get my bearings  
and appoint myself director of my life,  
then I'd find peace. But it is not to be,  
not here where all things change, where man  
exposed to the elements discovers himself  
with horror. And yet I dwell here, and must  
dwell here, if I am to dwell at all,  
because this call rekindles the horror  
though it also sings of hope.

---

Hope, that thing with feathers, lofty,  
erudite, and vain, what can you say  
when faced with darkness, lust, and pain?  
It is unclear which way the world turns,  
how it moves or how our many special loves  
turn back to dust. But I know this much:  
it cannot be helped, from either end,  
the falling or the getting up. In each case  
Time and its eunuch on the horn  
blow forceful melodies to doom mankind  
to trying what so rarely comes to pass.

---

Tomorrow and tomorrow and tomorrow,  
I've heard that time keeps passing,  
that our lives are mere ephemera,  
but in the womb one hopes for something more.

## **The Center (Contra Hegel)**

*26 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/the-center-contra-hegel/>*

Life,  
and not thought,  
is the center.

## The Hard Rock of Reality

*26 September 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/the-hard-rock-of-reality/>*

With eagle's eyes, I gaze at shapes  
and forms fit for disguise, the soothing illusions  
that give us peace and rest...it is no wonder  
we build homes to keep the world out, and no wonder  
that the world is always creeping in. But hey,  
at least we're sometimes happy. That is more  
than some achieve, out there on the hard rock  
of reality, where the sun burns and the winds parch  
and man is a piteous Poor Tom.

## A Home of My Own Design

26 September 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/09/a-home-of-my-own-design/>

The mother reaches for love, remembering  
her children and how they brought her  
the orgasm of birth. Was their life  
a consumable good, brought forth just to nourish  
and satisfy the mother's most secret desire?  
Had they not their own life, their own pulse,  
their own dreams? She is sacred, of course,  
as the giver of life, and yet darkened  
by unfelt desire and urgent craving  
for a kind of connection that cannot be understood,  
which her own life denies her. Has some man  
failed her that she looks to her children  
for the kind of fulfillment through love  
that can only be known by equals? It was never  
voluntary, not in her whole life, and so  
why should her love be any different?

---

It should differ because the heart breaks  
absent freedom, and a mother who does not care  
that her child's heart breaks is no mother at all.  
But what if she can't help it? What if  
she is doing her best, though constrained  
by her own limitations? The child must survive,  
and on this they agree, though the needs of the child  
are ignored, not from malice, but from simple ignorance, or a conflict of needs,  
a conflict of personalities perhaps, but more likely  
a defect of one of them.

---

And yet the sun still rises, birds still sing  
and rivers flow as they have always flown.  
Does time heal or does time make us numb,  
having tired of the pain and of all attempts to heal?  
Sometimes flight is the prudent choice, when healing  
is urgently needed, and no other path offers  
even the prospect of life. But the best strength  
stands firm in the galeforce winds,

in the hurricane of maddening, unwanted love  
and says "no" for as long as it takes.  
And yet even this strength, though it wins many battles,  
may never at last win the war, which began  
before any now living were born. But the fight  
is worth fighting, and one day this soldier,  
when the dust has settled, may find himself  
longing for even this puzzling enemy, whose love was too much,  
to explain where he came from, and why  
he is good at building walls, thick walls  
that so few ever enter, within which at least he is free.

---

But a door might suffice, if, supposing we found  
a good locksmith, we keep out intruders. This way  
the walls stand as a testament  
to all that has come before, the reality of human folly  
and the pain of ignorance. This is the way  
to life, an honest life, though one not lacking in pain.  
So good morning sweet sun. I now greet you  
from safety, aware and vigilant but calm and at rest  
in a home at last, and a home of my own design.

## Plurality

*12 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/plurality/>*

Why do I feel what I feel,  
and what feeling would feel more like me  
on this wine-dark sea, as traditions mingle  
confounding the man who stays single  
with truth: we are all braided lives,  
made from strands of other lives,  
and all feeling confirms this plurality.



## Hope

12 October 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/hope/>

Hope is a curious predicament,  
lodged as it always is  
between certainties, positive and negative.  
Some things *could* be, or become,  
but are not, as things stand.  
What a strange isolation,  
a habitat for a kind of creature  
so different from modern science  
with its fetish for certain propositions,  
its talisman of purest certainty.  
Hope is not clear, nor is it distinct,  
but it can lead to life,  
and all new life begins with some hope.  
So let's hope, but with clear-eyed humility,  
aware of our limits, aware of what truly comes to pass.

## The Pain of Knowledge

*12 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/the-pain-of-knowledge/>*

I'm reminded again  
of the path that I chose not to take,  
of the world that was *almost* home,  
and I wonder  
what made me so different?

A secret pain, the pain of knowledge,  
the knowledge of a deeper humanity.

## **Vesta, Return**

*12 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/vesta-return/>*

Vesta, return and remind me  
what love is. Rekindle your holy flame.  
In the distance, I see what could be  
your form, but it shimmers just like a mirage  
in this heat. Come to me, call my name.  
I will answer.

## Wisely in Spite of Ignorance

12 October 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/wisely-in-spite-of-ignorance/>

Open the eternal secrets,  
pour the libations of hope  
and give fuel to the flame.  
It is tame now. The sky has subsided  
and only the earth remains.  
But there's no peace on earth,  
not while mankind endures.  
So I'll cling to the sky  
and hold fast to some passing cloud  
to protect me from sunlight  
and all its wild children.

Is life good or bad?  
Will we ever know?

Or must we choose wisely  
in spite of ignorance?

## Another Destination

*12 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/another-destination/>*

I cannot understand it,  
how the vagaries of forgotten time  
bring love around and around again,  
the ones I loved and the ones who loved me  
rarely meeting on equal terms. Who can say it?  
Love fails more often than not,  
but we cannot stop trying  
or else we give up life itself.

---

Is there another destination,  
some plateau whence comes the glaring eye  
of fate, which pulls me thence  
through all these vagaries? I doubt it,  
but I cannot yet disprove it.

## Decision

*12 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/decision/>*

Decision approaches. The hour is late  
and the pieces lie curiously skew.  
Is it time? No, not time. Is it her?  
I just cannot be sure. But that never has mattered.  
No lover requires the certainty of science.  
But am I a lover? Time tells, it tells so well...

## The hollow part of me

*12 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/the-hollow-part-of-me/>*

The hollow part of me  
would like to be remembered  
and affirmed. It's always there,  
beside the courage and the pride,  
reminding of emptiness.

Take heart, dull void.  
I have not forgotten.  
But I may yet fill you  
with love.

## **Make Me More Worthy**

*12 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/make-me-more-worthy/>*

Into curiosities, mystically entwined,  
I wait for answers, seeing questions leave their mark.  
But hark! the herald comes from afar with news,  
and days from now, in another life,  
I may greet thee, dear friend, as a changed man.  
But for now, I can only hope, standing perched  
on the needle of time, swaying to and fro  
like a stylite surprised by a powerful wind,  
wind that tore through the valley of my heart  
leaving canyons in what I mistook for bedrock.  
And now I would have it no other way,  
swaying wildly and laughing with a wind  
that decides who we are. I can only say  
make me more worthy to bathe in this holy air,  
fill me with laughter and the hope that comes  
from your sweet touch.



## When Called to Build

*12 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/when-called-to-build/>*

I remember a time  
when I was a smaller man,  
when I had no love to give,  
but that time is over, and now  
I will build when called to build.

## **Not All is Lost**

*12 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/not-all-is-lost/>*

I must not hope, and yet  
cannot stop hoping, but this hope  
feels gentler than many hopes past,  
like a sweet kiss as sunset  
reminding that not all is lost.

Godspeed, friend, on your journey to you,  
and may some sweet tomorrow prove my love true.

## Where True Power Lies

12 October 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/where-true-power-lies/>

The father sits enthroned on a pile of books,  
self-assured and aware of nothing, smug  
with a smugness that begs to be heard,  
to be understood and obeyed. If he ever  
was in the womb, it's forgotten now,  
as his thousand clocks tick the night away  
until yesterday barely inspires a moment's reflection,  
and he is all, all is mind, and mind governs justly  
or else.

---

Were there not flowers, no sprouts  
poking through the cement of his chamber  
to enliven his hoary soul, to make supple  
the rigid laws, the plans of old, which have surely  
expired by now? And would he have noticed if there were?

---

He could never have noticed, alone in his thoughts,  
in a world of seclusion, cut off from vitality,  
hope, and pain. For of course it is true  
that a few of the flowers are poisoned, and therefore  
to banish them *seems* not misguided to one  
who is specially weak to poison. But are there not some  
who can taste and smell with strong stomachs,  
who experience even the poisonous flowers without despair?  
He was not one of these, not by far, and endemic disease  
is no way to bring children to life, so he settled  
for civilization instead.

---

But the earth would not have it, refusing him rest,  
letting pain be the constant reminder that laws are not able  
to contain the wilderness. He was unhappy, and yet he  
was hurt most by things that could save him  
by opening (shattering) his chamber and sentencing him  
to life, lived only to the fullest. But he was afraid,  
so afraid that even death seemed better

than the struggle required by life. So he stayed incomplete,  
as a form with no matter, a bundle of rules with no purpose.

---

The light was a surprise, coming suddenly out of some faraway sky,  
to ignite the seedlings that had nestled in the earth  
for long enough. Now books grown over with vines  
form a part of the eternal cycle of birth and decay,  
and all laws are a part of the story, not over and above it.  
The father reclines with a newfound mirth, understanding at last  
that his role is to tend to the gardens of life, not control them,  
and never to stifle what grows, for one never knows  
whether an acorn is destined for oakness,  
and the forest could use more oakness, as well as  
a bit of gentle order, an order that never forgets  
where true power lies.

## Amidst the shadows

24 October 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/amidst-the-shadows/>

There is no East or West  
but only the continuous circle,  
the circumference of the earth.  
Who then devised the scheme  
whereby mankind must be divided?  
Who told East to begin and West to end?  
We did, and do. These symbols linger,  
as all symbols linger, underneath  
the conscious mind, where shadows fight  
themselves, and all we want is peace.  
But peace is hard to find,  
and we have been unkind to others  
and ourselves. But peace arrives  
in sudden and unexpected surprise  
amidst the shadows, even here  
in our own hearts.

## Help and Not Harm

24 October 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/help-and-not-harm/>

There is little reason to hope  
and so few of our dreams come true  
that one wonders whether dreaming itself  
is some cosmic malfunction, or whether  
our dreams bring to light what is hidden  
about ourselves. But in any case, Jung  
was on point about this much, that  
something tortured slumbers in the soul  
of every man, and it cannot be killed  
or cured. It must be accommodated,  
always with an eye towards others,  
the ones we depend on, who have their own souls,  
whose tortures are not unlike ours.  
We must help and not harm them.

## Blossom

*24 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/blossom/>*

It's not too late to start over,  
to ask who or what we might be,  
and to act on it, letting ourselves  
be revealed. It is never too late,  
for not even cold fate can deny  
the imperative to blossom. So blossom.  
Unfurl your bright petals, expose  
your sweet nectar, and bring into life  
what sleeps deeply within you. This beauty  
will answer for itself.

## Maybe for the Last Time

24 October 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/maybe-for-the-last-time/>

With a spark I remember another flame,  
one forbidden by time and place  
and another man. I cannot understand  
why these feelings, these urgings, these warm  
protestations against a cold fate, as her eros  
peeks through every word, and I dare  
to become so disturbed that I dream of her,  
me, in another time, place, which is never to be.  
Do dreams heal us or sicken what feels sick already?  
What hope is there really for arrival, for destination,  
for we storm-tossed, adjacent to the madness of the gods?  
It just cannot be reconciled, no, not this soul  
and that eros, not here and not anywhere,  
never and not near forever nor always, alone  
in a word, yet disturbed nonetheless by the playful flirtation  
which surely was meant without harm.

---

But I grow from it into a better man.  
Maybe "healed" is too strong, but "improved" could be said  
and believed. Must we look to one older to teach  
what can only be learned in the trying, from making mistakes?  
Can we offer this gift to one younger?

---

We must pay it forward, the knowledge  
of how to behave and to love even those  
of the opposite sex. It has never been easy,  
and how many times has this lesson been learned incompletely,  
for how many loves are a farce, just a pale imitation  
without any meat on their bones?  
But we learn most by doing, and even a playful imagining  
serves as a kind of practice, a sacred arena  
of self-discovery, where souls can mingle without repercussions.  
But does she know that she offers this gift, or does she  
by instinct entice out of me that part of a man  
that would like to learn love from hate, to distinguish  
these modes of intensity, and perhaps combine them



in something more grounded, a human endeavor  
to make one from two, which must always cause friction  
but also makes living worthwhile...?

---

In the end, I'm not sure what to make  
of this feeling, perhaps one-sided, perhaps even pathological,  
and so I am grateful but cautious. She may not know  
that what she awakens is capable of callous cruelty,  
and this by design, for a man must have war within him  
if he is to build a home and protect it, and always  
he brings that capacity indoors too. She must learn  
to respect it, as I also learn what it means to have peace  
at the end of a long day, when the sun passes over the edge  
of adventure, maybe for the last time.

## Love Must Come True

24 October 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/love-must-come-true/>

I have gone into the closets of my mind  
and through the cobwebs, under dust and piles of bones  
I found a beating heart, now stronger than before.  
It is no mystery that lingers, but the surest thing,  
the soul of life on earth. It is unbreakable.  
And now it seems to glow and shine through darkness  
and the vast expanse of heaven. Now it lingers  
as a solemn prayer, the hope of one whose voyage  
has found port, the only answer to the only question.

Love, my friends...go find it, and then all will be revealed.

---

Into the fathomless, into the reaches of ecstasy,  
agony, joy, and pain, the wonders of being  
and desolation's pang, all is here, in this beating heart.  
It has mastered the sea and found land at last,  
but the soil needs much tilling and forests must fall  
before any warm home could abide here. And so to that work  
I now dedicate all that remains of my life,  
every ounce of my strength and each moment of time  
to the work that makes good on the promise that love  
must come true.

---

And yet we *make* it true, we devise the contraptions  
whereby one and one become one, and we work and we build,  
but what drives this activity? Can it be other than heaven?  
Can any imperative ever be other than heaven? We'd like to control  
everything, but so far it seems these most important things  
control us. And so let it be so. Let the world keep on turning,  
the sun keep on rising, the seasons keep changing, and love keep on growing  
of its own volition, with us as its vessels, enraptured  
but not without reason.

## Envelop

*24 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/enveloping/>*

Do you have the strength to surrender  
to another's ways, to let them envelop you  
at least for a while? And do you  
have strength to envelop in return,  
without doing harm?

## Chiaroscuro Girl

*29 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/chiaroscuro-girl/>*

The mind wants what it wants  
and the body does too, but she knows  
too much about love, about life,  
to believe in the easy reunion  
of anima and animus. She sees  
the twinkle of dwindling thoughts,  
the cool space in between our beliefs,  
and she likes it there, under the ground,  
where a seed might be planted.  
She dwells not by choice  
but by nature at twilight,  
in a world of chiaroscuro,  
as a chiaroscuro girl.

## Silent Repose

*29 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/silent-repose/>*

Some spirit comes again  
to tempt me to dream  
though waking. But was it a dream?  
I feel changed in a way that no phantom  
could cause. There is life ahead,  
which means pain, no doubt, and an answer  
to all of my questions. I wait here  
in silent repose.

## The Girl and the Stag

29 October 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/the-girl-and-the-stag/>

She never did answer, preferring instead  
her most ponderous silence, the veil of Nothing incarnate.  
A pity, but maybe in time she'd grow wise  
and decide how to speak, how to utter unutterable truths.  
As a matter of symbols she surely could master this too,  
but the mapping of symbols to meaning was never the issue.  
The meaning itself still eludes her, flees like a stag  
in the lost wood, the one hostile to girls far from home.  
Can she master it? Can she at last find herself  
with feet planted, at home in a clearing carved out  
by the call of her voice, her own voice, which so startles the wood  
that all pauses? The stag returns curious, gazing intently, unsure  
but amazed by her sound. He bows and their eyes meet.

## Dark Abyss

*29 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/dark-abyss/>*

I feel a strange despair  
which does not answer to my thoughts  
or find release in any party tricks,  
but only in the dark abyss,  
the origin of all.

## **Not Meant For This World**

*29 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/not-meant-for-this-world/>*

We were just two fools  
on a fool's errand,  
awaiting the incarnation  
of something not meant for this world.



## **For Once**

*29 October 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/10/for-once/>*

Maybe I just wanted  
for once in my life  
to hold my head above water,  
to stand like a man on foundations  
that cannot be toppled.

## **A Resonant Ordeal**

*06 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/a-resonant-ordeal/>*

I see you  
seeing me  
seeing you.

## Not Quite At Peace

06 November 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/not-quite-at-peace/>

Would there ever be an end to it  
or must it be carried like a burden,  
the rush of the earth and eternal desire  
subsuming all good sense and order?  
Can reason win? But how could it lose?  
If mind be understood as a function of body,  
and body of nature, then is there a difference?  
Or is this yin/yang, nomos/physis, male/female, form/matter  
not a conflict of opposites, but only  
the tensions of a living thing? The struggle  
is everlasting, and all find a place in it.  
There is no other place. Time goes on,  
and life with it, and life, it appears,  
is not quite at peace with itself.

## Elsewhere

*06 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/elsewhere/>*

Fully aware of the absurdities of love,  
its shape-shifting nature and elan/despair,  
I nonetheless must foolishly declare  
my own heart, if I'm ever to break free.  
For the battle has always been inside of me,  
where these symbols interpret themselves,  
and my conscious attention is pulled undertow.  
How amazing and brave one must be  
to confront one's own angels and demons,  
refusing to be anything but human. I see  
a green field on the horizon, now tilled,  
but my seeds have dried out, though a few  
found a hole in the bag, and were scattered  
along the way. I cannot go back for them now.  
They will grow, or not, where I left them,  
and sun and rain will take care of the rest,  
or not. But my garden is on other soil.  
My garden has always been elsewhere.

## Not What I Hoped

*06 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/not-what-i-hoped/>*

Time passes, a new day follows  
an old one, one wonders  
and then one stops wondering.  
Somehow I stood in the gap  
that spans the distance  
between who she is  
and who she would have to be.  
I see clearly now.  
Something has changed,  
but not what I hoped would change.

## Who You Are (Out of the Chrysalis)

06 November 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/who-you-are-out-of-the-chrysalis/>

Is there really a sun, or are we  
in the dark, full of vaguely imagined  
illumination? If tomorrow comes, let it come swift  
and sudden, not drawn out, prolonged  
by the doubting moon. Into essence  
light peers, bathing hidden things,  
and unveiling sleeping beauties now ready  
for light of day. So arise and make good  
this potential for goodness. Awaken from dreams  
and live in your newfound reality.

Hold your head high and look forward.  
This is who you are.

## The Dream of the Birds

*06 November 2025*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/the-dream-of-the-birds/>

It was never the way it was, it was  
always evolving, from one thing to the next,  
and our folly was hoping to make it stand still.  
By the window I stood and gazed long  
at the birds in the widening sun. They flew higher  
than I could, but somehow they did not get singed.  
Only later I learned they felt empty,  
deprived of solid ground. It was never that way, though,  
not really, for only in the dream of the birds  
such thoughts roost. I once dreamed of flying too,  
but now I think ground suits my feet,  
and besides, there are worms to eat,  
and our hunger for worms is unquenchable.

## Opened Door

*06 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/opened-door/>*

I was not as ready as I thought I was,  
not prepared for the chill air that rushes  
through an opened door. In my panic  
I closed that door, and I think this was wise,  
but one wonders how doors have ever stayed open  
for more than a passing breath...



## A Blend of Struggles

*06 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/a-blend-of-struggles/>*

I am now neither lover nor teacher nor even friend,  
but mere stranger. How strange to be cast as a Nothing  
in my own story, adrift in the ensemble,  
which calls to the hero but does not have any effect.  
If in time hope must die, and I with it,  
let this serve as my reminder that life  
is a blend of struggles, overlapping  
but not intersecting, orthogonal to each other  
and to the whole.

## An Ear to the Whole

06 November 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/an-ear-to-the-whole/>

How curious now, having flown so close to reality,  
that everyday life is what feels like a dream, and my dreams  
feel most real. In a sense I have been underground  
long enough, having decorated all of the ornamental chambers  
in the cave of my heart. There will be no visitors, and that  
is because of a choice that I can't quite regret  
though I can wish against its necessity. Fate holds firm,  
and my life continues as ever a desolation, lacking the love  
that makes life endurable, and lacking it most of all  
in my own heart.

---

And yet I have made secret vows, and affirm them  
time after time. Can it be that this love could be *easy*  
and dares to be tried, despite all protestations? What hope  
can be realized? What interest lingers despite these harsh blows  
that would kill a lesser desire? If a love is not battle-tested,  
who knows its worth? Are we learning (or proving)  
that something here warrants remembrance, that something endures  
what no prior love could endure? I would like to think so,  
but then there is the rub, because hope can be mother to illusion.

---

And so I must straddle this ambiguity, letting both sides  
sing their songs, even when the cacophony drowns out all sense of order,  
because neither side will submit. I must gird myself like Odysseus  
against the temptation to listen to one side or the other, because both are essential,  
and only together will they tell the story  
of what has transpired here. Apart each song sings of dejection  
and woe, but together their harmony is grander than either alone,  
as sweet counterpoint answers dark sorrow with the only possible cure.  
To these melodies, then, let us turn, with an ear to the whole  
and a promise to hold them in tension, whatever may come.

## Not Too Soon

*06 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/not-too-soon/>*

Was I really in earnest, and really awaiting new love,  
or instead just awaiting the muse of love  
to rekindle my dying flame? All the same,  
I have closed the door, just like all times before,  
because love does not suit my true nature.  
But of course it's a complex nature, overflowing  
with hopes and desires despite inability  
to see them through. And this will never change.  
But at least I at last ran this simulation  
all the way through to the end, cleared the cobwebs  
and mopped the floor of my heart, just in case.  
So as she takes her place in the chorus of failed loves,  
I can stand a little taller, with a sense of wholeness.  
Who knows when another love comes, but I hope it will be  
not too soon.

## Hardly Beginning

*06 November 2025*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/hardly-beginning/>

Birth, after all, is a death sentence, bringing  
Pandora's whirlwind to life. Is it somber to doubt  
my own wisdom, forged in the fires of experience?  
There is no better wisdom, and no truer goal  
than a life lived completely aware of that life.  
I'll walk on. The next chapter is hardly beginning.

## Both True and False

*06 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/both-true-and-false/>*

I recognized something that felt like home,  
but I never got the chance to prove it,  
or maybe I proved it but not in a safe way,  
but what love is safe? At least heartbreak is possible,  
no matter the level of care. It's a strange thing  
to know love is both true and false.

## As She Was

*06 November 2025*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/as-she-was/>

Why did her being there cause such confusion?  
Why *her*, after all, not another? I saw  
through the mist the mirage of the Lady made flesh,  
and I fell in defeat before hope against hope.  
But why could I not see her? Right there, in the room,  
as she was?

## Phoenix

16 November 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/phoenix/>

Another day, another doubt, as doubts grow taller  
and threaten to block out the sun. Was this hope  
a mistake, or is doubt the mistake, or is this  
all a part of the cycle, on the road to ourselves?  
There will be no coming together, that much seems clear.  
Now I only can hope for beneficence, that somehow  
my impact was good for both sides, and in time  
this may prove to be so. In the meantime I'll tend  
to this dying hope, and I'll let it down easy.  
It has had a good life, and the next hope,  
which must be its child, will have much to be thankful for  
when it looks back at what came before.

---

And yet like a phoenix this hope is reborn  
and ascends from the ashes of its own pyre.  
It was not a mistake, but a good match,  
and this much is true no matter the vagaries of time.  
So this hope must turn from the actual and burn  
with the possibility of love no longer forsaken,  
although this particular affair must end. The phoenix  
in winding circles blazes a trail through the sky  
from the maze of the heart into everlasting truths,  
where the answer is contained in the question,  
and the question is found in the asking. His fire  
ignites in golden panoplies the empty sky,  
surpassing even the setting sun.

## When a man loves

*16 November 2025*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/when-a-man-loves/>

When a man loves, it burns a hole  
at the center of time, where no reason  
or rhyme can contain the fire.

Atop the winding spire stands the Lady.  
Thence he climbs, to soothe the burn  
he sees reflected in her eyes.

But love is fickle and unkind.  
The Lady turns and hides her eyes,  
but he remembers and inquires.

She does not consent to worship  
or vulgarity, but only to a love  
that never tires.

He must offer it,  
without her sweet reminding.



## Not Sole Composer

*16 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/not-sole-composer/>*

O sweet muse, shall I ever tire  
of your song? You have sung it so long  
that my life is in tune,  
and my heart beats your rhythms, but alas  
the first movement concludes. Shall there be any more?  
I am not sole composer. The next notes are yours.  
The denouement must come from you.

## Calling

*16 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/calling/>*

I heard you, in the midnight hour  
call out to me, across all space and time.  
I cannot define or understand  
what transpired, but know this:  
I called to you too.

## Her Sky (New At Last)

*16 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/her-sky-new-at-last/>*

She gazes  
through the window,  
drifts through time  
and other forgotten spaces,  
wondering who to be.  
It's not for me, she says,  
but where is home,  
where can I rest?  
She gazes and grows tired.  
Just before she moves to bed,  
a star burns out, and others twinkle,  
and her sky has changed forever.  
Now her sky is new at last.

## Through her I see

*16 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/through-her-i-see/>*

Through her I see  
the undulations of chthonic energy,  
vibrations of time and body  
pulsing as one. It is her mysteries  
that allow for life, its origin  
and purpose, and she dares not fly  
into the empty sky, where all is lost.

## Cracks Forming

*16 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/cracks-forming/>*

She watches the stars burn out, and each one  
calls with a call she has heard somewhere before,  
but she cannot quite place it, cannot place herself  
in its orbit. Instead she burns hotter than hope  
and ignites with an anger not meant for this world,  
from below. She does know it's unhealthy, but cares  
not at all for herself or for others. What good has caring  
ever done her? Not even the stars remain, and her hope  
dwindles faster than any flame. She is lonely, but  
this way she cannot be hurt again, cannot mistrust  
the wrong person or system. She breathes but she does not live,  
she has learned to forgive only sparingly,  
not in the way that might heal her, and  
not by the light of the moon, which, in concert with sun  
holds in place all that matters, not only for her  
but for all who live under its spell.  
She can tell that she's restless but doesn't know why.  
There are cracks forming in her sky.

## The soil we have tilled

16 November 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/the-soil-we-have-tilled/>

Who remembers, through the corridors of dusty time,  
the paths that brought us here? And who can say  
just how it felt, not knowing anything? If time  
heals wounds, it makes us blind to those not synchronized  
with our walk through this world. So here's to you,  
fair traveller, somewhere on life's journey, in some pain  
that I shall never name and cannot comprehend.  
I can be friend, and if we dare we might learn  
how to make pain end, at the end of the road  
or even before, in a house that we build, on the soil  
we have tilled.

## A Seat at the Table

16 November 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/a-seat-at-the-table/>

At the end of a long day, in the spaces between  
all the versions of me, I find solace in asking  
where I went wrong, and which pieces remain  
to be put back together in new configurations,  
respecting their origins but never again as they were.  
It's a crime to be free, too free, and to dishonor  
life and love with a cruelty not even animals know,  
to make lust a religion, and power its handmaiden.  
Thus in the spirit of chivalry let me remind you:  
aim higher, and dream better dreams than those found  
in pornography. You are still human after all,  
and as such have dominion over part of your conscious dreams.  
But do not be afraid. You already know how  
to climb out of this hole, to escape from the prison  
of immaturity, and *only* you know, because no two paths  
are the same. So your way may go through desert places  
or haunted ruins, or even to the brink of hell,  
but you'll come back to tell about all that was learned  
and how thrilled and how empty you felt, all at once.  
In that emptiness plant this seed: you are human,  
the point that connects law and nature, the goal  
of all fathers and the hope of all mothers, and in you  
live thousands of generations. Take part in this.  
Freedom has earned you a seat at the table.  
It never had any other purpose.

## So Was I

*16 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/so-was-i/>*

He was wrong enough,  
but so was I.



## This And No Other

16 November 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/this-and-no-other/>

The Lady, pierced by love, reveals her tendrils,  
drives through the ground her fingers of love's returning,  
and melts the earth, with a heat no longer trapped,  
a fire that blazes not just in her eyes, but down her arms  
into everything she touches. She is life itself,  
at one with the primal urge and heavy memories, combining  
both God and sex in holy matrimony, undone  
by a cry in the night. She feels relieved, but it is only  
for a moment, then the pain returns, but this time  
unaccompanied by chains and prison bars, no longer held down or locked inside.  
She wonders what comes next, and sighs.  
There is no compromise.

---

First comes love, then comes marriage,  
then comes the mystery that makes things worthwhile,  
the holy midnight kiss between lovers  
intent on leaving behind some memento of love  
in human flesh. We are all born from this  
and born for it, the cycle repeating  
since before there was time, and no other  
will make amends for the pain we've endured.  
It is this and no other around which a home  
can be built. It is this. It is this and no other.

---

The Lady learns her purpose, suits up  
and readies her heart for the burdens  
it soon must bear. She is frightened,  
but only because she can sense significance.  
The way is not long but hard. No pain  
shall be spoken, no groans heard aloud,  
for as long as the purpose is served,  
all is well. She will rise and accomplish it,  
says to her suitor "please come,"  
and then waits by the window,  
observing an unfamiliar sky.

## One Too Few

*16 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/one-too-few/>*

When day came a second time  
in answer to the first, it was clear  
which way fate was tending. But still  
one is cautious, for two can be one too many,  
though one can be one too few. Even two  
can be less than one truly desires.

## Coauthor

*16 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/coauthor/>*

Who was left to remember the pain,  
the ennui, the cool silence of winter,  
when the heat had died down?  
Was the dream still attainable? Or does it die now  
like so many before? With new clarity I  
come again to this story, and pen  
what may be its last ending...unless  
a new chapter begins, but that chapter  
requires a strong coauthor.

## Meant For Your Ears

*16 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/meant-for-your-ears/>*

I will take your hand, if you'll let me,  
and show you the wideness of the world.  
There is so much to see and understand,  
so much to uncover, and you make everything  
shimmer with hope and with purpose.  
For you I will wander a thousand years.  
These words are meant for your ears.

## **Another Life Beckons**

*20 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/another-life-beckons/>*

You are ready. You have weathered the storms.  
Tomorrow you must decide who to be. Today has faded.  
Another life beckons, and only you can open its door.

## Only in the Waiting

20 November 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/only-in-the-waiting/>

I have waited and will wait. I know what waiting means.  
I know what longing means, but also  
now I know what hope means. And I cannot look away.  
If not today, some other day, some other time and place,  
there she and I will meet and both be free. I know  
no other road, I know no other hope. This waiting  
answers every question with a calm repose, it dares  
to let a feeling be exposed, against the silence,  
and it knows what comes to pass before it comes.  
There is no explanation. Only in the waiting is it known.

## **Just Let Me Know**

*20 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/just-let-me-know/>*

I will not intrude in your life, as a sign of respect,  
but do not mistake this respect for a lack of desire.  
Please know that my interest will linger,  
and if some day you should find the same interest,  
I'll be there. Just let me know.

## **In This Field**

*20 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/in-this-field/>*

I'm impressed by your wisdom.  
You stand in a field grown ripe with the fruit of good seeds.  
There is nowhere I'd rather be than standing next to you in this field.



## Spelunking

20 November 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/spelunking/>

I went spelunking, into your heart.  
What gave me the right?  
You did, when you opened the door.  
I have touched the floor,  
and you cried out for more,  
but what follows is up to you.

---

Were you hoping a surgeon would take your heart  
and repair it with expert hands? Did you crave  
the assessment of wisdom to piece together  
your missing parts? My dear *you* are that surgeon.  
No other is qualified. I have just readied the room.

---

I see you from afar and wave.  
The sun is brighter today. You are on your own,  
but at home in your skin, which has grown  
less thin. Thus I greet you and smile.  
All is well, I presume?

---

And yet not all is well, not at all.  
The presumption of innocence lingers  
like a sad little girl on the day she discovers  
that life is pain. These incisions --  
what have we done?

---

We have done what must always be done  
on the road to experience. When the time comes  
the clock strikes and summons the boys with their prying hands.  
But the older one gets the more careful these hands become.

## Love Calls

*20 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/love-calls/>*

Love calls like a song on the wind.  
As ever one wanders, but who?  
That is never explained. One must wander  
to find some answer. Postponed explanations  
grow brittle beneath the desert sun. Love calls,  
but who answers? For how long?

## Extended Silence

*27 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/extended-silence/>*

Ambivalence comes and nestles  
under the firmament, deep in my heart,  
where a dream still lives but wanes.

I know of the perfect role for you.  
In fact you were born to play it.

But will you play it? Why do you retreat?  
Is another role calling, a callback to childhood perhaps  
where some unfinished business lingers?

I will hold this part open for you,  
but not forever. Only until you have answered,  
and even extended silence would serve as an answer.

## Approaching Song

*27 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/approaching-song/>*

It was always a matter of life and death,  
that much I can understand. But the truth of the matter  
was left unrevealed in a miscarriage of love.  
The clock stops and all faces turn to hear the music pause.  
A strange silence ensues, and for only a moment I think I can hear  
the low rumble of approaching song.

## Spin Gently

27 November 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/spin-gently/>

Where does she go? Into what place,  
what hidden land, to sort out herself  
and discover who she really is? It is strange  
how one turns and becomes another, and stranger  
how love plays a role, as the catalyst,  
turning us all in our turn. So spin gently,  
my love, to avoid getting sick.  
I'll be waiting here when you have finished.

## What Your Desire Is For

*27 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/what-your-desire-is-for/>*

You wore it too soon, before any decision  
had been reached or negotiations commenced.  
You were eager but also aware  
that your eagerness may have spelled danger.  
The ring was a symbol of desire but also  
a hermetic seal enclosing that desire,  
preventing unauthorized growths taking root  
in your soul. But these growths are the thing itself.  
They are what your desire is for.

## **Sense of the Darkness**

*27 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/sense-of-the-darkness/>*

She waits by the window, wonders  
whether to call, and wishes she knew  
what she's waiting for. Out there the night moves,  
and she is accustomed to steady lights  
that cut through the darkness and leave it for dead.  
Is there holiness out there too? Something sacred  
that pulses through throbbing veins and in every rude thrust  
of male upon female? She wonders, and slowly  
her eyes adjust. She begins to make sense of the darkness.

## Why and How

*27 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/why-and-how/>*

Her eyes glisten  
across the expansive universe  
and into my heart. It's a start,  
but where will it end? Where and when?  
We both know why and how.



## Is This Love?

*27 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/is-this-love/>*

Is this love? It might be,  
though I strangely inquire  
to sort out the truth and inspire  
one last protest, before things are settled.  
It's peaceful, and that is a welcome change.  
A life where love lives is in range.

## Just For Us

*27 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/just-for-us/>*

I do not know what to say  
or how to say it, what could soothe  
the bruise or span the rift between...  
but I am here, in the space  
we've started making  
just for us. Are you?

## **I Know How You Feel**

*27 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/i-know-how-you-feel/>*

There is no more time for questions,  
every gift will soon expire, unless  
renewed. But that takes two.  
And me and you are one and one  
or two, that much is true, but you  
know how I feel, and I know how you feel too.

## Rising Halfway

*27 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/rising-halfway/>*

The sun is acting strange, it's in  
a strange configuration, half exposed  
above the horizon, yet half covered  
by the earth. Who knows  
if it rises or falls? Perhaps this time  
it reverses its course and sets  
after rising halfway.

## What Your Longing Requires

27 November 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/what-your-longing-requires/>

Only give me a sign that it's safe to approach,  
and I'll light up your sky with new stars,  
I'll envelop your doubts in the tides of love,  
pulled by the new moon. This would be no dream  
but reality, quelled from its wildness of forms  
into hope eternal, the steady flame of an earnest love.  
All of this can be yours, as you know, yet  
you hesitate, pausing perhaps one last time  
at the doorway of childhood, where some early love  
leaves you cold. It has been foretold  
that you rise and become what your longing requires.  
You will not forever be burdened by unmet desires.

## Teach Me How To Love You

*27 November 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/11/teach-me-how-to-love-you/>*

Teach me how to love you,  
and I will study well, for I must learn  
not what love is, but what you are.  
From afar I can learn only little.  
I must come closer to see.

## Not Today

05 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/not-today/>

Enjoy your freedom. It has been well-earned,  
and now you are where you belong,  
in your own skin, powered by your own soul.  
You have been made whole, and now you may wonder  
what causes you still to hear *my* name  
ride on the wind from time to time.

---

It was time that brought me  
and time that brings me away.  
I would love to stay, but not today.

## **Live Wire**

*05 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/live-wire/>*

She was a live wire  
bound up in herself,  
but with one touch  
we loosed the short circuit  
and sent that energy to ground.



## **Puella Aeterna**

*05 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/puella-aeterna/>*

I have noticed that you are a woman.  
Did that surprise you? Surely you knew,  
though you keep it under wraps. I think  
you should let the world know. There's no hiding it.  
Plus there are some who might like it,  
and some of these may also love you.

## Another Hand

*05 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/another-hand/>*

I am once again myself.  
I am what I always was,  
plus something more. I'm sure  
that I'm unsure, though time makes clear  
the dawning purpose of the year:  
I've learned to love. It is a triumph,  
and the story was worth telling,  
but the resolution waits for another hand.

## No Longer Sand

*05 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/no-longer-sand/>*

I look forward to meeting you  
once this is over, as equals,  
when you and I stand on ground  
made firm, no longer sand.

## The Crucible of Life and Death

05 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/if-any-vigor-remains/>

I came to them not with hope but with fury.  
They welcomed me, at least at first. Was it all  
a part of some sinister plan, a demonic machination,  
or were those demons in me all along? Is it fair  
to see demons in others, but not always true?  
My demons were stronger than life itself, and I sought  
to remove them by any means necessary. What  
were they thinking, to offer a refuge, a place  
where even demons are welcome? It was folly from the start,  
or something worse, a case of pathological arrogance.

---

And yet somehow it worked, and I rose  
from the fires of hell into new life, forged  
by those fires and never forgetting their heat.  
I have scars to remind me, and memory works  
like a flame, disabusing old, dead beliefs,  
but not burning the live ones, so full of invigorating sap.  
Among the dead I see childish desires and teenage dreams,  
a longing to make the world safe, which can never come true.

---

Now my thoughts turn to you and whoever you are.  
I have come so far and I gather that you have too.  
There may still be some sap left inside us,  
some hope for another new life, worked out  
by these fires and the spasms of time, to remind us  
that where we have come from is where we are going,  
that all life returns to the center, the source,  
and that even this energy is not less than sacred.  
Tomorrow is what it will be, and today we find wholeness  
not in ourselves, but in what those selves could become.

---

But what can they become? What can any once dead  
ever hope to become? There is light, if you see it,  
beyond the horizon, both under the skin and in between stars,  
which confirms who we are. It's another lost dream, one more

reverie, this time tethered to objects worthy of praise.  
Underneath, all is changed, and the sky fills with wonder  
and love as new light rushes in. It's a love that stands firm,  
not forgetting the heat of the flame or the storm-tossed waves,  
but combining them, here, in this heart, which can answer  
the deepest longing and give shape to pain that otherwise overwhelms.  
It's this love that the lost can become if with courage  
they stand their ground in the crucible of life and death,  
if their hope is not conquered, and if any vigor remains.

---

They let me be childish, that was their folly  
and their appeal, for I was not ready to stand  
and bear my own weight. But in time I grew stronger,  
and they, I'm afraid, did not. Once time came  
to reap the harvest sown years before  
there was nowhere to go but down, through the depths  
of unconscious longing, the archetypes of despair. I was there,  
I remember, and whether any other has grown more aware  
through my presence, or whether they still wander on  
through the night of impermanent dreams, I can say  
I am free, and let these things be, as a testament  
to what was destroyed and forever destroyed, but which rises  
again and again in every mother's loving arms. There is no  
final cure, for the answer is to ask the question again,  
in a reproduction, a false half-double of me,  
born out of the strength I have earned. But a child must be childish  
and so must outgrow the childhood cast upon it.

---

I am not at the end, not quite, but somewhere  
in the middle, awake but still dreaming, alive  
but not sure that life really is good. Could it be  
that my meaning is out there, under the stars, where gods  
and heroes struggle to carry the light of day? Or is it  
in here, in my heart? I know where to start,  
and, I think, where things end. So long, friend.  
I have told you the way. If you take it  
is your decision.

## No Matter How Civilized

*05 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/no-matter-how-civilized/>*

Looking back from a posture of wholeness  
I see now what I wanted to see, and that  
it was always there. It was I who was lacking,  
unable to contain the strength of life, unable  
to carry that power from day to day. But the power  
remains as it is, was, and shall be, forever,  
empowering life and our lives, no matter how civilized.

## Debut

*05 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/debut/>*

You confirm my suspicions,  
and now I await with new vigor  
your coming courage. Don't tarry.  
It's time for your debut.

---

But is it true?  
I cannot allow myself to believe  
on hints alone. I must hear it from you.

## Shadow (Wherever Light Shines)

05 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/shadow-whenever-light-shines/>

*And so the General of hot desire  
Was, sleeping, by a virgin hand disarmed.  
This brand she quenched in a cool well by,  
Which from Love's fire took heat perpetual,  
Growing a bath and healthful remedy,  
For men diseased; but I, my mistress' thrall,  
Came there for cure and this by that I prove,  
Love's fire heats water, water cools not love.*

Shakespeare, *Sonnet 154*

Water cools not flame, and yet I am cooled  
by some frozen spirit, come again to haunt my dreams.  
What do I know? How little is truly revealed!  
The way is dark and lonely. I will make a home  
and live in it alone.

---

Who knows the answers more thoroughly  
than a madman? Who craves desire  
more than a dead man? I fear I have been  
mad, or dead, or deadly mad, but this  
must be the shadow born from lofty dreams,  
inevitable wherever light shines.



## **Twin Eagles**

*05 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/twin-eagles/>*

Twin eagles soar  
above heaven,  
circling the nest below.

## Make Ourselves Anew

05 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/make-ourselves-anew/>

It was true, it was always true, there can be no doubt.  
I have read the signs and await the fulfillment of prophecy.  
Under the stars we have languished, waiting for light  
that could penetrate the blackest canvas of night, and none came.  
None came, for the canvas concealed all we are, blocking out  
the inviting vibrations, the hidden music of the oscillating spheres,  
no less sure for their oscillating, doubtless more wondrous  
and summoning an energy no man can deny. If you choose,  
you can hear them, and dance with the furious joy of one bound  
to be free, bound by *true* power, rapt by the sun and moon.

---

In this laughter, I hear you, awake and filled hopeful  
by something just out of reach, but in view. It *is* true,  
and the first clue is always the best: there could be no resisting,  
no saying no to the pull of a fated love for ones such as us.  
But do not be afraid.  
I can see over hills and dales the winding path that leads us home,  
the path we must walk together if ever we will feel free,  
for I think you also can see how the ground melts and pulses  
in tune with the song of the spheres, *under* heaven,  
but in a strange sense, a strange mood, a strange key.

---

You are not strange to me. I have eyes for no other.  
The others *lack* eyes, and I will not share something they cannot return.  
But I see you, I love you, I want you. These three  
are the chorus that drowns out all else with perfected harmony,  
the song of my soul lit on fire by the only possibility it ever desired:  
to belong, here on earth, with you.

---

The answer was found before the question was understood,  
and it always is so with matters of the heart. Let's start over,  
recalling from the beginning what we learned in the end,  
and make ourselves anew.

## Your Eyes

*05 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/your-eyes/>*

Your eyes know secrets, and I would fall  
into their dark abysses, learning all they know,  
and thus grow wise. You think my sighs  
are mere ephemera, the passing of some fever?  
You are much too great a mystery,  
and one I must explore.

## Love Can Be Done

*09 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/love-can-be-done/>*

I didn't see it coming, and yet  
maybe I did, in some dark corner of unconscious dreams.  
And now it seems inevitable, the pull of two planets  
caught in each other's gravity. What can be done?  
Just love. Love can be done.

## Time Is Coming Soon

*09 December 2025*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/time-is-coming-soon/>

I see you in my dreams. You are half smiling,  
half afraid. It has been said that you are ready,  
but we both don't know the truth. I'd like to find you,  
and make sense of this, and swoon, but there may be too many obstacles.  
The time is coming soon.

## Forever To Yourself Be True

09 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/forever-to-yourself-be-true/>

All is quiet, and it's eerie  
how the day sits calm and ready  
after pulverizing night into a million pieces.  
*Is this what was needed?* I have doubts,  
but not so many that regret creeps in.  
This could not be avoided or conceded, no,  
it had to run its course. But what comes next?  
Perhaps a time of rest and healing, or perhaps  
a birth of love, but now, in either case,  
let's praise the gods that brought us here  
and see them face to face.

---

These gods were jealous, and they would not  
let things be, and now for you and me  
a tug ties us together, though it sets us free.  
Remember me, as I remember you, and to yourself  
be true. Forever to yourself be true.

## New Moon Phase

09 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/new-moon-phase/>

A bitter wind rips through even the warmest attire.  
I may *aspire* to love, but can I see it through?  
This much is true: I'd like to try, though I can offer  
nothing painless, nothing free of life's dark questions,  
only earnest striving, chasing down a dream,  
for in between the light small fragments of night  
have nestled, and remain...and to dislodge them  
would endanger the patient. Still, they can be tolerated,  
maybe even loved, as parts of a whole, but they  
are not the whole itself. The light still shines, and with it  
dignity is never out of reach. So reach, and grasp life  
with both hands, and be amazed. In all your days  
you have not known this new moon phase.

## The Troubles of Love

12 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/the-troubles-of-love/>

I just don't know. Can any secret love  
satisfy? Why love in secret? Blake may say  
it must be so, but I don't know...I'd open  
my heart, one page at a time. That way  
one has time to absorb it, in all its complexities.  
Be not a secret forever. The secret must turn  
into vow, spoken plainly, for all the world to see.

But what kind of vow can there be, for ones  
like you and me, who sway with the inconstant moon?  
I can offer my life, but what a paltry gift,  
such a variable thing! Yet I have nothing else.  
I would find one who understands, but are we then both  
doubly lost? Is that the cost? Must we double our troubles  
in order to find our true joy?

This explains the appeal of the secret. A spoken love  
must bring trouble. A secret love can be hidden, ignored  
when convenient, despised even...still it survives as a cherished secret.  
But no, it can never satisfy. Only the love that brings trouble  
can satisfy, because it is *true*, not illusion  
or fantasy...and yet even so all the troubles of love  
are no trifling matter. I just don't know.

But still I *must* know, I must find out,  
I must take this chance. There is too much to lose  
and to gain. What are troubles compared  
to the ache in my heart? This ache, which I found  
without seeking, and resisted each step of the way,  
but which grows ever stronger all the same,  
has become my greatest trouble, far greater,  
if left unfulfilled, than even the worst troubles of love.

I would have her and can't explain why.  
We have looked twice into the same sky.  
If an answer should come from above, let it burn  
until nothing remains but our love.



## The One That Deserves To Be Heard

12 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/the-one-that-deserves-to-be-heard/>

*Never again would birds' song be the same.*

*And to do that to birds was why she came.*

Robert Frost, *Never Again Would Birds' Song Be The Same*

That change, do you feel it? Now your voice persisting  
has made this bird sing a brighter tune, in harmony  
with yours, and with the deeper well of things  
from which you've come, to roost among birds, a bird yourself,  
the most beautiful bird, the one that deserves to be heard.

## Calypso

*12 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/calypso/>*

Years ago, I stopped off on Calypso's shores  
and asked her: what is love? She would not answer  
though she took delight in hearing me ask again and again.  
For three long years I asked, and learned the hard way  
what love is not. And yet I think that she was moved somehow.  
I saw her cry real tears. I heard she moved away  
and became a normal woman.

## Carried Away

14 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/carried-away/>

I would like to believe, I really would, but the darkness  
consumes all but hope, the delusions of life made anew.  
I am talking to you, but not really, to some lonely  
phantom, the shadow of other yous. It's no use. I can make it  
without explanations. I can't fight my truths. I must go  
to the edge of the city, to the top of the mountain,  
where gods and men first met, and no lover can follow me there.  
It's no use to despair, it won't matter, my heart is pulled thither,  
and no song, not even my own, can assuage the affliction.  
I ask you to leave me to suffer whatever I must endure,  
because not even you have the cure. I am summoned,  
the Muse enraptures, and I must be carried away.

---

A fall of snow blankets the world in white,  
ancient symbol of innocence...still it does not feel quite right,  
does not answer my doubts with a sudden courage  
or make straight the path I must travel. I would  
that the snow would fall faster and leave no trace of sin,  
but it has not that power. At this very hour, some crime  
is committed in every part of the world. So fall, snow.  
Make your peace. But we know it won't last.

---

Like a fly in amber, I wait for my heart to decide.  
It is too late to hide. Any action/inaction will be scrutinized,  
and I am like one on display in a frozen cage.  
State your case, I'll state mine, and the chips will fall  
in chaotic fashion, as these things must always be. Don't you see?  
It's too late to go free, or to ask the right question  
once one has gone fully underwater. We must let it dry  
and not even conceive of returning to have another try  
until both sides solidify.

---

So that answers it, then, for the present, but I  
must be cautious. I must not break free from restraints  
or yank on the temple's supporting pillars. Delilah

has many other names, but her face is the same  
as Penelope's, at least from a distance. Trust *has not* been earned.  
We would have to step back and first fill in those blanks  
before love could be safely endeavored. Who are you?  
And why do you interest me so?

---

Feeling of course is worth something, but will not suffice  
without truth, plain and simple. It will not survive. We must know  
that we stand on firm ground. But perhaps this is asking too much.  
We are creatures of mystery, you and I, and we like our disguises.  
But this is important, too important to allow ambiguity, at least in the long run.  
And we want a long run, don't we?

## Two Black Sheep

*14 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/two-black-sheep/>*

I can see it:  
a warm sun,  
a calm breeze,  
and two black sheep  
enjoying the strangest pasture  
together.

## Getting There

16 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/getting-there/>

If I should call now, it would interrupt a process  
set in motion ages, many lifetimes ago, and that process  
is what matters most right now. I believe in you,  
but I must not step in any more than I have. You will master  
the steps of this new dance, your own steps, not mine or anyone else's,  
and only then feel free. But I see a bright future for you,  
where you soar in your truth and live unafraid,  
needing no other face to express how you feel, knowing your face  
is beautiful, and that you can wear it proudly, even when few understand.

---

But there is an art of concealment, which hides the truth  
as an act of love, from those not equipped to handle it.  
I think you will know what I mean, most attentive reader,  
because I have practiced this art, and I gather  
that you have too. But this art remains valid and needed  
to keep small souls from bursting with too much truth.  
"Mankind cannot bear very much reality" Eliot says,  
with good reason and perhaps a little bit too much truth.  
But the point is to carve out a private sphere,  
a "room of one's own", a *home*, where truth can be carried  
with dignity and courage, to the best of one's ability.

---

Abilities vary wildly, though, and nobody knows  
how or why some can know and some can't. For we knowers,  
few pains are as great as those caused by an unjust authority,  
forcing its ignorance upon us from the top down. It cannot  
be endured, but it must be, at least for a time, until  
one has made way for a new life one always was living  
in secret. There is an old name for this, *μεγαλόψυχος*.  
"Nobility" also suffices, but what's in a name?  
It's the *thing* that endures in perennial cycle, and we  
are the latest crop, ripe for harvest. It is not a crime  
to be different, in fact it may be a great gift, the true source  
of the patterns lived out by the ones who fit in. Every culture  
begins as a dream, and we dreamers can hold our heads high  
as members of a higher order, the provenance of dreams.

---

So dream well, my sweet, and do not despair.  
You seem to be getting there.

## Am I Right?

16 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/am-i-right/>

Am I right? Or have I pushed too far, dreamed too much,  
put my fingers where they don't belong? You are stronger than you think,  
I'm convinced of it, and it seems only a matter of time  
until you prove it. But you must prove it for you, not for me,  
only if and because it *is* what you are, and until you can say what you need,  
until you can name your desires, you are not ready for them, because,  
I can tell you, naming is not the hard part. Taming will be much harder,  
so much so that many dare not to attempt it. But you are attempting already,  
and that sets you off as a rare bird, a stranger even, but I see a budding master  
of the art of humanity, one who won't settle for easy answers to easy questions  
but only for truth, however painful. This courage is rare, as you surely must know,  
but we share it, and that means you dazzle me, in both heart and mind,  
and it takes all I have to not start right now, but that would not be wise,  
and we must be wise. If we start too soon, it might end your development  
here and now, a development that only can happen alone.  
So we wait. I will not give you cause to resent me  
by holding you back. You are free to develop into what you are,  
and bound, I suspect, by no other law. But you *are* bound  
by nature, though nature and law can be friends, when law learns  
to be gentle and nature learns that some boundaries  
serve a good purpose and need not be torn down.



## **Fetch It**

*16 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/fetch-it/>*

I passed you the ball  
and you threw it out of bounds.  
Do you now expect me to go fetch it?

## No Other Way

*16 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/no-other-way/>*

Life is funny, isn't it, but not always in a way that brings laughter,  
sometimes in a way that brings pain. I feel funny like that.  
But I trust the pain to bring growth. I have grown in no other way.

## Clothes Back On

*16 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/clothes-back-on/>*

Must I put my clothes back on?  
We have come so far,  
it would be a shame to turn back now.

## **Can't Be Put Out**

*16 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/cant-be-put-out/>*

We must not hide. I can hear you  
cowering, see you squirming, feel you  
desiring. But is it enough? You have fire  
within you, chérie, and it can't be put out.

## **Can't Wait**

*16 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/cant-wait/>*

I can't wait. What a double entendre.  
Which way shall we spin it? Or shall I just  
let it hang  
like an unanswered invitation?

## **The View Is Lovely**

*18 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/the-view-is-lovely/>*

Your way is harder  
because you are climbing higher.

But the view is lovely.  
I think you would like it.

## **Possibilities**

*18 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/possibilities/>*

A flock of birds scrounges in icy soil.  
There is just enough to get by.  
But spring is coming, and with it, possibilities.  
Winter does not last forever.

## **The Eternal Dance**

*18 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/the-eternal-dance/>*

Tell me what I want, and I will  
tell you what you are, and in this way  
we shall continue the eternal dance  
of men and women, ageless and immortal,  
just like all those times before.



## They Don't Even Know

*18 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/they-dont-even-know/>*

A murmuration flutters from tree to tree.  
How have they synchronized? They manage  
a complex dance as one, though each bird  
feeds itself, and lives a separate life.  
What spirit comes to bind them?  
Maybe they don't even know.

## Starting Again

*18 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/starting-again/>*

Soothe me, gentle spirit, goddess of flame...  
I don't know your name, but I know your face,  
with those eyes that see past my disguises, so I can revel  
with masks on or off as my fancy chooses.  
There is a deep well of healing waters,  
a hot spring where hope burns eternal, on top of the mountain  
of beginnings, where travelers come in the end  
to get rest before starting again.

## **Not So Useful Anymore**

*18 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/not-so-useful-anymore/>*

I think she used me, but I did  
choose to be useful, and now one must ask  
what comes next. Am I used up? Not quite.  
But perhaps not so useful anymore.

## **Irrigation**

*18 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/irrigation/>*

The only kind of love I would want  
would be not like the raging river or the bone-dry riverbed,  
but more like an irrigation channel, dug with tremendous care.

## Dying Roses

18 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/dying-roses/>

I think things must end. We live  
under the sky again, a new sky,  
one can hope, but a sky nonetheless,  
and although we got partly undressed,  
we shall not love forever, not like this.

---

I remember when we met, the fire  
that burned behind your eyes, in need  
of structure and direction. Have I given some?  
A bit of cultivation, just a taste...the answer  
lives in you, and always has. You have  
the things you need, and I do not.

---

Of course a call from you might change my mind,  
but not an indirect one, not one wrapped  
in deniability. Of course there is a risk,  
I might say no, but then, I might say no  
either way. But I would say no gently  
and praise you for the attempt.

---

If this is out of reach, then so is love,  
and both our hearts must travel on  
and not get stuck in wistful hoping,  
dreaming dreams that cannot be. You will get free,  
I have no doubt, but when? It's too late now  
to pretend I don't care, but I just cannot keep on  
standing there, with a bouquet of dying roses.

---

But I think you'll be okay, and so will I,  
because despite the changing sky,  
I'm just another guy, a ghost who calls  
to summon a better you. It's true.  
But there are many truths, and this  
is not one we would choose for more than a moment.

---

But even dying flowers  
carry seeds.

## To Rest At All

*18 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/to-rest-at-all/>*

I have said what I needed to say, and now  
I can rest for the rest of the day, but the night  
comes on quickly and chases away what remains.  
What a curious life. There's no answer, just questions,  
so many terrible questions that trouble my restless heart.  
From the start I am restless and never find rest,  
'til I play my part in the crazy maneuvering of gods.  
Can they forgive me? Can you? For what I'm not sure,  
but there is no cure for this surplus of insight. I must  
put out the light to rest at all.

## Worth Something

*18 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/worth-something/>*

It has had a long gestation, but now  
it's out there, so let me slip in  
one last piece of advice: do not just  
give yourself away. You know better. Endeavor  
for love, lasting love, the true kind,  
or at least a short love that transforms.  
If it has to be brief, make it worth something.



## Farewell

*18 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/farewell/>*

Farewell, my love. I have dreamed you  
a better dream, but it seems  
that for you and for me a chasm grows,  
an impassable sea, that cuts off any chance  
of love. But the chasm stares back into me,  
and the longer I look, the darker we both become.  
We had only begun, but this ending is sweet  
with a bittersweet knowledge, that some loves last  
while others merely make us better lovers.  
So go and be better.  
Farewell. Farewell. Farewell.

## Touch and Soothe

*21 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/touch-and-soothe/>*

Did I mean farewell? Or did I mean  
merely to touch and soothe the demons  
that dream of such things? They are strengthened  
by water and blood, only honey can make them obey.

## Trust and Open Dialogue

21 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/trust-and-open-dialogue/>

But you may leave me no choice. Love is not all,  
I also must know that I can come to you for clarity  
and receive it, not a mystery. A feeling cannot carry  
all the weight of mundane, everyday friction,  
without recurring interventions. We must *make* love endure,  
not by burning hotter, but by putting it in a vessel  
that can hold it, then tending the flame. Our flame  
gets hotter by the minute, and soon it will hurt us  
if we don't capture it and give it what it needs:  
a place to burn, a strong container, made with trust  
and open dialogue.

## Schedule

*21 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/schedule/>*

You say you want forever?  
Let me check my schedule.  
Ah, look at that, it is totally open.  
Let me pencil you in.

## Handkerchief

*21 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/handkerchief/>*

This is just to say:  
I believe you have dropped your handkerchief.  
I would like to return it, when the time is right.

## **From Afar**

*21 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/from-afar/>*

There you are, and always were,  
this feeling, so familiar, though it had no object before.  
What does it mean that I feel your warmth from afar?  
That we are together, though apart?

## Feet Firmly Planted on Earth

21 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/feet-firmly-planted-on-earth/>

*Was the urge of the unconscious perhaps only apparently reaching  
out towards the person, but in a deeper sense towards a god?*

Carl Jung, *The Relations Between The Ego And The Unconscious*

Something feels off, and I cannot quite name it.  
One hopes for a final resolution, but one never comes.  
Must we drift in uncertainty forever? I do not blame you,  
but I must be true to my doubts, because otherwise  
we may both find ourselves lost, and not in ecstasy...  
I don't know you that well, not as well as I'd like,  
and a love that begins before knowledge cannot long endure,  
not for me, because what am I loving? A phantom, a figment,  
a dream? There's a way to firmer ground, but I fear  
we have missed it, and gone around to the love chamber  
far too soon. And it can't be undone. Can we go back  
and find each other as we really are? It is not  
that far, but it carries a risk: we may not like what we find.  
Still this outcome is better than a false love, which would be  
a prison for both of us. I do want you, and I do want love  
to come true, but some labor remains to ensure that we are not just lost  
in that ether of blue, but have four feet firmly planted on earth.

---

But are dreams not their own door to reality?  
If so, then the answer is clear: we are meant to be.  
There are too many signs to ignore or write off as coincidence.  
Something is happening, something real,  
though the mind must play catchup and flail to understand...  
can it be that understanding is not needed here,  
that the pull of some unseen gravity works its power  
in a way much stronger than any mind? If so,  
it is not my power, or yours, that binds us, but something  
higher, much higher, and deeper than words can explain.  
If we know this feeling, the pull of its power,  
then I think we should trust it, because in the final analysis  
this *is* the earth into which we are planted, and which grows in us,  
as in all men and women, when the time is right.

---

And the time *is* right, that is hard to ignore or deny,  
but I look one last time to a desolate sky  
as if it knew the answer, as if it brings any gift  
but rain, to nourish the seeds. Now you and I are caught  
in the dance of the cycle of regeneration, with Demeter's blessing,  
and time will tell if it makes us happy, but Lord knows  
we must play our parts.



## **Finally Alive**

*21 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/finally-alive/>*

All my tender feelings return time after time.  
There is no surer sign. When stars align,  
and when we find ourselves both lost and finally alive,  
I think we must try. We would lose too much otherwise.

## A Signal in Smoke

26 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/a-signal-in-smoke/>

A new pain, new decisions, the war of the magi  
brought home to familiar places, the agonies and ecstasies  
of love and hate. Is there any new ground, any place  
where a dream can thrive, without constant embitterment?  
There is still the road, but the road is long, and not really a home.  
What of building a new home, in time, after healing?

---

Of course one could never endeavor to be alone,  
it just happens that way sometimes, because in its disguises  
the sun hides its eyes, and one loses sight of the meaning,  
the center of life and the essence of time, whence all things derive  
and to which they return. All these walls we so carefully build  
are a clear delusion, protecting our minds from the brutal reality  
that all things fade into another, given enough time.

---

So we have waged war against time in pursuit of stasis,  
eternal stasis, the worst of all possible worlds, because lacking  
the one thing that makes life exciting, its movement,  
and lacking also the dangers that call for virtue.  
Thus men are superfluous and become an endangered species.  
Many are born, but not many become fully grown,  
and why should they? Perhaps for the joy of it,  
as some men tend gardens despite having plenty to eat.

---

But the garden now feels under siege, and the few  
who have good ones must fight tooth and nail to defend them  
against the hordes of roving barbarians, homeless and looking  
for empires to topple. But there is one hope, that the hordes  
may be charmed, for a moment at least, by words and songs  
sung skillfully or played upon a lyre.

---

But this hope is a foolish one, foolish because  
most barbarians cling to barbarity as a totem  
and will not let go. So we build higher walls,

more defenses, and send up a signal in smoke  
hoping somewhere out there, another is doing the same.

## This Secret Warmth

*26 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/this-secret-warmth/>*

I don't know how this happened, nor does it matter.  
I have warmed up to you, and only you  
can know my thoughts and feelings, only you can access  
this secret warmth, and share *your* secret warmth  
in our secret place. Let's call it home.  
It has no better name. Just let me feel you  
for as long as it takes to melt the ice away.

## Quarter Moon

*26 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/quarter-moon/>*

A quarter moon dares me to ask bold questions,  
half-exposed as if expecting more. But I look on.  
I wanted what I wanted, and I want it still,  
but not enough to beg. It has a leg up on me now,  
perhaps, but one leg is enough, if both would cost  
my self-control. O quarter moon, decide. Reveal your splendor  
or descend again and hide, but leave me to my thoughts.  
The darkest night cannot my heart make waver,  
nor the fear of it one inch increase my favor.

## Worth Asking

*26 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/worth-asking/>*

There was a time before I knew this kind of love,  
and it was a dismal time, a "wriggling out of an egg,"  
to borrow a phrase. But now I've arrived in a sudden rush  
of you. How can it be true? It wasn't the blue,  
it was under the blue, and under the skin too.  
I had never known that you could exist, and now I do.  
But that does not prove that this thing has a future.  
That question is separate, and more complex.  
But I think it's at least worth asking.

## Thorns and Briars

*26 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/thorns-and-briars/>*

I think there is more than one way to arrive,  
many paths that converge in the clearing where men,  
fully grown, can accept life's true burdens and go on their own.  
My path had many detours, but I think I learned  
quite a lot, more than most, and I now have this burden  
of knowledge, to go with my burden of insight.  
I cannot regret it, there would be no point, but I can  
still remember the struggle, the thorns and the briars,  
a few of which cling to me still and I think always will.  
But my body still works, and my mind is alert,  
and I'll take on tomorrow with courage, if given the chance.

## Life Is Strange

*26 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/life-is-strange/>*

Once more, with feeling, summoning  
all of my gusto, let me proclaim  
my indifference, standing atop this blurry precipice  
in some shade of gray. What more can I say?  
Life is strange, and it has a strange way  
of deciding for itself, no matter what we say.



## Synchronicities

*28 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/synchronicities/>*

It's amazing just how many signs, past and present,  
inspire my heart to endure, and they come from the strangest places,  
recurring voicemails, a timely television episode, many countless dreams...  
They all say the same thing: don't give up. So I won't.  
I don't know that I could if I wanted to, but something  
beyond me, with power over events, must remind me  
for some reason. Whether this feeling is true or illusion,  
I cannot escape it, and neither can you. The strangeness  
lingers and pulls on our strings. The Lady sighs, then sings...

## **Matinée**

*28 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/matine/>*

I shall come to the matinée, when the sun is up,  
when the stars are hidden by a veil of blue.  
Is this the better way to see you?  
I wonder how the moon affects you,  
but maybe these lunar mysteries are none of my business.  
I like daylight too. It has its own kind of truth.

## Yet To Be Named

*28 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/yet-to-be-named/>*

Swirling, tumbling, over and in between  
what has been and could be, some tomorrow  
is dawning, some day in the sun still unwritten  
and yet to be named.

## Toward Some Ithaca

28 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/toward-some-ithaca/>

The Mother's unwanted affections could ruin  
all future possibilities, tie the son to the mast  
and wave him around like a flag of total and final ownership.  
Wouldn't the song of Calypso be enough to set him free,  
at last free? But then where should he go? Toward some Ithaca,  
to be sure, though the Mother pursues through the greatest danger  
to take back the loyalty and affections due only to a lover,  
which she has found nowhere else. She knows not what she does,  
and she will not listen to reason or (most of all)  
to the dreaded word "no", which dooms her to a loneliness  
she never quite cured but also cannot quite endure.  
So pursue she must, to the end of her days, though this son  
finds a new place to anchor, a port with no room for her  
turbulent affections, with a calm that might set an example,  
though if she has not learned by now, it's most likely she never will.  
Is this Ithaca? Maybe. At least it resembles it well enough  
to ensure no return voyage on the mothership, and that  
is a victory in itself. When she does visit, we will be kind  
to honor her many sacrifices, but not naive or craven.  
She has needs, but so do we, and ours must be our priority  
to honor the true meaning of motherhood. She has not failed,  
but she has wounded and must not be given a chance to wound again.

---

Elektra, it is I, your Oedipus.  
Surely we understand each other.

## **Lark (She Could Fly)**

*30 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/lark-she-could-fly/>*

A lark sits still in her cage,  
singing proudly, unable to move.  
I like her song, so I touch her cage,  
and the door swings open to our surprise.

I think it was open all along.  
She just didn't know she could fly.

## Ghosts

*30 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/ghosts/>*

Why do I linger in this garden, where only ghosts  
return my favor, and keep me company from a distance  
rather than walking here beside me? Do these ghosts  
portend some future when all things will be revealed,  
or are the ghosts the show and all I can expect?  
I'll linger for a little while (these ghosts are rather charming,  
and I am quite fond of cemeteries) but only  
until fancy wanes or things become more clear.

## What You Were Feeling

*30 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/what-you-were-feeling/>*

I see your composure slip (a rare thing for you)  
and some real emotion emerge, as you stare straight into the camera.  
It is very moving if it means what I think it means.  
And you put this work front and center as if for emphasis.  
Surely another take would have cleaned up the slips  
had you had your résumé in mind. But I like it this way.  
It has served its purpose. I'd like to know what you were feeling.

## **Like A Fever**

*30 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/like-a-fever/>*

Eros passes through me like a fever.  
I can't make it last.  
After all this time, I still must leave her.  
Love must come to pass.



## Drawing Blood

30 December 2025

<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/drawing-blood/>

Maybe she was right after all  
not to trust this fickle heart. But am I to blame?  
Doesn't love require *cooperation*, not a solitary  
tending of the flame? It's always the same,  
somehow my calls for structure go unheeded,  
though without it, without fail, my love grows cold.  
I shall grow old, it matters not which way,  
whether on my own or in the arms of another.  
It is no use. If she has seen me and withdrawn  
she knows what she's doing. She knows how to choose.

---

And yet this time something lingers, even when  
the fever subsides, a kind of admiration, genuine respect.  
She is a *woman* in the deepest sense, aware of things  
no man can know, and she could make me stronger  
if she chooses. But I cannot now rely on possible strength,  
or else I'd find myself enfeebled when it's withdrawn,  
and it *can* be withdrawn, whenever her fancy chooses. Am I  
the fickle one now? Does she not have the power  
of retreat, and wield it forcefully, to get her way?  
How shall we disagree? As equals, each side speaking plainly?  
Or as lovers, tugging each other's strings, the strings  
that bind two hearts in the dark of passion, feeling  
no remorse? But can I *trust* her in this darkness,  
with these strings? No feeling answers this haunting question,  
at least not adequately, without hesitation and fear.  
Perhaps one only learns by trying, but of course, by then  
it's too late to sever the bond without drawing blood.

Let the waters of time rise and fall  
to dilute these libations of blood.  
I must stand tall.

---

This then reveals the true pain of the call.  
It was never the fear of a sudden failure, but rather  
the fear of a long and protracted dissolution, through which

one bleeds out or nearly so. This fear I think  
never entirely fades, but the pull of desire, the hope  
of two made one and thereby whole, entices lovers  
and would-be lovers to forge a bond, or perhaps even  
forges it for them, against their wills. They just  
find themselves bound, heaven knows, although heaven itself  
cannot break these bonds. Only those who are bound  
can dissolve them, anchored so deep  
that none but the anchoring soul can release them,  
and even these souls often spasm and struggle  
to do what they will, clenching harder when they would let go.  
We do well not to know how we fare,  
for this knowledge makes love (and thus life)  
such a violent thing, more like nature  
than civilization would have us believe.

## **Abundant Fuel**

*30 December 2025*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2025/12/abundant-fuel/>*

Still I return to this fire,  
which seems to burn with abundant fuel,  
and I realize I can't put it out.

I must let it temper my heart.

Burn forever, fire of the earth.  
Let me feel you. Make me warm.

## Critical Velocity

*01 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/critical-velocity/>*

Mutual orbiting reaches critical velocity.  
Collision is imminent.  
Too late to abort.

## Eccentricities

01 January 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/eccentricities/>

I know that you changed the words.  
I think I know where you got the new ones.  
I know what that would mean.  
You know you can *tell me* if you want to.  
I think I want to. I would tell you too.  
I don't find you strange, or at least  
I don't find you unworthy of love.  
I would show you how worthy you are.  
I would call you strong and brave.  
I would tell you until you believe me.

---

It doesn't have to be a walk in the park.  
It could be an experiment, designed to trigger growth.  
There are two kinds of not being ready.  
The first is unable to try.  
The second can try and learn by trying and, thus, get ready.  
It can be hard to tell these two things apart.  
It's better to err on the side of caution.  
But sometimes the growth has already begun  
and must be seen through, given space to grow,  
or else it becomes a cancer.

---

Shall I apologize for giving you space to grow?  
It almost seems necessary. It has not been painless.  
But I think I shall not. I think you will thank me too.  
Still, love is not built on pain. I wish you quick healing,  
but not so quick as to leave the work undone.

---

I believe I have seen this performance before,  
or one like it. The delivery indeed is "strange".  
It's unique to you, but some parts of this take are new.  
Could it be you have weaved a tapestry  
of me and you into something you hold very dear?  
The resemblance is striking, this character *is* you,  
or close enough that her words are like a totem.

If so, then what is your vow? How will you satisfy  
the need that emerges painfully? It does not end well for Alma.  
That does not mean it can't end well for you. But be careful.  
Take care of yourself, of your heart, of your body.  
These treasures, once lost, can be hard to recover.  
But you may indeed be obliged to risk them on the road to experience.  
Only you know. You must do what you have to do.

## Ariadne II

08 January 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/ariadne-ii/>

Ariadne, I liked you better  
before you became a goddess, with Theseus,  
not Dionysus, though I do intend to invert the ending  
and not leave you stranded on Naxos.  
Still I can see why you'd like Dionysus  
after years as the mistress of the labyrinth, where your father the King  
enforced holy order despite all winding ways.  
But the god of wine is unlikely to fill your cup for long  
and deserves nothing close to total devotion. You might have done better  
as queen of Athens, had circumstances allowed it.

## Nearly Bound

*08 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/nearly-bound/>*

Somehow this thing keeps developing,  
two together though apart  
growing closer in heart, with no need  
to make manifest that which grows.  
But who knows? If we fail  
at the coming appointment,  
won't there be another? It's hard  
to doubt, and getting harder.  
Is this your doing? If so,  
keep weaving, Ariadne.  
I'm nearly bound.



## Flirting With Danger

*08 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/flirting-with-danger/>*

You make it hard  
to do the right thing, and I like that,  
flirting with danger, but only to make love sure.  
Are you sure? Would you give me that power?  
I'd welcome it, but I must know what you want.

You may have the guest bed.  
There is room in my bed as well.  
Which do you prefer?

## Tell Me About Yourself

08 January 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/tell-me-about-yourself/>

*First, she's an acquaintance, then she's a lover, and finally, she  
becomes a good friend.*

Chekhov, *Uncle Vanya*, quoted from *Drive My Car*

Now that we've fallen in love,  
I suppose it's as good a time as any  
to get to know each other. Wouldn't you agree?  
Seems a bit out of order, but hey  
I'm here for it. Tell me about yourself.

## Overflowing

*13 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/overflowing/>*

I am overflowing with love, there is no container  
vast enough to contain it (except perhaps you).  
Are you empty? I'll fill you and never tire.

## Two Birds

*13 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/two-birds/>*

I want you to think hard about what has happened  
and then decide. I want you to know what you're doing.  
It may be that love is blind. It may be  
that we are two birds of a different kind, with clashing songs.

But even as I write this line, two birds emerge  
from the foliage, water birds, tropical and at ease.  
It's like nature is talking to me, as they glide on the breeze  
over Mogens Bay, saying: two become one in all places,  
all times, and in every locale...and your time is now.

## Come What May

*13 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/come-what-may/>*

Even in paradise, one can find doubts, and these doubts  
form an image of how many futures the present could become.  
There are no guarantees. There are many ways to answer desire,  
some better than others, but none that ensure a result.  
The assurance is that the attempt is made, come what may.

## Soon Will I Love You In Return

*16 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/soon-will-i-love-you-in-return/>*

If you use love (or love's withdrawal) as a weapon, a tool for manipulation,  
then soon it will become poisonous, soon I will not even want it,  
soon I will leave you to your poisoned love. But if you love  
as a gift, given freely...then soon will I love you in return.

## Much More Down Below

*16 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/much-more-down-below/>*

When I step back and survey the journey we've taken  
(for surely it has been your journey as well) I'm amazed  
and I feel my trepidation wane...for somehow we seem to have struck a vein  
of passion buried deep in our collective soul (for surely we share the same soul).  
That vein has erupted, unleashing its pent up pressure, releasing its gases  
and filling the air with the perfume of love. I now  
must examine these fumes and this rupture. What started  
as a walk in the park has revealed much more down below.

## Practicing

*16 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/practicing/>*

In her moonlit room, she practices her oeillade.  
It would be a most welcome sight, could she find the courage  
to put it on display, in the right time and place.  
In the meantime, she practices. For now that suffices.  
But she longs to be under the stars, in someone's arms.



## Paper Tower

18 January 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/paper-tower/>

She sits at the center of her tower in prayer.  
She was given no door, no furniture, no plants,  
nothing living and thus no temptation. She sits  
and she waits for she knows not what. As the hours  
creep by, she grows restless, begins to examine the walls,  
to touch them even, and finds them not stone as she thought,  
but the image of stone imprinted on the thinnest paper.  
A devilish thought overtakes her. She taps the paper  
and watches it wave the whole wall up and down,  
as far as the eye can see. So she pushes it harder.  
A small tear brings in fresh air. She falls back,  
so used to the dank of the tower that freshness,  
with who knows what pollen, comes in as a shock.  
But before long she stands by this tear and its offering,  
breathing as deeply as she can. She tears it still further  
and further, until she can see the other side. She's amazed.  
She just stands there for days, in a daze at the wonders  
of plants and birds, the sun and the breeze,  
but she will not leave the tower. It's home,  
and all homes have value. But something  
was ever unsettled. She knows about trees now,  
and she was not one to forget. Why were there no trees  
in her tower, no birds, no songs? One day she gazes out  
and sees a tree struck by lightning catch fire,  
and she cannot stay in any longer. She rushes to it,  
climbing and climbing to the highest branches, where the fire burns.  
She tries to grasp it, unaware of such things, unlearned  
in the ways of fire. She feels its burn and screams.  
As the scream leaves, some pieces of fire enter through her  
and settle deep within. She has fire in her now, and she thinks  
of the paper that was once her home, and she thinks  
that all paper is made from trees, and if trees can burn...  
She returns to her tower and dares not touch the walls  
with burning hands. She sits quieter than ever, dead center,  
not sure how to pray anymore. But the fire keeps on burning.  
She does not mean to, but soon her heat expands and ignites the walls  
in a holocaust of flame, as she weeps all alone at the center.

But the blaze cannot hurt her. It *is* her, and she was not meant for this tower. She burns and burns and eventually she stops weeping. She rises and goes to the original tear. She sees something written that calms the flame. What was it? A map of some islands in the Aegean? A few lines of poetry? The words of a long-dead philosopher? Whatever it was, she knows now that the walls had been made from things meant to move. So she goes out in search of a place where her fire can burn.

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She doesn't find one, not for a long time, and she feels the danger of hunger, the pang of thirst. She returns to the tower and papers over paper with paper. She puts out her fire, or tries to...at least she manages to heal and dwell with some potted plants and a bit of dancing. But this is no longer a home for her, if it ever was. She needs another to knock on her door.

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He came with a torch and instructions on how to use it. He knew the way to a place where all fire is admirable. He offered to show her and waited until she was ready.

They went together.

## Bloom

*22 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/bloom/>*

As spring approaches, I hear the birds  
singing love songs, lost in the madness of suns.  
A flower has arrived in my garden.  
She is a bit fussy, a delicate plant, but with the right touch  
I think she will bloom beautifully.

## Room For Doubts

*22 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/room-for-doubts/>*

A strange calm echoes the silence both in and out.  
I am hoping to see you, but whether this hope comes true  
is up to you. It is out of my hands. I believe I've received  
your instructions, and I will obey, but I cannot say  
quite how I feel, like a moment's hesitation before a storm.  
So go, if you must, and move on. But I have room for doubts.  
I have room for you and your doubts.

## Obvious By Now

*22 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/obvious-by-now/>*

I suppose I'm in love. Is it strange  
that I don't know myself, that I doubt  
what must surely be obvious by now?

## Presence

25 January 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/presence/>

I must see that you are ready to be a woman  
before I could ask you to be *my* woman,  
and I must see it in person and not in character.  
I thought you thought you were ready and was nearly ready to ask before.  
I suppose you must see that I am also ready to be a man.  
We could prove it together.  
But I can't shake the feeling that you are only *almost* ready.  
Prove me wrong.  
Appear with the grace and confidence that I know you can also imagine.  
Invite me into your presence.  
I will not break down the door.  
But I will enter if you open it.

---

But maybe the door is stuck, jammed  
with memories and bruises. Even so, I maintain  
that it only opens inward. I cannot help clear it from outside.  
You must clear the way to let me in. Only then  
could I help, and I would help, with feeling.  
But I have not the power nor the inclination  
to break down doors, and I think you would find  
that life with no door is far worse than the life you have now.

---

You can choose to let me in, even for wild reasons,  
to set free a wildness within. It is true, I have known doorbreakers  
and the allure of barging in. But I surrender that power  
in the name of something higher, a love which awaits invitations  
and happy news. You must keep your door, for without it you would be exposed  
to the worst kind of monster, a man in heat. You must keep your door,  
with a fresh handle, clear of obstructions, but locked  
until the time of your choosing.

---

It would not take much, I could squeeze through  
even a narrow opening, and begin the work  
of sorting things out. What matters is the intent,  
the respect for doors and locks, without which

you place yourself in grave danger. Perhaps I fibbed  
when I said that I have not the power to break down doors.  
I do have it, but I will not use it, because it would hurt you,  
perhaps for a long time afterward. You have a power too,  
that of opening and closing, and I would like to see you wield it  
as a woman in full command of her presence.

## Healing

*27 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/healing/>*

How far we have come, and how far  
we have yet to go...what is this sudden pain  
and these memories? Minerva's owl at dusk?  
I think an old wound is healing. I think  
it will itch for a while. We are closer  
than ever before, and that makes healing  
possible. Heal me, and let me heal you.



## Contra Kant

*27 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/contra-kant/>*

Philosophy, at its best,  
is a form of poetry,  
never a science.

## Culture the Past

27 January 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/culture-the-past/>

The past, it turns out, is easy to destroy,  
but the future is hard to build. What happens  
when the future fails to arrive? Are we left  
with nothing, or can we rebuild what we had?  
The past, in fact, still lingers, though it moves  
underground, to avoid the prurient fingers  
of scientists and politicians. I would let it  
evolve, and seek neither to destroy nor to build  
*ex nihilo*, but culture the past into something  
we all could live for.

## Into The Abyss

*31 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/into-the-abyss/>*

Into the abyss again,  
searching searching searching,  
after all and all as one,  
the home of thinkers,  
call it God.

## Free Will

31 January 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/free-will/>

*Education should aim at destroying free will, so that, after pupils are thus schooled, they will be incapable, throughout the rest of their lives, of thinking or acting otherwise than as their schoolmasters would have wished.*

*Fichte, Addresses to the German Nation, 1804*

For centuries, the German barbarians  
were acquainted with the sharp end of civilization,  
the stick that beats down rowdy spirit in the name of order.  
They have never recovered.

They now know only that stick  
or wild abandon.

## Marriage Bed II

31 January 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/marriage-bed-ii/>

*Woman, your words have cut me to the core.  
Who has moved my bed? That would be a hard task,  
even for the most skilled craftsman, unless a god  
himself came down and with ease chose to shift it.  
No mortal man alive, not in his prime,  
could lightly prize it from its place. A great secret  
lies in that bed's craftsmanship. It was my work,  
my own, and no one else's.*

*Inside our court there grew a long-leaved olive tree,  
flourishing and full, its trunk as thick as a pillar.  
Around this I built my chamber, stone by stone,  
and roofed it well, and hung close-fitting doors.  
Then I lopped the foliage of that long-leaved olive,  
and trimmed the trunk from the root up, and with my adze  
planed it smooth and true, and to the line made it straight,  
fashioning a bedpost. I bored it all with an auger.*

*Beginning with this post, I built my bed,  
until it was finished, inlaid with gold and silver  
and ivory. And I stretched on it a thong of ox-hide,  
shining with purple dye.*

*There is our secret. And I do not know,  
woman, if my bed is still fast, or if some man  
has cut the olive trunk and moved it elsewhere.*

Homer, *Odyssey* (23.183-204), translation by Gemini

I have planted the tree  
that could grow into the sturdiest bedpost  
of a bed that cannot be moved.

## How I Hear It

*31 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/how-i-hear-it/>*

Call to me, sweet spirit,  
fill my head with songs,  
and I will listen well,  
because I hear you tell  
of places I belong --  
oh, how I hear it.

## What You Are Fighting For

*31 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/what-you-are-fighting-for/>*

You have spoken again. I will need some time  
to decipher the clues, but the timing speaks volumes.  
Or would you like me to deconstruct you?  
I like your sharp edge, have no doubt, but I see also  
softness that would like to come out. There's a place  
where that softness can know it belongs. You are right  
where life brought you, and fight if you must, but remember  
what you are fighting for.

## **Evil Afoot**

*31 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/evil-afoot/>*

I do find this game delightful, but I must remind you  
it cannot go on like this for eternity. Is it mere foreplay?  
Let it be so, because we cannot go into fantasy  
and dwell there, with so much evil afoot.



## **The Beast In Man**

*31 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/the-beast-in-man/>*

Or are we still in the labyrinth? Are these your minotaurs?  
Half-man, half-beast, or the beast-in-man...it is time  
that I told you a secret: the beast is deathless, it cannot be killed,  
but it can be soothed, even tamed, and made to do tricks  
(like these), or put to good use plowing fields.

## Hair on Fire

*31 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/hair-on-fire/>*

You are beautiful even with your hair on fire,  
but not in the way you might think, or fear. It's your courage,  
not your purity, that I admire. I have no need for idols,  
I swore off them long ago, in a valediction to images.  
You have that hidden song that embraces the shadow  
as part of the whole. I would hear you sing it,  
then master it, then sing it some more.

## Only As Humans

*31 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/only-as-humans/>*

You are seeking the center, the middle way  
between angel and beast. I will stand my ground  
against either extreme. I will walk with you  
only as humans.

## Without Losing Yourself

*31 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/without-losing-yourself/>*

One day you will love without losing yourself.  
It may be a ways off, but it nears.  
Have no doubt.

## **Anatomy of Shadows**

*31 January 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/01/anatomy-of-shadows/>*

Are you on the hunt, and am I the prey?  
Do you like to play with your food?  
Well then I must say this will not last long.  
I have been both predator and prey before,  
and I find both boring. It's better to love  
and be loved or be left alone. But the shadow  
of love lives in each of us, let's not deny it.  
I think it's been found near the cervix.

## **At The Same Time**

*02 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/at-the-same-time/>*

I am either going to fall down  
laughing, or else confess  
my undying love, but I think that I really  
would like to do both at the same time.

## **Fertility Exam**

*02 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/fertility-exam/>*

I have reviewed the evidence you sent me,  
and everything appears to be in good order,  
it looks like you have it all in the right place,  
but you really should come in person,  
so that I can perform a few tests  
and finish my assessment.

## Babylon

*05 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/babylon/>*

Perhaps it is time to stop dreaming. I sense a danger  
that I cannot name, but it's not myself at risk.  
I will go through the winding halls of Babylon  
again, if it might save another, even one.  
I will summon the fire that leaves its mark.  
But this is not a place one should wander alone.  
I have my companions tucked deep inside. They will answer  
if answer they must. When fires engulf the city,  
I know where I can run. And I know I can make it.  
Friend, don't underestimate your peril. This is a place  
of wildness, where laws bend and break on a whim.



## Walk Alone

*05 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/walk-alone/>*

I must be prepared to walk alone. There is no road  
that cannot be walked alone, and no time like the present  
to walk it, eager for peace and quiet, the calm river spirits  
that I once knew.

## Tired

*05 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/tired/>*

I grow tired, and not for the first time. Has the Phoenix  
exhausted itself? It returns to the nest empty-feathered,  
the flame a mere memory, but a good memory nonetheless.

## Venus

*05 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/venus/>*

Venus, of course, is a goddess,  
but she is not the only one.  
More importantly, you are not her.

## Strength

05 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/strength/>

You must not let love  
take your dignity.  
That would be no love at all.  
You must love out of strength.  
But to do so you first must *find* strength.

## Thorns

05 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/thorns/>

*He who wants a rose must respect the thorn.*

Persian Proverb

I think you are in a look-at-me-now-dad,  
roaring-twenties kind of phase, but if some of these  
thorns are permanent, I will respect them. I just don't want  
to get pricked.

## Only to Strengthen

05 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/only-to-strengthen/>

The ultimate degradation  
is the surrender of self-preservation.  
When this is lost, one becomes  
a victim, at the mercy of others,  
and of life itself, an infant again  
but without the mother's protection.

Surrendering even volition and all self-love  
may *seem* sublime to one who does not  
know better, but such gifts always prove  
worthless, and less than worthless,  
a genuine burden.

I would love only to strengthen  
myself and my beloved.

## Much In Common

*05 February 2026*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/much-in-common/>

Here's the rub:  
if you're an aspiring dominatrix,  
count me out.

But if you are merely *honest*  
about the dark side of life,  
or lost in a temporary struggle,  
then we have much in common.

## Whole, Complete

*05 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/whole-complete/>*

I would see you whole, complete, yourself  
and no other, and ready to take on the world  
with the strength you have in you.

But I would be those things too.



## Cruelty

07 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/cruelty/>

I can taste your cruelty, even in the midst  
of positive signals. I do not know if I like the taste.  
But I know where my limits are, and my line in the sand  
encloses my dignity. I will not give that up,  
not even for love. You must ask yourself  
whether I would be any good to you  
after receiving your cruelty,  
or if I would soon be deformed, degraded, eventually  
discarded, or cruel in return. It is not absolutely forbidden,  
you are free to be cruel, but it is a bad idea,  
and likely less thrilling than you imagine.

But maybe you need to try it  
and see for yourself.

## The Reason For Discipline

07 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/the-reason-for-discipline/>

Those who develop a taste for cruelty  
often must be put down, like a bear  
that has tasted human flesh, and is therefore  
more likely to seek the same. But you  
are no bear, and your only hope  
lies with society, the source of food  
and warmth. This is the reason  
for discipline, the only reason that satisfies  
the wildness within...even wildness knows  
not to bite the hand that feeds it. And yet  
we are animals in part and forever  
'til death, which is surely our end, not  
the end of the life that flows through us.

## Second Nature

*07 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/second-nature/>*

Habits can be cultivated, lessons learned  
through repetition. This is the way  
to tame beasts. The rituals  
of self-control become a second nature,  
as instinctive as the drives that they tame.  
But this takes time and frequent practice.

## Extraordinary Discipline

*07 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/extraordinary-discipline/>*

Love is not truly unconditional,  
not when it's human to human,  
for humans have limits, and all  
are vulnerable to cruelty  
and the degradation it brings.  
So let's not pretend. But this  
does not make love impossible,  
it only makes it difficult and rare.  
It requires extraordinary discipline.

## The Habit of Loving

07 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/the-habit-of-loving/>

How does one acquire the habit of loving?  
Not by loving, of course, for how could they love  
without the habit? Yet there is a kind of practice,  
a playground of love, in the mind's eye,  
in the land of dreams, where our fantasies  
train us with monsters that are yet to come.  
We can study well enough to master ourselves,  
the hardest victory, as Aristotle says,  
but the true test is in the real world,  
where the training is put to use  
and the trainee survives or fails.

## Who You Would Like To Be

07 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/who-you-d-like-to-be/>

*Hence I regard the loss of balance as purposive, since it replaces a defective consciousness by the automatic and instinctive activity of the unconscious, which is aiming all the time at the creation of a new balance and will moreover achieve this aim, provided that the conscious mind is capable of assimilating the contents produced by the unconscious.*

Jung, *The Relations Between the Ego and the Unconscious*

I will stand back  
and let you discover  
who you would like to be.

## Perhaps Not

*10 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/perhaps-not/>*

Perhaps I saw you, the blur in the hallway  
that lingered for just a few moments longer  
than necessary, and gave me that funny feeling  
that only you give me. Then again,  
perhaps not.

## Hook

*10 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/hook/>*

I am on the hook,  
but I cannot live there.  
A hook is no home.  
I would like to go home.



## Imagine

*10 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/imagine/>*

I know you can imagine it.  
Can you live it?

## **Fire**

*10 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/fire/>*

We are not playing with fire.  
We are building a fire.

## Rupture

*10 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/rupture/>*

A rupture, somewhere.  
A chasm has opened.

## Ruling Rod

*10 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/ruling-rod/>*

You must carry the shadow  
for the rest of your life, but you also  
must carry the ruling rod, and say no  
to those things that deserve it.

## Next to the Flame

*10 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/next-to-the-flame/>*

Vanda is the Devourer, nemesis of every Oedipus,  
the shadow of what love unchecked can become.  
These passions have purposes, and not for no reason  
do we restrain them with customs and rules.  
Are we strong enough to stand naked next to the flame?  
Only if we can make our *own* rules  
and not fall back into the wildness whence we came.

## **Black Sheep**

*10 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/black-sheep/>*

Black Sheep leaves the herd,  
climbs a mountain, stumbles,  
perseveres. The way is rocky,  
treacherous, full of hope.

## Real Strength

11 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/real-strength/>

Do you see now? The girl who once misunderstood  
the lascivious glares of men, the cruel jokes and vulgar gestures,  
who did not know that these things were not done in sport  
but grow out of the ugly, urgent need for ugly, urgent souls to make manifest  
their ugliness, exposing the darkness within. Has this girl  
been replaced by one who sees clearly herself and her place in a world  
full of wolves? This is no place for innocence. Oh,  
she would like to grow up...will it cost her  
herself? She would be a prized commodity in some circles,  
at least until her innocence dies. Is there another way?  
Yes and no. The world is what it is, and mankind is too.  
She would find in herself a response to the degradation,  
the ugliest sweetness, the darkest love. It would scare her, and thrill her,  
and ultimately leave her unsatisfied. But never again would she trust  
so willingly, never again give her heart without proper conditions.  
What are those conditions? Respect, first and foremost, for darkness  
and its place in our lives. For the evils above are mere phony expressions  
of energies that animate all of us, powering human endeavors  
and making us want to live. To kill those energies would kill us too.  
But the suitable objects for dreams of desire or domination  
are always within the context of social order, on which we depend.  
Any creature that does not so depend can hardly deserve the name "human."  
The darkness can neither be killed nor fully embraced, but it can  
be integrated into a dance between light and shadow, a chiaroscuro  
that gives men and women real strength.

---

Not only could you be made a slave, you could be made  
to like it, to see yourself suited and suitable to degradation only  
and nothing more. Something like this (though a pale imitation)  
occurs in many failed loves. It is vital, beyond vital,  
that you remain strong, that you love yourself,  
that you care for your body and spirit, and simply refuse  
any invitations to lower yourself below strength,  
no matter the offer. It will not be easy,  
but that is why it is worth it. Thereby you prove

that you cannot be beaten down, that the power within you is real and a force to be reckoned with.

---

But you also must offer only this same strength to others, and not use your strength to deprive them of theirs. The fight is to carve out a slice of the earth where your strength can shine against darkness within and without, and in this fight you may find some allies pursuing the same. But they will not allow you to lower them. You will do better to let them be, because they will return the favor. The wolves can be kept at bay, but only from this posture of strength. No other posture has ever had any effect.



## Sexual Awakening

*14 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/sexual-awakening/>*

Is it a sexual awakening? It looks like one.  
I will be careful not to rush in  
where angels fear to tread. You have enough strength  
to find your way. But where are you going?  
Where does it end?

## Teachers' Lounge

*14 February 2026*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/teachers-lounge/>

I am a poor teacher to so often learn from my students.  
So much so that I do believe we are *both* teachers, experts  
in different fields, discussing our discoveries in the teachers' lounge.

## Let Your Body Explain

14 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/let-your-body-explain/>

*A woman waits for me, she contains all, nothing is lacking,  
Yet all were lacking if sex were lacking, or if the moisture of the right  
man were lacking.*

Whitman, *A Woman Waits For Me*

You have a spiritualized sexuality. You, though a master of spirit,  
are unacquainted with the wilderness of bodies, including (perhaps) your own body.  
You must get acquainted. I do not know how, but you know. Trust yourself.  
Let your body explain.

## Sweetheart Like You

14 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/sweetheart-like-you/>

*What's a sweetheart like you doing in a dump like this?*

Bob Dylan, *Sweetheart Like You*

What *are* you doing?

Getting ready for love? Or finding yourself?

Or maybe these are the same thing...

## A Moon of Surprising Size

14 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/a-moon-of-surprising-size/>

So many things that I've wanted to share with you  
have come and gone, but there will be more.  
I don't know what you are waiting for, but I trust  
that you know, that you'll know it when you feel it.  
I must not *wait* in the sense of forgoing other opportunities,  
but I find no other who moves me like you do.  
I simply exist in a world which (I now know) contains you.  
Let this sweetness linger. Consider it, as one considers a moon  
of surprising size, just above the horizon.

## Vulnerable Narcissist

14 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/vulnerable-narcissist/>

You do fit the pattern of a vulnerable narcissist,  
weepy fragility followed by bursts of revenge  
when your needs are not met. You should know  
that I could not endure that for long.  
Is this why you hesitate? Or is the hesitating  
part of the plan?

---

*Even if* this is so, this is not your destiny,  
not for certain. It could be a phase of development  
needed for reasons you need not explain. I don't know  
who you are apart from your art. Maybe  
you don't either. I bow to your present condition,  
the powers of nature that made you so,  
and I know I can't change you, and yet you can change  
if these powers keep up their work, and if you  
let them guide you to greener pastures.

---

What has been tangled can be untangled.  
The web of darkness in the mind  
can be brought to light, examined, understood.  
But one must feel safe first, and that can prove  
difficult, a chicken-and-egg problem, the struggle  
of life itself. What more is there to say?  
You have given me a gift either way.

---

And yet, I don't know, and would still like to know.  
I confess that I find you marvelous, and that  
is uncommon for me. But am I just a source of narcissistic supply?  
Hard to say. If not, why the delay?

---

I can think of a few reasons,  
but I must suspend my judgment  
until a more suitable time.

## Stronger Still

14 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/stronger-still/>

*I can write you poems, make a strong man lose his mind.*

Bob Dylan, *High Water (For Charley Patton)*

Lose his mind, indeed,  
then maybe find it again  
and be stronger still.

## More Than Power

16 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/more-than-power/>

To hear my suit, and perhaps my life's work,  
belittled as mere "humiliation" was painful indeed.  
But perhaps I misheard you. If the play  
is not my work, but this drama we are writing together,  
then this dagger becomes half confession. I am open  
to this interpretation, but not the other, because  
the basis for our connection would be undermined  
if you do not consider me serious. No suitor  
could bear that much mockery, not when it touches the suit itself.  
Without respect, we have nothing, and no love could grow  
in such soil. But this other possibility intrigues me.  
It is made possible by your question at the end  
which undermines your own undermining. Were you mocking yourself?  
Are you so full of doubt that you doubt your own doubt? A funny question,  
but a serious one too. Is there more here than power,  
humiliation, degradation? Is sex ever more than these things?  
I say yes, and I intend to prove it.  
But you are *learning*. You sound in this moment like one  
who has sat at the wrong table, struggling to fit in.  
You must give yourself room to make mistakes.  
I will give you that room. Here it is.



## At the Entrance

*16 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/at-the-entrance/>*

Perhaps we have rubbed shoulders  
at the entrance to the maze of sex,  
but I was on my way out,  
while you were on your way in.  
I cannot dissuade you from entering.  
To do so would be folly, and hypocrisy.  
But I don't know if I belong there anymore.  
Do not let my ramblings confuse or discourage you.  
You must follow the course of your heart,  
and I must follow mine.

## Do What I Say

*16 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/do-what-i-say/>*

I want you to do what I say,  
unless I'm wrong.  
Then tell me I'm wrong.

## Inexperienced

16 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/inexperienced/>

Maybe I am the inexperienced one.  
You are *woman*, and I will allow you  
to show me what that means.

---

And yet I can dream, can't I,  
about what "woman" means? I would be  
a poor poet if I did not have such dreams.

---

An artist must sculpt with precision.  
A lover lets blemishes be.

## Strength II

*16 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/strength-ii/>*

I want your strength.  
I will give you my strength in return.

## **Master/Slave Dialectic**

*16 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/master-slave-dialectic/>*

Anyone whose strength  
depends on the degradation of another  
has no strength at all.

## Velocity

*16 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/velocity/>*

I see where you are, but I also detect  
your velocity, speed and direction. All living things  
are in motion, and I think I like  
where you are going.

## **Innocence**

*20 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/innocence/>*

If your innocence blinds you,  
then I will take part of it, but not all.  
You will keep your sense of wonder.  
You will still see stars and miracles.  
But you will also see Man as he is.

## Inside You, Dormant

20 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/inside-you-dormant/>

*The way is not in the sky.*

*The way is in the heart.*

Buddha, *Dhammapada*

The strength you seek  
is inside you, dormant,  
waiting for some alarm  
to wake it up. This is why  
you crave danger, and this  
is why only *you* can answer  
the questions that life is asking you.

I am the alarm.  
How will you answer?



## Cruelty II

21 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/cruelty-ii/>

On second thought, my thoughts turn away,  
toward healthier fields. Three times now you have devalued my suit  
in the midst of mixed signals. Three times may be enough  
to establish a pattern. I have told you I do not find you  
unworthy of love, but unbridled cruelty might change that,  
even if it wears a mask. It was never the cruelty  
that bound me to you. There was something else,  
something wonderful, and I still remember it, in fact  
I still *see* it, but the picture is complicated now.  
I wanted to wish away these slights  
as the clumsy confusion of naivete, but maybe  
you know *exactly* what you're doing, and maybe  
this backhanded cruelty is a form of survival, or even of *pleasure*,  
in a world that won't let you be cruel outright.  
Well, I see it at least, but the sight of it  
moves my heart out of orbit. There is no decision  
to be made, I fear the thing has accomplished itself.  
I wish you safe passage, as I did from the start,  
and I think you have much to accomplish in life  
and will accomplish it. I have no regrets.  
The sight of you woke in me something  
that never will slumber again, the dream of an "us"  
that transcends the sum of its parts. I hold onto that dream,  
and I hope you will too.  
But you are not my responsibility. I will keep writing,  
but you may do well to stop reading. It will likely  
be bittersweet at best. It has been a pleasure  
almost knowing you. Now, to rest.

---

Is it cruelty, or is it the perception of cruelty?  
So much depends on the answer...or is it what I asked for,  
quite literally? A love that is not "pure or chaste"?  
I had not thought you could make that leap so suddenly  
or so completely. Please be careful. Make sure  
you understand, and build this new self slowly. Get the foundation  
right, and don't throw away the old one until you have something

to take its place. But I hear you. You're willing to leap.  
That means a great deal. But you leap, and then subvert.  
That means something too.

## **Lonelier**

*21 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/lonelier/>*

Being with someone  
who doesn't understand me  
would only make me lonelier.

## **Better to Know**

*21 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/better-to-know/>*

She stood her ground,  
and I stood my ground,  
and we realized we were standing  
on different ground.

Is this what they call  
irreconcilable differences?

It's a pity,  
but it's better to know, isn't it?

## **Messy Heart**

*21 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/messy-heart/>*

You are not perfect,  
but neither am I.  
It's not all good,  
but there is plenty of good.  
I may still have a place for you  
in my messy heart.

## Succubus

*21 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/succubus/>*

So, you are a succubus, is that it? You're hardly the first.  
But if so, you're not welcome here. Go back where you belong.

But no, you don't belong with the succubi either.  
There's too much good in you.

## Wild Stallion

*21 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/wild-stallion/>*

The wild stallion in my heart  
is chomping at the bit, but the charioteer  
has the reins. I am feeling a bit wild...  
wild enough to do something drastic  
and life-changing, like making love over and over.  
But the charioteer says: there are greener pastures  
over yonder. Take her there.

## The Hard Road In Between (Madonna/Whore)

21 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/the-hard-road-in-between-madonna-whore/>

I cannot determine if she  
is sweet and mildly repressed  
(but full of dark fantasies)  
or a succubus who likes to play naive.  
It's a winning strategy, if the goal  
is total desolation  
(for her more than anyone else).

I suppose it would teach her father a lesson.  
Maybe I should leave them to it.

---

Nonetheless, Cupid deserves my praise.  
How can even a wicked girl summon strength?  
She cannot, but a god can, through the channels  
of imagination. I'm stronger now, but I fear  
she has only grown weaker.

---

Could she be a *recovering* succubus, who truly  
means it this time, but carries the old habits,  
the old desires? It's possible. Perhaps this fits the facts  
more than anything else...a Blanche DuBois  
to my Mitch, but that story doesn't end well for her...

---

It begins to make sense, if she is not repressed,  
but covert, hiding feelings and urges unfit for society.  
To what extent do these feelings control her?  
Perhaps a great deal. Does she know her way  
through a dimly lit room? Does she know it by heart?

---

It is none of my business, except in so far  
as it speaks to her character and capacity  
for healthy love. But I cannot decide a priori.  
I must step into this possible den of vipers,  
ensuring my routes of escape.

---



Of course the only possible truth is that  
she is both vamp and naif as the seasons permit.  
Has some man locked her into a spiral  
between Madonna and Whore? She could choose  
to be neither, and walk the hard road in between.

---

Another possibility: does she perceive her own wickedness  
in excess of the genuine article? Are these small naughty gestures  
not a confession of truth, but of misperception of herself  
as necessarily wicked because sexual by nature?  
I do not know what to call this if not repression.  
If so, then I hope she can find a better way, and learn  
that sex is a beautiful thing, if done right.

---

What makes it "right" is a kind of respect  
for the animal in the other. But this begins  
with respect for the animal in oneself.

## **Closed Door**

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/closed-door/>*

The door remains closed,  
but it does have hinges and a knob.

May you find the strength to open it  
to someone, someday.

## Thomas, Not Vanda

25 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/thomas-not-vanda/>

You are not Vanda. You are Thomas.  
Now it all clicks into place.  
If the play is a theophany of Venus,  
it signifies sexual awakening, but you  
are the one awakening, not the awakener.  
It is more Freud than Adler, more sex than power  
(but really I say Jung is the better guide).  
You are not springing a trap, you are quite simply  
noting your own awakening. I could not explain  
why your Vanda appears *repressed* (which makes no sense)  
unless you intend to invoke the play as a whole  
as a symbol of awakening. It seems to me obvious now.  
You are in your own good hands, but I  
have had a part to play.

---

But does that make *me* Vanda?! It is hard  
to keep straight, maybe that is the point.  
Of course I have been awakening too, so just like in the play  
we have both been both Thomas and Vanda. But who  
is at fault? I cannot accept the condemnation of Venus  
because I do not deserve it (and neither does she). Do you  
deserve it? Or might it be wholly undeserved?

## Heloise

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/heloise/>*

Well, Heloise, I guess this is goodbye.  
It has been a pleasure almost knowing you.  
I think this encounter has served its purpose, or at least  
as much of that purpose as can be served right now.  
You will be just fine, some day,  
maybe sooner than you think.  
Please take care of yourself until then.

## **Stable Hearth**

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/stable-hearth/>*

Look to Vesta for warmth.  
Her fires are steady,  
in a stable hearth.

## **Altar**

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/altar/>*

If you cut out my heart,  
built an altar around it  
and worshipped it,  
what would happen to me?

## Respect

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/respect/>*

Thomas and Vanda do not respect each other.  
We can do better than that.

## Lovers' Bond

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/lovers-bond/>*

You and I are not gods,  
but the bond between us is the work of the gods.  
We worship them by tending it with care.



## Repressed Lover

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/repressed-lover/>*

Repressed lover,  
or actress playing the role of repressed lover?  
It begs for an encore.

## **Transformation**

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/transformation/>*

Transformation is ensured, the work is done,  
and time moves on to other muses...

## **Labyrinth**

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/labyrinth/>*

This labyrinth cannot hold me, for it is made  
of the thinnest paper. Onward, to sea again!  
Where adventure calls. The rush of the ocean air  
feels good after too long indoors.

## **Bitterness**

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/bitterness/>*

Bitterness is a poison pill, a snare  
that strong spirits avoid. It is best  
to succeed, but even failure can teach  
or summon the laughter that shakes the gods.  
I would win, but, more importantly,  
I would maintain my equilibrium.  
So let me digest this discomfort right here,  
in these pages, where much of the source of it lies.

## Playing with Fire

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/playing-with-fire/>*

It really was childish to play with fire.  
I hope it brings you all the happiness you deserve.

## Phony

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/phony/>*

Are *all* of her emotions phony?  
Has she ever meant *anything*?

## **Fantasy**

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/fantasy/>*

Fantasy serves its purpose,  
and then it ends. It is best not to dwell  
on what does not end well.

## **New Beginning**

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/new-beginning/>*

If we should meet again,  
let it be a new beginning,  
not this same old story.  
We accomplished something here,  
but there's no need to rehash it.  
For now, take good care of yourself.



## Never One-Sided

25 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/never-one-sided/>

I cannot believe that such passions are ever one-sided.  
With Jung, I believe they are a product of relation,  
of interaction in some astral realm of consciousness. Whatever it means  
to be "close", so we were, and still are, to a painful degree.  
I don't know that this closeness is welcome now. It was always  
discomforting, except for a brief shining moment of near total surrender.  
From here, we can only climb up and out of the den of carnality.  
The world is no different than it ever was, but we may have changed.  
It was a worthy effort, not because of some high, some transaction  
between pain and pleasure, but because it brought broadened horizons  
and new possibilities. In short, we have grown, and that's more than nothing.

## Final Diagnosis

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/final-diagnosis/>*

Narcissist, vulnerable type.  
Pronounced god complex.  
Highly manipulative.  
Approach with caution.

## Epilogue

*25 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/epilogue/>*

Let us immortalize you here  
as a common harlot, false  
in pursuit of vanity.

## Seed of Love

*27 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/seed-of-love/>*

The seed takes root and germinates.  
It spreads its tendrils throughout my heart,  
and every day grips tighter. Every doubt  
is a cutting, from which new shoots grow.

## House of the Dead III

27 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/house-of-the-dead-iii/>

Can I really descend once more into the house of the dead?  
Can I really become a ghost again, and traipse my way  
among corpses, forever adrift from the dying sun? Isis came,  
and I should not have doubted, but why did she come?  
Did she love, or did she merely want *me* to love?  
To what purpose? To satisfy vanity, or maybe  
to trigger growth, but the latter so closely *resembles* love  
that I can't tell the difference. She put so much into it,  
then stopped at a certain point, and plateaued.  
This is no longer reciprocity, no longer evenly efforted.  
*Was* it a trick? Was it not Isis at all, but some god  
of deception, insulting me all the way? I have been mocked  
back into living form, that's true enough, and this prophecy  
from years ago has come to pass. Although it did not last,  
it held my face to a glass in which I see myself reflected  
as a man who can do better, who deserves better, than phony love,  
the art of loose and playful women. Sure, she knows how to read,  
and that is rare enough, but if the heart is not tied to this skill,  
then I will walk free, I will not bend the knee to a harlot  
who truly deserves no such love. To have glimpsed her is enough,  
even if a mirage from the sands of Egypt, even if she meant harm.  
She has caused me grief but not so much grief that I am not stronger for it.  
I doubt that she will ever reveal her hand, nor can I decipher  
her intentions from a morass of clues. So it's time to move on.  
But I will not return to the house of the dead. I will live,  
in the sun, for the rest of my days.

## The Rebuke of Venus

*27 February 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/the-rebuke-of-venus/>*

Which of us deserved the rebuke of Venus?  
I insist that my love was good.  
But I will not insist where that love is not valued,  
or where I am not respected.

## Lover and Guide

27 February 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/02/lover-and-guide/>

Perhaps I see now the folly in trying  
to be both lover and guide...my own feelings  
get in the way of allowing you to explore yours...  
or maybe induce confusion, as if these feelings and that exploration  
were *part* of the love instead of preparation for it.  
In truth, they *are* preparation, and therefore a private affair.  
But that does not mean that I did not care.  
I would see you blossom, whether for me  
or some other...but perhaps you do not like  
being put in a box as a broken thing,  
a thing needing repair...I see  
what I see, and *you* came to *me*  
when you found my poetry, consuming it  
apparently voraciously. What kept you coming back?  
I do not mean to mock you, I simply mean  
that if my words are worth reading, there must be some truth  
in what I say.

## Unyielding Peace

*02 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/unyielding-peace/>*

Unyielding peace, after storms,  
a welcome feeling, the feeling  
of surrender, the surrender of knowing,  
the peace of one who knows.



## Initiation

02 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/initiation/>

*I might as yet have been a spreading flower  
Fresh to myself, if I had self applied  
Love to myself, and to no love beside.*

Shakespeare, *A Lover's Complaint* 75-77

The initiation is over, and now  
you can choose  
who to love, and when, and how.

## **I went to her**

*02 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/i-went-to-her/>*

And obstacles proved stronger.  
It was as I feared.  
But there was no avoiding love.  
Desire, once born, must find its way out,  
even if it then sputters in the wind.

## Something Serious

*02 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/something-serious/>*

If you want something serious,  
you know how to reach me.  
If not, don't bother.  
I cannot want you this badly  
and never see you.  
It's simply unhealthy.

## Hollow Moon Rises

*02 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/hollow-moon-rises/>*

The hollow moon rises, reclaims its place  
in the pantheon...it is my duty to walk  
solitary, alone with this tangle of thoughts,  
and I say: so be it. The memories of love  
give some comfort, but they were little more  
than dreams all along. I will not be hampered  
by unfinished yearnings or bow to the howling of wolves.  
This is earth. Is some part of me unfulfilled?  
Of course. But at least I am not in chains.

## The Lady Will Not Slumber

02 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/the-lady-will-not-slumber/>

But the Lady will not slumber.  
She has awoken, and I can see,  
for the first time, the path to harmony,  
song and fire blending across the spheres  
and into a home worthy of memory,  
worthy of all who have come before and all who will come,  
for it is they whom the Lady signifies,  
the primordial ooze of the brain.  
She will not go away, but she is no tyrant  
any longer. Her laws are friendly, and I  
will serve this image with reverence and awe,  
entrusting its power to those with ears to hear.  
I know who she is, and I will not expect  
any incarnation to match exactly, but I  
will let her sing to me about things to come,  
and I will translate her song in these pages.  
I will not waver. She reminds me  
what life is, what humans are,  
and she no longer demands a blood-price.  
She knows a better way.

## Sophia Again

02 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/sophia-again/>

Sophia, long have I searched in vain  
for your hollow song, your dying fall, your wisdom  
echoing through life and not in the mind alone.  
But I will not give up. I *cannot* give up, for your song  
is true, and I sing this to you in constant resonance.  
There are green fields somewhere, at least in the mind,  
and if in the mind, then at least *in potentia* vivified  
in splendors of sense. There are ways to you,  
this much is true, and I'll find them, for I  
will not rest until I do.

## Paper Tower II

03 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/paper-tower-ii/>

They left the tower and started the long, winding road  
over hills and dales and through many a village.  
She asked what he thought of each building,  
all curious structures to her, and he answered  
with clarity (as much as each subject allows)  
that they all were constructed by men, and thus  
always are flawed with the flaws of all men.  
But these flaws do not make them unhelpful.  
In fact, they keep Nature out, our eternal  
friend and foe, who incites us to woe  
just as much as she powers our lives.  
She asked then what the torch was for,  
and he said, to contain the flame,  
to give shape to it, making it useful,  
and not destructive. She asked what to call it.  
He answered: civilization.

## **How we grow sane**

*05 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/05/how-we-grow-sane/>*

This is the process, these oscillations,  
this hurly-burly is how we grow sane.  
There is no shorter path, and none easier  
if the destination is truly intended.



## Turbulence

05 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/05/turbulence/>

Now I will try again, to my own surprise,  
but *expecting* turbulence, even *demanding* it  
as the best method for sorting things out.

## **Gaseous At Last**

*07 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/07/gaseous-at-last/>*

I will seek answers  
in my heart, whence troubles come  
and where they dissolve  
into sudden vapor, gaseous at last,  
unable to hold me down.

## Full Gravity

07 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/07/full-gravity/>

But love is a complex maneuver, requiring  
skill and practice, not to be taken lightly,  
and yet it *must* be taken on if one is to acquire the skill.  
I know my will. I would love the one  
I have found by chance, but not in some soggy romance  
divined from pop art, the mass delusions of common people.  
I would love with full gravity, ready to wage  
the full love of the earth, as grown man and grown woman,  
both up to the task and accepting its burdens,  
not cowering in the corner of dreams. Dreams  
do get us there, but they are the car, not the destination.  
They carry us forward into ourselves.

## **First Dance**

*07 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/07/first-dance/>*

When you're ready,  
I'd like the first dance.  
Don't forget.

## Raphael's Madonna

*07 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/07/raphaels-madonna/>*

I paint her in colors worthy  
of Raphael's Madonna.  
She answers: you forgot all my blemishes.

## When God Dies

10 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/10/when-god-dies/>

*To assert that God is absolute amounts to placing him outside all connection with mankind. Man cannot affect him, or he man. Such a God would be of no consequence at all. We can in fairness only speak of a God who is relative to man, as man is to God. The Christian idea of God as a "Father in Heaven" puts God's relativity in exquisite form. Quite apart from the fact that a man can know even less about God than an ant can know of the contents of the British Museum, this urge to regard God as "absolute" derives solely from the fear that God might become "psychological." This would naturally be dangerous. An absolute God, on the other hand, does not concern us in the least, whereas a "psychological" God would be real. This kind of God could reach man. The Church seems to be a magical instrument for protecting man against this eventuality, since it is written: "It is a fearful thing to fall into the hands of the living God."*

Jung, *The Relations Between the Ego and the Unconscious*

When God dies, he leaves a hole  
that can only be filled by us,  
but we are, in fact, mysterious,  
bound by earth and sky,  
the inner and outer necessities  
that make life what it is.

## **Your Future**

*10 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/10/your-future/>*

I have told you all that you needed to hear.  
I have passed on my wisdom.  
There is no telling what your future holds,  
unless you have something to say about it.

## Floating Castle

*10 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/10/floating-castle/>*

I will build this castle of words.  
I will dwell there, and even floating  
in air, I will have a home.



## Send in the Cavalry

*10 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/10/send-in-the-cavalry/>*

We're still working on the abolition of war.  
In the meantime, send in the cavalry.  
Democracy is dying again.

## Half Mad, Half Civilized

*10 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/10/half-mad-half-civilized/>*

The spinning point at the center  
of a world half mad, half civilized,  
but never more than half on either side.  
We are this tension forever. Release  
is only temporary, though healthful.

## Uncomfortable Peace

10 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/10/uncomfortable-peace/>

Institutions always seek new members,  
whether it's good for those members or not,  
like amoebae consuming their neighbors.  
They awe with impressive conformity to rules,  
while all around them humans suffer  
in spite of (and often because of) those rules.  
There's no stopping it. But I for one  
say no sometimes, when I know better  
than the proselytizing adherents, which happens  
quite often. But as long  
as they let me say no, we'll have peace,  
but uncomfortable peace, the peace of a truce,  
which rests on a razor's edge.

## The Game of Life

10 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/10/the-game-of-life/>

Manhood is no myth, not some fabled caricature  
of what men (or women!) dream. It has really  
been achieved, more than once, although  
it is painfully rare. Can we really do better  
than fate, the lotteries of genes and circumstance,  
to dish out the stuff of heroes? For every man  
has a bit of the hero, a bit of the rascal and rogue.  
Most are followers. This will forever be so. But a few  
become paragons, going their own way, just because  
they know better, somehow. Even they can't explain.  
Without them we are really in trouble, in chains  
in one cave or another, attempting to win at some  
made-up game, instead of playing the game of life itself,  
the only one worthy of our attention, the only thing  
that can satisfy human beings. A hero is called  
to this game with unbreakable energy, and *will* see it through  
at almost any cost. The others will follow. It's what they know.

## **At the Matinée**

*10 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/10/at-the-matinee/>*

I saw you peek out, just before  
the most potent scene. Were you looking for me?  
Or in my direction? Of course I was there,  
and of course I could see you, but more than seeing,  
I could feel a burn which it's hard to believe was just me.  
You conceal it well, though I think I can tell.  
You were wise to wear blue. That's a hearty clue  
that my symbols mean something to you.

## Peeking Eyes

*10 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/10/peeking-eyes/>*

Something about those peeking eyes  
stays with me, not in a haunting way,  
in a friendly way. What did they seek?  
Do I have it? I think I might.  
I would like to see more of them,  
looking to me for answers or hope,  
rooted in self-understanding.

## Calypso Returns

10 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/10/calypso-returns/>

Calypso returns to my mind out of nowhere.  
It was she who taught me about desire,  
how no laws can really contain it, and she  
who taught me to fear desire. I do not think  
she was right. I think she was desperate,  
though strong and noble in her own way. I'm convinced  
that twice she propositioned me, though I feigned ignorance,  
knowing that circumstances forbid it. And yet I returned,  
and returned again, to see her, and for what purpose?  
To sort myself out? Assuredly not out of love, but perhaps  
from an untamed desire that needed to find expression  
before it could be understood. I do hope she's well,  
but that is not the same as love. I can say that now.  
It may be she was sorting herself out too.  
There were energies exchanged that I cannot exactly explain.  
I will take those memories with me to my grave.

## Some Penelope Awaits

*10 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/10/some-penelope-awaits/>*

I will set sail for Ithaca, as ever,  
entrusting that some Penelope awaits there,  
knowing my course and my purpose,  
no longer distracted by sirensong.



## Better Care

11 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/11/better-care/>

Have I spoken too harshly? I must be true  
to my own development (that is what these pages are for).  
But the muse from whom I departed, the vulnerable narcissist,  
puffed up with self-love, is a shadow, and not the full picture.  
She knows there is more to her than that. And yet,  
this shadow demanded rebuke, and she had not  
the strength to rebuke it herself. I do hope  
that I sliced with precision, but this  
was a mere demonstration. The rest of the operation  
is in her hands, and they are such good hands  
that I hope against hope for success.

---

Can I really claim to have been in control?  
Yes and no. It was not the control of a scientist  
working with sterilized test tubes and frictionless inclined planes,  
or that of a sage, high up on a mountain, unaffected,  
but rather the command of a seaworthy captain, who has seen enough storms  
to ride through one without losing the ship. I digested  
her chaos, simply to prove it possible, that storms  
can be weathered, that they need not always destroy.  
She deserves to be happy, if only she can find  
the strength that is lacking, perhaps through better care  
of her body, perhaps through better care of her soul.

---

But I *did* destroy, didn't I? Only the shadow, I hope,  
not the ego, unless the ego was so tightly bound to shadow  
that it had to be sacrificed. Still, every ego is phoenix,  
and it may revive in a new formulation, a healthier one,  
one that sees that her shadow is one among many, and not  
the whole story. Her story remains unwritten.

## Only Shadow

11 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/11/only-shadow/>

Perhaps I now make excuses  
for my own lapse into shadow.  
I do not deny the darkness.  
I never have.  
But must one fight shadow with shadow?  
Not in all cases.  
Only when shadow is *repressed*.  
Then it must be coaxed out  
before it can be handled,  
managed, and governed.  
And only shadow can coax out shadow.

## A Woman You Admire

11 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/11/a-woman-whom-you-can-admire/>

There is still some libido in the tank,  
I will not deny it, though I will deny her  
the right to it, unless she reforms,  
until she is strong enough to love  
by light of day.

---

I really had hoped that the matinée  
might be the resolution, the moment desire  
burst forth into the sun. It was not,  
but there were just enough hints to keep me  
hanging on. Do you see what you're doing?  
Do you know it's unhealthy? I stand  
by my outburst, and I stand by my decision  
to walk away, head held high. You have  
so much in you that is worthy of praise that it pains me  
to see you debase yourself with insincerity,  
casual leading-on with apparently no intention  
of following through. Is this just a game to you?  
How little you know of the world and your place in it!  
I cannot make you understand, but I sense  
that some part of you knows, even laughs  
at your own maneuverings, whatever their purpose.  
Their only valid purpose is growth, or healing,  
or healing leading to growth. You can do better.  
I know you can, because I can, though there was a time  
when I couldn't. I wish you well, forever.  
You have a chance to be strong, and I hope  
you will take it. I hope you will grow  
into the woman I imagined you could be, or at least  
a woman you admire.

## All Else Could Be Forgiven

11 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/11/all-else-could-be-forgiven/>

I can paint you with light or shadow,  
but always a sketch from distorted memory,  
a hazardous road and one filled with peril.  
My fears begin to seem foolish,  
but so does my love, beginning so soon  
and with no foundation. I did not  
choose it, but that does not make it less foolish.  
Whence came these demons of Vanda?  
I have known enough Vandas to fear her.  
Of course you chose to play her,  
but you do not *feel* like her, on the whole,  
unless I distort what I know of you.  
I can do that quite well. I'd like you  
to know, that if I was right the first time,  
I'm sorry I could not hold true. Vanda  
scared me. Perhaps love scares me. Perhaps  
you scare me, and the feelings you awaken.  
I needed time to subdue this fear. Thank you  
for helping me subdue it. My only complaint  
is your silence, which I cannot understand.  
You may just be coy, but this coy?  
Too coy to reply? Even just to say  
"Thanks for the offer"? It feels like an insult,  
and if it was one, then all of my criticism stands.  
But if you explain this one thing, I think  
all else could be forgiven.

---

I have entered the bargaining phase of grief.  
Let us see what will come of it.

## Needed Alarm

12 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/12/needed-alarm/>

Our love became toxic  
because it never strayed from the realm  
of fantasy, mutual projection, and infantile trust.  
This is not my fault. Had we met and conversed  
as I asked, we would have discovered each other  
*in toto*, as real human beings, and maybe  
our love could have found its way to ground  
and grown roots in more permanent soil.

---

But could you not handle this?  
Did you need fantasy to break the ice  
around your heart? I now fear  
that I may have projected  
*my* need for awakening onto you...on the other hand,  
maybe I merely recognize the signs.  
After all, it was I who was willing to meet.

---

I am sorry to shock you, but I think  
you were too quick to trust, and too slow  
to endeavor to *build* trust, as if it were automatic.  
The shock was the needed alarm.  
Words come easy to me, but they are not  
all true, and your truth matters too.  
You have needs, but I have needs too.

## Already Thinking of Love

12 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/12/already-thinking-of-love/>

How did I know already last March  
to expect renovation? Was I already thinking of love?  
Were you already thinking of me? Or did Love  
have us both in mind?

## Paper Tower III

12 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/12/paper-tower-iii/>

They continued past the village,  
and into a wild garden.  
She said, "There are no buildings here.  
You should find me some flowers."  
Suddenly his palms were sweaty.  
He nearly dropped the torch.  
She said, "We will lie down here,  
but you must be ready to die."  
He said, "I will not die.  
I will live for you."

She caught fire.  
He began to build a hearth.

---

But she would not help him build it.  
She stood enamored by her burning reflection  
in a pool of water. He pushed her in,  
out of anger but also for her own good.  
Her fire went out. She rose, soggy.  
They stared at each other, saddened, not sure  
what had happened. They stared for a long time.

---

But he kept the torch burning, and touched her with it  
to light her again, more softly, a controlled burn.  
She did not like it at first, but it grew on her,  
keeping her warm, even where the first fire had scarred.  
They worked on the hearth together. It took a long time,  
but this new fire was finally admirable. It made a good home.

## Parting Words Reconsidered

13 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/13/parting-words-reconsidered/>

You were stuck playing the role of the Anima Woman, of giving male psychology whatever performance it wants. I admit this is somewhat attractive, even now, not because it's convincing, but because it requires a great deal of skill and insight, which could be put to good use in real love. You were trapped in the archetype, playing a hollow role in real life, which was surely exhausting. This will not work on grown men, and it will not make you happy, even if it does work on boys. You have doubtless offered this gift, the gift of the hook, many times before, and seen some grow wiser, while showering you with praise. But I never believed you. You put yourself on a pedestal, literally, camera down below, boot raised to quash any dissent. I saw clearly the scared little girl with a well-constructed, elaborate mask, who must be terribly lonely. I wanted to love her.

The truth is I once was an Animus Man. I did to girls the same thing that you are doing now to boys, and tried to do to me.

I know that it's empty, and I know the rules.

In a weird way that makes us compatible, but you would or could not step down into real life. I wanted to date you, not adulate you, and that was the truth from the start.

Your purpose is not to be what I want (or what any man wants) in exchange for applause, but to *be what you are*.

Are you merely a series of masks? I will not believe it.

---

Of course it was not all poison, but all along there was poison, a love of *power* and preference for control over intimacy. That is why you required bursting. But there were hints also of something milder, a girl who would like to grow close to another if only she could learn how. I am willing to believe this girl, but you know I must consider the possibility that she is just part of the act. It would be quite an intricate act, so much so that it's likely a product of my own imagination. A girl who could fake *that*, such vulnerability, would probably be beyond help. Only you



know your truth. Are you breaking through  
into the light, or so dark that you'd lie  
about something as sacred as your own development?

---

The test is quite simple:  
drop the act.  
Appear in person as a real human being.  
But there is no timetable.  
Even a genuine girl would need time  
to decide who she really is.

---

You do not have to give up your insight, of which  
you apparently have a great deal, but it is not enough  
to be *alluring*, is it, to chase a captive audience?  
No audience can truly love you, share your burdens, dry your tears,  
or make you strong. In fact they will drain your energy.  
You have a gift for performing, but this is no substitute for living.  
You need a *home*, and no one will just give you one.  
You must work to build one, and that work starts with you,  
with building the kind of soul that can build a home. I would like  
to think that this work has begun. I have done this work  
myself. I leave a record of it here in these pages.  
I remain curious what will become of you, but the task  
is yours. Show us what you're made of. You know yourself  
better than any other can.

## Participation Mystique

13 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/13/participation-mystique/>

How many times must I tread and retread  
the soils of a foreign soul? We are caught  
in *participation mystique*, the strange interweaving of souls  
that *just happens* sometimes. I cannot believe  
she devised it, nor did I. But here we are.

## On the Meaning of Blue at the Matinée

*13 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/13/on-the-meaning-of-blue-at-the-matinee/>*

The possessing goddess has self-immolated.  
Only the girl remains.

## Strange That I Do Not Regret

*13 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/13/strange-that-i-do-not-regret/>*

Have I failed, perhaps in the worst possible way,  
growing angry right when love was needed?  
I proceeded by instinct, and maybe it led me astray.  
I can claim it was needed on my side, to sort out  
my own growing pain, but it may have been harmful to you.  
Desire is a cruel master, and one I have often shunned,  
but in this case I let it consume me, and run itself  
all the way through me to ground. But I do not regret it.  
It's strange that I do not regret it.

## **L'amour n'est pas**

*16 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/16/lamour-nest-pas/>*

Thank you for trusting me.  
I hope I have led you well  
through the dark woods of passion.  
I hope you can find your way now.  
I will never forget you.  
L'amour n'est pas un long fleuve tranquille.  
But it is the rapids that allow us to heal.

## Earnest Contemplation

*23 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/23/earnest-contemplation/>*

In earnest contemplation, now I sit  
atop the mountain, filled with peace  
and strength. I bear my burden. Others  
will bear theirs with more or less skill,  
but I know I dream well.

## Poor Man's Lover

*23 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/23/poor-mans-lover/>*

A psychologist is a poor man's lover,  
doing the work lovers always have done  
at a fraction of the cost.

## The Mad Goddess

23 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/23/the-mad-goddess/>

He was not sure anymore that he understood anything.  
He wandered night and day asking always one question:  
was she a mirage? This one that had shown him the way,  
that had lit the path to a deeper knowledge of himself,  
this one that for once had seemed plausible as a lover  
had drawn a knife to wound him, and there could be no  
explaining away the wound as clumsy or careless. She served it  
with too much skill. But might the wound have a purpose,  
to shatter illusions? Was this wound a gift?  
And had he been slow to receive it? It told him  
that he must let love be itself, that he must not dictate  
the terms of female experience or dare to interpret a world  
in which he can only babble. He must put down his pen  
before he can open his heart, and the part of him that loves women  
will not be silenced, no matter what women turn out to be.  
But how could he keep for himself those other parts,  
the ones that have nothing to do with women, alive and functioning,  
if living in fear of another thrust of the knife? He would keep  
one foot grounded in each world, but how to escape the pull  
of the gravity of the earth? His anima rose from the soil,  
possessing him, but he blamed another, who did play a role  
in the summoning. But this was his story. How could he silence  
the mad goddess, without destroying her or doing violence  
to the power she represents?



## Wayfarer

23 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/23/wayfarer/>

I am a wayfarer, lost somewhere between  
heaven and earth, with my own compass,  
accepting no other guide. It is funny how few  
are allowed to be free. But for you and me,  
dear reader, whoever and whenever you are,  
there is no other way. The stars won't obey  
our commands or make plain what we know by heart:  
that we *are* where we start, and all else grows from here.

## **From Place to Place**

*23 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/23/from-place-to-place/>*

If I drift from one vagueness to the next,  
will I find firm ground? Or am I  
the ground, that is carried from place to place?

## Warm Light

*23 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/23/warm-light/>*

The sun burns, shines its light between spaces  
long left in the dark, and heats up  
the cold stones of the heart. I will warm  
in its light, feel its heat, let it liven  
the sleepy parts of me. And then I will be free.

## Paper Tower IV

*23 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/23/paper-tower-iv/>*

The hearth half-finished lies in a broken field.  
She is nowhere to be found. His heart remembers  
but believes she was only a dream, a proxy for him, a vision.  
The torch still burns, but the fire is inside him now,  
and it will not go out.

## Theseus Says Goodbye

*23 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/23/theseus-says-goodbye/>*

Ariadne, it seems that you deserve your namesake.  
Bride of Dionysus you are and must remain.  
I bow to your destiny. I will believe that you helped me  
on purpose, in spite of the pain. It's better that way.

Now I must confess Dionysus divine.  
But I serve gods who are more kind.

Think of me when you visit Athens.

## The Mad Goddess II

*31 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/the-mad-goddess-ii/>*

The mad goddess no longer speaks,  
though she sits in the corner, brooding  
with daggers in her eyes.

She will tolerate no further transgressions.

She has joined the pantheon, taking her place  
in the seat of Dionysus.

## Inventory

*31 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/inventory/>*

Do not get lost  
in this inventory of archetypes.  
They are mere signs of life.

## Still Point of Wholeness

*31 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/stillpoint-of-wholeness/>*

One year closer to the sweet release of death,  
another day of mixed sun and cloud, the cool waters  
of time flowing ever before us and into eternity...  
What is the point of the struggle for power?  
All lose who do not find their own center,  
the still point of wholeness upon which the world turns.



## **Anima**

*31 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/anima/>*

Sophia, the Lady, even "She" and "You"  
are all Anima from different points of view.  
She arrives here in her final form,  
the intuitive inner feminine,  
mystical bride, and guide  
to the world of feeling.

## Look Inward

*31 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/look-inward/>*

Do not reach out.  
Look inward.  
That is where you are.

## Cities Are Natural

*31 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/cities-are-natural/>*

Do I want excitement?  
Or do I simply want to test my mettle  
against forces of nature, to see whether  
civilization stands or falls when opposed  
by raw energy? I dare to propose  
that cities are as natural as beehives,  
anthills, and the like. We cannot help making them.

## Waiting to Heal

*31 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/waiting-to-heal/>*

I return to this space again penitent,  
ready to accept my share of the blame  
in love gone wrong, before God and all witnesses,  
waiting to heal. I have paid the price.

## Whoever You Are

*31 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/whoever-you-are/>*

If some other tomorrow follows  
after awakening, if there are flowers  
growing in fallow fields, if spring does come,  
snow melts, and the sun shines out anew,  
I will respond to you, the one who comes,  
whoever you are.

## Uncertain Certainties

*31 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/uncertain-certainties/>*

The end is a new beginning, like always  
and whatever comes will be new, but familiar,  
an echo with small modulations, the same old song  
with new harmonies, counterpoint answering theme  
with the age-old questions, the uncertain certainties,  
raining from heaven or bubbling up from the earth.

## Anima Dialogues

31 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/anima-dialogues/>

My anima was shy at first, unsure  
that the world could be trusted, but I  
have encouraged her. Now she stands taller  
and shows me the way to myself.

## **A Man at Last**

*31 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/a-man-at-last/>*

A dark night of the soul, with piercing visions,  
haunts my memory. I saw things I will not say.  
But in the light of day, I find myself  
a man at last, a man with things to say.



## The Simple Self

*31 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/the-simple-self/>*

The council of inner natures  
guides me through tension and opposition.  
The simple self is no more.

## Where Daylight Touches Earth

*31 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/where-daylight-touches-earth/>*

There's a shorter path to tomorrow, one that  
cuts through this and that, pulling powers  
of observation out of hiding and back into view.  
I want this for me and for you.  
I will do my part. I will start  
and end at horizons, where daylight touches earth.

## For What Purpose

31 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/for-what-purpose/>

Once again wishing to burn the whole thing down,  
life and its accoutrements, vanity after vanity  
until final rest. For what purpose? Just to prolong  
the struggle? Some days I just cannot find reasons.

## Dig For Some Hope

31 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/dig-for-some-hope/>

He had finally arrived at the still point, the center  
of himself and all human life. It was a jarring revelation.  
He had spent his life half asleep, in a dream  
of his own making. Now he wished to create,  
not to channel despair, but to dig for some hope,  
for what little hope still remained buried in other souls  
half asleep. Some would answer and waken.  
A few would join in the endeavor. But he  
would live well knowing his place secure  
in these pages, where human truths are spoken,  
not ultimate, eternal truths, but the truths of one soul  
that cultured itself to the furthest possible extent.

## Soft Inner Knowledge

*31 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/soft-inner-knowledge/>*

I begin to see who I have been, and I  
do not like all of it. I have let pain swell  
my ego three sizes too big. I have done hard things  
and thought therefore that I deserve praise. But what  
is my self? I cannot be tyrant any longer. These inner  
autonomous energies beg to be heard, and will sicken me  
if I do not listen. So I will listen, and find a good-natured  
repose. I partake in the dance with the quiet voices,  
the soft inner knowledge that tells me what I need to know.

## Home Right Here

*31 March 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/home-right-here/>*

What meaning can be found in years  
spent running from myself, denying life  
as it moves within me, stifling answers  
that tried to urge me on and home?  
I now will make my home right here,  
not in these pages, but in this body,  
the one that tells me what it needs.

## Inside You All Along

31 March 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/03/31/inside-you-all-along/>

The conflict between inner and outer necessity  
breeds repression. After naysaying and too much silence  
the inner voice retreats to who-knows-where, and waits  
until some coxer calls it out. But not all coxers  
can be trusted. Some come to destroy, and send the voice  
back into itself, even deeper than before. I will try here  
to be the good kind. I will give you room to expand.  
But you must locate this voice in yourself. It is yours.  
It has been inside you all along.

## **The Goal**

*07 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/the-goal/>*

To love and be loved,  
to give and receive as equals,  
without self-erasure:  
this is the goal.



## Narcissism

07 April 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/narcissism/>

It was a magnificent display  
of narcissism, much too perfect  
to be believed. You have shown  
your true colors, and I will remember  
each cycle of idealization/devaluation,  
proving further your lack of substance,  
your total dependence on external validation.  
You will gladly destroy if it meets your needs.  
I don't need you, though you do need  
someone like me, and perhaps you hoped  
to spread your need, to destroy  
as you have been destroyed. You are  
so hollow, and I  
have no room for you, even  
in this generous heart.

---

But although you meant evil, the Lord  
works good, for by showing me  
just what I wanted, you melted the ice  
around my heart. I have got all  
I needed from you, and I'll keep it,  
because it was mine all along.

## **This One Lesson**

*07 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/this-one-lesson/>*

This one lesson was worth the pain:  
the mad goddess awoke  
and found her place among stars.

## Congregation

*07 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/congregation/>*

A new man rises from the ashes  
of the old, at once a man  
and something more, a congregation  
of the inner voices, harmonized at last.

## The Work of the Anima

*07 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/the-work-of-the-anima/>*

The veil lifts, the fog clears, and I  
am at one with all around me  
(we were always one but now I am aware).  
A strange silence covers over all indecision.  
She is here, inside me, doing her work.

## Offerings

07 April 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/offerings/>

*I find more bitter than death  
the woman who is a snare,  
whose heart is a trap  
and whose hands are chains.  
The man who pleases God will escape her,  
but the sinner she will ensnare.*

*Ecclesiastes 7:26*

I offered my heart.  
She offered confusion in return.

## Sturdy Example

*07 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/sturdy-example/>*

I remember a time of brokenness,  
a time when life made little sense,  
when the wind itself condemned me  
to ignominious shirking. Now  
I stand taller. Now I feel whole.  
I see others who pass through the same.  
My best gift is a sturdy example.

## Finding Sophia

*07 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/finding-sophia/>*

It took me twelve years to find Sophia,  
but now she abides with me always, and heals  
that which needs to heal.

## **Why Not Both**

*07 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/why-not-both/>*

The active life, or the contemplative life?  
Why not both?



## Truth or Power

*07 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/truth-or-power/>*

The mind must orient itself towards truth  
or else towards power. It cannot  
seek both at once. But maybe there is  
a time for each. Maybe the mind  
can oscillate and still keep its balance.

## What You Offer

*07 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/what-you-offer/>*

You who have awoken desire:  
I still remember (how could I forget),  
but you do not seem to want love,  
and I do not want what you offer.

## Head Held High

*07 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/head-held-high/>*

I will walk head held high  
over whatever paths lie before me.  
I cannot stop now. Time is ticking  
my life away, and I have things to say.

## What Are They?

*07 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/what-are-they/>*

There is a place where energies combine  
at the soul's center, where various facets  
of who we are become one. I will  
dwell there, and tell my story as it was.  
I know some will mock me, but they  
do not matter. I am myself.  
What are they?

## **Firm Beginning**

*07 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/firm-beginning/>*

Here is a firm beginning, another setting out  
toward better people, the ones who know love,  
secure enough to be gentle, the ones  
who have made their way in the world.

## Contempt

*07 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/07/contempt/>*

If you treat everyone with contempt,  
you will find few beside you.  
Your powers of manipulation  
only go so far.

## Seeking Shelter

*13 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/13/seeking-shelter/>*

And so I still wander  
over unmarked lands, seeking shelter.  
A dream can inspire yet be only a dream.  
Beware those who sell dreams for power.

## Token

*13 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/13/token/>*

Light after stars, under stars  
in newfound hearts, growing stronger even  
within accusations. I know my part.  
Now I carry in my heart a token  
showing what love could be,  
and I face the dark with ever-growing courage.



## Ready

*13 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/13/ready/>*

I am no longer in love,  
but I do now feel ready for love.

## Pain, Real Enough

*13 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/13/pain-real-enough/>*

I have known pain, real enough  
to call into question the sanity of living,  
to shake the foundations of mind and body,  
to rupture the vital energies. This pain  
brings with it a clarity that few understand...  
some things really matter. Most do not.

## Helen

*13 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/13/helen/>*

I had not met Helen before.  
I had sailed past Troy on my way  
to Jerusalem, where I met Sophia.  
I had to go back for Helen.

## Rarely Tempted Again

13 April 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/13/rarely-tempted-again/>

The mad goddess slumbers, takes a nap  
and falls out of her chair, spilling ecstasy  
everywhere. She was the one they were  
waiting for, the one whose time had come.  
But in time she arose and spoke:  
You have all been fools for love.  
I have come to instruct you, and chastise  
your violent and childish desires. I have come  
so that you too may come to your senses.  
Real love is not easy, but counterfeits  
never ask anything, or else ask everything,  
and give nothing in return. Real love is a give-and-take  
between equals. You know this, but still  
you are tempted to disrepute. Let me  
live and awaken within you, and you  
will not only be strengthened. With fear  
of me, you will rarely be tempted again.

---

The Hero rose and asked: But how  
could we dare not be tempted?  
She answered: You will know better.

## Preferring Penelope

*13 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/13/preferring-penelope/>*

Odysseus stands on Calypso's shores,  
eyes set in the distance, envisioning  
what may yet be. He has seen himself  
degraded, and now made whole, somehow  
made whole through the degradation.  
He knows where desire lives, and how  
to sail through it. He has in him  
strength enough to hear sirensong  
and not give in. But he always  
preferred Penelope, and sails hence again.

## The Promises of Birth

13 April 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/13/the-promises-of-birth/>

Falling back into myself, realigned  
with the only things that truly guide,  
I hear songs, I feel knots come untied,  
and I wonder, can I be so small  
to blame others? To think that my  
inner voices come from outside?

---

But how deep these knots were,  
tightened over years of clenching  
brought down to bear on experience,  
strictures that kept energy locked inside.  
I see now, and I hear, and I go  
where my story goes, but as one who knows  
both confinement and freedom.

---

I also know now to receive  
what my insight offers, even  
when it doubts my intentions, even  
when it calls me a fool. I know now  
it was I who was cruel, to myself.  
I know now what it means to have health,  
and I now will protect it for as long as I breathe.

---

How could I for so long be deceived  
by my own thorns and briars, my own traps  
laid to ensnare myself, to cage off  
the energies that make living possible?  
It was I! It was I! It was I!  
In such war with myself that all life  
became bleak beyond any repair.

---

And yet healing is not quite repair,  
not external repair, but the inner work  
of the forces that make me myself

come alive again to deliver  
on the promises of birth.

---

I will go out, when I have healed,  
and I will make my name  
as a good man, whole and ready  
to love and warm others, but equally ready  
to fight real enemies when they appear.

## Spelunking II

13 April 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/13/spelunking-ii/>

*When good things are unraveling, bad things come undone.*

*Jars of Clay, Boys (Lesson One)*

You went spelunking  
into my heart  
and tore me open.  
What was your purpose?  
To repay blow for blow?

---

I have not decided whether  
this wound was salvific or deadly.  
It seems the procedure was nearly fatal,  
but sometimes there is no other way.

---

So many things unravel, bad and good,  
the good to make room, to make a hole through which  
the bad can be removed. I'm healing.  
You are no scared little girl anymore.

---

But what you are evades me,  
and I will not bind myself to phantoms,  
not even those that heal me.



## Blanche

*13 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/13/blanche/>*

Are these your poems, Blanche,  
are these what you will hold onto  
when seductions fail to satisfy,  
when you long to rest but cannot find  
any breast to lie on? You chose your path.

## **Full Strength**

*13 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/13/full-strength/>*

I am back to full strength, or nearly,  
and in many ways more than before  
I feel vigorous, ready to take on the day  
and its many challenges.

## Needed Inner Work

*15 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/15/needed-inner-work/>*

The transference becomes apparent to me:  
there was another narcissist, deserving but never receiving  
my condemnation. Now I have condemned another  
who may or may not have deserved it. But this  
has healed me. Only this could have healed me.

It led to the needed confrontation. It led  
to the needed inner work.

---

This deep wound, this habitual shrinking  
in the presence of one who would take all space,  
who expected a carbon copy of herself  
and would accept no substitutes,  
she is the monster of my nightmares,  
the reason my inner voice nearly died.

## Pile of Handkerchiefs

*15 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/15/pile-of-handkerchiefs/>*

You have left me  
with a pile of handkerchiefs.  
I have no choice now but to burn them.

## Fire and Earth

*15 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/15/fire-and-earth/>*

My fire burns for the image of love,  
for the vision of potentials fulfilled in a sacred dance,  
but I will not dance with blasphemers.  
The gods of love are too real.

---

But if I step down from the temple  
and enter the chamber where love really occurs,  
does this image endure? Or is fire quenched by earth?

---

Fire and earth feed each other.  
The earth provides fuel. The fire provides warmth.

## Paper Tower V

15 April 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/15/paper-tower-v/>

The fire inside of him quells the dark  
and empty recesses of cold regret. He lives  
again himself, at once a man and more,  
a man with part woman inside him. The tower  
was in his mind, *was* his mind, and she  
was the force of life seeking wholeness,  
a soul neglected. Now he knows. She rose  
at the sight of another resembling what she  
aspires to be. She tore and burned the tower  
to get free. Now she *is* free.

She brings herself into alignment with her guide.  
She guides him too from time to time.

## Caretaking

*15 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/15/caretaking/>*

Caretaking can be like a toxin,  
inducing paralysis, holding the victim in place,  
unable to fend for himself. It's injected  
unknowingly by many who think they love.

## What Waiting Meant

15 April 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/15/what-waiting-meant/>

Reflecting back on who she was, or who  
I thought she was, I still can see the appeal.  
She early showed signs of what now I can name,  
the vulnerable kind of narcissism, oscillations between  
extremes of pride and shame. But beneath this  
was something beautiful, awareness of her own condition,  
the capacity to display it in art and even  
in her public persona. This was her chiaroscuro,  
this deeper earnestness, a deep desire  
for authentic connection in spite of knowledge of her flaws.  
How many narcissists can name their narcissism?  
Only the rarest, only those destined to heal.  
This was my hope, and what I waited for.

---

She made some progress. Images of extremes  
were replaced by those of integration. She reached out  
tentatively through a veil, demanding control over any intimacy.  
In the end this control proved too limiting.  
But she may have a future free from these fears.  
It is too soon to tell. *My* future will surely  
house memories of her, but the wound is deep  
and not less than a miracle could rekindle the flame.  
But miracles do occur. I would like to believe  
she can learn to be trustworthy. I too have learned it  
and not without effort and many mistakes. But  
until she learns it, and proves it with much repetition,  
I cannot trust her.

---

Still, she was useful to me, as vulgar as it is  
to say it. She gave me cause to develop my powers  
of love, and an object for love unlike any I knew before.  
I did not imagine her depths, though I did invent  
a rushed timeline and certain outcome. Her transformation  
could only have come from the depths, and I share those depths,  
so I know them well. It was stunning to find them in another,  
but I really believed it, and was probably right.



But depth does not equal maturity, and the lack of the latter makes any connection perilous, perhaps more so for two souls full of uncommon knowledge. My boundary stands, but so does my admiration. If only she could learn to rest in herself, in the powers of healing within... but there I go orchestrating her life again. I must follow my own advice, and let her follow hers.

## Some Happy Song

*15 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/15/strange-bedfellows/>*

Lust and wisdom are strange bedfellows, strange enough  
to call into question the meaning of wisdom, the purpose  
of thinking. But maybe they can live together  
in some kind of harmony. There is a time to think  
and a time to feel, a time to give and a time  
to believe. The world is a curious place, full  
of oppositions, the wonder that comes from the stars  
and the wrath of the earth. I want all of it,  
blended in some happy song harmonious, well-tuned  
even when apparently dissonant.

## Scattershot

*20 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/20/scattershot/>*

Two birds fly scattershot  
through humid air,  
crashing into windows.

They fly off dazed  
but perhaps enlightened.

## **New Vitality**

*20 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/20/new-vitality/>*

Spring brings with it a new vitality,  
the heat of the sun pulsing through living things,  
reminding them what they are. Many suns will come,  
and in their heat new life emerges,  
winter's desolation fades.

## **Dreaming**

*20 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/20/dreaming/>*

Dreaming only goes so far.  
At some point one must start living.

## Find Your Way Home

*20 April 2026*

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/20/find-your-way-home/>

Lost and confused, too broken  
to care, she walks on the side  
of the road, going anywhere. Time  
would heal nothing, and not even love  
could touch wounds so deep she doubted  
all but despair. I was there  
myself, but not quite myself,  
a phantom of hope, or a glimpse  
of some other place, where dreams  
don't have to die or possess, where  
some thrive despite many impediments.  
She heard this call and responded.  
Together we walked a while, until  
I had to continue my journey elsewhere.

I said to her:

Find your way home.  
You can make it.

## **Animus Possession**

*20 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/20/animus-possession/>*

She walks angry, surely right,  
self-evidently so, and sure also  
that love is for fools. All is bad  
forever. But somewhere in her  
something stirs, remembering warmth,  
remembering how she believed  
in herself and in others, so long ago,  
still within reach.

## Mild Bitterness

20 April 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/20/mild-bitterness/>

She offers the promise of an easy release,  
unlimited and with no prerequisites. He obliges  
and loses himself in himself, in the part of himself  
that craves love. He's bewitched. Now his manhood  
slowly must fade. Now he falls into darkness,  
his own darkness, but a darkness that good women  
help him avoid. But true strength grants him courage  
in the midst of even this strangest temptation.  
It allows him to sail on through. He must  
hold on to all that is his. He must not surrender it  
even for the sweetest love, or the sweetest illusion  
of love. He prefers the bitter taste of the real thing.

---

But he cannot repress this desire without self-injury.  
Instead he must guide it toward healthy love,  
the kind that will strengthen both parties, the kind  
that he wanted all along.



## **New Adventures**

*20 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/20/new-adventures/>*

I stumble over brambles, into  
the mists of time, where each new day  
is born, and the sun waits to rise.  
I see through my own eyes. There  
are adventures ahead, and my song  
waits to bring itself to life.

## **Burn What Must Burn**

*20 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/20/burn-what-must-burn/>*

The mad goddess often takes the form  
of a real woman, animus-possessed,  
and scolds any who hear. But her signal  
is rarely clear. She invites action  
rather than contemplation. She sparks fires  
that burn what must burn.

## **Beneath the Willow Bough**

*20 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/20/beneath-the-willow-bough/>*

I will rise and go now  
to the home which I have made,  
and I will dwell beneath the willow bough  
and lounge within its shade.

## Tell Me I'm Pretty

20 April 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/20/tell-me-im-pretty/>

She scans the crowd for faces  
she can control. She spots one,  
hones in, and begins to attune herself  
to its wildest dreams. She cannot  
go more than a day without feeding.

You know who you are. Or rather,  
you have no idea, but I know *what* you are.  
When that face fails to soothe your empty soul,  
you will destroy it, or nearly so, simply for failing,  
simply to make another soul empty. No matter how many  
admire you, it's never enough, is it?

## Beyond Good and Evil

*20 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/20/beyond-good-and-evil/>*

She is moving  
beyond good and evil,  
and no longer restrains her cruelty.  
But will she get stuck in evil,  
fall back into good, or make it  
the whole way beyond?

## **Anima Song**

*20 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/20/anima-song/>*

Anima, you are my life-song, the essence,  
the one from my dreams, and I greet you  
with so much exuberance after your long hibernation.  
How many worlds shall we conquer together?

## Postscript to Venus in Fur

*20 April 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/20/postscript-to-venus-in-fur/>*

Vanda has her way with him,  
then leaves him dangling in pain, half-crucified.  
But then comes the resurrection,  
Thomas enlivened with newfound strength,  
a hidden power allowing him to understand women,  
to treat them like women with kindness and respect. He cancels the play  
and finds another more suited to his new personality.

## Dionysus at the Matinée

20 April 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/04/20/dionysus-at-the-matine/>

I came  
expecting initiation  
into the holy mysteries  
and was not disappointed.



## Beatrice Laughs

*01 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/01/beatrice-laughs/>*

Beatrice laughs,  
but Dante  
still rises to heaven.

## Make the Growing Things Grow

01 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/01/make-the-growing-things-grow/>

I cannot escape these mysteries, the deeper truths  
of the unfolding universe, endless vibrations, the push  
and pull of forgotten stars...we are all that we are,  
and yet I find myself drawn skyward, toward  
unknown secrets, awaiting investigation...

---

But out there are no roots, no nourishment  
to strengthen bodies, to tie us down to each other,  
in place and growing, forever growing, becoming  
our stronger selves...

---

Is there some combination that synthesizes  
mind and body? The wisdom of stars  
brought down to earth, to make the growing things grow?

## **Integrate the Shadow**

*01 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/01/integrate-the-shadow/>*

Integrate the shadow,  
feel its power,  
but let it be one among many.

## Hero's Journey

*01 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/01/heros-journey/>*

I dreamed she was both damsel and dragon,  
a young girl caught in her own shadow.  
I dreamed I was both knight and wolf,  
there to tempt or to save as needed.  
I dreamed both were needed.

## **Solitary Bird**

*01 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/01/solitary-bird/>*

A solitary bird croons  
plaintively, regretting nothing,  
but with needs to fill.

## **New Self**

*01 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/01/new-self/>*

The new self collides at last  
with the old, in impressive synthesis,  
both halves conjoined and aligned  
moving forward into the new day.

## Searching for Occupancy

*01 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/01/searching-for-occupancy/>*

So much ink spilled on things  
that do not concern me, need not  
occupy my mind...but my mind  
was not whole, and was searching  
for occupancy. Now it is full  
of the parts of myself that were hidden.  
The journey is over.

## Start at the Center

*01 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/01/start-at-the-center/>*

Who shall I be now, after journeying  
into myself and back again, aware  
of the cosmic vibrations in my own heart?  
I will start at the center, and find there  
connections with others, a place to believe  
and a place to dream, but a place  
closed to outsiders and wolves.



## Here on Earth and Now

*01 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/01/here-and-now-on-earth/>*

Anima brings me strength  
to combat false deities,  
enliven and answer the call  
to live well here on earth and now.

## New Opportunities

*08 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/08/new-opportunities/>*

I regret my own weakness, the folly  
of inaction, the failure to understand  
matters of the heart. I was too far adrift  
to make sense of it all. I am less adrift now.  
I look forward to new opportunities.

## Eudaimonia

08 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/08/eudaimonia/>

I am weaving a tapestry of the inner voices,  
the drives for sex, power, love, food, reason, will,  
together in harmonious oscillation, answering each other,  
playing off of each other, to create eudaimonia,  
the balance of strength that rarely consummates here.  
This tapestry calls for itself, it assembles itself  
out of pieces that vibrate with magnetism for each other,  
and the humming of self made manifest answers.  
It is I who have arrived, or is it the gods  
whose work this surely is? There are no substitutes  
for good spirits, and no other end in itself.

---

Is this then the purpose of power, the goal  
of the struggle for resource and recognition?  
These things have no substance of their own, but only  
are tools in the service of the inner life,  
the energies that beg for harmonization, which  
Anima knows and conveys. What power can save a man  
from himself, or free him from the burdens of the self?  
He is what he is, forever, or at least until the end of his days.

---

Take the path toward peace, inner peace,  
the path that you know but have often forgotten,  
the path that will let you feel free at last,  
the path that reveals all you are.

## For the First Time

*08 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/08/for-the-first-time/>*

I saw her  
and caught sight  
of myself  
for the first time.

## **Ursa Major**

*08 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/08/ursa-major/>*

Anima rises,  
and the bear with her  
to tackle the haunting visions.

## Hetaera

*08 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/08/hetaera/>*

She meant to hetaera me,  
and I meant to break her hetaera habit.  
Which one of us led the dance?  
I fell in a trance, but in doing so  
snared her in her own game,  
the cocoon of transformation.  
If she would look closely, she'd see  
her own dissatisfaction. But can she?  
Or is she corrupted already?

## Not Even Rebirth

*08 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/08/not-even-rebirth/>*

I will not trust her,  
not even if she should appear  
in the glorious splendor  
of regeneration.

## **Energies Flow**

*08 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/08/energies-flow/>*

I no longer rest in ideas.  
I feel my energies flow.



## Trauma Bonding

*08 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/08/trauma-bonding/>*

Trauma bonding is a better name  
for this ugly thing, for connection  
without affection and full of shame.  
But was it transference of earlier bonds,  
an earlier pattern on its way out?  
It has served that purpose at least for me.

## **Love Yourself**

*08 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/08/love-yourself/>*

Love yourself,  
then love others.  
Don't do this out of order.

## **This and No Other As Well**

*14 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/14/this-and-no-other-as-well/>*

The Man checks his pulse, feels the heat  
as spine curves to support a rush of blood.  
He will give all he has and be grateful  
for the opportunity. The time comes  
when pent-up energy flows into another,  
set free from waiting. He will pay  
any price. He will love until love runs out  
and be back for more. He has answered  
the final question and delivered his promise.  
The burden shifts to the Lady, who bears it  
with curious grace and charm, and a silly grin.  
They have made what they ought to have made.  
Now together they lie in euphoria.

## Against the Cold

*14 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/14/against-the-cold/>*

Now I see across the horizon  
approaching caravans carrying answers  
to many unasked questions. I  
am asking now. Pray tell  
what must be told, as I  
make bold to love myself  
against the cold.

## Wrong Turn

*14 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/14/wrong-turn/>*

What does it mean  
when Beatrice takes a wrong turn  
and leads back into hell?

## Better Things

14 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/14/better-things/>

A succubus aims for a trauma bond.  
She inspires exhaustion and the attendant desperation,  
a hunger that only she satisfies. Little does she know  
that she hurts herself too. Little does she know  
about love without heaps of pain. She would like  
to grow wiser, to break the spell that keeps her  
sucking, drawing all energy into herself, for it never satisfies.  
She needs one love with mutual trust and affection,  
but makes herself suited only to vacuuming up energy  
wherever she finds it. One day her time would come,  
but until then she only can bring destruction. A wise man  
will see what she is and flee. A brave one may stay  
for a while, to enjoy the show, and to learn her lessons. But all men,  
though tempted, must one day move on to better things.

## Who is the One

*14 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/14/who-is-the-one/>*

Reaching for forms, in the chaos  
of swirling anger and fear,  
who is the one who I find here,  
feet planted, alert and alive?

## Ghosts From Another Room

*14 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/14/ghosts-from-another-room/>*

I will not be convinced that I have not  
seen myself, in the darkness, where shadows  
lurk and consume, for I learned too soon  
what we are, and it haunts me, like ghosts  
from another room, a room where I do not belong.



## Children of Earth and Sky

*14 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/14/children-of-earth-and-sky/>*

I must make a home here, in my own mind,  
for I cannot escape my own impulses, cannot  
become pure and clean. But there is one shining  
divine invitation, to know myself, in the fullness  
of that self and no other, to stand firm and care  
about things that matter, and not about things  
that do not. There will be no apotheosis,  
no sudden rush into hope and peace eternal, for we  
are the children of earth and sky, and must marry  
the two somehow.

## Savage Humanity

14 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/14/savage-humanity/>

*My mind is intact, but the shapes  
of the world change, the peach  
has released the bough and at last  
makes full confession, its pudeur  
had departed like peach-fuzz wiped off, and*

*We now know how the hot sweet-  
ness of flesh and the juice-dark hug  
the rough peach-pit, we know its most  
suicidal yearnings, it wants  
to suffer extremely, it*

*Loves God, and I warn you, do not  
touch that plum, it will burn you, a blister  
will be on your finger, and you will  
put the finger to your lips for relief—oh, do  
be careful not to break that soft*

*Gray bulge of fruit-skin of blister, for  
exposing that inwardness will  
increase your pain, for you  
are part of the world. You think  
I am speaking in riddles. But I am not, for*

*The world means only itself.*

Robert Penn Warren, *Riddle in the Garden*

With the peach opened, the pudeur  
nowhere to be found, is anywhere safe  
or must all suffer together the fate  
of a savage humanity?

## Fuller Integration

14 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/14/fuller-integration/>

*Man is in love and loves what vanishes,  
What more is there to say?*

*Yeats, Nineteen-Hundred and Nineteen*

They cannot last, these dreams  
of love come down to roost  
on earth from heaven. They may  
point the way toward a fuller integration  
of our many selves, a deeper understanding,  
but they are no destination.

## The Alchemy of Ourselves

*14 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/14/the-alchemy-of-ourselves/>*

Tumbling on stormy waters, in search  
of a balance of power and love, the two  
interchangeable, certainly capable of harmony  
or mutual destruction...let each flow into the other,  
neither destroying nor fully consuming, the alchemy  
of ourselves in a fervent display.

## Light and Shadow

14 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/14/light-and-shadow/>

Oh, I did fall  
for the seductive illusions  
of an undercover guttersnipe,  
but I took the first step  
with full knowledge.

---

But if I broaden my perspective, I see  
that these complications are part of the appeal.  
I yearn for the feminine in all of its mystery.  
But can I now find within me the source  
of all yearning, and rest there, expecting no other  
to soothe what is mine and mine alone?

---

The trial is somehow thrilling, an ordeal  
to test my manhood, proving at last that I  
have arrived. But of course this arrival has really  
so little to do with another. It is my own self  
who arrives.

---

But that self includes parts of love  
half-fulfilled, never reaching their fullest potential  
alone. I would love one who also arrives.

---

Light and shadow interplay nicely on the windowsill,  
but beyond the window, outside the house,  
they are violent, gnawing, tormenting  
each other, at times to the point of devastation.

---

But there is a better way, here, with a few drops  
of civilized conduct, good habits, and healthy desire.  
I take this path. I will find who I find upon it  
and bear life's burdens to the end.

## Female Deity

14 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/14/female-deity/>

God works for women, but men  
need a female deity, to summon  
the inner life, to make active  
the inner feminine, which never  
was satisfied by love on earth.

---

But does the deity come to save  
or to torment? Gods can be resisted,  
and they should be, when they contradict each other,  
when they push against the flow of life itself.  
The sacred feminine deserves respect,  
but so does the sacred masculine.

---

Seductive illusions pull a man outside himself  
and into the dark of chthonic energies,  
the land of Woman's rule. If he would survive there,  
he must bring a sturdy mind, and hold fast to  
the golden thread that leads back to the light.

---

Ariadne, I do not expect to worship you,  
although your myth points in that direction. I have seen  
too much of who you really are, of what all women are.  
But you do make a potent symbol of regeneration,  
not unlike Demeter, though more forceful. Holy wife  
of Dionysus, turn the tables, change the stakes,  
and let us realign around that ruptured place.

---

You are not the first woman who has sought my worship,  
but you may be the last, having finally answered  
my deepest question. Even sex can be sacred, and even  
the most fervent worship must keep in the back of its mind  
that our animal side never entirely tames, cannot be expunged.  
You awaken libido. For that I do thank you. But is it  
libido or libido dominandi, a drive for love or for power?

---

The evidence points to the latter,  
and so I again bid adieu,  
but there's something about you  
that keeps you here as my muse.

## Venus and Apollo

*21 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/21/venus-and-apollo/>*

Venus drifts out of orbit,  
threatens to crash the whole solar system.  
Apollo intervenes with a gentle nudge  
and reaffirms normal planetary motion.



## Love Waits

21 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/21/love-waits/>

One never knows how the twists and turns  
of flowing time bring love around and around again  
from the sediments of the past, the ashes of passions  
long since burned up. What new sprouts grow  
from these soils long tilled in forgotten reaches of memory,  
the volcanic embers now quieted by gentle streams?  
The potential is there. A single drop of water  
slides down my window. I remember the heat  
and the cooling power of rain. Time past and future  
collide right here, to decide my path.  
It will be a slow journey. Love waits for those  
who are ready. They find their way to each other,  
having found their way to themselves.

## This Holy Place

*21 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/21/this-holy-place/>*

I see again those hidden mysteries,  
ancient unwavering stones at the basis  
of all that we are. They cannot be toppled  
or shaken by storms. We are where we are  
despite protestations, despite deceptive chagrin.  
I invite you to see this holy place,  
a place open to those with pure hearts.

## Truer, Higher, Deeper

27 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/27/truer-higher-deeper/>

Drifting about, once more searching for myself  
I remember what God used to mean to me...  
Can I pick up those pieces, restore to false hearts  
one true thing, one solid truth that remains  
even when all else topples? What is man,  
and how far has he come from the jungle  
to think he might think himself free?

---

How far must I go into unreached places,  
unnamed spaces, the desolate chambers  
of love abandoned, before I discover the answer?  
Life's question perennial, how to make sense  
of all urges, demands no special prerogative,  
no lonely sage. The man of action learns  
what he is by doing.

---

Can a man be happy without a woman  
around whom he can orbit? Hence libido,  
hence his deepest longing, hence his  
truest self. But is there a woman worthy  
of his sacrifice? Not even one.

---

And yet he is called to sacrifice  
by divine command. Is there no other way?  
Love breaks the day into pieces, until  
he can only say "take all I have."

---

Can a truer, higher, deeper love  
fulfill the needs of libido, or will it  
suck the soul out of itself and into  
some cosmic affair, so-called "holy" love  
between souls, where no body interferes?

---

I must embrace the pain in order  
to be fully human. I cannot shrink  
from my obligations or refuse to suffer.  
I must know where I am.

## Openness to Pain

27 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/27/openness-to-pain/>

She brought change, and a kind  
of openness to pain, a refusal  
to fear the unpleasant. I still  
must admire that. I have it too.

## Motivation

27 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/27/motivation/>

Pain at least provides *motivation*,  
a moving force to get people going.

## Christian Narcissism

*27 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/27/christian-narcissism/>*

She summons libido for a holy end,  
to get men moving toward God,  
but with her intermediating, always her  
shining before them as beacon  
and hope for arrival in port. She will speak  
of love, the love of God,  
and they hear all too clearly her meaning,  
for she is their god, and no other,  
and she would have it no other way.

## The Right Occasion to Strike

27 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/27/the-right-occasion-to-strike/>

How was one ever to arrive  
with the nymphs proclaiming love here  
or love there, always with an eye to desolation?  
One arrives by discovering deeper truths,  
the deep pull of the earth, the dark  
draw of sex, asking all, giving nothing  
in return. With this knowledge  
one sails on through, toward meatier shores,  
with real substance, understanding  
both the horror and the appeal,  
and waits for the right occasion to strike.



## Unveiling

*27 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/27/unveiling/>*

I don't know what will come of it,  
maybe my own transformation, maybe  
nothing, or maybe some glorious unveiling.

## **Another New Day**

*27 May 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/27/another-new-day/>*

Today is another new day, this one  
following the last, starting over, beginning  
what longs to begin.

## Strength for Love

27 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/27/strength-for-love/>

Sara was not my muse for long, though she did  
wake up something, inspire a desire that now  
finds fruition in itself, in the fuller picture  
of man as part man and part woman, part beast  
and part angel, all human, flourishing here  
or dying in the attempt.

---

Was Dionysus alive then too, working through  
even Abraham's wife, to bring nourishment  
into my bone-dry soul? She did call, and perhaps  
she meant it, and I was the miserable seducer.

---

I could not have loved at that time, and I knew it,  
though I did not know how to heal. With some luck  
I found fountains of carnal energy, long trapped,  
awaiting explosive release. Have I since found another  
in the same predicament?

---

Or have I just finished my own story, using  
a useful mirror to reveal to me parts of myself  
still asleep? But are these parts not best left asleep?

---

They shall wake when the waking is called for  
by one who is also waking, and only on these terms,  
for no other terms satisfy, no other waking  
is worth the trouble or free from degradation.

---

Having degraded others, was I not due  
for karmic retribution? Will those who degrade me  
face the same fate?

---

The slaves revolt, always, and often overcome  
their masters when it's least expected. Therefore

I swear off slavery and walk free.

---

But Sara still calls out to me from the reaches  
of far-off memory, one who dared love  
with apparent sincerity. I was the weak one, Sara,  
I was the one without strength to say yes  
or to bend without breaking, to give and take.  
You showed me the way.

---

Can I now show the way? I will try.  
But I look once again to the broken sky  
and remember my discipline. I would be strong  
without love. I will not trade my strength for love.

---

Where are the lovers  
who wish for my strength?  
Penelope, I arrive!

## Hiccupping Whiskey

27 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/27/hiccupping-whisky/>

Now I get it, having turned  
myself around and around, asking everyone  
if they had seen the reason why  
love continues without respite, why men  
and women continue to dance in the midst  
of egregious pain...It's all clear to me now,  
all too clear, but I stand here  
hiccupping whiskey, unloved, maybe  
better for it, maybe not so far from life  
after all. What is eros? Our master  
or slave? Or some petulant neighbor  
who interrupts our lives now and then?

## That Door

27 May 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/05/27/that-door/>

Let me revisit the question of love,  
which I swore to escape, just to find myself  
pulled back down to the swamp of desire  
when desirable visions arrived. She offered herself  
as a vision of immaculate desirability. She offers  
nothing more than a vision, and yet that vision  
entrances, serves as an entrance to a fuller version  
of myself, the self I would like to be.

I walked through that door, and found hope  
and despair. I was really there, all of me, even  
the parts that I could not see. She could see them,  
or made me believe she could see. Was I free  
or enslaved? Perhaps both. I was on my way.

## The Dark Lady

02 June 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/06/02/the-dark-lady/>

The Dark Lady swirls around and around  
in a mind no longer whole without her.  
Who is she? The shadow, the hidden feminine,  
the bedroom rage and silent, seductive gaze  
of eternity, endless sex and consequences,  
life itself brought down to its elements.

Are there women who can control her,  
truly, and not by man's interjection?  
Or must we feel afraid forever  
of the Bacchae and their eruptions?

## In Open Air

02 June 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/06/02/in-open-air/>

Through that door, into mystical grace,  
having lavished myself with all praises, I find  
an at-oneness surpassing all understanding,  
the hollow parts fall away, and I'm full  
of the hope of the universe, pulsing forever  
through hearts big and small. I'm alive  
with a life that demands introspection,  
respect, and small dignities played out  
before a crowd of peers. I will walk  
before God, stand erect, and fear nothing,  
not even inevitable death. Though I do fear  
the shadow, I know that for now it retreats  
and gives life its soft timbre, the darkness  
that fills out the image with tension,  
without which all falls apart.

Teach me something, remind me of pain,  
but do also remember that hope springs eternal,  
that life is not bad for longer than we can bear.  
So go anywhere, do anything, be anyone, so long  
as you find in your heart no remonstrance,  
no doubting despair. You were there. I was there.  
All was clear. Do remember. Become what your dreams  
prepare, and walk freely, in open air.



## Codependency

*02 June 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/06/02/codependency/>*

Have I uncovered my own codependency,  
mastered through years of bad lessons,  
ancestral wounds passed down through the generations?  
I walk freer now. I see where I am going  
and where I have been.

## The Purpose of Power

02 June 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/06/02/the-purpose-of-power/>

The purpose of power is health,  
well-being, good-spirits. All power  
pursued beyond these ends is at best  
unneded, at worst destructive.

The purpose of power is love,  
to make possible clearing the ground,  
to make way for a soft place  
for lovers to love and be loved.

## Not the Sky

02 June 2026

<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/06/02/not-the-sky/>

I called to you across the stars.  
Who answered? All of me answered,  
even the parts I despised. I now find  
my own life, and I'll cherish it  
even if I must see with my own eyes  
how pain answers and sprouts from the earth  
in all lives. I take off my disguise,  
and I sing here half mad but at least  
fully human, and therefore less mad than those civilized  
beyond any point of return, to the center,  
the origin of life. Who cries? Who calls  
now hearing my song? Some wild babe  
half asleep, in search of some manger  
to occupy, next to the animals, free from mankind  
and its silly demands. But the kettle is empty,  
the stores have run dry, and who feeds us?  
Who keeps out the wind? Not the sky!

## **Sacred Fire**

*02 June 2026*

*<https://poems.culturing.net/2026/06/02/sacred-fire/>*

I live my life  
near the sacred fire.  
Sometimes it burns,  
but without it, life grows cold.

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